

Your complete SEO interview workout.

One combined edition covering all 95 supplied URLs: 9 fundamentals, 41 crawling/indexing, and 45 ranking/search-appearance pages. All 669 existing question-and-answer cards are retained, including the 10 cross-topic scenarios and the 76 additional appearance questions. A separate glossary contains 127 source-backed definitions. Every answer has supporting Google excerpts and section links. The source library preserves all main-article text, tables and code from the 94 licensed supplied pages; the supplied Google Support article has a labeled complete-topic brief and original link. Seven official supplements clarify current guidance. Linked subguides are not recursively included.

95

SUPPLIED DOCUMENTS

669

QUESTIONS & ANSWERS

127

DEFINITIONS

Reviewed 6 October 2026 · Combined fundamentals, crawling, ranking and appearance edition

Use the pack to practise

Open `SEO_Interview_Practice.html` for hidden answers, topic and status filters, cross-topic scenarios, a glossary, a timer and saved review marks. Each printed answer is followed by exact evidence. Coaching describes how you might apply the documented rule; Google does not prescribe every suggested workflow or interview response.

1. **10 minutes:** Read the source notes and rapid facts. Refresh crawl vs index vs serve, eligibility vs actual display, and current AI guidance.
2. **45 minutes:** Use priority questions. Say each answer aloud before revealing it and mark uncertain answers for review.
3. **20 minutes:** Repeat your review queue and use the definitions tab for terminology you cannot explain.
4. **15 minutes:** Rehearse cross-topic scenarios and three truthful examples of your own technical, content and business work.

Page-by-page contents · all 95 supplied links

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5. D05 · [Using gen ai content](#) · 11 questions · [Google source](#)
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7. D07 · [Get started developers](#) · 13 questions · [Google source](#)
8. D08 · [Do i need seo](#) · 13 questions · [Google source](#)
9. D09 · [Third party seo](#) · 8 questions · [Google source](#)
10. D10 · [Crawling overview](#) · 3 questions · [Google source](#)
11. D11 · [Indexable file types](#) · 4 questions · [Google source](#)
12. D12 · [URL structure](#) · 6 questions · [Google source](#)
13. D13 · [Crawable links](#) · 6 questions · [Google source](#)
14. D14 · [Sitemap overview](#) · 4 questions · [Google source](#)
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18. D18 · [News sitemaps](#) · 6 questions · [Google source](#)
19. D19 · [Video sitemaps](#) · 8 questions · [Google source](#)

20. D20 · Combine extensions · 3 questions · [Google source](#)
21. D21 · Request recrawling · 4 questions · [Google source](#)
22. D22 · Crawling errors · 8 questions · [Google source](#)
23. D23 · Crawler overview · 6 questions · [Google source](#)
24. D24 · Googlebot · 5 questions · [Google source](#)
25. D25 · Reduce crawl rate · 5 questions · [Google source](#)
26. D26 · Verify Google requests · 4 questions · [Google source](#)
27. D27 · Robots.txt introduction · 5 questions · [Google source](#)
28. D28 · Robots.txt specification · 12 questions · [Google source](#)
29. D29 · Canonicalization · 5 questions · [Google source](#)
30. D30 · Choose canonical URLs · 8 questions · [Google source](#)
31. D31 · Canonical issues · 5 questions · [Google source](#)
32. D32 · Mobile-first indexing · 8 questions · [Google source](#)
33. D33 · JavaScript basics · 7 questions · [Google source](#)
34. D34 · Debug JavaScript · 6 questions · [Google source](#)
35. D35 · Lazy loading · 5 questions · [Google source](#)
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37. D37 · Valid metadata HTML · 3 questions · [Google source](#)
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39. D39 · Robots meta & headers · 11 questions · [Google source](#)
40. D40 · Noindex · 5 questions · [Google source](#)
41. D41 · Outbound link qualifiers · 4 questions · [Google source](#)
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43. D43 · Remove pages · 4 questions · [Google source](#)
44. D44 · Remove images · 5 questions · [Google source](#)
45. D45 · Safe redaction · 5 questions · [Google source](#)
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57. D57 · Discover · 9 questions · [Google source](#)
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61. D61 · Property display opt-out · 2 questions · [Google source](#)
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63. D63 · Interstitials · 6 questions · [Google source](#)
64. D64 · Core Web Vitals · 6 questions · [Google source](#)
65. D65 · Preferred sources · 8 questions · [Google source](#)
66. D66 · Ranking systems · 16 questions · [Google source](#)
67. D67 · Reviews system · 7 questions · [Google source](#)
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70. D70 · Regional features overview · 3 questions · [Google source](#)
71. D71 · Aggregator unit · 6 questions · [Google source](#)
72. D72 · Supplier unit · 3 questions · [Google source](#)
73. D73 · Ecosystem carousel · 3 questions · [Google source](#)
74. D74 · Job sites · 3 questions · [Google source](#)
75. D75 · Places sites · 3 questions · [Google source](#)
76. D76 · South Africa features · 4 questions · [Google source](#)
77. D77 · Carousels beta · 16 questions · [Google source](#)
78. D78 · Search profiles · 4 questions · [Google source](#)
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84. D84 · Enriched results · 5 questions · [Google source](#)
85. D85 · JavaScript structured data · 7 questions · [Google source](#)
86. D86 · Search gallery · 5 questions · [Google source](#)
87. D87 · Title links · 10 questions · [Google source](#)

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- 89. [D89 · Ads & translation](#) · 5 questions · [Google source](#)
- 90. [D90 · Video SEO](#) · 19 questions · [Google source](#)
- 91. [D91 · Visual elements](#) · 5 questions · [Google source](#)
- 92. [D92 · Enable Web Stories](#) · 6 questions · [Google source](#)
- 93. [D93 · Story creation practices](#) · 8 questions · [Google source](#)
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[127 definitions](#) · [28 rapid facts](#) · [10 cross-topic scenarios](#) · [Project stories and employer questions](#)

Source wording to handle carefully

Retired crawl-rate setting

The migration article and temporary-closure FAQ retain wording about a manual Search Console crawl-rate setting. Google's official notice retired the tool on January 8, 2024. Use the current reduce-crawl-rate guide for emergency response methods.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE · EXACT EXCERPT

“Friday, November 24, 2023 The crawl rate limiter tool in Search Console is being deprecated on Jan 8th, 2024. This tool has been available for over a decade , but with the improvements we've made to our crawling logic and other tools available to publishers, its usefulness has dissipated. Googlebot reacts to how the site—or”

S1 · Upcoming deprecation of Crawl Rate Limiter Tool in Search Console · Official retirement notice

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE · EXACT EXCERPT

“If you need to urgently reduce the crawl rate for short period of time (for example, a couple of hours, or 1-2 days), then return 500 , 503 , or 429 HTTP response status code instead of 200 to the crawl requests. Google's crawling infrastructure reduces your site's crawling rate when it encounters a significant number of URLs with 500 , 503 , or 429 HTTP response”

D25 · Reduce the Google crawl rate · Urgently reduce crawler traffic (for emergencies)

Fetch limits have different scopes

The crawler infrastructure overview gives a 15 MB default and allows project-specific overrides. The current Googlebot article gives 2 MB for ordinary files and 64 MB for PDFs, uncompressed. These statements refer to different scopes; use the Googlebot numbers when asked specifically about Search Googlebot.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“By default, Google's crawlers and fetchers only crawl the first 15MB of a file, and any content beyond this limit is ignored. However, individual projects may set different limits for their crawlers and fetchers, and also for different file types. For example, a Google crawler like Googlebot may have a smaller size limit (for example, 2MB), or specify a larger file size limit for a PDF than for HTML.”

D23 · Overview of Google crawlers and fetchers (user agents) · File size limits

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE · EXACT EXCERPT

“When crawling for Google Search, Googlebot crawls the first 2MB of a supported file type , and the first 64MB of a PDF file. From a rendering perspective, each resource referenced in the HTML (such as CSS and JavaScript) is fetched separately, and each resource fetch is bound by”

D24 · Googlebot · How Googlebot accesses your site

US crawling is the usual case, not an absolute

The closure FAQ says blocking the US prevents access. The newer crawler overview qualifies this: Google may try other countries if US requests are blocked. Use the newer overview to describe crawler geography and verify actual access.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Google's crawlers and fetchers are designed to be run simultaneously by thousands of machines to improve performance and scale as the web grows. To optimize bandwidth usage, these clients are distributed across many datacenters across the world so they're located near the sites that they might access. Therefore, your logs may show visits from several IP addresses. Google egresses primarily from IP addresses in the United States. In case Google detects that a site is blocking requests from the United States, it may attempt to crawl from IP addresses located in other countries.”

D23 · Overview of Google crawlers and fetchers (user agents) · Technical properties of Google's crawlers and fetchers

Old and new migration sitemaps

The migration article says the new sitemap can replace the old one at launch, and later describes submitting both for comparison. Submit the new sitemap; keeping an old sitemap for monitoring is not a permanent requirement. Redirect warnings on the old URLs can be expected.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Submit the new sitemap in Search Console . This will help Google learn about the new URLs. At this point you can remove your old sitemap, since Google will use the new sitemap going forward.”

D48 · How to move a site · Start the site move

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE · EXACT EXCERPT

“Sitemaps : Submit the two sitemaps you saved earlier from the mapping. Initially, the sitemap containing the new URLs would have zero pages indexed, while the sitemap of the old URLs would have many pages indexed. Over time the number of pages indexed from the old URLs”

D48 · How to move a site · Use Search Console to monitor traffic

Newer AI reports and inclusion controls

The supplied AI article was last updated in December 2025. Google's newer official sources describe dedicated generative-AI impressions reports and a Search Console inclusion control, both rolled out worldwide by August 31, 2026. Overall performance reporting continues. The control covers listed Search AI features, is distinct from AI training controls, and can inherit or override parent-property choices.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“As of August 31, 2026, we’ve rolled out these insights to all websites worldwide.”

S2 · [Introducing Search Generative AI performance reports in Search Console](#) · [Introduction](#)

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE · EXACT EXCERPT

“Search generative AI control”

S3 · [Search generative AI control](#) · [Search generative AI control](#)

Use inclusive Web Vitals thresholds and field data

The short Search article describes aspirational values with strict less-than wording. Google's linked Web Vitals reference defines good thresholds inclusively: LCP at most 2.5 seconds, INP at most 200 ms, CLS at most 0.1. Assessment uses the 75th percentile, separately for mobile and desktop; lab tests do not substitute for real-user measurement.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Largest Contentful Paint (LCP) : measures loading performance. To provide a good user experience, LCP should occur within 2.5 seconds of when the page first starts loading.”

S4 · [Web Vitals](#) · [Core Web Vitals](#)

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Interaction to Next Paint (INP) : measures interactivity . To provide a good user experience, pages should have a INP of 200 milliseconds or less.”

S4 · [Web Vitals](#) · [Core Web Vitals](#)

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Tools that assess Core Web Vitals compliance should consider a page passing if it meets the recommended targets at the 75th percentile for all three of the Core Web Vitals metrics.”

S4 · [Web Vitals](#) · [Core Web Vitals](#)

Current favicon size guidance

The current favicon guide specifies a square icon of at least 8×8 pixels and recommends larger than 48×48. Do not present the older multiples-of-48 rule as this current document's requirement. Favicon display is still not guaranteed.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

"Your favicon must be a square (1:1 aspect ratio) that's at least 8x8px. While the minimum size requirement is 8x8px, we recommend using a favicon that's larger than 48x48px so that it looks good on various surfaces. Google Search supports the following favicon file formats: BMP, GIF, ICO, PNG, JPEG, PPM, and TIFF."

D54 · [Define a favicon to show in search results](#) · [Guidelines](#)

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

"Your favicon must be a square (1:1 aspect ratio) that's at least 8x8px. While the minimum size requirement is 8x8px, we recommend using a favicon that's larger than 48x48px so that it looks good on various surfaces. Google Search supports the following favicon file formats: BMP, GIF, ICO, PNG, JPEG, PPM, and TIFF."

D54 · [Define a favicon to show in search results](#) · [Guidelines](#)

Page architecture depends on the feature

The regional beta host carousel requires a summary page with standalone detail URLs. The enriched-search guide requires leaf/detail pages. These concern different features; do not apply one page-location rule to every type of structured data.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

"Your site must have a summary page and multiple detail pages. Currently, this feature isn't designed to support other scenarios, such as an all-in-one page where the "details" are anchor points within the same page."

D77 · [Structured data carousels \(beta\)](#) · [Guidelines](#)

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

"Leaf content: Enriched search is only available for leaf pages, not for listing pages. A leaf page is a page that describes the detailed properties of an item. A listing page, on the other hand, is a category page that links to multiple leaf pages. The following are examples of listing pages: A page that describes "10 best ideas for cooking turkey" with links out to each recipe. A page listing all the jobs at Mountain View, CA, with links to individual jobs."

D84 · [Enriched search results](#) · [Enriched search quality guidelines](#)

Rich Results Test does not cover every appearance feature

Rich Results Test can check supported rich-result markup, but site names are explicitly unsupported. Use a schema validator plus URL Inspection for site-name markup. A passing rich-result test cannot guarantee display or detect every quality issue.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Validate your markup with a schema testing tool (for example, Schema Markup Validator) to make sure there are no syntax errors. Site names aren’t supported in the Rich Results Test.”

D79 · [Provide a site name to Google Search](#) · [Test structured data](#)

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“These quality guidelines are not easily testable using an automated tool. Violating a quality guideline can prevent syntactically correct structured data from being displayed as a rich result in Google Search, or possibly cause it to be marked as spam .”

D83 · [General structured data guidelines](#) · [Quality guidelines](#)

Two Story pages give different text-length advice

The creation guide suggests about 280 characters per page. The richer-experience policy warns that most pages over 180 characters can make a Story ineligible. Preserve both statements and use the policy when designing for richer-experience eligibility. The creation page also retains the older Index Coverage report name; the enablement guide uses Page Indexing.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Reduce your character count Avoid including multiple pages with walls of text. Consider reducing text to approximately 280 characters per page (the length of a tweet).”

D93 · [Best practices for creating Web Stories](#) · [Design](#)

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“We don't allow Web Stories that are text heavy. Web Stories may not be eligible if the majority of pages have more than 180 characters of text. Usage of bite-sized video (less than 60 seconds per page) wherever possible is encouraged.”

D94 · [Web Story Content Policies on Google](#) · [Text-heavy Web Stories](#)

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Check to see if Google Search has indexed your Web Story. Use the URL Inspection Tool to submit individual URLs or review status using Page Indexing report or Sitemaps report . If your Web Story isn't indexed:”

D92 · [Enable Web Stories on Google](#) · [Check if the Web Story is indexed](#)

28 rapid-revision facts

Condensed reminders; use the linked chapters and evidence for exceptions. The senior-answer framework is interview coaching.

- **Search stages:** Crawl, index, serve; discovery and rendering are explained within that pipeline. No stage is guaranteed.
- **Payments:** Google accepts no payment for organic inclusion, better rankings, or more frequent crawling.
- **Timing:** Hours to months; the Starter Guide generally recommends a few weeks before assessing benefit.
- **robots.txt:** Controls crawling; it is not reliable web-page index exclusion.
- **noindex:** Google must be able to fetch and process the directive; avoid contradictory crawl blocking.
- **Private data:** Use authentication or password protection, not robots.txt as secrecy.
- **Canonicals:** Google groups similar pages and selects a representative; declare preferences coherently.
- **Duplicates:** Ordinary same-site duplication is not itself a manual-action penalty; it can waste crawling and confuse users.
- **301 / 302 / 404:** Permanent move / temporary move / genuinely missing page, as presented in the maintenance guide.
- **JavaScript:** Google runs it, but limitations and inaccessible resources can affect what it sees.
- **DOM text:** Put important information in accessible page text; CSS content and canvas are not reliable substitutes.
- **Sitemaps:** Help discovery; no indexing guarantee. Google ignores priority/changefreq; use truthful lastmod.
- **E-E-A-T:** Experience, expertise, authoritativeness, trustworthiness; trust is central. It is not one specific ranking factor.
- **Quality raters:** Evaluate Search systems; do not directly set rankings or feed individual ratings into ranking algorithms.
- **Main-content quality:** Effort, originality, talent or skill, and accuracy; purpose and satisfaction guide the assessment.
- **Authorship:** Identify real creators when expected. Fabricated expert identities and credentials undermine trust.
- **Word count / headings:** No preferred ranking word count, ideal number of headings, or required AI chunk length.
- **Titles / snippets:** Accurate unique inputs influence presentation; Google may generate different title links or snippets.
- **Link qualifications:** sponsored for paid placements; ugc for user contributions; nofollow when appropriate.
- **Structured data:** Supports applicable rich-result eligibility; no display guarantee and no special mandatory AI schema.
- **AI content:** Useful assistance is allowed; review accuracy and added value. Scaled low-value production can violate policy.
- **AI search:** Core Search systems underpin it; use distinctive content and technical foundations.
- **RAG / fan-out:** Ground responses in retrieved pages / generate concurrent related queries to gather information.

- **llms.txt:** Google Search ignores it; the guide says it neither helps nor harms Google visibility or rankings.
- **AI eligibility today:** Indexed + snippet-eligible + appropriate Search requirements + included through the current Search Console control.
- **AI measurement today:** Current linked report documents AI Overviews and AI Mode impressions. Do not invent unlisted metrics.
- **Third-party tools:** Useful for workflow; vendor scores are not internal Google ranking data and cannot guarantee success.
- **Senior SEO answer:** Explain the principle, the evidence you would inspect, the action, and the business outcome; use truthful examples.

Search Engine Optimization (SEO) Starter Guide

Google last updated: 2025-12-10 • Reviewed 6 October 2026

<https://developers.google.com/search/docs/fundamentals/seo-starter-guide>

Help Google discover and understand useful content, and help people decide whether it answers their needs. Technical eligibility and sensible optimization improve opportunities; they never guarantee indexing or first place.

Detailed points to revise

- Purpose, eligibility, and expectations
- SEO helps search engines understand content and helps people find a site and decide whether to visit. Google treats a search engine as one of the website's users.
- Search Essentials establishes eligibility. Following it makes inclusion more likely, but no particular website is guaranteed a place in the index. There is no secret that automatically produces a number-one ranking.
- Google is automated: publishing accessible content is usually enough for eventual discovery. Most listed websites are found through crawling rather than manual submission.
- The guide's recommendations depend on the business. Some changes can be reflected in hours; others take months. Google generally recommends allowing a few weeks before assessing whether an optimization helped. A change may produce no noticeable effect; iterate when business constraints permit.
- Discovery and seeing what Google sees
- First check whether Google already knows the site. A site: search showing your pages confirms that those returned pages are in the index. If no results appear, investigate technical requirements. This is an initial check, not a complete URL-level diagnostic; use URL Inspection for a specific URL.
- Google primarily discovers new pages from links on already known pages, including external websites. Promotion can help people discover content and subsequently link to it.
- A sitemap lists URLs you care about and can be submitted; a CMS may generate one. It is useful but is not a universal requirement or an indexing guarantee. Do not ignore discoverable links or audience awareness.
- Let Google access important CSS, JavaScript, and other resources so its rendered view resembles an ordinary visitor's. Blocking these can damage understanding and visibility.
- Location-dependent pages need special attention: Googlebot generally crawls from the US. Check that the content served from its location is the version you intend Google to see.
- Use Search Console's URL Inspection to inspect Google's view. The guide also points to separate methods for keeping files, directories, or a whole website out of crawling or indexing; choose the mechanism for the actual objective.
- Logical architecture and descriptive URLs
- Logical organization helps users and search engines understand relationships between pages. Google does not tell every established website to restructure immediately; prioritize changes

that justify their cost.

- Use descriptive words in URLs for users. URL words can inform breadcrumbs, and breadcrumb structured data can influence their presentation. `/pets/cats.html` communicates more than a random identifier.
- On sites with more than a few thousand URLs, grouping related pages into directories can help Google learn different update patterns. Policy pages may change rarely while promotions change frequently; Google can crawl these groups at different frequencies.
- Duplicate content means substantially the same information under different URLs. Google selects a canonical representative. Routine duplication on your own website is not itself a spam-policy violation, but it can confuse users and consume crawling resources.
- Prefer one URL per piece of content when feasible. Redirect redundant URLs to the preferred version when users should go there; use a `rel="canonical"` link element when redirects are unsuitable. Google can also canonicalize without an explicit declaration. Copying other publishers' content is a different issue.
- Useful content, search language, ads, and links
- Useful, compelling content is likely to matter more than the other improvements in this guide. Write naturally, organize paragraphs and sections, use helpful headings, and correct spelling and grammar.
- Contribute original content rather than copying or rehashing. Review older pages, update when necessary, and remove material that no longer serves a relevant purpose.
- Make information helpful, reliable, and intended for readers. Expert or experienced sources can demonstrate the knowledge behind the article.
- Understand how novices and specialists describe the same need, such as cheese board versus charcuterie. You need not include every keyword variant; Google's language systems can understand relevance without the exact query wording.
- Advertising should not distract so heavily that it prevents use of the content. Interstitials that obstruct expected content are an example to watch.
- Internal and external links support discovery and supply context or corroboration. Anchor text should explain the target page so users and search engines can anticipate what they will find.
- Link to sources you trust. For a link you cannot endorse, use `nofollow` or a similar qualification. User-posted links should receive suitable qualifications automatically to discourage spam and avoid blindly associating your site with their destinations.
- Titles, snippets, images, and video
- The title link is the search result's headline. Google may generate it from the HTML title element and other headings; your title is an input, not a promise of exact display. CMS software often creates the title element automatically.
- Good titles are unique, concise, descriptive, and accurate. Include a business name, location, or relevant offering when useful. This page gives no mandatory character limit.
- A snippet is the descriptive text beneath a title link. It is generally drawn from page content and can sometimes come from the meta description. Write a short, page-specific description summarizing the important information; do not assume it will always be displayed.
- Images can be an independent discovery channel. Use sharp, clear images near text that explains their relevant context. A yarn-store image belongs near the corresponding store's location and review information.
- Alt text briefly describes how the image relates to the page. Add it with an `img` element's `alt` attribute or the CMS field; write a meaningful description rather than a keyword list.
- For video-led pages, create a high-quality video and a standalone watch page with relevant supporting text. Use descriptive video titles and descriptions. Video-heavy websites should

follow the linked specialist guidance too.

- Promotion and the complete myth list
- Promote content through social channels, communities, online and offline advertising, and word of mouth. Include the URL in business cards, stationery, posters, and other business materials. Newsletters are suggested with the recipients' permission.
- Promotion can improve discovery; overpromotion can fatigue people, and manipulative practices can be seen as search spam.
- Meta keywords: Google Search does not use the keywords meta tag.
- Keyword stuffing: excessive repetition, including variations, violates Google's spam policies.
- Keywords in domains or URL paths: alone they have hardly any ranking effect beyond their appearance in breadcrumbs. Choose names for the business and users.
- TLDs: generally not important to Google; country targeting can make a country-code TLD relevant, usually as a low-impact signal. A generic .com does not automatically outrank .org or .asia.
- Content length: there is no magical minimum, maximum, or target word count for ranking. Natural breadth may cover more relevant language; padding has no inherent value.
- Subdomains versus subdirectories: choose what makes organizational and business sense. The guide does not declare a universal ranking winner.
- PageRank: links matter and PageRank is one fundamental algorithm, but it is only one among many ranking signals.
- Duplicate-content penalty: ordinary duplication under multiple URLs does not itself cause a manual action. Distinguish inefficiency from copying other sites or spam.
- Headings: semantic order is valuable for screen readers; Google does not require an ideal heading count or perfect order. Avoid unnecessary excess for users.
- E-E-A-T: it is not a single ranking factor. See the helpful-content chapter for the full distinction.
- Next steps and staying current
- Set up Search Console and learn the relevant reports. Maintain SEO over time, including migrations and multilingual configurations.
- Appropriate valid structured data can make pages eligible for special search appearances. Eligibility does not guarantee display.
- Keep up with Google Search Central's blog, LinkedIn, X, YouTube, and Help Forum. The forum includes Product Experts and sometimes Googlers.

Complete source section checklist: How does Google Search work? · How long until I see impact in search results? · Help Google find your content · Check if Google can see your page the same way a user does · Don't want a page in Google's search results? · Organize your site · Use descriptive URLs · Group topically similar pages in directories · Reduce duplicate content · Make your site interesting and useful · Expect your readers' search terms · Avoid distracting advertisements · Link to relevant resources · Write good link text · Link when you need to · Influence how your site looks in Google Search · Influence your title links · Control your snippets · Add images to your site, and optimize them · Add high-quality images near relevant text · Add descriptive alt text to the image · Optimize your videos · Promote your website · Things we believe you shouldn't focus on · Next steps · Stay informed and ask questions

What does SEO actually do according to this guide?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

It helps search engines understand content and helps people discover the website and decide whether to visit. I apply it to useful content, with technical access and a clear search presentation.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“When you built your website, you likely created it with your users in mind, trying to make it easy for them to find and explore your content. One of those users is a search engine, which helps people discover your content. SEO—short for search engine optimization—is about helping search engines understand your content, and helping users find your site and make a decision about whether they should visit your site through a search engine.”

D01 · Search Engine Optimization (SEO) Starter Guide · Search Engine Optimization (SEO) Starter Guide

How long should we wait to evaluate an SEO change?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

Google says effects can take hours to months, and generally advises waiting a few weeks to assess benefit. I establish a baseline and allow time for recrawling and processing; I do not promise an exact improvement date.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Every change you make will take some time to be reflected on Google's end. Some changes might take effect in a few hours, others could take several months. In general, you likely want to wait a few weeks to assess whether your work had beneficial effects in Google Search results. Keep in mind that not all changes you make to your website will result in noticeable impact in search results; if you're not satisfied with your results and your business strategies allow it, try iterating with the changes and see if they make a difference.”

D01 · Search Engine Optimization (SEO) Starter Guide · How long until I see impact in search results?

Does every website need a sitemap to rank?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

No. Google can discover pages through links, and the Starter Guide calls a sitemap optional. It is useful for communicating important URLs, particularly when discovery through links is weaker, but does not guarantee indexing.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“If you're open to a little technical challenge, you could also submit a sitemap —which is a file that contains all the URLs on your site that you care about. Some content management systems (CMS) may even do this automatically for you. However this isn't required, and you should first focus on making sure people know about your site .”

D01 · Search Engine Optimization (SEO) Starter Guide · Help Google find your content

QUESTION 004 · D01

Priority practice

How would you check whether Google can see a page properly?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

Use URL Inspection to examine the rendered page and accessibility of its resources. Check CSS and JavaScript blocking and location-dependent responses, rather than trusting only my browser view.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“When Google crawls a page, it should ideally see the page the same way an average user does . For this, Google needs to be able to access the same resources as the user's browser. If your site is hiding important components that make up your website (like CSS and JavaScript), Google might not be able to understand your pages, which means they might not show up in search results or rank well for the terms you're targeting.”

D01 · Search Engine Optimization (SEO) Starter Guide · Check if Google can see your page the same way a user does

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“To check how Google sees your page, use the URL Inspection Tool in Search Console .”

D01 · Search Engine Optimization (SEO) Starter Guide · Check if Google can see your page the same way a user does

QUESTION 005 · D01

Why organize related URLs into directories?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

For users, it clarifies structure. At larger scale, it can help Google learn that different groups change at different frequencies. It is not a reason to rebuild every healthy site immediately.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“If you have more than a few thousand URLs on your site, how you organize your content may have effects on how Google crawls and indexes your site. Specifically, using directories (or folders) to group similar topics can help Google learn how often the URLs in individual directories change.”

D01 · Search Engine Optimization (SEO) Starter Guide · Group topically similar pages in directories

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“The content in the policies directory seldomly changes, however the content in the promotions directory likely changes very often. Google can learn this information and crawl the different directories at different frequencies. To learn more about search-friendly site structures, check out our guide for ecommerce sites , for which a good URL structure is more important as they tend to be larger.”

D01 · Search Engine Optimization (SEO) Starter Guide · Group topically similar pages in directories

QUESTION 006 · D01 Priority practice

Will duplicate product URLs trigger a duplicate-content penalty?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

Routine duplication on one's own site is not itself a spam violation or cause of a manual action. I consolidate where appropriate because duplicates can confuse users and waste crawling, and distinguish this from copied or manipulative content.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Having duplicate content on your site is not a violation of our spam policies, but it can be a bad user experience and search engines might waste crawling resources on URLs that you don't even care about. If you're feeling adventurous, it's worth figuring out if you can specify a canonical version for your pages. But if you don't canonicalize your URLs yourself, Google will try to automatically do it for you.”

D01 · Search Engine Optimization (SEO) Starter Guide · Reduce duplicate content

QUESTION 007 · D01

When would you choose a redirect rather than a canonical tag?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

Use a redirect when the redundant URL should send users to the preferred page. If the alternate URL needs to remain accessible, a canonical declaration can indicate the preferred representative. Google ultimately performs canonical selection.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“If you have multiple pages that have the same information, try setting up a redirect from non-preferred URLs to a URL that best represents that information. If you can't redirect, use the rel="canonical" link element instead. But again, don't worry too much about this; search engines can generally figure this out for you on their own most of the time.”

D01 · Search Engine Optimization (SEO) Starter Guide · Reduce duplicate content

QUESTION 008 · D01

Must I include every exact keyword variation?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

No. Understand audience language and use relevant terminology naturally. Google's language matching can relate a page to queries without every exact phrase appearing.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“However, don't worry if you don't anticipate every variation of how someone might seek your content. Google's language matching systems are sophisticated and can understand how your page relates to many queries, even if you don't explicitly use the exact terms in them.”

D01 · Search Engine Optimization (SEO) Starter Guide · Expect your readers' search terms

QUESTION 009 · D01

Priority practice

Does Google always show the title and meta description we write?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

No. Title links have several inputs, including title elements and headings; snippets usually come from page text and can sometimes use a meta description. I improve accurate inputs and inspect actual presentation.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“The title link is the headline part of the search result and it can help people decide which search result to click. There are a few sources that Google uses to generate this title link, including the words inside the <title> element (also called the title text) and other headings on the page. This title text can also be used for the title that's shown in browsers and bookmarks.”

D01 · Search Engine Optimization (SEO) Starter Guide · Influence your title links

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“The snippet is sourced from the actual content of the page the search result is linking to, thus you have complete control over the words that can be used to generate the snippet. Occasionally the snippet may be sourced from the contents of the meta description tag, which is typically a succinct, one- or two-sentence summary of the page. A good meta description is short, unique to one particular page, and includes the most relevant points of the page. Check out our tips for writing good meta descriptions for more inspiration.”

D01 · Search Engine Optimization (SEO) Starter Guide · Control your snippets

QUESTION 010 · D01

What makes a good image optimization answer?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

Sharp relevant images placed near explanatory text, with descriptive alt text explaining their relationship to the page. The guide focuses on discoverability and understanding, not a prescribed keyword density.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Use images that are sharp and clear, and place them near text that's relevant to the image. The text that's near images can help Google better understand what the image is about and what it means in context to your page.”

D01 · Search Engine Optimization (SEO) Starter Guide · Add high-quality images near relevant text

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE · EXACT EXCERPT

“Alt text is a short, but descriptive piece of text that explains the relationship between the image and your content. It helps search engines understand what your image is about and the context of how your image relates to your page, so writing good alt text is quite important. You can add this to your HTML with the alt attribute of the img element, or your CMS may”

D01 · Search Engine Optimization (SEO) Starter Guide · Add descriptive alt text to the image

QUESTION 011 · D01

How would you optimize a video page from this guide?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

Create a high-quality video, give it a standalone page where the video is the main focus, add relevant supporting text, and write descriptive video titles and descriptions. Then consult Google's video-specific guidance.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Create high-quality video content, and embed the video on a standalone page, near text that's relevant to that video.”

D01 · Search Engine Optimization (SEO) Starter Guide · Optimize your videos

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Write descriptive text in the titles and description fields of a video (the title of a video is still a title, and so you can apply the best practices for writing titles here too).”

D01 · Search Engine Optimization (SEO) Starter Guide · Optimize your videos

QUESTION 012 · D01

Should we add nofollow to all external links?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

The guide recommends linking to trusted relevant resources normally and qualifying links you cannot endorse or that come from users. Additional official guidance prefers sponsored for paid placements and ugc for user contributions.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE · EXACT EXCERPT

“Links can provide more context on a topic, both for users and search engines, which may help demonstrate your knowledge on a topic. However when you're linking to pages outside of your control, for example content on other sites, make sure you trust the resource you're linking to. If you can't trust the content and you still want to link to them, add a nofollow or”

D01 · Search Engine Optimization (SEO) Starter Guide · Link when you need to

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“rel="sponsored" Mark links that are advertisements or paid placements (commonly called paid links) with the sponsored value. Read more about Google's stance on paid links . Appenzeller Note: The nofollow attribute was previously recommended for these types of links and is still an acceptable way to flag them, though sponsored is preferred.”

D41 · Qualify your outbound links to Google · Qualify your outbound links to Google

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Multiple values You may specify multiple rel values as a space- or comma-separated list. Examples: <p>I love Appenzeller cheese.</p> <p>I hate Blue cheese.</p>”

D41 · Qualify your outbound links to Google · Qualify your outbound links to Google

QUESTION 013 · D01

Do domain keywords or a .com domain guarantee better rankings?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

No. Domain and path keywords alone have little ranking effect; select names for the business. Country-code domains can help communicate a geographic target, but generic TLDs have no universal advantage.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE · EXACT EXCERPT

“for your business. Users will use this name to find you, so we recommend following general marketing best practices. From a ranking perspective, the keywords in the name of the domain (or URL path) alone have hardly any effect beyond appearing in breadcrumbs . And while still on the topic of domain names: the TLD (the domain name ending like “.com” or “.guru”) only matters if you're targeting a”

D01 · Search Engine Optimization (SEO) Starter Guide · Things we believe you shouldn't focus on

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE · EXACT EXCERPT

“in the name of the domain (or URL path) alone have hardly any effect beyond appearing in breadcrumbs . And while still on the topic of domain names: the TLD (the domain name ending like “.com” or “.guru”) only matters if you're targeting a specific country's users, and even then it's usually a low impact signal. For example, if you're trying to sell Dutch cheese to people”

D01 · Search Engine Optimization (SEO) Starter Guide · Things we believe you shouldn't focus on

QUESTION 014 · D01 Priority practice

What is Google's ideal word count and heading structure?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

There is no ideal ranking word count or magic number of headings. Use enough detail and a logical accessible structure to satisfy the audience. Do not pad articles to meet an invented threshold.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE · EXACT EXCERPT

“using (whether it's a .com or .org or .asia). Minimum or maximum content length The length of the content alone doesn't matter for ranking purposes (there's no magical word count target, minimum or maximum, though you probably want to have at least one word). If you are varying the words (writing naturally to not be repetitive), you have more chances to show up in Search simply because you are using”

D01 · Search Engine Optimization (SEO) Starter Guide · Things we believe you shouldn't focus on

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE · EXACT EXCERPT

“them out of order. The web in general is not valid HTML, so Google Search can rarely depend on semantic meanings hidden in the HTML specification. There's also no magical, ideal amount of headings a given page should have. However, if you think it's too much, then it probably is. Thinking E-E-A-T is a ranking factor No, it's not.”

D01 · Search Engine Optimization (SEO) Starter Guide · Things we believe you shouldn't focus on

QUESTION 015 · D01

Is PageRank still relevant, and is it the whole ranking system?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

It remains one fundamental algorithm involving links, but Google uses many signals. Treating rankings as a PageRank-only problem misses relevance, quality, and the wider search process.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE · EXACT EXCERPT

“by subdirectories, but other times it might make sense to partition topics into subdomains, depending on your site's topic or industry. PageRank While PageRank uses links and is one of the fundamental algorithms at Google, there's much more to Google Search than just links. We have many ranking signals, and PageRank is just one of those. Duplicate content "penalty" If you have some”

D01 · Search Engine Optimization (SEO) Starter Guide · Things we believe you shouldn't focus on

QUESTION 016 · D01

Can a paid promotion campaign directly buy organic ranking?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

No. Legitimate promotion can improve awareness and discovery. Google does not accept money for organic inclusion, higher rankings, or faster crawling.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Advertising with Google won't have any effect on your site's presence in our search results. Google never accepts money to include or rank sites in our search results, and it costs nothing to appear in our organic search results. Resources such as Search Console , the official Google Search Central blog , and our discussion forum can provide you with a great deal of information about how to optimize your site for Google's non-advertising search results (often called "organic search").”

D08 · Do you need an SEO? · Do you need an SEO?

QUESTION 017 · D01

What should follow an initial SEO cleanup?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

Monitor Search Console, keep content and technical configurations maintained, plan changes such as migrations carefully, and add appropriate structured data for eligible search features while staying current with official guidance.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Get started with Search Console : Setting up a Search Console account helps you monitor and optimize how your website performs on Google Search. Learn how to set up your account and what reports to check out first .”

[D01](#) · [Search Engine Optimization \(SEO\) Starter Guide](#) · [Next steps](#)

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Maintain your website's SEO over time : Learn more about managing your site's presence in the long term , including more in-depth SEO tasks and scenarios, such as preparing for a site move, or managing a multi-lingual site.”

[D01](#) · [Search Engine Optimization \(SEO\) Starter Guide](#) · [Next steps](#)

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Enhance how your site looks in Google Search results : Valid structured data on your pages also makes your pages eligible for many special features in Google Search results, including review stars, carousels, and more. Explore the gallery of search result types that your page can be eligible for.”

[D01](#) · [Search Engine Optimization \(SEO\) Starter Guide](#) · [Next steps](#)

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE · EXACT EXCERPT

“Google Search Central blog : Get the latest information from our Google Search Central blog. You can find information about updates to Google Search, new Search Console features, and much more. Google Search Central on LinkedIn and X (Twitter) : Follow us for updates on Google Search and resources to help you make a great site. Google Search Central Help Forum : Post”

[D01](#) · [Search Engine Optimization \(SEO\) Starter Guide](#) · [Stay informed and ask questions](#)

In-depth guide to how Google Search works

Google last updated: 2025-12-18 · Reviewed 6 October 2026

<https://developers.google.com/search/docs/fundamentals/how-search-works>

Separate URL discovery, crawling, indexing, and serving. An accessible URL can be discovered without being crawled, crawled without being indexed, or indexed without appearing for a particular query.

Detailed points to revise

- Automation and the three stages
- Google finds most pages automatically using crawlers. Manual submission is not the usual route into Search.
- The three named stages are crawling, indexing, and serving search results. URL discovery is explained within the crawling stage; rendering is part of processing fetched content, not a fourth named stage in this article.
- Google accepts no payment for more frequent crawling or higher organic rankings. Compliance with Search Essentials does not guarantee crawling, indexing, or serving.
- Crawling: discovery, scheduling, access, and rendering
- There is no central registry of every web page. Google continually discovers new and updated URLs from previous visits, links extracted from known pages, and submitted sitemaps. A category hub linking to a new article is one example.
- Discovering a URL does not mean Google will fetch it. Googlebot chooses which sites to crawl, how often, and how many pages using an algorithmic process.
- Crawlers avoid overloading servers. Server responses affect behavior; HTTP 500 errors can cause crawling to slow down. Infrastructure health matters independently of content quality.
- Some discovered URLs are blocked from crawling or require authentication. Common crawl access problems are server issues, network issues, and robots.txt rules.
- Google renders pages and runs JavaScript using a recent Chrome version. Rendering helps expose content produced by scripts. A page that appears complete to a logged-in human can still present incomplete content to Google.
- Indexing: understanding, clustering, and canonical selection
- Google analyzes page text, title elements, image alt attributes, images, videos, and other information to understand a crawled page.
- Similar pages are grouped into clusters, and Google selects a canonical page that best represents each group. Other cluster members are alternate versions and may be served in particular contexts, such as a mobile user or a very specific request.
- Google gathers signals about the canonical and its content, including language, geographic relevance, and usability. The resulting information may be stored in the index, a distributed database on thousands of computers.
- Crawling and processing do not guarantee indexing. Reasons indexing can fail include low content quality, robots meta rules disallowing indexing, and a site design that makes understanding difficult.

- Serving: relevance, context, and result types
- When a query arrives, Google searches its index and returns what it considers relevant, high-quality results. Ranking is programmatic and involves hundreds of factors.
- User location, language, and device can change relevance. A bicycle repair search can return different local businesses in Paris and Hong Kong.
- Query needs also affect result features. A repair-shop search can show local results; a query for a modern bicycle may favor images. The article links to the visual-element gallery.
- Search Console can show a page as indexed even when you cannot find it for a particular query. Possible reasons include weak query relevance, low quality, and serving restrictions from robots meta rules.
- Google continuously improves its algorithms; the Search Central blog is the recommended update source.
- Practical interpretation for an experienced candidate
- Diagnose the failed stage before prescribing a fix. A blocked resource, missing discoverable link, non-indexable page, unintended canonical, and weak match to search intent are different problems.
- Treat a recrawl request or sitemap as a discovery/processing aid, not a command to index or rank. Evidence from URL Inspection, the rendered page, and server logs makes the diagnosis more credible.
- Those diagnosis steps are interview applications of the article; the article itself does not prescribe one universal troubleshooting checklist.

Complete source section checklist: A few notes before we get started · Introducing the three stages of Google Search · Crawling · Indexing · Serving search results

QUESTION 018 · D02 Priority practice

Explain how Google Search works in under a minute.

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

Google discovers URLs through known pages, links, and sitemaps. Googlebot may crawl and render them, including JavaScript. Google then analyzes content, groups similar pages and selects canonicals, and may store information in its index. For a query, it serves relevant, high-quality results based on many signals and user context. None of the stages is guaranteed.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Crawling: Google downloads text, images, and videos from pages it found on the internet with automated programs called crawlers.”

D02 · In-depth guide to how Google Search works · Introducing the three stages of Google Search

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Indexing: Google analyzes the text, images, and video files on the page, and stores the information in the Google index, which is a large database.”

D02 · In-depth guide to how Google Search works · Introducing the three stages of Google Search

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Serving search results: When a user searches on Google, Google returns information that's relevant to the user's query.”

D02 · In-depth guide to how Google Search works · Introducing the three stages of Google Search

QUESTION 019 · D02

What is the difference between discovery and crawling?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

Discovery means Google knows a URL exists. Crawling means it actually requests and downloads the content. A discovered URL can remain uncrawled because of scheduling, access restrictions, or server issues.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE · EXACT EXCERPT

“The first stage is finding out what pages exist on the web. There isn't a central registry of all web pages, so Google must constantly look for new and updated pages and add them to its list of known pages. This process is called "URL discovery". Some pages are known because Google has already visited them. Other pages are discovered when Google extracts a link from”

D02 · In-depth guide to how Google Search works · Crawling

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE · EXACT EXCERPT

“Once Google discovers a page's URL, it may visit (or "crawl") the page to find out what's on it. We use a huge set of computers to crawl billions of pages on the web. The program that does the fetching is called Googlebot (also known as a crawler, robot, bot, or spider). Googlebot uses an algorithmic process to determine which sites to crawl, how often, and how many”

D02 · In-depth guide to how Google Search works · Crawling

QUESTION 020 · D02

How can a newly published page be discovered?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

A known category or hub page can link to it, another website can link to it, or its URL can appear in a submitted sitemap. Google also knows URLs it has visited before.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE · EXACT EXCERPT

“The first stage is finding out what pages exist on the web. There isn't a central registry of all web pages, so Google must constantly look for new and updated pages and add them to its list of known pages. This process is called "URL discovery". Some pages are known because Google has already visited them. Other pages are discovered when Google extracts a link from”

D02 · In-depth guide to how Google Search works · Crawling

QUESTION 021 · D02 Priority practice

Does Google execute JavaScript?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

Yes, it renders using a recent Chrome version. That does not mean every JavaScript implementation works reliably for Search; resources, rendering limitations, and how content appears still need checking.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“During the crawl, Google renders the page and runs any JavaScript it finds using a recent version of Chrome , similar to how your browser renders pages you visit. Rendering is important because websites often rely on JavaScript to bring content to the page, and without rendering Google might not see that content.”

D02 · In-depth guide to how Google Search works · Crawling

QUESTION 022 · D02

Why might a URL not be crawled?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

It may be blocked by robots.txt, unavailable without login, affected by server or network problems, or simply not selected for crawling yet. Discovery alone is insufficient.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“However, Googlebot doesn't crawl all the pages it discovered. Some pages may be disallowed for crawling by the site owner, other pages may not be accessible without logging in to the site.”

D02 · In-depth guide to how Google Search works · Crawling

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Problems with the server handling the site”

D02 · In-depth guide to how Google Search works · Crawling

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Network issues”

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GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“robots.txt rules preventing Googlebot's access to the page”

D02 · In-depth guide to how Google Search works · Crawling

QUESTION 023 · D02

Why do repeated 500 responses matter to SEO?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

They indicate server trouble and can cause Google to slow crawling to avoid overload. I would investigate server health before interpreting reduced crawl activity as a content problem.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE · EXACT EXCERPT

“Once Google discovers a page's URL, it may visit (or "crawl") the page to find out what's on it. We use a huge set of computers to crawl billions of pages on the web. The program that does the fetching is called Googlebot (also known as a crawler, robot, bot, or spider). Googlebot uses an algorithmic process to determine which sites to crawl, how often, and how many”

D02 · In-depth guide to how Google Search works · Crawling

QUESTION 024 · D02 Priority practice

What happens during indexing?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

Google interprets text and important attributes, images and videos, identifies similar-page clusters, selects a canonical representative, and gathers language, locality, and usability information that may be stored in the index.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“After a page is crawled, Google tries to understand what the page is about. This stage is called indexing and it includes processing and analyzing the textual content and key content tags and attributes, such as <title> elements and alt attributes, images , videos , and more.”

D02 · In-depth guide to how Google Search works · Indexing

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Google also collects signals about the canonical page and its contents, which may be used in the next stage, where we serve the page in search results. Some signals include the language of the page, the country the content is local to, and the usability of the page.”

D02 · In-depth guide to how Google Search works · Indexing

QUESTION 025 · D02

What is a canonical page in this explanation?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

It is the representative Google selects from a group of pages with similar content, generally the one that may be shown in results. Other pages in the cluster can be alternate versions served in some contexts.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE · EXACT EXCERPT

“During the indexing process, Google determines if a page is a duplicate of another page on the internet or canonical . The canonical is the page that may be shown in search results. To select the canonical, we first group together (also known as clustering) the pages that we found on the internet that have similar content, and then we select the one that's most”

D02 · In-depth guide to how Google Search works · Indexing

QUESTION 026 · D02

Priority practice

Why can a crawled page remain unindexed?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

Possible causes in this article include low quality, robots meta restrictions, and design that makes indexing difficult. Google also explicitly does not promise to index every page it processes.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“The collected information about the canonical page and its cluster may be stored in the Google index, a large database hosted on thousands of computers. Indexing isn't guaranteed; not every page that Google processes will be indexed.”

D02 · In-depth guide to how Google Search works · Indexing

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“The quality of the content on page is low”

D02 · In-depth guide to how Google Search works · Indexing

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Robots meta rules disallow indexing”

D02 · In-depth guide to how Google Search works · Indexing

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“The design of the website might make indexing difficult”

D02 · In-depth guide to how Google Search works · Indexing

QUESTION 027 · D02 Priority practice

Why can an indexed page fail to appear for our target keyword?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

Indexing establishes potential availability, not query relevance or a ranking position. Low relevance, quality, serving restrictions, and the query's context can keep it from appearing where we expect.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“When a user enters a query, our machines search the index for matching pages and return the results we believe are the highest quality and most relevant to the user's query. Relevancy is determined by hundreds of factors, which could include information such as the user's location, language, and device (desktop or phone). For example, searching for "bicycle repair shops" would show different results to a user in Paris than it would to a user in Hong Kong.”

D02 · In-depth guide to how Google Search works · Serving search results

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“The content on the page is irrelevant to users' queries”

D02 · In-depth guide to how Google Search works · Serving search results

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“The quality of the content is low”

D02 · In-depth guide to how Google Search works · Serving search results

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Robots meta rules prevent serving”

D02 · In-depth guide to how Google Search works · Serving search results

QUESTION 028 · D02

Why do two people see different results for the same phrase?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

Google can consider location, language, and device. For a local-intent query, businesses near one searcher can be more relevant than those near another.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“When a user enters a query, our machines search the index for matching pages and return the results we believe are the highest quality and most relevant to the user's query. Relevancy is determined by hundreds of factors, which could include information such as the user's location, language, and device (desktop or phone). For example, searching for "bicycle repair shops" would show different results to a user in Paris than it would to a user in Hong Kong.”

D02 · In-depth guide to how Google Search works · Serving search results

QUESTION 029 · D02

Why does Google show images for some queries and local results for others?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

The features depend on the user's query and the information likely to satisfy it. The article contrasts bicycle repair shops with modern bicycle images.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Based on the user's query the search features that appear on the search results page also change. For example, searching for "bicycle repair shops" will likely show local results and no image results, however searching for "modern bicycle" is more likely to show image results, but not local results. You can explore the most common UI elements of Google web search in our Visual Element gallery.”

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QUESTION 030 · D02

Can anyone pay Google for faster crawling or higher organic ranking?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

No. Google explicitly rejects both claims. Advertising and organic search processes should be explained separately.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Before we get into the details of how Search works, it's important to note that Google doesn't accept payment to crawl a site more frequently, or rank it higher. If anyone tells you otherwise, they're wrong.”

D02 · In-depth guide to how Google Search works · A few notes before we get started

QUESTION 031 · D02

If a stakeholder says 'we submitted it, so it should rank', how do you respond?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

Submission can help discovery. I would show whether the URL was crawled, indexed, selected as canonical, and relevant to the target query, then address the actual bottleneck. Submission is not a ranking guarantee.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Google doesn't guarantee that it will crawl, index, or serve your page, even if your page follows the Google Search Essentials .”

D02 · In-depth guide to how Google Search works · A few notes before we get started

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Google Search works in three stages, and not all pages make it through each stage:”

D02 · In-depth guide to how Google Search works · Introducing the three stages of Google Search

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Serving search results: When a user searches on Google, Google returns information that's relevant to the user's query.”

D02 · In-depth guide to how Google Search works · Introducing the three stages of Google Search

Creating helpful, reliable, people-first content

Google last updated: 2026-10-05 · Reviewed 6 October 2026

<https://developers.google.com/search/docs/fundamentals/creating-helpful-content>

Judge whether the page fulfills a real purpose for a real audience. Trust, original effort, useful evidence, and satisfaction matter; E-E-A-T and rater feedback are not direct numerical ranking scores.

Detailed points to revise

- Self-assessment and auditing a decline
- Google's automated systems seek helpful, reliable information created to benefit people rather than manipulate rankings.
- Evaluate your own pages and obtain an honest assessment from trusted people who are not affiliated with the website. Avoid relying only on the team that produced the content.
- If performance dropped, identify the affected pages and search types, then evaluate those pages against the actual questions. The guide recommends targeted assessment rather than declaring all content bad.
- All twelve content-quality checks, paraphrased
- Original contribution: does the page offer its own information, reporting, research, or analysis?
- Completeness: does it explain the subject substantially and comprehensively enough for its purpose?
- Insight: does it go beyond obvious information and offer useful analysis or discoveries?
- Added value from sources: when drawing on other work, does it add originality and substantial value instead of merely copying or rewriting?
- Descriptive title: does the main heading or title accurately and helpfully summarize the page?
- Responsible title: does it avoid sensationalism, exaggeration, or shock as a substitute for value?
- Recommendation value: would a reader bookmark it, share it, or recommend it?
- Editorial credibility: is its quality comparable to material someone would expect in a book, encyclopedia, or print magazine?
- Competitive value: does it offer substantial value compared with other search results?
- Language care: are spelling and stylistic problems addressed?
- Production care: does it look thoughtfully produced rather than rushed or sloppy?
- Attention per page: has mass production, outsourcing, or publication across a large site network reduced the care given to individual pages?
- All four expertise checks, paraphrased
- Trust evidence: clear sourcing, proof of relevant knowledge, and background on the author or publisher, including appropriate author or About pages.
- Reputation: would someone investigating the publisher see it as trusted or recognized in its subject?
- Knowledgeable production or review: was the content written or reviewed by an expert or informed enthusiast?

- Factual reliability: does it avoid errors that are easy to verify?
- Page experience and all five people-first checks
- Evaluate the overall experience rather than optimizing only one or two aspects. The guide refers readers to Google's separate page-experience documentation.
- Audience: an existing or intended audience would find the page useful even if they arrived directly.
- First-hand knowledge: the content demonstrates real experience, such as using a product, using a service, or visiting a place.
- Focus: the website has a primary purpose or subject focus.
- Goal completion: a reader learns enough to accomplish the intended task.
- Satisfaction: the reader leaves feeling the experience was worthwhile.
- All eleven search-engine-first warning signs
- The main purpose is attracting search visits rather than helping an audience.
- Publishing across many unrelated topics in the hope some pages rank.
- Extensive automation across many topics.
- Mainly summarizing other people's work without meaningful added value.
- Choosing topics solely because they trend rather than because the audience needs them.
- Readers must search again because the page did not adequately answer their need.
- Writing to a supposedly preferred Google word count. Google says no such preference exists.
- Entering a niche without real expertise because it appears to offer search traffic.
- Promising an answer that is not known, such as an unconfirmed release date.
- Changing displayed dates without substantial content changes to simulate freshness.
- Adding many pages or removing old pages mainly to make the whole site appear fresh. The guide says this is not a general ranking improvement mechanism.
- These are warning signs for reassessment, not a formula that proves a particular page has a penalty. SEO itself is useful when applied to people-first material to support discovery and understanding.
- E-E-A-T, YMYL, and quality raters
- E-E-A-T stands for experience, expertise, authoritativeness, and trustworthiness. Trust is the most important aspect; the other aspects support it.
- Useful content need not demonstrate every aspect equally. First-hand experience can make one page valuable; specialist expertise can make another valuable.
- E-E-A-T is not itself a specific ranking factor. Google's systems use a mixture of factors that can identify content exhibiting these qualities; do not invent an E-E-A-T score or fixed weight.
- Strong E-E-A-T matters particularly for Your Money or Your Life topics that can significantly affect health, financial stability, safety, or societal welfare.
- Quality raters assess whether Google's systems deliver good results, following the evaluator guidelines. They do not control page rankings, and their ratings are not directly used in ranking algorithms. Their feedback helps evaluate improvements to systems.
- The guidelines can inform self-assessment; they are not an instruction manual for getting first place. They also emphasize how effectively main content fulfills a page's purpose.
- Main content: definitions and all four quality attributes
- Main content is any part of the page that directly achieves its purpose. It can include text, articles, images, audio, and videos.

- It can also include working tools, calculators, games, and search features. A useful page is not necessarily an article.
- User contributions can be main content when they fulfill the page's purpose, including forum discussions, customer reviews, comments, or uploaded media.
- Tabbed and expandable information, such as product specifications, safety details, and reviews, can be main content. Visible titles and headings also qualify because they explain the page's subject and help users decide.
- Effort: human work in the content or underlying system. Original analysis, a manual poem translation, and a custom game map illustrate effort. Automatically generated feed pages or large volumes of AI text without oversight illustrate little effort. Attribution alone does not replace original work.
- Originality: unique information or perspectives beyond what other websites already provide.
- Talent or skill: the ability required to deliver a satisfying result, such as clear writing, well-made videos, or functioning tools. Not every useful experience requires professional credentials; everyday practical experience can be valuable.
- Accuracy: informational pages should be factually sound. YMYL content needs especially high accuracy and alignment with established expert consensus.
- Who, How, and Why
- Who: make actual authorship clear when expected. Add accurate bylines and relevant author-background links. Ask whether visitors can identify the author, whether a byline is present where appropriate, and whether it explains the creator's background.
- Avoid fabricated expert identities, made-up names, false credentials, and AI headshots used to make nonexistent experts appear real. The guide explicitly identifies deceptive authorship as untrustworthy and a low-quality signal.
- How: explain the production process when it matters. For reviews, show how many products were tested, how testing worked, what results were obtained, and evidence such as photos.
- For substantial automation, assess whether it is apparent or disclosed, whether the process is explained, and why AI or automation was useful. Disclosures are useful when readers would reasonably ask how the material was created; this is not stated as a mandatory universal label for every page.
- Why: the primary reason should be helping people, including people who arrive directly. The guide calls this the most important question. Automation used primarily to manipulate rankings violates the spam policies.

Complete source section checklist: Self-assess your content · Content and quality questions · Expertise questions · Provide a great page experience · Focus on people-first content · Avoid creating search engine-first content · What about SEO? Isn't that search engine-first? · Get to know E-E-A-T and the quality rater guidelines · Main content · Ask "Who, How, and Why" about your content · Who (created the content) · How (the content was created) · Why (was the content created)

QUESTION 032 · D03

How would you evaluate whether content is helpful?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

I would assess original value, completeness for the task, accuracy, source credibility, readability, audience relevance, and whether visitors can achieve their goal. I would use the page's self-assessment questions and independent feedback, rather than word count as a quality proxy.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Does the content provide original information, reporting, research, or analysis?”

D03 · Creating helpful, reliable, people-first content · Content and quality questions

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Does the content provide a substantial, complete, or comprehensive description of the topic?”

D03 · Creating helpful, reliable, people-first content · Content and quality questions

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“If the content draws on other sources, does it avoid simply copying or rewriting those sources, and instead provide substantial additional value and originality?”

D03 · Creating helpful, reliable, people-first content · Content and quality questions

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Does the content present information in a way that makes you want to trust it, such as clear sourcing, evidence of the expertise involved, background about the author or the site that publishes it, such as through links to an author page or a site's About page?”

D03 · Creating helpful, reliable, people-first content · Expertise questions

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Does the content have any easily-verified factual errors?”

D03 · Creating helpful, reliable, people-first content · Expertise questions

QUESTION 033 · D03

Priority practice

What are the four parts of E-E-A-T?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

Experience, expertise, authoritativeness, and trustworthiness. Google says trust is the most important aspect, with the others contributing to it.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Google's automated systems are designed to use many different factors to rank great content. After identifying relevant content, our systems aim to prioritize those that seem most helpful. To do this, they identify a mix of factors that can help determine which content demonstrates aspects of experience, expertise, authoritativeness, and trustworthiness, or what we call E-E-A-T.”

D03 · Creating helpful, reliable, people-first content · Get to know E-E-A-T and the quality rater guidelines

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Of these aspects, trust is most important. The others contribute to trust, but content doesn't necessarily have to demonstrate all of them. For example, some content might be helpful based on the experience it demonstrates, while other content might be helpful because of the expertise it shares.”

D03 · Creating helpful, reliable, people-first content · Get to know E-E-A-T and the quality rater guidelines

QUESTION 034 · D03 Priority practice

Is E-E-A-T a ranking factor?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

Not as a single specific factor. Google's automated systems use a mixture of signals that can identify these qualities. I would explain the quality concepts without claiming that adding a byline produces a direct numerical ranking boost.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“While E-E-A-T itself isn't a specific ranking factor, using a mix of factors that can identify content with good E-E-A-T is useful. For example, our systems give even more weight to content that aligns with strong E-E-A-T for topics that could significantly impact the health, financial stability, or safety of people, or the welfare or well-being of society. We call these “Your Money or Your Life” topics, or YMYL for short.”

D03 · Creating helpful, reliable, people-first content · Get to know E-E-A-T and the quality rater guidelines

QUESTION 035 · D03

Does every page need a certified expert author?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

No. Some pages are valuable because of first-hand experience, and not every useful task requires specialist expertise. Higher-stakes YMYL information requires greater accuracy and appropriate expertise; authorship must always be truthful.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Of these aspects, trust is most important. The others contribute to trust, but content doesn't necessarily have to demonstrate all of them. For example, some content might be helpful based on the experience it demonstrates, while other content might be helpful because of the expertise it shares.”

D03 · Creating helpful, reliable, people-first content · Get to know E-E-A-T and the quality rater guidelines

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Talent or skill: Whether the content shows the talent, skill, or expertise necessary to provide a satisfying experience for visitors (such as clear writing, well-produced video, or functional page tools). Keep in mind that not all content requires specialized expertise. For example, a person sharing their experience about finding a new way to clear their driveway of snow generally doesn't necessarily require specialized expertise.”

D03 · Creating helpful, reliable, people-first content · Main content

QUESTION 036 · D03 Priority practice

What are YMYL topics and why do they matter?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

Subjects that can significantly affect health, financial stability, safety, or societal welfare. Google gives greater weight to content aligned with strong E-E-A-T in these areas, and stresses highly accurate information consistent with expert consensus.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“While E-E-A-T itself isn't a specific ranking factor, using a mix of factors that can identify content with good E-E-A-T is useful. For example, our systems give even more weight to content that aligns with strong E-E-A-T for topics that could significantly impact the health, financial stability, or safety of people, or the welfare or well-being of society. We call these “Your Money or Your Life” topics, or YMYL for short.”

D03 · Creating helpful, reliable, people-first content · Get to know E-E-A-T and the quality rater guidelines

QUESTION 037 · D03 Priority practice

Can a quality rater directly lower my rankings?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

No. Raters evaluate whether Google's systems produce good results; they do not control individual rankings, and their feedback is not directly inserted into ranking algorithms.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Search quality raters are people who give us insights on if our algorithms seem to be providing good results, a way to help confirm our changes are working well. In particular, raters are trained to understand if content has strong E-E-A-T. The criteria they use to do this is outlined in our search quality rater guidelines .”

D03 · Creating helpful, reliable, people-first content · Get to know E-E-A-T and the quality rater guidelines

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Search raters have no control over how pages rank. Rater data is not used directly in our ranking algorithms. Rather, we use them as a restaurant might get feedback cards from diners. The feedback helps us know if our systems seem to be working.”

D03 · Creating helpful, reliable, people-first content · Get to know E-E-A-T and the quality rater guidelines

QUESTION 038 · D03

What does people-first content mean in practice?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

Content serves an intended audience, reflects useful knowledge or experience, fits the site's purpose, helps people complete a task, and leaves them satisfied even if they came directly rather than through Search.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“People-first content means content that's created primarily for people, and not to manipulate search engine rankings. How can you evaluate if you're creating people-first content? Answering yes to the questions below means you're probably on the right track with a people-first approach:”

D03 · Creating helpful, reliable, people-first content · Focus on people-first content

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Does your content clearly demonstrate first-hand expertise and a depth of knowledge (for example, expertise that comes from having actually used a product or service, or visiting a place)?”

D03 · Creating helpful, reliable, people-first content · Focus on people-first content

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“After reading your content, will someone leave feeling they've learned enough about a topic to help achieve their goal?”

D03 · Creating helpful, reliable, people-first content · Focus on people-first content

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Will someone reading your content leave feeling like they've had a satisfying experience?”

D03 · Creating helpful, reliable, people-first content · Focus on people-first content

QUESTION 039 · D03

Give examples of search-engine-first warning signs.

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

Publishing unrelated topics for traffic, summarizing without added value, excessive automation, chasing trends unrelated to the audience, artificial date changes, and targeting an invented word count. These should trigger reassessment of the production strategy.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Are you producing lots of content on many different topics in hopes that some of it might perform well in search results?”

D03 · Creating helpful, reliable, people-first content · Avoid creating search engine-first content

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Are you using extensive automation to produce content on many topics?”

D03 · Creating helpful, reliable, people-first content · Avoid creating search engine-first content

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Are you mainly summarizing what others have to say without adding much value?”

D03 · Creating helpful, reliable, people-first content · Avoid creating search engine-first content

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Are you writing about things simply because they seem trending and not because you'd write about them otherwise for your existing audience?”

D03 · Creating helpful, reliable, people-first content · Avoid creating search engine-first content

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Are you writing to a particular word count because you've heard or read that Google has a preferred word count? (No, we don't.)”

D03 · Creating helpful, reliable, people-first content · Avoid creating search engine-first content

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Are you changing the date of pages to make them seem fresh when the content has not substantially changed?”

D03 · Creating helpful, reliable, people-first content · Avoid creating search engine-first content

QUESTION 040 · D03

Can deleting old pages improve rankings just by making a site fresher?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

Google says bulk removal or addition mainly to create a freshness impression does not provide that general benefit. I would update, merge, or remove pages according to relevance, accuracy, usefulness, and business purpose.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Are you adding a lot of new content or removing a lot of older content primarily because you believe it will help your search rankings overall by somehow making your site seem “fresh?” (No, it won’t)”

D03 · Creating helpful, reliable, people-first content · Avoid creating search engine-first content

QUESTION 041 · D03

What should you inspect after a content-related traffic decline?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

First identify which pages and types of searches lost visibility. Then evaluate those pages against the quality and audience questions and get independent feedback. I would not assume the cause before examining the evidence.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Also consider an audit of the drops you may have experienced. What pages were most impacted and for what types of searches? Look closely at these to understand how they’re assessed against some of the questions outlined here.”

D03 · Creating helpful, reliable, people-first content · Self-assess your content

What is main content, beyond article text?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

Anything that directly fulfills the page's purpose: text or media, calculators and tools, forum discussion or reviews, relevant tabbed content, and visible headings. A calculator's functional value can be its main content.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Google Search defines “main content” as any part of the web page that directly helps the page achieve its purpose. Depending on the primary intent of the page, the main content directly fulfills the page's purpose and could include:”

D03 · Creating helpful, reliable, people-first content · Main content

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Primary text and media: The main text, articles, images, audio, or video files on the page.”

D03 · Creating helpful, reliable, people-first content · Main content

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Interactive features: Built-in functionality such as calculators, online tools, games, or search functionality.”

D03 · Creating helpful, reliable, people-first content · Main content

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“User-generated contributions: Forum discussions, customer reviews, comments, or user-uploaded media when they directly fulfill the page's purpose (for example, when the page is about discussing a particular user question).”

D03 · Creating helpful, reliable, people-first content · Main content

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Tabbed or expanded sections: Information housed behind interactive tabs (such as product specifications, safety notes, or user reviews).”

D03 · Creating helpful, reliable, people-first content · Main content

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Page titles and headings: The visible title and headings throughout a page that summarize its topic and helps users make informed decisions about visiting.”

D03 · Creating helpful, reliable, people-first content · Main content

What four attributes do quality raters consider for main content?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

Effort, originality, talent or skill, and accuracy. These concern how effectively the page fulfills its purpose, not a mandatory format or minimum word count.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Effort: The extent to which human work went into creating the content or the systems powering it. For example, writing original analysis, translating a poem manually, or building a custom interactive map for a game represents high effort. Conversely, automatically generating pages from feeds or using generative AI to produce large amounts of text without manual oversight or curation represents little to no effort. Attribution or giving credit to other sources doesn't replace the need for original effort.”

D03 · Creating helpful, reliable, people-first content · Main content

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Originality: The extent to which the content offers unique, original information or perspectives that aren't already available on other websites.”

D03 · Creating helpful, reliable, people-first content · Main content

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Talent or skill: Whether the content shows the talent, skill, or expertise necessary to provide a satisfying experience for visitors (such as clear writing, well-produced video, or functional page tools). Keep in mind that not all content requires specialized expertise. For example, a person sharing their experience about finding a new way to clear their driveway of snow generally doesn't necessarily require specialized expertise.”

D03 · Creating helpful, reliable, people-first content · Main content

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Accuracy: For informational pages, the content should be factually accurate. For topics that could significantly impact people's lives or well-being (YMYL topics), the content must be highly accurate and consistent with established expert consensus.”

D03 · Creating helpful, reliable, people-first content · Main content

Is citing a source enough to make an AI summary original?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

No. Attribution does not substitute for original effort or added value. I would contribute evidence, analysis, testing, or a useful application rather than republishing a lightly rewritten summary.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“If the content draws on other sources, does it avoid simply copying or rewriting those sources, and instead provide substantial additional value and originality?”

D03 · Creating helpful, reliable, people-first content · Content and quality questions

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Effort: The extent to which human work went into creating the content or the systems powering it. For example, writing original analysis, translating a poem manually, or building a custom interactive map for a game represents high effort. Conversely, automatically generating pages from feeds or using generative AI to produce large amounts of text without manual oversight or curation represents little to no effort. Attribution or giving credit to other sources doesn't replace the need for original effort.”

D03 · Creating helpful, reliable, people-first content · Main content

QUESTION 045 · D03

Can product specifications behind a tab count as main content?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

Yes. The guide explicitly includes tabbed or expanded sections that fulfill the page's purpose. I would still verify that the actual implementation exposes the intended information to Google.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Tabbed or expanded sections: Information housed behind interactive tabs (such as product specifications, safety notes, or user reviews).”

D03 · Creating helpful, reliable, people-first content · Main content

QUESTION 046 · D03

Priority practice

How would you strengthen Who, How, and Why on a product review?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

Identify the real reviewer and relevant background; document the testing method, products, results, and evidence; and ensure the review exists to help a buyer make a decision. Avoid fabricated authors and unsupported claims.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“If you're clearly indicating who created the content, you're likely aligned with the concepts of E-E-A-T and on a path to success. We strongly encourage adding accurate authorship information, such as bylines to content where readers might expect it.”

D03 · Creating helpful, reliable, people-first content · Who (created the content)

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“For example, with product reviews, it can build trust with readers when they understand the number of products that were tested, what the test results were, and how the tests were conducted, all accompanied by evidence of the work involved, such as photographs. It's advice we share more about in our [Write high quality product reviews help page](#).”

[D03](#) · [Creating helpful, reliable, people-first content](#) · [How \(the content was created\)](#)

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“The "why" should be that you're creating content primarily to help people, content that is useful to visitors if they come to your site directly. If you're doing this, you're aligning with E-E-A-T generally and what our core ranking systems seek to reward.”

[D03](#) · [Creating helpful, reliable, people-first content](#) · [Why \(was the content created\)](#)

QUESTION 047 · D03

Must we label every use of AI on every page?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

The guide recommends context and disclosures where readers would reasonably expect an explanation of substantial automation. It does not prescribe one universal label. Merchant Center has separate specific requirements for certain AI-generated product data.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Overall, AI or automation disclosures are useful for content where someone might think "How was this created?" Consider adding these when it would be reasonably expected. For more, see our [blog post](#) and [FAQ: How Google Search views AI-generated content](#) .”

[D03](#) · [Creating helpful, reliable, people-first content](#) · [How \(the content was created\)](#)

QUESTION 048 · D03

Priority practice

Would adding AI-generated expert headshots help E-E-A-T?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

Using them to fabricate human expert identities is deceptive. Google explicitly treats fabricated creator profiles and credentials as untrustworthy. Real provenance and honest expertise are the appropriate direction.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“However, avoid using deceptive authorship information. Fabricating creator profiles (such as by using AI-generated headshots, made-up names, or false credentials to make content appear as if it was written by human experts) is a form of deception. Any form of deception makes a page untrustworthy to both users and our automated quality systems, and is a signal of a low-quality page.”

D03 · Creating helpful, reliable, people-first content · Who (created the content)

Optimizing your website for generative AI features on Google Search

Google last updated: 2026-07-10 · Reviewed 6 October 2026

<https://developers.google.com/search/docs/fundamentals/ai-optimization-guide>

For Google AI Overviews and AI Mode, foundational SEO still applies. Build accessible, useful, distinctive content and verify eligibility. Avoid special-file, schema, keyword, or mention schemes sold as mandatory AI shortcuts.

Detailed points to revise

- Relevance of SEO, RAG, and query fan-out
- Google's generative AI features are rooted in its core Search ranking and quality systems. The guide treats optimization for these experiences as SEO.
- Retrieval-augmented generation, also called grounding, retrieves relevant current pages from the Search index using core ranking systems. The response can use information from those pages and show clickable supporting links. This is different from assuming a model answers only from training memory.
- Query fan-out generates related queries concurrently to find more information for the original request. For a weed-filled lawn, examples include herbicide selection, non-chemical removal, and preventing future weeds.
- AEO means answer engine optimization; GEO means generative engine optimization. These are industry labels, not separate mandatory Google ranking frameworks. Evaluate providers against official guidance.
- Distinctive content and reader satisfaction
- The guide prioritizes unique, compelling, useful material. First-hand reviews and informed perspectives provide information a generic summary cannot.
- Non-commodity content adds distinctive experience or expert insight beyond common knowledge. The guide contrasts a generic homebuyer tips list with a detailed account of a specific decision about an inspection and sewer line. The lesson is original evidence and insight, not a special headline formula.
- Write well and organize content into paragraphs and sections with helpful headings. Relevant high-quality images and videos provide additional opportunities for discovery in AI experiences as well as ordinary Search.
- Do not create separate pages for every possible query variant or fan-out request mainly to manipulate rankings or AI responses. That can violate scaled content abuse policy; page quantity is not a substitute for quality.
- Google's systems can understand relevance without an exact query match. AI-assisted production still needs to meet Search Essentials and the spam policies. The decision test is whether a visitor would find the page helpful and satisfying.
- Technical eligibility and access

- A page must be indexed and eligible to appear in Google Search with a snippet. Meeting technical requirements and policies does not guarantee crawling, indexing, or selection for display.
- The current article also says the site must be included in Search generative AI features through Search Console. Check the actual setting and inheritance rather than claiming that all indexed pages necessarily participate.
- Maintain crawlable content and resources. Large, frequently changing sites may need crawl-budget work. Keep JavaScript implementations compatible with Google's access and rendering behavior.
- Semantic HTML is useful, especially for screen-reader navigation; perfect semantic markup is not a requirement for AI visibility. Make content understandable and readable.
- Provide a good experience across devices, reduce latency, and make the main content easy to distinguish. Reduce duplicate content where it wastes resources or confuses users. Verify the property in Search Console to support diagnosis.
- Local and ecommerce details
- Keep relevant Merchant Center product information, including feeds, and Google Business Profile information maintained. Generative AI responses can include local-business and product details.
- The article also suggests considering Business Agent where it fits the business and its goals, describing a conversational Search experience that lets customers talk with the brand. This is an optional experience, not a universal SEO requirement.
- All five AI-search myths
- llms.txt and special files: Google Search does not use these files to improve visibility or rankings. They are not required. Creating them for another system that actually uses them is fine; this neither helps nor harms Google Search ranking. Google can crawl many file types without granting them special status.
- Content chunking: no requirement to split content into tiny pieces. Google can understand multiple topics and identify relevant parts. Choose length and organization for the audience.
- AI-specific rewriting: no required prose style or exhaustive long-tail keyword coverage. Synonyms and intent can be understood without exact wording.
- Inauthentic mentions: manufacturing mentions across blogs, forums, or videos is not a supported path. AI features depend on core quality and spam systems too.
- Special structured data: no mandatory AI schema.org markup. Normal applicable structured data remains useful for rich-result eligibility, but is not required for generative AI visibility.
- Measurement, agents, and next steps
- The current article directs readers to Search Console's Generative AI performance report for visibility. It also warns that third-party tools have no access to Google's internal ranking or AI systems.
- AI agents can perform tasks on behalf of people, such as making reservations or comparing specifications. Browser agents may use screenshots, the DOM, and accessibility trees to understand a site.
- The guide links to agent-friendly website practices and mentions the emerging Universal Commerce Protocol. Explore these if relevant and if time permits; do not confuse an emerging commerce protocol with a mandatory ranking factor.
- Priorities are foundational technical SEO, unique audience-focused content, avoiding unsupported shortcuts, measuring visibility, and keeping informed about relevant agent experiences.

- Follow the Search Central blog, social channels, Help Forum, and YouTube. The guide also notes that some content succeeds without overt SEO and that every listed recommendation is not a prerequisite for success.
- Verified current detail from linked Search Console documentation
- The Search generative AI control is under Settings > Search generative AI. Inclusion is the default for properties without an inherited choice; child properties can inherit or override a parent. Excluding affects the covered AI appearances, not ranking in other Search surfaces. This visibility control is distinct from AI-training controls. [S1]
- The Search Generative AI performance report covers AI Overviews and AI Mode impressions, with pages, countries, dates, and devices; Discover has a separate report. Do not claim this report supplies AI clicks, CTR, or query-level data merely because ordinary Search performance does. The linked help pages say worldwide rollout occurred August 31, 2026. [S2]

Complete source section checklist: Is SEO still relevant for generative AI search? · Apply foundational SEO best practices to generative AI search · Create valuable, non-commodity content for your audience · Build and maintain a clear technical structure · Optimize your local business and ecommerce details · Mythbusting generative AI search: what you don't need to do · Measure visibility in generative AI features with Search Console · Explore agentic experiences · Next steps: what to focus on · Stay informed and ask questions

QUESTION 049 · D04 Priority practice

Is SEO obsolete because of AI Overviews and AI Mode?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

No. Google says these experiences rely on its core Search ranking and quality systems. I would prioritize technical eligibility, distinctive useful content, a good experience, relevant business data, and measurement.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“In short, yes! The best practices for SEO continue to be relevant because our generative AI features on Google Search are rooted in our core Search ranking and quality systems. These features rely on AI techniques to highlight content from our Search index, such as:”

D04 · Optimizing your website for generative AI features on Google Search · Is SEO still relevant for generative AI search?

QUESTION 050 · D04 Priority practice

Explain RAG in an SEO interview.

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

Retrieval-augmented generation grounds a response in relevant pages retrieved from the Search index, using Google's core systems. It can improve freshness and accuracy and provide supporting links, rather than relying entirely on a model's training memory.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Retrieval-augmented generation (RAG) : A technique (also known as grounding) used to improve the quality, accuracy, and freshness of AI responses by relying on our core Search ranking systems to retrieve relevant, up-to-date web pages from our Search index. Our systems then review the specific information from those retrieved pages to generate a more reliable and helpful response, showing prominent, clickable links to relevant web pages that support the information in the response.”

D04 · Optimizing your website for generative AI features on Google Search · Is SEO still relevant for generative AI search?

QUESTION 051 · D04 Priority practice

What is query fan-out?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

The model issues multiple related queries to gather supporting information for the user's original request. It expands information retrieval; it is not a recommendation to publish a separate page for every variant.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Query fan-out : A set of concurrent, related queries generated by the model to request more information and fetch additional relevant search results to address the user's query. For example, if the original user's query is "how to fix a lawn that's full of weeds", fanout queries might include "best herbicides for lawns", "remove weeds without chemicals", and "how to prevent weeds in lawn".”

D04 · Optimizing your website for generative AI features on Google Search · Is SEO still relevant for generative AI search?

QUESTION 052 · D04

What does non-commodity content mean?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

Information with distinctive value, such as original testing, first-hand experience, expert interpretation, or a unique perspective. A generic rewording of common advice provides less unique value than a documented real-world case.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE · EXACT EXCERPT

“Providing a unique point of view : Our AI systems take a look at a variety of sources, so it can be helpful to have a unique viewpoint that stands out. For example, a first-hand review provides a unique perspective based on personal experience, whereas a summary of existing content simply restates information already available elsewhere. Create the content yourself”

D04 · Optimizing your website for generative AI features on Google Search · Create valuable, non-commodity content for your audience

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Creating non-commodity content that's helpful, reliable, and people-first : Be sure that you're writing non-commodity content that your readers will find helpful and reliable. Commodity content (for example, something like "7 Tips for First-Time Homebuyers") is often based on common knowledge, which could originate from anyone, and typically adds little unique insight for readers. In contrast, non-commodity content (such as "Why We Waived the Inspection & Saved Money: A Look Inside the Sewer Line") provides unique expert or experienced takes that go beyond common knowledge and the ordinary.”

D04 · Optimizing your website for generative AI features on Google Search · Create valuable, non-commodity content for your audience

QUESTION 053 · D04 Priority practice

What makes a page eligible for Google AI features?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

The current guide says it must be indexed, eligible for Search with a snippet, meet technical requirements, and be included in Search generative AI features through Search Console. Eligibility does not guarantee appearance.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE · EXACT EXCERPT

“Meet the Search technical requirements: To be eligible to be shown in generative AI features on Google Search, a page must be indexed and eligible to be shown in Google Search with a snippet, fulfilling the Search technical requirements . In addition to the technical requirements for Search, a site must be included in Search generative AI features in Search Console”

D04 · Optimizing your website for generative AI features on Google Search · Build and maintain a clear technical structure

QUESTION 054 · D04 Priority practice

Does Google require llms.txt?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

No. This guide explicitly says Google Search ignores it, including for its AI capabilities. It can be useful to a different system that uses it, but it is not a Google visibility requirement or ranking boost.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE · EXACT EXCERPT

“LLMS.txt files and other "special" markup : You don't need to create new machine readable files, AI text files, markup, or Markdown to appear in Google Search (including its generative AI capabilities), as Google Search itself doesn't use them. Note that Google may discover, crawl, and index many kinds of files in addition to HTML on a website: this doesn't mean that”

D04 · Optimizing your website for generative AI features on Google Search · Mythbusting generative AI search: what you don't need to do

QUESTION 055 · D04

Must we split every article into short chunks for AI?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

No. Google can understand several topics within one page and select relevant material. I would choose sections and length for readers rather than comply with an invented AI chunk size.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“"Chunking" content: There's no requirement to break your content into tiny pieces for AI to better understand it. Google systems are able to understand the nuance of multiple topics on a page and show the relevant piece to users. However, sometimes shorter (or longer!) pages can work well depending on your audience and subject matter. There's no ideal page length, and in the end, make pages for your audience, not just for generative AI search.”

D04 · Optimizing your website for generative AI features on Google Search · Mythbusting generative AI search: what you don't need to do

QUESTION 056 · D04

Is there a special schema required for AI Overviews?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

No. The guide says structured data is not required for generative AI search and there is no special AI schema.org markup. Appropriate standard markup remains useful for rich-result eligibility.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Overfocusing on structured data : Structured data isn't required for generative AI search, and there's no special schema.org markup you need to add. However, it's a good idea to continue using it as part of your overall SEO strategy, as it helps with being eligible for rich results on Google Search.”

D04 · Optimizing your website for generative AI features on Google Search · Mythbusting generative AI search: what you don't need to do

QUESTION 057 · D04

Should we publish hundreds of fan-out query pages?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

Not primarily to manipulate AI responses or rankings. The guide warns this can violate scaled content abuse policy. I would identify genuine audience needs and avoid redundant low-value pages.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE · EXACT EXCERPT

“Focus on what your users want, and avoid overdoing it. While it might be tempting to create separate content for every possible variation of how people might search (for example, by focusing on other queries that people have asked, or fan-out queries), doing so primarily to manipulate rankings or generative AI responses in Google Search violates Google's scaled”

D04 · Optimizing your website for generative AI features on Google Search · Create valuable, non-commodity content for your audience

QUESTION 058 · D04

Does perfect semantic HTML determine AI visibility?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

No. The guide recommends semantic HTML where useful for readability and accessibility, but does not require perfect markup. Crawl access, rendering, actual content, and experience still need attention.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“When it comes to semantic HTML, focus on human readability and don't worry about perfect code: While it's not required to have perfectly semantic HTML (the web in general is not valid HTML, and Google can understand it), it's generally a good idea to try to use semantic HTML when possible, as it helps other types of users, such as screen readers, parse and navigate your web page more easily .”

D04 · Optimizing your website for generative AI features on Google Search · Build and maintain a clear technical structure

QUESTION 059 · D04

How would you help an ecommerce or local business in AI search?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

Maintain useful distinctive site content, technical access, relevant Merchant Center data and Google Business Profile information. Consider optional merchant experiences when they fit the business rather than treating them as required ranking factors.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Where appropriate, generative AI responses can include product listings, product information, and information about local businesses. Using products like Merchant Center (such as Merchant Center feeds) and Google Business Profiles can help your products and services to be visible in both AI responses and other Google Search results. Learn more about how to add and manage your business details on Google Search .”

D04 · [Optimizing your website for generative AI features on Google Search](#) · [Optimize your local business and ecommerce details](#)

QUESTION 060 · D04 Priority practice

How should we measure Google AI visibility today?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

The current guide points to the Generative AI performance report. The linked Search help page documents AI Overviews and AI Mode impressions, with page, country, date, and device breakdowns. I would combine that visibility evidence with separate business outcome measurement.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“To measure how your content is performing in generative AI features on Google Search and Discover, use the Generative AI performance report in Search Console. This can help you get an idea of how people are discovering your content through generative AI features on Google Search.”

D04 · [Optimizing your website for generative AI features on Google Search](#) · [Measure visibility in generative AI features with Search Console](#)

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Impressions: How often URLs from your site appeared in generative AI features in Search and Discover.”

S2 · [Introducing Search Generative AI performance reports in Search Console](#) · [Introduction](#)

QUESTION 061 · D04 Priority practice

Can a site opt out of AI features without using noindex everywhere?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

The linked current Search Console documentation provides a Search generative AI inclusion control. It covers specified AI features and does not act as a ranking or inclusion signal for other parts of Search. Check inheritance and the actual property setting.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE · EXACT EXCERPT

“Meet the Search technical requirements: To be eligible to be shown in generative AI features on Google Search, a page must be indexed and eligible to be shown in Google Search with a snippet, fulfilling the Search technical requirements. In addition to the technical requirements for Search, a site must be included in Search generative AI features in Search Console”

D04 · Optimizing your website for generative AI features on Google Search · Build and maintain a clear technical structure

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE · EXACT EXCERPT

“Search generative AI control”

S3 · Search generative AI control · Search generative AI control

QUESTION 062 · D04

What do AEO and GEO change in your strategy?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

They describe optimization for answer or generative engines, but Google treats optimization for its AI experiences as SEO. I would evaluate the specific claim and platform, rather than accept that a new label requires unsupported tactics.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“AEO” stands for “answer engine optimization” and “GEO” for “generative engine optimization”. These are both terms you may see used to describe work specifically focused on improving visibility in AI search experiences. From Google Search’s perspective, optimizing for generative AI search is optimizing for the search experience, and thus still SEO. If you’re considering third-party “AEO” or “GEO” advice or services, review our”

D04 · Optimizing your website for generative AI features on Google Search · Is SEO still relevant for generative AI search?

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“We recommend carefully evaluating any advice you might be considering implementing against our official SEO guidance, including our guidance on optimizing for generative AI, and making your own informed decisions.”

D09 · Google Search’s guidance on using third-party SEO tools, services, and advice · Evaluate and verify external SEO advice against official Google guidelines

QUESTION 063 · D04

What is an agentic experience in this guide?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

An AI agent performs tasks for a user, such as booking or comparing products. It may inspect screenshots, DOM content, or accessibility structure. Relevant sites can explore agent-friendly practices and emerging protocols without presenting them as guaranteed ranking improvements.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“AI agents are autonomous systems that can perform tasks on behalf of people, such as booking a reservation or comparing product specifications. These agents can take many forms; for example, browser agents may access your website to gather the data they need to complete these tasks, such as analyzing visual renderings (like screenshots), inspecting the DOM structure, and interpreting the accessibility tree.”

[D04 · Optimizing your website for generative AI features on Google Search](#) · [Explore agentic experiences](#)

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“If this is something that's relevant to your business and you have extra time, check out the available agentic experiences and review the guide to agent-friendly website best practices , which gives some insights into how a website can generally prepare for current browser agents. Protocols like Universal Commerce Protocol (UCP) are emerging that will allow Search agents to do more.”

[D04 · Optimizing your website for generative AI features on Google Search](#) · [Explore agentic experiences](#)

Google Search's guidance on using generative AI content on your website

Google last updated: 2026-10-01 · Reviewed 6 October 2026

<https://developers.google.com/search/docs/fundamentals/using-gen-ai-content>

AI can assist research and organization, but publishers remain responsible for accuracy, added value, and policy compliance. Review both visible content and generated metadata before publishing.

Detailed points to revise

- Useful assistance versus scaled abuse
- Generative AI can help research a subject and structure original work. Google does not describe AI assistance as automatically prohibited.
- Generating many pages without value for users can violate scaled content abuse policy. All AI-assisted content must meet Search Essentials and the spam policies.
- The article points to evaluator-guideline sections 4.6.5 for scaled content abuse and 4.6.6 for main content with little or no effort, originality, or added value. These are evaluation criteria, not a first-place ranking recipe; rater judgments do not directly determine rankings.
- Accuracy, quality, relevance, and metadata
- Generative models predict likely word sequences from training data; their output can contain inaccurate claims or hallucinations. The current guide explicitly calls manual fact-checking and review of all AI-generated content critical before publication.
- Check truthfulness and trustworthiness, as well as relevance and overall quality. A grammatically polished output is not necessarily correct or useful.
- Review generated title elements, meta descriptions, structured data, and image alt text too. These can influence or appear in Search; metadata can misrepresent content even when the body is accurate.
- Structured data must satisfy the general guidelines and each applicable search feature's policies. Validate the markup to establish eligibility; validation does not guarantee rich-result display.
- Context and ecommerce-specific requirements
- Explain how content was produced when that helps the audience. Describe the role of automation and include relevant image metadata. The general Search guidance encourages appropriate context rather than declaring one required disclosure format for every page.
- Merchant Center imposes specific rules: AI-generated images require IPTC DigitalSourceType metadata identifying TrainedAlgorithmicMedia. AI-generated product titles and descriptions must be supplied separately and identified as AI-generated.
- Verified detail from the linked Merchant Center help page: use structured_title and structured_description with content and digital_source_type=trained_algorithmic_media for AI-generated text. Preserve applicable embedded source metadata on images. These are feed requirements, not a new schema.org type for ordinary article pages. [S3]
- The article links to Google's AI-content blog FAQ for further explanation.

- Practical publishing workflow (interview application)
- Start from the audience's real question and an original contribution. Use AI for assistance, verify claims against reliable evidence, and obtain appropriate subject review.
- Inspect every affected field, including metadata and product data. Validate structured markup, review the actual page, and disclose processes where readers reasonably need context.
- Keep human oversight and added value proportional to the stakes. Do not sell this workflow as a fixed algorithmic ranking formula.

Complete source section checklist: Focus on accuracy, quality, and relevance · Give users context

QUESTION 064 · D05 **Priority practice**

Does Google ban AI-generated content?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

No. It can assist useful research and structuring original content. The problem is low-value or manipulative production, especially many pages without user value, and failure to meet Search Essentials and spam policies.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Generative AI can be particularly useful when researching a topic, and to add structure to original content. However, using generative AI tools or other similar tools to generate many pages without adding value for users may violate Google's spam policy on scaled content abuse . If you're using generative AI content on your website, make sure your work meets the standards of the Search Essentials and our spam policies .”

D05 · [Google Search's guidance on using generative AI content on your website](#) · [Google Search's guidance on using generative AI content on your website](#)

QUESTION 065 · D05

What is scaled content abuse in this page's context?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

Using AI or similar tools to produce many pages without adding value for users may violate the policy. I would evaluate purpose and actual value rather than assume that changing the production tool removes the risk.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Generative AI can be particularly useful when researching a topic, and to add structure to original content. However, using generative AI tools or other similar tools to generate many pages without adding value for users may violate Google's spam policy on scaled content abuse . If you're using generative AI content on your website, make sure your work meets the standards of the Search Essentials and our spam policies .”

D05 · [Google Search's guidance on using generative AI content on your website](#) · [Google Search's guidance on using generative AI content on your website](#)

QUESTION 066 · D05 Priority practice

Why is manual review important for AI-generated content?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

Models can generate plausible but inaccurate claims. The current guide says to manually fact-check and review all generated material for accuracy and trustworthiness before publication.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE · EXACT EXCERPT

“When creating content for the web, focus on accuracy, quality, and relevance, especially when automatically generating the content. Keep in mind that generative models don't retrieve facts, but predict a likely sequence of words based on their training data. Because of this, generative AI outputs may contain inaccuracies (also known as hallucinations). It is critical”

D05 · [Google Search's guidance on using generative AI content on your website](#) · [Focus on accuracy, quality, and relevance](#)

QUESTION 067 · D05 Priority practice

Which AI-generated fields should be reviewed besides body copy?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

Title elements, meta descriptions, structured data, and image alt text. These fields can be inaccurate or misleading and can appear in search experiences.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE · EXACT EXCERPT

“as hallucinations). It is critical to manually factcheck and review all AI-generated content for accuracy and trustworthiness before publishing. This review also applies to metadata like <title> elements , meta description elements , structured data , and alternate texts for images , which can appear in Search results.”

D05 · [Google Search's guidance on using generative AI content on your website](#) · [Focus on accuracy, quality, and relevance](#)

QUESTION 068 · D05

What should be done with AI-generated structured data?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

Check it against the real page, general structured-data guidelines, and feature-specific policies, then validate the markup. Do not assume generated JSON is accurate because it is syntactically valid.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“For structured data, also ensure compliance with the general guidelines , the specific policies for the individual search features, and validate the markup to ensure eligibility for Search features .”

D05 · Google Search's guidance on using generative AI content on your website · Focus on accuracy, quality, and relevance

QUESTION 069 · D05

What information should users get about AI-assisted production?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

Context that helps them understand how and why automation was used, where reasonably expected. The general guide recommends explaining the process; Merchant Center has separate explicit labeling and metadata requirements.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Sharing information about how a piece of content was created can help give your readers more context. If you're automatically generating content, consider adding information on how your content was created in a way that makes sense for your audience, such as by providing more background information on how automation was used and adding image metadata .”

D05 · Google Search's guidance on using generative AI content on your website · Give users context

QUESTION 070 · D05

What is required for an AI-generated product image in Merchant Center?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

The required IPTC DigitalSourceType metadata must identify the AI origin, including TrainedAlgorithmicMedia. Preserve embedded source metadata rather than stripping it during optimization.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“For ecommerce sites, Google Merchant Center has policies for AI-generated content . In particular, AI-generated images must contain metadata using the IPTC DigitalSourceType TrainedAlgorithmicMedia metadata. AI-generated product data such as title and description attributes must be specified separately and labeled as AI-generated.”

D05 · Google Search's guidance on using generative AI content on your website · Give users context

QUESTION 071 · D05 Priority practice

How are AI-generated product titles and descriptions supplied?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

The article says to identify them separately. The linked Merchant Center policy specifies structured_title and structured_description, using digital_source_type=trained_algorithmic_media and the generated content.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“For ecommerce sites, Google Merchant Center has policies for AI-generated content . In particular, AI-generated images must contain metadata using the IPTC DigitalSourceType TrainedAlgorithmicMedia metadata. AI-generated product data such as title and description attributes must be specified separately and labeled as AI-generated.”

D05 · Google Search's guidance on using generative AI content on your website · Give users context

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE · EXACT EXCERPT

“structured_title”

S6 · AI-generated content · Title

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE · EXACT EXCERPT

“structured_description”

S6 · AI-generated content · Description

QUESTION 072 · D05

Do the quality rater guidelines tell us how to rank first?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

No. They help raters evaluate the quality of Search systems. The AI-content page specifically cautions that ratings do not directly influence ranking and the guidelines are not a first-place recipe.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“You might find value in looking at the Search Quality Raters guidelines on how to evaluate both scaled content abuse (section 4.6.5) and main content created with little to no effort, little to no originality, and little to no added value (section 4.6.6). These guidelines are not a guide to ranking first in Google; they're used by our search raters to help evaluate the performance of our various search ranking systems , and their ratings don't directly influence ranking.”

D05 · [Google Search's guidance on using generative AI content on your website](#) · [Google Search's guidance on using generative AI content on your website](#)

Maintaining your website's SEO

Google last updated: 2025-12-18 · Reviewed 6 October 2026

<https://developers.google.com/search/docs/fundamentals/get-started>

Maintain SEO as the site changes: manage crawl and indexing controls, resources, duplicates, localization, migrations, search appearance, and the overall user experience. The current on-page title is Maintaining your website's SEO.

Detailed points to revise

- Crawl and index controls, resources, and duplicates
- Understand the crawl/index/serving pipeline before diagnosing problems. Learn how canonicals affect crawling and indexing.
- Pages and essential resources must be accessible to an anonymous visitor and not blocked where Google needs them. The guide directs readers to URL Inspection for blocked resources and rendering checks; not every inaccessible item is visible in aggregate reporting.
- robots.txt prevents crawling; it is not a reliable method of keeping a web page out of the index. Use noindex for index exclusion with crawling allowed, or require login for private material.
- The article recommends avoiding unnecessary crawling of duplicates or unimportant resources when they create load. Do not block CSS or scripts needed to understand an important page. Separate resource access, canonical consolidation, and privacy objectives.
- Sitemaps and international sites
- Sitemaps communicate important URLs and support discovery, especially for changing content, media, and pages not easily discovered through links. Google may crawl URLs outside the sitemap.
- Specific linked-guide clarification: Google ignores sitemap priority and changefreq values. It can use a lastmod value when consistently accurate and representative of a significant update. The general article's mention of update frequency is not proof that changefreq controls scheduling. [S4]
- For multilingual or multiregional content, consult the specific guidance and use hreflang to communicate alternate language/locality versions. Locale-adaptive pages can be affected by the location from which Googlebot accesses them.
- URL and whole-site migrations
- For a permanent single-page move, implement a 301 redirect. For a temporary move, the article gives 302. Match the response to the actual intent rather than treating all redirects identically.
- A removed page can use a helpful custom error page, but return a real HTTP 404. An error-like page returning a success response can be a soft 404.
- For a whole-site move, implement required 301 redirects and sitemap changes and tell Google about the move using the appropriate migration process. The guide links to the full procedure; it does not promise instant transfer or unchanged traffic.
- Every additional crawl/index practice named on the page

- Make links crawlable. The broad article suggests nofollow for paid, login-restricted, or untrusted links. More specific current guidance prefers sponsored for paid placements and ugc for user contributions; nofollow remains acceptable for paid links and when other values do not apply. [S5]
- Very large or rapidly changing sites can need crawl-budget management. Use important and updated sitemap URLs and appropriate blocks for content you do not want crawled.
- The linked current crawl-budget guide describes capacity and demand and says its scale examples are rough, not hard thresholds. It includes roughly one million pages changing weekly, 10,000+ changing daily, or many discovered-but-unindexed URLs. Small sites already crawled promptly usually need routine sitemap and indexing checks. [S6]
- Follow JavaScript SEO recommendations. For multipage articles, provide prominent crawlable next/previous links.
- For infinite scrolling, supply a crawlable paginated alternative. Do not assume the crawler scrolls and clicks exactly like a visitor.
- Block state-changing action URLs, such as posting comments, registering accounts, or adding to carts, from crawling with appropriate robots.txt rules.
- Review Google's indexable file types. If crawling genuinely overloads the site, consult current crawl-rate guidance; this should be uncommon.
- Migrate HTTP sites to HTTPS for user and publisher security.
- Helping Google understand content
- Put essential information in text rather than relying solely on graphics. Google can process many file types, but text is the safest way to communicate key information.
- Appropriate structured data can clarify meaning and make pages eligible for rich results. Use relevant types and follow the developer guidelines.
- The page mentions hand-authored markup, Structured Data Markup Helper, and Data Highlighter. It warns that highlighting can break after layout changes. These are options mentioned in the source, not a guarantee that every legacy interface will be available in every account.
- Search Essentials and every content-specific category
- Follow Search Essentials: some items are recommendations, while violations of applicable requirements or policies can lead to index removal. Do not describe every best practice as mandatory.
- Video: follow video-specific crawling, discovery, and appearance guidance.
- Images: follow image guidance and provide applicable metadata on the host page. The article specifically mentions a robots.txt Disallow rule to stop image indexing; distinguish this image-specific advice from web-page noindex behavior.
- Children's content: the page directs readers to child-directed tagging and its linked COPPA guidance. This is the source's SEO/documentation pointer, not a complete legal-compliance checklist.
- Adult content: appropriate tagging can support SafeSearch filtering.
- News: consult Publisher Center documentation, provide a News sitemap, prevent abuse, review flexible sampling, mark subscription/paywalled content while enabling intended crawling, and use snippet/image controls as needed.
- The page also mentions AMP and Web Stories as formats to consider. It does not make either a requirement for ranking or for all news publishers.
- Experience, mobile, appearance, and Search Console
- The page describes good experience as a priority and refers to it as a ranking consideration. Its helpful-content companion stresses evaluating the whole experience rather than only one or two

metrics.

- Use HTTPS; HTTP can be marked not secure in Chrome. Review performance using the Core Web Vitals report for site-level information and PageSpeed Insights for individual-page diagnostics. The article also mentions web.dev and AMP.
- Mobile usability matters; Google uses a mobile crawler as the default for websites. Do not treat a strong desktop view as sufficient proof of what Google sees.
- Explore suitable supported search features, provide a favicon and article date where applicable, improve title links and snippets, and use available controls when limiting snippet length or image/text previews is desired.
- Use Search Console's reports to monitor and improve Search performance. The article links to the reporting guidance rather than prescribing one metric for every business.

Complete source section checklist: Control how Google crawls and indexes your site · Duplicate content · Resources · Robots.txt · Sitemaps · Internationalized or multi-lingual sites · Migrating a page or a site · Migrating a single URL · Migrating a site · Follow crawling and indexing best practices · Help Google understand your site · Follow our guidelines · Content-specific guidelines · Manage the user experience · Mobile considerations · Control your search appearance · Using Search Console

QUESTION 073 · D06 Priority practice

What is the difference between robots.txt and noindex?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

robots.txt controls crawling. noindex controls indexing when Google can fetch and process it. Blocking the URL first can prevent Google from seeing its noindex instruction; private information should use access restrictions.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“To block Google from finding your page, restrict access to your content to logged in users (for example, use a login page or password-protect your page).”

D07 · Get started with Search: a developer's guide · Control what content Google sees

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“To block Googlebot from crawling your page, create a robots.txt . A robots.txt is not a mechanism for keeping a web page out of Google. To keep a web page out of Google, use the noindex robots rules, or password-protect your page.”

D07 · Get started with Search: a developer's guide · Control what content Google sees

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“To block Google from indexing your page but still allow crawling, add a noindex tag . Combining multiple crawling and indexing rules might cause some rules to counteract other rules. Learn how to configure these rules properly by reading Combining crawling with indexing / serving rules .”

D07 · Get started with Search: a developer's guide · Control what content Google sees

QUESTION 074 · D06

Can I block required CSS to save crawl budget?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

Not if Google needs it to render and understand important pages. The guide explicitly requires access to important resources. Target redundant or unnecessary crawl requests after diagnosing the actual problem.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE · EXACT EXCERPT

“Be sure that any resources (images, CSS files, and so on) or pages that Google is meant to crawl are accessible to Google; that is, they are not blocked by any robots.txt rules and are accessible to an anonymous user. Inaccessible pages will not appear in the Page Indexing report, and the URL Inspection tool will show them as not crawled. Blocked resources are shown”

D06 · Maintaining your website's SEO · Resources

QUESTION 075 · D06 Priority practice

Does sitemap changefreq tell Google how often to crawl?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

The maintenance page mentions update information, but the specific sitemap guide says Google ignores changefreq and priority. Accurate lastmod can be used for significant updates. I would rely on that more precise current guidance.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Google ignores <priority> and <changefreq> values.”

D15 · Build and submit a sitemap · Additional notes about XML sitemaps

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

```
<?xml version="1.0" encoding="UTF-8"?> <urlset xmlns="http://www.sitemaps.org/schemas/sitemap/0.9">
<url> <loc>https://www.example.com/foo.html</loc> <lastmod>2022-06-04</lastmod> </url> </urlset>
```

D15 · Build and submit a sitemap · XML sitemap

QUESTION 076 · D06 Priority practice

How do you choose 301 versus 302?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

In this guide, 301 is for a permanent move and 302 is for a temporary one. I match the response to whether users and search engines should treat the new location as lasting.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“If you move a page permanently to another location, don't forget to implement 301 redirects for your page . If the move is only temporary for some reason, return 302 instead to tell Google to continue to crawl your page.”

D06 · Maintaining your website's SEO · Migrating a single URL

QUESTION 077 · D06

What is a soft 404?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

An error-like or missing-content page that does not return the appropriate missing-page status is a typical example. A useful custom error design should still return an actual 404 for a removed page.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“When a user requests a page that has been removed, you can create a custom 404 page to provide a better experience. Just be sure that when a user requests a page that is no longer there, you return a true 404 error, not a soft 404 .”

D06 · Maintaining your website's SEO · Migrating a single URL

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“soft 404 pages : Return a 404 code when a page no longer exists.”

D22 · Troubleshoot Google Search crawling errors · Hide URLs that you don't want in search results

QUESTION 078 · D06 Priority practice

What are the main SEO steps for moving an entire site?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

Implement the necessary permanent redirects and sitemap updates, then follow Google's site-move process to notify it and support recrawling and forwarding signals. Operationally, I also validate mappings and monitor results; those are implementation steps, not a promise of zero volatility.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“If you're migrating an entire site, implement all the 301 and sitemap changes you need, then tell Google about the move so that we can start crawling the new site and forwarding your signals to the new site. Learn how to migrate your site.”

D06 · Maintaining your website's SEO · Migrating a site

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Prepare a URL mapping from the current URLs to their corresponding new format.”

D48 · How to move a site · Overview

QUESTION 079 · D06

How should an infinite-scroll site be made discoverable?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

Provide a crawlable paginated version and links to its parts. Do not rely solely on scroll-triggered requests that a crawler may not perform.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Infinite scroll pages : Google can have trouble scrolling through infinite scroll pages; provide a paginated version if you want the page to be crawled. Learn more about search-friendly infinite scroll pages.”

D06 · Maintaining your website's SEO · Follow crawling and indexing best practices

QUESTION 080 · D06

Is rel=next/prev required for multipage articles in this page?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

The article's explicit requirement is prominent crawlable next and previous links. I would not invent an extra indexing requirement from that wording.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Multi-page articles : If you have an article broken into several pages, be sure that there are prominent next and previous links for users to click (and that these are crawlable links). That's all you need for the page set to be crawled by Google.”

D06 · Maintaining your website's SEO · Follow crawling and indexing best practices

QUESTION 081 · D06 Priority practice

When should crawl budget become a priority?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

When site scale, rapid change, or crawl evidence shows important content is not being processed promptly. The current linked guide gives rough scale examples and recommends simpler routine checks for sites already crawled quickly.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Managing your crawl budget : If your site is particularly large (hundreds of millions of pages that change periodically, or perhaps tens of millions of pages that change frequently), Google might not be able to crawl your entire site as often as you'd like, so you might need to point Google to the most important pages on your site. The best mechanism for doing so at present is to list your most recently updated or most important pages in your sitemaps, and hiding your less important pages using robots.txt rules.”

D06 · Maintaining your website's SEO · Follow crawling and indexing best practices

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Large sites (1 million+ unique pages) with content that changes moderately often (once a week)”

S7 · Optimize your crawl budget · Who this guide is for

QUESTION 082 · D06

How would you handle multiple language versions?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

Use the appropriate multilingual/multiregional setup and hreflang annotations. Also inspect locale-adaptive responses because crawler location can determine the content Google receives.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Use hreflang to tell Google about different language variations of pages on your site.”

D06 · Maintaining your website's SEO · Internationalized or multi-lingual sites

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“If your site adapts the content of its pages based on the locale of the request, read how this can affect Google's crawl of your site .”

D06 · Maintaining your website's SEO · Internationalized or multi-lingual sites

QUESTION 083 · D06

Which ecommerce action URLs should not be crawled?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

State-changing URLs such as adding to carts or creating accounts. The maintenance guide recommends appropriate robots.txt blocks for such URLs, rather than exposing them as ordinary discoverable content.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Block access to URLs that change state, such as posting comments, creating accounts, adding items to a cart, and so on. Use robots.txt to block these URLs.”

D06 · Maintaining your website's SEO · Follow crawling and indexing best practices

QUESTION 084 · D06 Priority practice

Does valid structured data guarantee a rich result?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

No. It supports understanding and eligibility for appropriate features. It must comply with general and feature-specific rules, and display is not guaranteed.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Important: Google does not guarantee that your structured data will show up in search results, even if your page is marked up correctly according to the Rich Results Test . Here are some common reasons why:”

D83 · General structured data guidelines · General structured data guidelines

QUESTION 085 · D06

Which content-specific areas does this guide cover?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

Video, images, children's content, adult content, and news. News includes sitemaps, abuse prevention, paywalls, flexible sampling, snippet controls, and optional formats such as AMP or Web Stories.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Video : Be sure to follow our video best practices to enable Google to find, crawl, and show results for videos hosted on your site.”

D06 · Maintaining your website's SEO · Content-specific guidelines

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Images : Follow our image best practices to get your images to appear in Search. You can show additional information about your image in Google Images by providing image metadata on the image host page. To block an image from being indexed, use a robots.txt Disallow rule .”

D06 · Maintaining your website's SEO · Content-specific guidelines

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“For children: If your content is specifically for children, tag your pages or site as child-directed in order to comply with the Children's Online Privacy Protection Act (COPPA).”

D06 · Maintaining your website's SEO · Content-specific guidelines

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Adult sites : If your site (or specific pages) contain adult-only content, you might consider tagging it as adult content , which will filter it in SafeSearch results.”

D06 · Maintaining your website's SEO · Content-specific guidelines

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE · EXACT EXCERPT

“News: If you run a news site, here are some important considerations: If you have news content, be sure to read the Google Publisher Center help documentation . In addition, create a News sitemap to help Google discover content more quickly. Be sure to prevent abuse on your site. If you want to provide a limited number of views to visitors without a subscription or”

D06 · Maintaining your website's SEO · Content-specific guidelines

QUESTION 086 · D06

What is the difference between the Core Web Vitals report and PageSpeed Insights here?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

The guide points to Core Web Vitals for site-wide performance information and PageSpeed Insights for inspecting individual pages. It does not say one perfect score guarantees rankings.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“A fast page usually beats a slow page in user satisfaction. You can use the Core Web Vitals report to see your site-wide performance numbers, or PageSpeed Insights to test performance for individual pages. You can learn more about building fast pages on the web.dev site . Also consider using AMP for fast pages.”

D06 · Maintaining your website's SEO · Manage the user experience

QUESTION 087 · D06

How can we influence more than just the blue title link?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

Implement relevant supported search features, an appropriate favicon and article dates, good titles and snippets, and applicable structured data. Use preview controls when there is a business reason to limit text or images.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Google provides many kinds of search result features and experiences in Google Search , including review stars and special result types for specific types of information such as events or recipes. See which ones are appropriate for your site and consider implementing them. You can provide a favicon to show in search results for your site. You can also provide an article date to appear in search results.”

D06 · Maintaining your website's SEO · Control your search appearance

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Be sure to read the articles on how to help Google provide good titles links and snippets . You can also restrict the snippet length, or omit it entirely if you wish. See how to use meta tags to limit text or image use when generating search result snippets .”

D06 · Maintaining your website's SEO · Control your search appearance

Get started with Search: a developer's guide

Google last updated: 2025-12-10 · Reviewed 6 October 2026

<https://developers.google.com/search/docs/fundamentals/get-started-developers>

Search-friendly development means discoverable URLs, usable crawlable links, accessible text in the DOM, correct rendering, clear indexing controls, and accurate metadata. Inspect Google's view instead of assuming it matches the browser.

Detailed points to revise

- Inspect Google, not just the human browser
- Developer work should support relevant discovery while keeping the website secure, fast, accessible, and usable on all devices.
- Use URL Inspection or Rich Results Test to understand Google's view. The article illustrates a browser displaying images that Google misses because of an unsupported JavaScript feature.
- Googlebot discovers new and updated pages, but what a human sees does not prove the crawler has the same content or resources.
- Links, sitemaps, and app URLs
- Googlebot navigates by fetching and parsing links, sitemaps, and redirects. The page emphasizes that it should not depend on prior browsing context to understand the requested URL.
- Use crawlable elements and ensure every important page is reachable from another findable page. Link text, or alt text for an image link, should describe the destination.
- Submit a sitemap describing important pages, media, files, and their relationships.
- A single-page JavaScript application still needs a URL for each screen or piece of individual content. A browser-only state without a discoverable URL is insufficient as a search destination.
- JavaScript, updates, and error evidence
- Google executes JavaScript, but crawlers have differences and limitations in access and rendering. Follow the JavaScript SEO and troubleshooting guidance.
- For new or changed content, submit sitemaps and use available recrawl requests. If indexing remains problematic, inspect server logs for errors.
- These are ways to help Google discover and reprocess content, not a guarantee of indexing or immediate ranking.
- Words, titles, descriptions, semantic HTML, and the DOM
- Express important visual information in text. The article's product-category example shows why a grid of shirt images needs explanatory text rather than pictures alone.
- Give each page a descriptive title and meta description that explain relevance. Unique accurate metadata supports useful search presentation.
- Prefer semantic HTML for substantive content. The article notes that Google can index HTML, PDFs, images, and videos, while plugin-dependent material and canvas-rendered content are not indexed as ordinary page text.
- Make meaningful text accessible in the DOM. Content inserted only through the CSS content property is not part of the DOM and is ignored by Google Search in the article's current wording.

Decorative CSS text is fine; critical facts should be actual page content.

- Do not turn the warning into the broader false claim that Google never processes video or image information; the other guides explicitly explain that media is analyzed. The practical requirement here is a reliable textual representation of important meaning.
- Alternate versions and visibility controls
- Google does not automatically know every mobile/desktop or international relationship. Consolidate duplicate URLs, identify localized versions, and make any applicable AMP alternatives discoverable.
- Login or password protection restricts access. robots.txt blocks crawling. A noindex directive, with crawling allowed, prevents indexing.
- Multiple controls can conflict. If Google cannot crawl a page, it may not see the noindex directive in that page. Choose coherent controls for the objective.
- If intended content is missing from Search, use URL Inspection to check access, review robots.txt for unintentional blocks, and inspect HTML for noindex directives.
- Rich results
- Structured data provides explicit clues to page meaning and can support rich search appearances with styling, images, or interactive features. Explore the supported-feature gallery and choose an appropriate type.
- Eligibility requires suitable content and compliant implementation; neither adding markup nor passing a test guarantees display.

Complete source section checklist: Find out how Google sees your site · Check your links · Check how you're using JavaScript · Keep Google updated when content changes · Don't forget about the words on the page · Tell Google about other versions of your content · Control what content Google sees · Enable rich results for your site

QUESTION 088 · D07 Priority practice

Why can my browser show content that Google misses?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

The browser may use unsupported features, prior state, authentication, or resources Google cannot access. I would inspect the rendered Google view and resource access with URL Inspection or Rich Results Test.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“To get started, test your site in the URL inspection tool or Rich Results Test to see how Google sees your site. Googlebot is Google's web crawling bot that discovers new and updated pages for the Google index. For more information about the process, go to How Google Search Works .”

D07 · [Get started with Search: a developer's guide](#) · [Find out how Google sees your site](#)

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“You may be surprised to find that Google doesn't always see everything that you see in the browser. In the following example, Google doesn't know there are images on this page because the page uses a JavaScript feature that isn't supported by Google.”

D07 · [Get started with Search: a developer's guide](#) · [Find out how Google sees your site](#)

QUESTION 089 · D07 Priority practice

What makes a navigation link search-friendly?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

A crawlable anchor with a resolvable destination and descriptive text, or relevant alt text for an image link. Important pages should be reachable from another findable page.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Use <a> elements that Google can crawl . Ensure that all pages on the site can be reached by a link from another findable page. Make sure the referring link includes either text or, for images, an alt attribute, that is relevant to the target page.”

D07 · [Get started with Search: a developer's guide](#) · [Check your links](#)

QUESTION 090 · D07 Priority practice

What does a single-page app need for SEO?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

Individual content or screens need their own URLs, with discoverable links and reliably accessible rendered content. One HTML shell does not remove the requirement to address each meaningful search destination.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“For JavaScript apps that have only one HTML page, make sure that each screen or piece of individual content has a URL.”

D07 · [Get started with Search: a developer's guide](#) · [Check your links](#)

QUESTION 091 · D07

Google can execute JavaScript, so why test rendering?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

Execution has limitations and does not prove that scripts, resources, or browser APIs expose all essential content. Testing reveals the actual output Google receives.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“While Google does run JavaScript, there are some differences and limitations that you need to account for when designing your pages and applications to accommodate how crawlers access and render your content. Learn more about the basics of JavaScript SEO or how to fix Search-related JavaScript problems.”

D07 · Get started with Search: a developer's guide · Check how you're using JavaScript

QUESTION 092 · D07

How can developers help Google notice updates?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

Maintain and submit sitemaps and use available recrawl requests. If processing fails, inspect server logs and access errors. These assist discovery and reprocessing rather than guarantee rankings.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Submit sitemaps.”

D07 · Get started with Search: a developer's guide · Keep Google updated when content changes

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Ask Google to recrawl your URLs.”

D07 · Get started with Search: a developer's guide · Keep Google updated when content changes

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“If you're still having trouble getting your page indexed, check your server logs for errors.”

D07 · Get started with Search: a developer's guide · Keep Google updated when content changes

QUESTION 093 · D07

Why is an image-only product category insufficient?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

It provides little reliable textual explanation of what each item represents. Add relevant textual descriptions and metadata so Google and users can understand the products and page purpose.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Make sure that your visual content is expressed in text form. For example, a product category page that contains a list of images of shirts with no textual context about each image is suboptimal. The product category page should include some textual explanation for each image.”

D07 · Get started with Search: a developer's guide · Don't forget about the words on the page

QUESTION 094 · D07 Priority practice

Can important text be added only through CSS content?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

The guide says that CSS-generated content is not in the DOM and is ignored by Google Search. Use DOM-accessible text for substantive information; reserve CSS-generated text for decoration.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Make sure your text content is accessible in the DOM. For example, content that is added via the CSS content property is not part of the DOM and Google Search ignores it at the moment. It's fine to use the content property for decorative content; Google Search may not index this content.”

D07 · Get started with Search: a developer's guide · Don't forget about the words on the page

QUESTION 095 · D07

Would drawing all important copy into a canvas be safe for SEO?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

The guide says canvas-rendered content is not indexed as ordinary page content. Provide accessible semantic HTML text representing the important information.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Use semantic HTML . While Google indexes HTML, PDF content, images, and videos, it doesn't index content that requires plugins (for example, Java or Silverlight) or content that is rendered in a canvas. Instead of using a plugin, use semantic HTML markup for your content whenever possible.”

D07 · Get started with Search: a developer's guide · Don't forget about the words on the page

QUESTION 096 · D07

How do we tell Google about international or duplicate versions?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

Consolidate duplicate URLs and provide the appropriate localized-version annotations. If AMP alternatives are used, make them discoverable. Do not assume Google automatically understands every version relationship.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Google doesn't automatically know that there are multiple versions of your site or content. For example, a mobile and desktop version, or international versions of your site. To make sure that Google serves the right version to users, you can:”

D07 · Get started with Search: a developer's guide · Tell Google about other versions of your content

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Consolidate duplicate URLs .”

D07 · Get started with Search: a developer's guide · Tell Google about other versions of your content

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Tell Google about localized versions of your site .”

D07 · Get started with Search: a developer's guide · Tell Google about other versions of your content

QUESTION 097 · D07 Priority practice

Why might disallow plus noindex fail to remove a page?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

A disallow rule can stop Google from fetching the page and seeing its noindex directive. Use a coherent method: allow crawling for noindex, or require authentication for private content.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“To block Googlebot from crawling your page, create a robots.txt . A robots.txt is not a mechanism for keeping a web page out of Google. To keep a web page out of Google, use the noindex robots rules, or password-protect your page.”

D07 · Get started with Search: a developer's guide · Control what content Google sees

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“To block Google from indexing your page but still allow crawling, add a noindex tag . Combining multiple crawling and indexing rules might cause some rules to counteract other rules. Learn how to configure these rules properly by reading Combining crawling with indexing / serving rules .”

D07 · Get started with Search: a developer's guide · Control what content Google sees

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“To prevent only Google web crawlers from indexing a page:”

D40 · Block Search indexing with noindex · <meta> tag

QUESTION 098 · D07

What are the first checks when an intended page is missing?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

Inspect Googlebot access with URL Inspection, review robots.txt for accidental blocking, and look for noindex in HTML. Then investigate the relevant crawling, rendering, indexing, or relevance issue.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Check if Googlebot can access the page with the URL inspection tool .”

D07 · Get started with Search: a developer's guide · Control what content Google sees

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Test your robot.txt file to see if you're unintentionally blocking Googlebot from crawling your site.”

D07 · Get started with Search: a developer's guide · Control what content Google sees

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Check your HTML for noindex rules in meta tags.”

D07 · Get started with Search: a developer's guide · Control what content Google sees

QUESTION 099 · D07

What does adding structured data achieve?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

It can clarify meaning and make a page eligible for supported rich results. It does not guarantee display, and the markup must accurately describe the content and meet the feature's policies.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“A rich result can include styling, images, or other interactive features that can help your site stand out more in Search results. You can help Google understand your page better and show rich results for it in Search by providing explicit clues about the meaning of a page with structured data on the page . If you're not sure where to start, explore our gallery of available features .”

[D07](#) · [Get started with Search: a developer's guide](#) · [Enable rich results for your site](#)

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Important: Google does not guarantee that your structured data will show up in search results, even if your page is marked up correctly according to the Rich Results Test . Here are some common reasons why:”

[D83](#) · [General structured data guidelines](#) · [General structured data guidelines](#)

Do you need an SEO?

Google last updated: 2026-06-05 • Reviewed 6 October 2026

<https://developers.google.com/search/docs/fundamentals/do-i-need-seo>

A credible SEO understands the business, explains recommendations, follows Google's policies, gives realistic expectations, and measures useful outcomes. Google provides questions employers may directly reuse in your interview.

Detailed points to revise

- Services, benefits, and risk
- Hiring an SEO can improve visibility and save time, but irresponsible work can harm a website and its reputation. Assess both potential benefits and damage.
- The listed services are content or structure review; technical advice on hosting, redirects, error pages, and JavaScript; content development; online business-development campaigns; keyword research; SEO training; market/geographic expertise; and optimization for generative AI.
- Google advertising does not affect organic presence. Organic inclusion costs nothing, and Google does not accept payment for inclusion or ranking. Search Console, the official blog, and the forum are available information sources.
- A small local business can often handle much of the work itself. Knowing the Starter Guide also helps a client evaluate a hired professional's recommendations.
- Timing and all eight questions Google tells clients to ask
- Engage an SEO early in a redesign or new-site launch to design search-friendly foundations. An existing site can also benefit.
- Ask for examples of earlier work and success stories.
- Ask whether the candidate follows Search Essentials, formerly called the Webmaster Guidelines.
- Ask about expected results, timing, and how success will be measured.
- Ask about experience in the client's industry.
- Ask about experience in its country or city.
- Ask about international-site experience.
- Ask how long the SEO has been in business.
- Ask how communication will work, whether all changes will be shared, and whether recommendations and reasoning will be explained in detail.
- Business curiosity, references, audit access, and evaluation
- A good SEO should ask what makes the business distinctive, who its competitors are, how Search can help, and how customers currently discover it. Lack of interest in the business is a reason to look elsewhere.
- Check references for usefulness, ease of collaboration, and positive results.
- For an initial audit, carefully understand the work and grant only read access to Search Console, not write access. The audit should provide realistic improvement estimates and estimated effort.

- A first-place guarantee is a reason to reject a provider. Tools have no access to Google's internal ranking data and are not evaluated or endorsed by Google.
- Before significant changes based on a tool audit, compare recommendations with official guidance and decide critically. Ask for supporting Google documentation, alignment of AI/AEO/GEO advice, and appropriate tools.
- Every warning sign and the publisher's responsibility
- Be skeptical of unsolicited SEO emails, including claims that a site is absent from many engines or directories.
- No provider can guarantee number one, claim a privileged relationship that buys placement, or offer meaningful priority submission to Google.
- Reject secrecy and unexplained changes. Ask for clear descriptions; deceptive content can remove a site from the index, and the site owner remains responsible for a hired company's actions.
- If a provider has server/FTP access, it should explain all changes. Transparency matters for technical work as well as content.
- You should not have to link to the SEO as a condition of service. Link-popularity schemes and submission to thousands of search engines are warning signs and typically do not create worthwhile results.
- Unethical aggressive techniques can reduce visibility or lead to index removal under Google's spam policies.
- Reporting issues and interview preparation
- The page provides routes for reporting suspected deceptive services: the FTC for US complaints and econsumer.gov for complaints involving companies in other countries. These are source references, not a recommendation about a particular case.
- Prepare honest examples from your five to six years of work. For each, explain the business problem, baseline, intervention, result, timeframe, and limitations. Those presentation elements are interview coaching, not a Google-mandated report format.
- Do not invent success metrics, clients, or expertise. If a sector or country is new to you, explain the transferable process and how you would learn its constraints.

Complete source section checklist: Deciding on whether you need an SEO · Things to consider when hiring an SEO · Reporting issues

QUESTION 100 · D08

What SEO services can you provide?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

Match the role to truthful experience: technical and structural audits, content strategy and development, keyword research, developer collaboration, measurement, training, and relevant market expertise. Google's list now also includes generative AI optimization.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

"Review of your site content or structure"

D08 · Do you need an SEO? · Do you need an SEO?

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Technical advice on website development: for example, hosting, redirects, error pages, use of JavaScript”

D08 · Do you need an SEO? · Do you need an SEO?

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Content development”

D08 · Do you need an SEO? · Do you need an SEO?

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Keyword research”

D08 · Do you need an SEO? · Do you need an SEO?

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“SEO training”

D08 · Do you need an SEO? · Do you need an SEO?

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Expertise in specific markets and geographies”

D08 · Do you need an SEO? · Do you need an SEO?

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Optimizing for generative AI”

D08 · Do you need an SEO? · Do you need an SEO?

QUESTION 101 · D08

Priority practice

Can you show previous work and success stories?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

Prepare a real example with the original problem, baseline, actions, measurable outcome, timeframe, and your contribution. Explain uncertainty and avoid assigning all business growth to SEO without evidence.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE · EXACT EXCERPT

“Interview your potential SEO. Some useful questions to ask an SEO include: Can you show me examples of your previous work and share some success stories? Do you follow the Google Search Essentials (previously known as Webmaster Guidelines)? What kind of results do you expect to see, and in what timeframe? How do you”

D08 · Do you need an SEO? · Things to consider when hiring an SEO

QUESTION 102 · D08

Do you follow Google's Webmaster Guidelines?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

I follow the current Google Search Essentials, the newer name used in the guide, and relevant technical and spam guidance. I distinguish required policies from optional best practices and validate recommendations against the actual site.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE · EXACT EXCERPT

“SEO. Some useful questions to ask an SEO include: Can you show me examples of your previous work and share some success stories? Do you follow the Google Search Essentials (previously known as Webmaster Guidelines)? What kind of results do you expect to see, and in what timeframe? How do you measure your success? What's your experience in my industry? What's your experience in my”

D08 · Do you need an SEO? · Things to consider when hiring an SEO

QUESTION 103 · D08 Priority practice

What results can we expect, when, and how will you measure them?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

Start with the business objective and current constraints, then set realistic hypotheses and measures. The Starter Guide says effects vary from hours to months. I would track relevant search visibility and qualified business outcomes and avoid guaranteeing rank one.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE · EXACT EXCERPT

“of your previous work and share some success stories? Do you follow the Google Search Essentials (previously known as Webmaster Guidelines)? What kind of results do you expect to see, and in what timeframe? How do you measure your success? What's your experience in my industry? What's your experience in my country/city? What's your experience developing international sites? How long have you been”

D08 · Do you need an SEO? · Things to consider when hiring an SEO

QUESTION 104 · D08

What is your experience in our industry or location?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

Use accurate examples of audience needs, competitors, local or regional considerations, and any sector-specific constraints. If direct experience is limited, state that and explain the research and validation process rather than fabricate credentials.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE · EXACT EXCERPT

“(previously known as Webmaster Guidelines)? What kind of results do you expect to see, and in what timeframe? How do you measure your success? What's your experience in my industry? What's your experience in my country/city? What's your experience developing international sites? How long have you been in business? How can I expect to communicate with you? Will you share with me all the changes”

D08 · Do you need an SEO? · Things to consider when hiring an SEO

QUESTION 105 · D08

What is your experience with international SEO?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

Discuss real work with language/regional versions, hreflang, canonicals, discoverable URLs, and locale-dependent content where applicable. Be clear about what you personally implemented and what you collaborated on.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE · EXACT EXCERPT

“to see, and in what timeframe? How do you measure your success? What's your experience in my industry? What's your experience in my country/city? What's your experience developing international sites? How long have you been in business? How can I expect to communicate with you? Will you share with me all the changes you make to my site, and provide detailed information about your recommendations and the reasoning”

D08 · Do you need an SEO? · Things to consider when hiring an SEO

QUESTION 106 · D08

How will you communicate changes and recommendations?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

I would document the problem, evidence, proposed change, expected benefit, implementation requirements, and result. Significant changes should be understandable and reviewable, with clear ownership and an agreed reporting cadence.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE · EXACT EXCERPT

“my industry? What's your experience in my country/city? What's your experience developing international sites? How long have you been in business? How can I expect to communicate with you? Will you share with me all the changes you make to my site, and provide detailed information about your recommendations and the reasoning behind them? See if the SEO is interested in you and your business. If”

D08 · Do you need an SEO? · Things to consider when hiring an SEO

What questions should an SEO ask a new employer or client?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

What distinguishes the business, who the competitors are, how customers find it, and what Search should contribute. I would also clarify the conversion goals and available implementation resources as practical follow-up questions.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE · EXACT EXCERPT

“and the reasoning behind them? See if the SEO is interested in you and your business. If they're not interested, find someone who is. Your SEO should ask questions about what makes your business unique, who your competitors are, how search results can help, and how your customers find you.”

D08 · Do you need an SEO? · Things to consider when hiring an SEO

Why should an initial audit use read-only Search Console access?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

The hiring guide explicitly recommends read access rather than write access at that stage. It supports evidence gathering without granting premature permission to change the property; implementation access can be considered separately later.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE · EXACT EXCERPT

“If your SEO offers to do an SEO audit for you, be sure to carefully consider what's involved and only grant read access to Search Console (at this stage, don't grant them write access). An SEO audit should be about giving you realistic estimates of improvement, and an estimate of the work involved. If they guarantee you that their changes will give you first place in”

D08 · Do you need an SEO? · Things to consider when hiring an SEO

How would you respond to a request for guaranteed number-one rankings?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

Explain that nobody can guarantee that on Google. Commit to sound work, transparent recommendations, realistic estimates, and measurable progress toward the business objective instead.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

"No one can guarantee a #1 ranking on Google. Beware of SEOs that claim to guarantee rankings, allege a "special relationship" with Google, or advertise a "priority submit" to Google."

D08 · Do you need an SEO? · Things to consider when hiring an SEO

QUESTION 110 · D08

What agency red flags does Google list?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

Unsolicited spam, ranking guarantees, special-relationship or priority-submission claims, secret changes, required links to the agency, link schemes, mass search-engine submissions, and unsupported claims of Google-approved tools.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

"Be wary of SEO firms and web consultants or agencies that email you out of the blue. Amazingly, we get these spam emails too: "Dear google.com, I visited your website and noticed that you are not listed in most of the major search engines and directories..." Reserve the same skepticism for unsolicited email about search engines as you do for "burn fat at night" diet pills or requests to help transfer funds from deposed dictators."

D08 · Do you need an SEO? · Things to consider when hiring an SEO

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

"No one can guarantee a #1 ranking on Google. Beware of SEOs that claim to guarantee rankings, allege a "special relationship" with Google, or advertise a "priority submit" to Google."

D08 · Do you need an SEO? · Things to consider when hiring an SEO

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

"Be careful if a company is secretive or won't clearly explain what they intend to do. Ask for explanations if something is unclear. If an SEO creates deceptive or misleading content on your behalf, your site could be removed entirely from Google's index. Ultimately, you are responsible for the actions of any companies you hire, so it's best to be sure you know exactly how they intend to "help" you. If an SEO has FTP access to your server, they should be willing to explain all the changes they are making to your site."

D08 · Do you need an SEO? · Things to consider when hiring an SEO

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

"You should never have to link to an SEO. Avoid SEOs that talk about link popularity schemes or submitting your site to thousands of search engines. These are typically useless exercises that don't affect your ranking in the results of the major search engines—at least, not in a way you would likely consider to be positive."

D08 · Do you need an SEO? · Things to consider when hiring an SEO

Who is responsible if a hired SEO uses deceptive methods?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

Google says the website owner remains responsible for the actions of hired companies. That is why explained changes, documented recommendations, policy alignment, and references matter.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Be careful if a company is secretive or won't clearly explain what they intend to do. Ask for explanations if something is unclear. If an SEO creates deceptive or misleading content on your behalf, your site could be removed entirely from Google's index. Ultimately, you are responsible for the actions of any companies you hire, so it's best to be sure you know exactly how they intend to "help" you. If an SEO has FTP access to your server, they should be willing to explain all the changes they are making to your site.”

D08 · Do you need an SEO? · Things to consider when hiring an SEO

Google Search's guidance on using third-party SEO tools, services, and advice

Google last updated: 2026-06-05 · Reviewed 6 October 2026

<https://developers.google.com/search/docs/fundamentals/third-party-seo>

Tools can improve workflows, but their scores and predictions are not Google's internal ranking data. Evaluate claims against official guidance and use Search Console for first-party evidence.

Detailed points to revise

- Verify advice and identify what kind of claim it is
- The article covers external advice about SEO, listings, and AI experiences, including AEO and GEO.
- Some advice is useful; some misrepresents what Google says or how its systems work. Good advice either identifies itself as an opinion based on data or experience, or supports a Google-specific claim with actual official documentation.
- Compare proposed action with official SEO guidance and the generative AI guide, then make an informed site-specific decision. Citation quality matters: a link to Google is not proof that the cited page supports the exact claim.
- All five example tool/service categories
- Sitemap generation.
- Indexing directives.
- Content described as SEO-optimized.
- Recommendations claiming to improve rankings of existing material.
- AI-experience visibility tools marketed as AEO or GEO.
- These categories are not automatically prohibited. Their value depends on the work they actually do and the truth of their claims.
- Approval claims, internal-data claims, and guarantees
- Google does not evaluate third-party SEO services. Claims that a product is accepted, approved, or endorsed by Google Search should be treated skeptically.
- No third-party SEO tool has access to Google's internal ranking data. A vendor's score or prediction comes from the vendor, not from Google's ranking system.
- Using a tool does not guarantee ranking success. Predictions can fail. Distinguish a useful estimate from a known Google fact.
- Google strongly encourages Search Console, whether or not other tools are used, because it provides key information directly from Google Search.
- Practical evaluation framework (interview application)
- State the claim precisely, inspect its supporting source, and separate an observed tool metric from a proposed cause of ranking changes.
- Confirm the issue on actual pages or in first-party evidence. Estimate user benefit and

implementation cost, then prioritize by the business need.

- Test reasonable hypotheses when appropriate and explain limitations. Third-party research can be informative even when it is not an official rule; label it honestly.
- The guide does not state that every non-Google observation is worthless. It asks for critical evaluation and does not authorize vendors to present their own metrics as Google's.

Complete source section checklist: Evaluate and verify external SEO advice against official Google guidelines · Think critically about using third-party SEO tools and services

QUESTION 112 · D09

Are third-party SEO tools bad or prohibited?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

No. They can help with workflows such as sitemaps, audits, or analysis. The guide asks users to evaluate their claims critically and avoid assuming approval, internal-data access, or guaranteed performance.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Some of these services may be helpful in your work, while others may make claims or imply that what they do is somehow "acceptable" or "approved" by Google Search. Google doesn't evaluate third-party services, so be wary of such claims and those making them. Keep in mind that using a service or tool doesn't guarantee ranking success.”

D09 · Google Search's guidance on using third-party SEO tools, services, and advice · Think critically about using third-party SEO tools and services

QUESTION 113 · D09 Priority practice

Does a tool's SEO score equal a Google ranking score?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

No. Third-party tools do not have Google's internal ranking data. A vendor score is its own assessment and must be interpreted within its definition and limitations.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Some third-party services provide data that some users of those tools misinterpret as somehow being from Google. Third-party tools don't have access to our internal ranking data. They can't guarantee performance. Any predictions are their own and like predictions generally, may not happen.”

D09 · Google Search's guidance on using third-party SEO tools, services, and advice · Think critically about using third-party SEO tools and services

How should you evaluate an influencer's claim that 'Google says' something?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

Find the actual official source and check whether it supports the precise statement. If the claim is based on experiments or experience, label it as such and assess the evidence rather than convert it into an official rule.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“We recommend carefully evaluating any advice you might be considering implementing against our official SEO guidance , including our guidance on optimizing for generative AI , and making your own informed decisions.”

D09 · Google Search's guidance on using third-party SEO tools, services, and advice · Evaluate and verify external SEO advice against official Google guidelines

Can an SEO product be described as Google-approved based on this guide?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

Google says it does not evaluate third-party SEO services and warns against acceptable or approved claims. A vendor's marketing statement is not proof of endorsement.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Some of these services may be helpful in your work, while others may make claims or imply that what they do is somehow "acceptable" or "approved" by Google Search. Google doesn't evaluate third-party services, so be wary of such claims and those making them. Keep in mind that using a service or tool doesn't guarantee ranking success.”

D09 · Google Search's guidance on using third-party SEO tools, services, and advice · Think critically about using third-party SEO tools and services

How would you handle a large automated audit full of warnings?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

Validate the important findings on actual pages and in relevant first-party data, compare proposed fixes with official guidance, and prioritize by user impact and business value. A high warning count is not itself proof of a ranking problem.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“We recommend carefully evaluating any advice you might be considering implementing against our official SEO guidance , including our guidance on optimizing for generative AI , and making your own informed decisions.”

D09 · Google Search's guidance on using third-party SEO tools, services, and advice · Evaluate and verify external SEO advice against official Google guidelines

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Some third-party services provide data that some users of those tools misinterpret as somehow being from Google. Third-party tools don't have access to our internal ranking data. They can't guarantee performance. Any predictions are their own and like predictions generally, may not happen.”

D09 · Google Search's guidance on using third-party SEO tools, services, and advice · Think critically about using third-party SEO tools and services

QUESTION 117 · D09 Priority practice

Why use Search Console even with paid tools?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

It provides first-party Search information directly from Google. Third-party tools can complement it but cannot substitute their own scores for Google's internal data.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“, which provides you with key information and data directly from Google Search itself.”

D09 · Google Search's guidance on using third-party SEO tools, services, and advice · Think critically about using third-party SEO tools and services

QUESTION 118 · D09

What makes external advice credible in this article?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

It either backs Google-specific assertions with official guidance or clearly frames data-based and experience-based conclusions as opinions. Credibility also requires that the evidence supports the action being recommended.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“We recommend carefully evaluating any advice you might be considering implementing against our official SEO guidance , including our guidance on optimizing for generative AI , and making your own informed decisions.”

D09 · Google Search's guidance on using third-party SEO tools, services, and advice · Evaluate and verify external SEO advice against official Google guidelines

QUESTION 119 · D09

How would you evaluate a GEO tool promising guaranteed AI citations?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

Check the specific claim against Google's AI guidance, reject guarantees and alleged internal-system access, and assess whether the tool supports useful actual work. A new acronym does not exempt it from the same evaluation standards.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Some third-party services provide data that some users of those tools misinterpret as somehow being from Google. Third-party tools don't have access to our internal ranking data. They can't guarantee performance. Any predictions are their own and like predictions generally, may not happen.”

D09 · Google Search's guidance on using third-party SEO tools, services, and advice · Think critically about using third-party SEO tools and services

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE · EXACT EXCERPT

“LLMS.txt files and other "special" markup : You don't need to create new machine readable files, AI text files, markup, or Markdown to appear in Google Search (including its generative AI capabilities), as Google Search itself doesn't use them. Note that Google may discover, crawl, and index many kinds of files in addition to HTML on a website: this doesn't mean that”

D04 · Optimizing your website for generative AI features on Google Search · Mythbusting generative AI search: what you don't need to do

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“"Chunking" content: There's no requirement to break your content into tiny pieces for AI to better understand it. Google systems are able to understand the nuance of multiple topics on a page and show the relevant piece to users. However, sometimes shorter (or longer!) pages can work well depending on your audience and subject matter. There's no ideal page length, and in the end, make pages for your audience, not just for generative AI search.”

D04 · Optimizing your website for generative AI features on Google Search · Mythbusting generative AI search: what you don't need to do

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Overfocusing on structured data : Structured data isn't required for generative AI search, and there's no special schema.org markup you need to add. However, it's a good idea to continue using it as part of your overall SEO strategy, as it helps with being eligible for rich results on Google Search.”

D04 · [Optimizing your website for generative AI features on Google Search](#) · [Mythbusting generative AI search: what you don't need to do](#)

Overview of crawling and indexing topics

Google last updated: 2025-12-10 · Reviewed 6 October 2026

<https://developers.google.com/search/docs/crawling-indexing>

Detailed points to revise

- This is a navigation overview, not a detailed technical specification. It explains the scope: controlling how Google finds and parses content, and preventing unwanted crawling.
- Its topic map includes file types, URL structure, sitemaps, recrawl requests, faceted navigation, crawl budget, HTTP/network/DNS errors, and Google crawlers.
- Other areas are robots.txt, canonicalization, mobile sites, AMP, JavaScript, valid metadata, robots directives, crawlable links, and outbound-link qualifications.
- Removal topics distinguish controlling sharing, removing pages and images, and safely redacting information.
- Site-change topics include redirects, migrations, A/B tests, and temporary closures. Detailed claims must come from the corresponding specialist page.

QUESTION 130 · D10

What is the purpose of Google's crawling and indexing section?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

It explains how publishers can control Google's ability to find and parse content for Search and other properties, and how to prevent crawling of specified content.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“The topics in this section describe how you can control Google's ability to find and parse your content in order to show it in Search and other Google properties, as well as how to prevent Google from crawling specific content on your site.”

D10 · Overview of crawling and indexing topics · Overview of crawling and indexing topics

QUESTION 131 · D10

Where would you look for a rule about redirects or robots directives?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

This overview points to the appropriate specialist pages. It is a topic map; consult the relevant detailed guide for requirements and exceptions.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“robots.txt A robots.txt file tells search engine crawlers which pages or files the crawler can or can't request from your site.”

D10 · Overview of crawling and indexing topics · Overview of crawling and indexing topics

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Site moves and changes Redirects and Google Search Site moves Minimize A/B testing impact in Google Search Temporarily pause or disable a website”

D10 · Overview of crawling and indexing topics · Overview of crawling and indexing topics

QUESTION 132 · D10

Does this overview limit crawling issues to robots.txt?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

No. Its crawler-management links also cover recrawl requests, faceted navigation, crawl budget, HTTP status codes, and network or DNS errors.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Crawler management Ask Google to recrawl your URLs Managing crawling of faceted navigation URLs Large site owner's guide to managing your crawl budget How HTTP status codes, and network and DNS errors affect Google Search Google crawlers”

D10 · Overview of crawling and indexing topics · Overview of crawling and indexing topics

File types indexable by Google

Google last updated: 2026-02-03 · Reviewed 6 October 2026

<https://developers.google.com/search/docs/crawling-indexing/indexable-file-types>

Detailed points to revise

- Google can index most text-based files and certain encoded document formats. Content-Type is the principal type signal; extensions or reparsing can help when the header is missing or wrong.
- Flat formats listed: CSV; KML/KMZ; GPX; HTML; SVG; TeX/LaTeX; plain text and common programming-language source code; WML/WAP; and XML.
- Encoded formats listed: PDF, PostScript, EPUB, HWP, Excel, PowerPoint, Word, OpenOffice presentations/spreadsheets/text, and RTF. The full extensions are in the source reference.
- Image formats listed: BMP, GIF, JPEG, PNG, WebP, SVG, AVIF. Video formats include MP4, MOV, WebM and the complete longer list in the reference.
- The list describes supported types, not a promise that every accessible file will be indexed.
- filetype: restricts a search by file type or extension; the page's example searches RTF files containing a specified term.

Complete source section checklist: Supported flat file types · Supported encoded file types · Supported media formats · Search by file type

QUESTION 133 · D11

Can Google index documents other than HTML?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

Yes. The guide lists flat text formats, encoded formats including PDF and Word, and supported media formats. Support for a format is not a guarantee that each file is indexed.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Google can index the content of most text-based files and certain encoded document formats. The file type is determined by the Content-Type HTTP header returned when Google crawls the file, though in some cases Google may use the file extension or re-parse the file using a different parser if the Content-Type header is missing or incorrect.”

D11 · File types indexable by Google · File types indexable by Google

QUESTION 134 · D11

How does Google determine a file's type?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

Primarily from the Content-Type HTTP header returned when crawling. It may use the extension or a different parser when the header is missing or incorrect.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Google can index the content of most text-based files and certain encoded document formats. The file type is determined by the Content-Type HTTP header returned when Google crawls the file, though in some cases Google may use the file extension or re-parse the file using a different parser if the Content-Type header is missing or incorrect.”

D11 · File types indexable by Google · File types indexable by Google

QUESTION 135 · D11

Are EPUB and spreadsheet files indexable formats?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

The current list includes EPUB, Microsoft Excel .xls/.xlsx, and OpenOffice spreadsheets .ods, alongside other supported document formats.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Electronic Publication (.epub)”

D11 · File types indexable by Google · Supported encoded file types

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Microsoft Excel (.xls, .xlsx)”

D11 · File types indexable by Google · Supported encoded file types

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“OpenOffice spreadsheet (.ods)”

D11 · File types indexable by Google · Supported encoded file types

QUESTION 136 · D11

How would you search Google specifically for a document format?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

Use filetype: with the desired type or extension and a search term. The page illustrates filetype:rtf with a topic term.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“You can use the filetype: operator in Google Search to limit results to a specific file type or file extension. For example, filetype:rtf galway will search for RTF files and URLs ending in .rtf whose content contains the term "galway".”

D11 · File types indexable by Google · Search by file type

URL structure best practices for Google Search

Google last updated: 2025-12-10 · Reviewed 6 October 2026

<https://developers.google.com/search/docs/crawling-indexing/url-structure>

Detailed points to revise

- Crawlable URLs follow IETF STD 66. Reserved characters must be percent encoded; non-ASCII characters should be percent encoded in link href values as documented.
- Do not use fragments such as `#/products` to load distinct content; use the History API for JavaScript routing.
- Use standard parameter encoding: `=` between a key and value, `&` between parameters; multiple values can use a compatible separator such as a comma.
- Make URLs intelligible: descriptive readable words, the audience's language or transliteration, and hyphens rather than underscores for word separation.
- Remove unnecessary parameters that do not change the content. Google treats differently cased URLs as distinct; normalize consistently when the server treats them as equivalent.
- Multiregional examples include country-code domains and locale subdirectories.
- URL explosions can arise from additive facets, irrelevant referral/sort parameters, session IDs, infinite calendars, and broken relative links.
- Prefer cookies to session IDs in URLs where possible. The source suggests `nofollow` for links to unrestricted future calendar pages and root-relative URLs to avoid broken parent-relative expansions.
- For problematic `dynamic/search/calendar/filter` spaces, appropriate `robots.txt` blocks may control crawling. They are not a substitute for `noindex` when index exclusion is the objective.

Complete source section checklist: Requirements for a crawlable URL structure · Follow IETF STD 66 · Don't use URL fragments to change content · Use a common encoding for URL parameters · Make it easy to understand your URL structure · Use descriptive URLs · Use your audience's language · Use percent encoding as necessary · Use hyphens to separate words · Use as few parameters as you can · Be aware that URLs are case sensitive · For multi-regional sites · Avoid common issues related to URLs · Additive filtering of a set of items · Irrelevant parameters · Calendar issues · Broken relative links · Fixing crawling-related URL structure problems

QUESTION 137 · D12

Why are hash-based routes a crawling problem?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

Google generally does not support fragments for changing page content. Give distinct content proper URLs and use the History API instead of `#/` routing.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Don't use URL fragments to change content Don't use fragments to change the content of a page, as Google Search generally doesn't support URL fragments. Here's an example of a URL fragment:
<https://example.com/#/potatoes> If you're using JavaScript to change content, use the History API instead.”

D12 · URL structure best practices for Google Search · URL structure best practices for Google Search

QUESTION 138 · D12

Which URL parameter syntax does Google recommend?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

Use = to separate each key-value pair and & to add parameters. Multiple values for the same key can use a separator that does not conflict with the URL standard, such as a comma.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE · EXACT EXCERPT

“Use a common encoding for URL parameters When specifying URL parameters, use the following common encoding: an equal sign (=) to separate key-value pairs and add additional parameters with an ampersand (&). To list multiple values for the same key within a key-value pair, you can use any character that doesn't conflict with IETF STD 66 , such as a comma (,).”

D12 · URL structure best practices for Google Search · URL structure best practices for Google Search

QUESTION 139 · D12

Hyphens or underscores in URLs?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

Google recommends hyphens to separate words because they help identify concepts. This is a URL readability recommendation, not a guaranteed ranking increment.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE · EXACT EXCERPT

“Use hyphens to separate words We recommend separating words in your URLs, when possible. Specifically, we recommend using hyphens (-) instead of underscores (_) to separate words in your URLs, as it helps users and search engines better identify concepts in the URL. For historical reasons, we don't recommend using underscores, as this style”

D12 · URL structure best practices for Google Search · Make it easy to understand your URL structure

QUESTION 140 · D12

Are /APPLE and /apple the same URL to Google?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

No. Google treats them as distinct URLs. If the server treats both as the same content, normalize the case to make that equivalence clearer.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Be aware that URLs are case sensitive Like any other HTTP client following IETF STD 66, Google Search's URL handling is case sensitive (for example, Google treats both /APPLE and /apple as distinct URLs with their own content). If upper and lower case text in a URL is treated the same by your web server, convert all text to the same case so it's easier for Google to determine that URLs reference the same page.”

D12 · URL structure best practices for Google Search · Make it easy to understand your URL structure

QUESTION 141 · D12

What can create an infinite or excessively large crawl space?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

Combinable facets, irrelevant parameters and session IDs, unrestricted calendars, and malformed relative links. The page recommends controlling problematic URL generation and crawling.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE · EXACT EXCERPT

“Additive filtering of a set of items Many sites provide different views of the same set of items or search results, often allowing the user to filter this set using defined criteria (for example: show me hotels on the beach). When filters can be combined”

D12 · URL structure best practices for Google Search · Avoid common issues related to URLs

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Calendar issues A dynamically generated calendar might generate links to future and previous dates with no restrictions on start or end dates. For example: <https://example.com/calendar.php?d=13&m=8&y=2011> If your site has an infinite calendar, add a nofollow attribute to links to dynamically created future calendar pages.”

D12 · URL structure best practices for Google Search · Avoid common issues related to URLs

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Broken relative links Placing a parent-relative link on the wrong page may create infinite spaces if your server doesn't respond with the right HTTP status code for nonexistent pages. For example, a parent-relative link such as `<a href="../../category/stuff">...</a>` on <https://example.com/category/community/070413/html/FAQ.htm> may lead to bogus URLs such as <https://example.com/category/community/category/stuff> . To fix, use root-relative URLs in your links (instead of parent-relative).”

D12 · URL structure best practices for Google Search · Avoid common issues related to URLs

QUESTION 142 · D12

Must URLs be written in English?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

No. The guide recommends the audience's language, with transliterated words when applicable, and appropriate encoding in links.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Use your audience's language Use words in your audience's language in the URL (and, if applicable, transliterated words). For example, if your audience is searching in German, use German words in the URL: <https://example.com/lebensmittel/pfefferminz> Or if your audience is searching in Japanese, use Japanese words in the URL: <https://example.com/ペパーミント>”

D12 · URL structure best practices for Google Search · Make it easy to understand your URL structure

Link best practices for Google

Google last updated: 2025-12-10 · Reviewed 6 October 2026

<https://developers.google.com/search/docs/crawling-indexing/links-crawable>

Detailed points to revise

- A reliably crawlable link is an a element with an href that resolves to an actual web address. Script-event-only elements or anchors without href are unreliable.
- JavaScript-inserted links can be crawlable if their resulting markup meets the same requirements.
- Put visible descriptive anchor text inside the anchor. An empty anchor may fall back to its title attribute; an image link uses the image's alt attribute.
- Test JavaScript-inserted anchor text in rendered HTML with URL Inspection.
- Good text is descriptive, reasonably concise, and relevant to both context and destination. Avoid generic labels, unwieldy phrases, forced keywords, and chains of adjacent links.
- Surrounding words also provide context. Read anchor text alone to check whether it communicates the destination.
- Every important page should be linked from at least one other page on the site; there is no magical ideal count of links per page.
- Trusted external citations can help readers and credibility. Do not add nofollow to every external link. Qualify paid and user-generated links appropriately.

Complete source section checklist: Make your links crawlable · Anchor text placement · Write good anchor text · Internal links: cross-reference your own content · External links: link to other sites

QUESTION 143 · D13 Priority practice

What markup makes a link reliably crawlable?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

An a element with an href resolving to a real URL. Google cannot reliably extract a destination from an anchor without href or another tag that relies on a script event.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Generally, Google can only crawl your link if it's an <a> HTML element (also known as anchor element) with an href attribute. Most links in other formats won't be parsed and extracted by Google's crawlers. Google can't reliably extract URLs from <a> elements that don't have an href attribute or other tags that perform as links because of script events. Here are examples of links that Google can and can't parse:”

D13 · Link best practices for Google · Make your links crawlable

QUESTION 144 · D13

Can dynamically inserted JavaScript links be crawled?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

Yes, if the resulting markup uses crawlable anchor elements and valid href destinations. Check the rendered HTML rather than merely the click behavior in a browser.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Links are also crawlable when you use JavaScript to insert them into a page dynamically as long as it uses the HTML markup shown above.”

D13 · Link best practices for Google · Make your links crawlable

QUESTION 145 · D13

What is good anchor text?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

Descriptive, reasonably concise text relevant to the current page and destination, supported by useful surrounding context. Avoid forced keywords or labels too generic to explain the destination.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Good anchor text is descriptive, reasonably concise, and relevant to the page that it's on and to the page it links to. It provides context for the link, and sets the expectation for your readers. The better your anchor text, the easier it is for people to navigate your site and for Google to understand what the page you're linking to is about.”

D13 · Link best practices for Google · Write good anchor text

QUESTION 146 · D13

What does Google use as anchor text for an image link?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

The img element's alt attribute. If an ordinary anchor is empty, its title attribute can be a fallback; explicit helpful text is the preferred starting point.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“For images as links, Google uses the alt attribute of the img element as anchor text, so be sure to add descriptive alt text to your images :”

D13 · Link best practices for Google · Anchor text placement

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“As a fallback, Google can use the title attribute as anchor text if the <a> element is for some reason empty.”

D13 · Link best practices for Google · Anchor text placement

QUESTION 147 · D13

How many internal links should each page have?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

There is no magic ideal count. Every page you care about should have a link from at least one other page, with additional links chosen for useful reader context.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“You may usually think about linking in terms of pointing to external websites, but paying more attention to the anchor text used for internal links can help both people and Google make sense of your site more easily and find other pages on your site. Every page you care about should have a link from at least one other page on your site. Think about what other resources on your site could help your readers understand a given page on your site, and link to those pages in context.”

D13 · Link best practices for Google · Internal links: cross-reference your own content

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“There's no magical ideal number of links a given page should contain. However, if you think it's too much, then it probably is.”

D13 · Link best practices for Google · Internal links: cross-reference your own content

QUESTION 148 · D13

Should all external links be nofollow?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

No. Cite trusted relevant sources normally. Use nofollow where trust is absent, sponsored or nofollow for paid links, and ugc or nofollow for user-inserted links.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Use nofollow only when you don't trust the source, and not for every external link on your site. For example, you're a cheese enthusiast and someone published a story badmouthing your favorite cheese, so you want to write an article in response; however, you don't want to give the site some of your reputation from your link. This would be a good time to use nofollow .”

D13 · Link best practices for Google · External links: link to other sites

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“If you were paid in some way for the link, qualify these links with sponsored or nofollow . If users can insert links on your site (for example, you have a forum section or Q&A site), add ugc or nofollow to these links too.”

D13 · Link best practices for Google · External links: link to other sites

Learn about sitemaps

Google last updated: 2025-12-10 · Reviewed 6 October 2026

<https://developers.google.com/search/docs/crawling-indexing/sitemaps/overview>

Detailed points to revise

- A sitemap describes important pages/files and their relationships, helping efficient crawling. It can contain modification dates, language alternates, and image/video/news information.
- Proper internal linking may allow Google to discover most content without a sitemap; a sitemap can still help large, complex, new, or media-heavy sites.
- Strong use cases: large inventories, few external links to a new site, rich media, or Google News content.
- It may be less necessary for a comprehensively linked site of about 500 important search pages or fewer, with little media or news requiring discovery.
- CMS software may already generate a sitemap. Check the platform rather than assume a new manual file is needed.
- Discovery support does not guarantee that every listed URL will be crawled or indexed.

Complete source section checklist: Do I need a sitemap? · Build a sitemap

QUESTION 149 · D14

What does a sitemap do?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

It provides information about important pages, media, other files, and their relationships, helping search engines crawl more efficiently. It can also provide updates and alternate-language information.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“A sitemap is a file where you provide information about the pages, videos, and other files on your site, and the relationships between them. Search engines like Google read this file to crawl your site more efficiently. A sitemap tells search engines which pages and files you think are important in your site, and also provides valuable information about these files. For example, when the page was last updated and any alternate language versions of the page.”

D14 · [Learn about sitemaps](#) · [Learn about sitemaps](#)

QUESTION 150 · D14

When is a sitemap especially useful?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

For large sites, new sites with few external links, and sites with substantial media or Google News content. These cases make ordinary link discovery or specialist content understanding harder.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Your site is large. Generally, on large sites it's more difficult to make sure that every page is linked by at least one other page on the site. As a result, it's more likely Googlebot might not discover some of your new pages.”

D14 · [Learn about sitemaps](#) · [Do I need a sitemap?](#)

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Your site is new and has few external links to it. Googlebot and other web crawlers crawl the web by accessing URLs found in previously crawled pages. As a result, Googlebot might not discover your pages if no other sites link to them.”

D14 · [Learn about sitemaps](#) · [Do I need a sitemap?](#)

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Your site has a lot of rich media content (video, images) or is shown in Google News. Google can take additional information from sitemaps into account for Search.”

D14 · [Learn about sitemaps](#) · [Do I need a sitemap?](#)

QUESTION 151 · D14

Does a sitemap guarantee crawling and indexing?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

No. Google explicitly says that discovery help does not guarantee every item will be crawled and indexed.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“A sitemap helps search engines discover URLs on your site, but it doesn't guarantee that all the items in your sitemap will be crawled and indexed. However, in most cases, your site will benefit from having a sitemap.”

D14 · [Learn about sitemaps](#) · [Do I need a sitemap?](#)

Can a small site operate without a sitemap?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

The guide says it might not need one when it has about 500 relevant pages or fewer, comprehensive internal linking, and no substantial media/news discovery need. These are considerations rather than a prohibition on sitemaps.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Your site is "small". By small, we mean about 500 pages or fewer on your site. Only pages that you think need to be in search results count toward this total.”

D14 · [Learn about sitemaps](#) · [Do I need a sitemap?](#)

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Your site is comprehensively linked internally. This means that Googlebot can find all the important pages on your site by following links starting from the home page.”

D14 · [Learn about sitemaps](#) · [Do I need a sitemap?](#)

Build and submit a sitemap

Google last updated: 2026-07-08 · Reviewed 6 October 2026

<https://developers.google.com/search/docs/crawling-indexing/sitemaps/build-sitemap>

Detailed points to revise

- Supported formats are XML; RSS/mRSS/Atom 1.0; and text. Google has no preferred format. XML can express the broadest extensions; feeds usually cover recent URLs; text is a simple URL list.
- A single sitemap is limited to 50 MB uncompressed or 50,000 URLs. Split larger inventories and optionally use an index.
- Use UTF-8 and fully qualified absolute URLs. Unless submitted through Search Console, location limits scope to descendants of the parent directory; root placement is recommended.
- Include preferred canonical URLs, rather than every duplicate. Annotate separate desktop/mobile versions correctly if both are listed.
- XML values need entity escaping. Google ignores priority and changefreq. Accurate lastmod should reflect significant changes, not a copyright-date-only edit.
- RSS 2.0 and Atom 1.0 are accepted; mRSS can convey video. Text files must contain one URL per line, no other content, and a .txt extension.
- CMS generation is often available. Manual creation suits a few dozen URLs; larger files should be generated from reliable website data. URL ordering does not matter to Google.
- Submission is a hint, not a guarantee of downloading or use. Submit through the Sitemaps report/API, declare in robots.txt, or use WebSub for RSS/Atom updates.
- Cross-site submission through Search Console requires verified ownership of all included sites. With robots.txt, prepare a separate sitemap per site and reference it from that site's robots.txt even if hosted centrally.
- Use the Sitemaps report and linked troubleshooting documentation for processing errors. The full format examples and cross-site examples are preserved in the reference.

Complete source section checklist: Sitemap best practices · XML sitemap · Additional notes about XML sitemaps · RSS, mRSS, and Atom 1.0 · Additional notes about RSS, mRSS, and Atom 1.0 · Text sitemap · Additional notes for text file sitemaps · How to create a sitemap · Let your CMS generate a sitemap for you · Manually create a sitemap · Automatically generate a sitemap with tools · Submit your sitemap to Google · How to cross-submit sitemaps for multiple sites · Sitemap cross-submission with Search Console · Sitemap cross-submission with robots.txt · Troubleshooting sitemaps

QUESTION 153 · D15 Priority practice

What are the standard sitemap size limits?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

A single sitemap can contain no more than 50,000 URLs and must stay within 50 MB uncompressed. Split it when either limit is exceeded and optionally submit a sitemap index.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Sitemap size limits: All formats limit a single sitemap to 50MB (uncompressed) or 50,000 URLs. If you have a larger file or more URLs, you must break your sitemap into multiple sitemaps. You can optionally create a sitemap index file and submit that single index file to Google. You can submit multiple sitemaps and sitemap index files to Google. This may be useful if you want to track the search performance of each individual sitemap in Search Console.”

D15 · Build and submit a sitemap · Sitemap best practices

QUESTION 154 · D15

Which sitemap format does Google prefer?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

Google says it has no preference. Choose XML for versatile extensions, RSS/Atom for readily available recent feeds, or text for a simple list of indexable page URLs.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Google supports the sitemap formats defined by the sitemaps protocol . Each format has its own benefits and shortcomings; choose the one that is the most appropriate for your site and setup (Google doesn't have a preference). The following table compares the different sitemap formats:”

D15 · Build and submit a sitemap · Build and submit a sitemap

QUESTION 155 · D15

Are relative URLs acceptable in a sitemap?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

The guide says to use fully qualified absolute URLs; Google attempts to crawl the URLs exactly as listed. Do not list /mypage.html in place of its complete URL.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Referenced URLs' properties: Use fully-qualified, absolute URLs in your sitemaps. Google will attempt to crawl your URLs exactly as listed. For example, if your site is at <https://www.example.com/> , don't specify a URL such as /mypage.html (a relative URL), use the complete, absolute URL: <https://www.example.com/mypage.html> .”

D15 · Build and submit a sitemap · Sitemap best practices

QUESTION 156 · D15**Priority practice**

Does sitemap priority or changefreq control Google's crawling?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

No. Google ignores both values. It can use lastmod if consistently accurate and representative of a significant update.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Google ignores <priority> and <changefreq> values.”

D15 · Build and submit a sitemap · Additional notes about XML sitemaps

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Google uses the <lastmod> value if it's consistently and verifiably (for example by comparing to the last modification of the page) accurate. The <lastmod> value should reflect the date and time of the last significant update to the page. For example, an update to the main content, the structured data, or links on the page is generally considered significant, however an update to the copyright date is not.”

D15 · Build and submit a sitemap · Additional notes about XML sitemaps

QUESTION 157 · D15

What counts as a meaningful lastmod change?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

A significant change to main content, structured data, or links can qualify; simply updating the copyright year does not. Do not mechanically refresh every lastmod on every visit.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Google uses the <lastmod> value if it's consistently and verifiably (for example by comparing to the last modification of the page) accurate. The <lastmod> value should reflect the date and time of the last significant update to the page. For example, an update to the main content, the structured data, or links on the page is generally considered significant, however an update to the copyright date is not.”

D15 · Build and submit a sitemap · Additional notes about XML sitemaps

QUESTION 158 · D15

Should a sitemap include all duplicate URL variations?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

Choose the preferred canonical version and include that rather than all URLs leading to the same content.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“When creating a sitemap, you're telling search engines about which URLs you prefer to show in search results. These are the canonical URLs . If you have the same content accessible under different URLs, choose the URL you prefer and include that in the sitemap instead of all URLs that lead to the same content.”

D15 · Build and submit a sitemap · How to create a sitemap

QUESTION 159 · D15

How can Google be told where a sitemap is?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

Use Search Console's Sitemaps report or API, or a Sitemap line in robots.txt. Atom/RSS updates can also use WebSub. None of these guarantees download or crawling.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Submit a sitemap in Search Console using the Sitemaps report . This will allow you to see when Googlebot accessed the sitemap and also potential processing errors.”

D15 · Build and submit a sitemap · Submit your sitemap to Google

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Use the Search Console API to programmatically submit a sitemap .”

D15 · Build and submit a sitemap · Submit your sitemap to Google

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“If you use Atom or RSS, you can use WebSub to broadcast your changes to search engines, including Google.”

D15 · Build and submit a sitemap · Submit your sitemap to Google

QUESTION 160 · D15

Can one centrally hosted sitemap serve several domains?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

Yes, with the documented cross-submission setup. Search Console submission requires verifying ownership of all included sites; the robots.txt route uses a per-site sitemap referenced by that site's robots.txt.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Make sure that you have verified ownership of all the sites that you will add in the sitemap.”

D15 · Build and submit a sitemap · Sitemap cross-submission with Search Console

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Create one or more sitemaps for each individual site. For each individual sitemap file, make sure you include only URLs from that particular site.”

D15 · Build and submit a sitemap · Sitemap cross-submission with robots.txt

QUESTION 161 · D15

Does the order of URLs in the sitemap matter?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

No. The guide explicitly says ordering does not matter to Google; correct URLs, scope, encoding, and size are more important.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“You don't have to worry about the order of the URLs in your sitemap, it doesn't matter to Google. Note the size requirements for sitemaps ; if the sitemap becomes too large, you must split it into smaller sitemaps. Learn more about managing large sitemaps .”

D15 · Build and submit a sitemap · Automatically generate a sitemap with tools

Manage your sitemaps with a sitemap index file

Google last updated: 2025-12-10 · Reviewed 6 October 2026

<https://developers.google.com/search/docs/crawling-indexing/sitemaps/large-sitemaps>

Detailed points to revise

- Split oversized sitemaps so each child remains under the generic size/URL limits; an index lets you submit many child sitemaps together.
- Index files follow the Sitemap Protocol and the general sitemap requirements.
- Child files normally must be on the same site and in the same directory or lower than the index. Documented cross-site submission can waive the same-site requirement.
- Required tags are sitemapindex, sitemap, and loc. An index can contain up to 50,000 loc entries; Search Console accepts up to 500 sitemap index files per site.
- Optional lastmod describes when the child sitemap file changed, in W3C Datetime format. Do not confuse this with a page's lastmod inside an ordinary sitemap.
- The reference retains the two-child XML example and links to submission, combined extensions, and troubleshooting.

Complete source section checklist: Sitemap index best practices · Example sitemap index · Sitemap index reference · Troubleshooting sitemaps · Additional resources

QUESTION 162 · D16

What is a sitemap index for?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

It lists child sitemap files so multiple sitemaps can be submitted together after splitting a file that exceeds the limits.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“If you have a sitemap that exceeds the size limits, you'll need to split up your large sitemap into multiple sitemaps such that each new sitemap is below the size limit. Once you've split up your sitemap, you can use a sitemap index file as a way to submit many sitemaps at once.”

D16 · Manage your sitemaps with a sitemap index file · Manage your sitemaps with a sitemap index file

QUESTION 163 · D16

Where can the child sitemap files be hosted?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

Normally on the same site as the index and at the same or a deeper directory level. The same-site condition can be waived with the documented cross-site submission setup.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“The referenced sitemaps must be hosted on the same site as your sitemap index file. This requirement is waived if you set up cross-site submission .”

D16 · Manage your sitemaps with a sitemap index file · Sitemap index best practices

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Sitemaps that are referenced in the sitemap index file must be in the same directory as the sitemap index file, or lower in the site hierarchy. For example, if the sitemap index file is at https://example.com/public/sitemap_index.xml , it can only contain sitemaps that are in the same or deeper directory, like <https://example.com/public/shared/...> .”

D16 · Manage your sitemaps with a sitemap index file · Sitemap index best practices

QUESTION 164 · D16

How many entries and index files are allowed?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

An index can have up to 50,000 loc entries, and Search Console lets you submit up to 500 sitemap index files for each site.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“loc The location (URL) of the sitemap. It's a child of the sitemap tag. A sitemap index file may have up to 50,000 loc tags.”

D16 · Manage your sitemaps with a sitemap index file · Sitemap index reference

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“You can submit up to 500 sitemap index files for each site in your Search Console account.”

D16 · Manage your sitemaps with a sitemap index file · Sitemap index best practices

QUESTION 165 · D16

What does lastmod mean in a sitemap index?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

The last modification time of the corresponding child sitemap file, in W3C Datetime format, rather than the modification time of an individual page.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“lastmod Identifies the time that the corresponding sitemap file was modified. It can be a child of a sitemap tag. The value for the lastmod tag must be in W3C Datetime format .”

D16 · [Manage your sitemaps with a sitemap index file](#) · [Sitemap index reference](#)

Image sitemaps

Google last updated: 2025-12-10 · Reviewed 6 October 2026

<https://developers.google.com/search/docs/crawling-indexing/sitemaps/image-sitemaps>

Detailed points to revise

- Image sitemaps help expose images Google might not otherwise find, including images reached with JavaScript. A separate image sitemap or extensions in an existing sitemap are equally acceptable.
- Generic sitemap requirements and general image best practices still apply.
- The image namespace is <http://www.google.com/schemas/sitemap-image/1.1>. Required tags are `image:image` and `image:loc`.
- Each url entry can have up to 1,000 `image:image` entries. The enclosing ordinary `loc` identifies the page; `image:loc` identifies the image.
- Images can be hosted on a different domain, such as a CDN, if both domains are verified in Search Console. Ensure `robots.txt` does not block intended image crawling.
- Removed/deprecated tags listed: `image:caption`, `image:geo_location`, `image:title`, `image:license`. Do not teach them as current required tags.

Complete source section checklist: [Example image sitemap](#) · [Image sitemap reference](#) · [Deprecated tags and attributes](#) · [Troubleshooting sitemaps](#) · [Additional resources](#)

QUESTION 166 · D17

Must images use a separate sitemap?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

No. A separate sitemap or image extensions within an existing sitemap are equally fine for Google.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Image sitemaps are a way of telling Google about other images on your site, especially those that we might not otherwise find (such as images your site reaches with JavaScript code). You can create a separate image sitemap or add image sitemap tags to your existing sitemap; either approach is equally fine for Google.”

D17 · [Image sitemaps](#) · [Image sitemaps](#)

QUESTION 167 · D17

Which image sitemap tags are required?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

image:image wraps a single image entry and image:loc supplies its URL. The general sitemap loc still identifies the page containing the image.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“<image:image> Encloses all information about a single image. Each <url> tag can contain up to 1,000 <image:image> tags.”

D17 · Image sitemaps · Image sitemap reference

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“<image:loc> The URL of the image. In some cases, the image URL may not be on the same domain as your main site. This is fine, as long as you verify both domains in Search Console. If, for example, you use a content delivery network such as Google Sites to host your images, make sure that the hosting site is verified in Search Console. In addition, make sure that your robots.txt file doesn't disallow the crawling of any content you want indexed.”

D17 · Image sitemaps · Image sitemap reference

QUESTION 168 · D17

How many images can one url entry list?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

Up to 1,000 image:image tags per url entry.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“<image:image> Encloses all information about a single image. Each <url> tag can contain up to 1,000 <image:image> tags.”

D17 · Image sitemaps · Image sitemap reference

QUESTION 169 · D17

Can an image sitemap refer to CDN images on another domain?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

Yes. The guide requires verifying both domains in Search Console and allowing intended crawling. Different-domain hosting is not automatically an invalid image sitemap.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“<image:loc> The URL of the image. In some cases, the image URL may not be on the same domain as your main site. This is fine, as long as you verify both domains in Search Console. If, for example, you use a content delivery network such as Google Sites to host your images, make sure that the hosting site is verified in Search Console. In addition, make sure that your robots.txt file doesn't disallow the crawling of any content you want indexed.”

D17 · Image sitemaps · Image sitemap reference

QUESTION 170 · D17

Priority practice

Are image:title and image:caption still required?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

No. The page lists those with image:geo_location and image:license as removed from its documentation.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“We removed the following tags and attributes from our documentation: <image:caption> , <image:geo_location> , <image:title> , <image:license> . See the deprecation announcement for more information.”

D17 · Image sitemaps · Deprecated tags and attributes

News sitemaps

Google last updated: 2025-12-10 · Reviewed 6 October 2026

<https://developers.google.com/search/docs/crawling-indexing/sitemaps/news-sitemap>

Detailed points to revise

- News entries can extend an existing sitemap or live in a separate one; a separate news sitemap may simplify Search Console tracking.
- Update the same sitemap as new articles appear; do not create a brand-new sitemap for each update. Google News crawls it as often as the rest of the site.
- Include articles created within the last two days. Older URLs can be removed from the news sitemap or retained without their news:news metadata.
- An empty sitemap after a quiet period can trigger an intentionality warning but does not itself cause problems for Search.
- Each url may have one news:news entry; a sitemap can contain up to 1,000 news:news entries. Split if necessary.
- Required child tags: news:publication containing name and language, publication_date, and title.
- Publication name must match Google News without parenthetical additions. Language uses ISO 639, with zh-cn and zh-tw exceptions.
- publication_date is the original publication timestamp, not the sitemap insertion time, in accepted W3C forms. title matches the article title without author, publication name, or date.

Complete source section checklist: News sitemap best practices · Example news sitemap · News sitemap reference · Troubleshooting sitemaps · Additional resources

QUESTION 171 · D18 Priority practice

How long should an article remain in a news sitemap?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

Use URLs for articles created in the last two days. After that, remove the URL from the news sitemap or remove its news:news metadata while keeping the URL in an ordinary sitemap.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Only include recent URLs for articles that were created in the last two days. Once the articles are older than two days, either remove those URLs from the news sitemap or remove the <news:news> metadata in your sitemap from the older URLs.”

D18 · News sitemaps · News sitemap best practices

QUESTION 172 · D18

Should a new news sitemap be generated for every publication batch?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

Update the existing news sitemap with new articles rather than create a new file for every update.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Update your news sitemap with fresh articles as they’re published. Don’t create a new sitemap with each update. Google News crawls news sitemaps as often as it crawls the rest of your site.”

D18 · News sitemaps · News sitemap best practices

QUESTION 173 · D18

What is the news-specific entry limit?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

Up to 1,000 news:news tags per sitemap, with one per url entry. Split news sitemaps exceeding that number.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“<news:news> The parent tag of other tags in the news: namespace. Each url sitemap tag can have only one news:news tag (plus the respective closing tag) and a sitemap may have up to 1,000 news:news tags. If there are more than 1,000 <news:news> tags in a news sitemap, split your sitemap into several smaller sitemaps .”

D18 · News sitemaps · News sitemap reference

QUESTION 174 · D18

Which date belongs in news:publication_date?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

The original time the article was first published on the site, not when it was added to the sitemap.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE · EXACT EXCERPT

“format (YYYY-MM-DD) or the "complete date plus hours, minutes, and seconds" format with time zone designator format (YYYY-MM-DDThh:mm:ssTZD). Specify the original date and time when the article was first published on your site. Don't specify the time when you added the article to your sitemap. Google accepts any of the following formats: Complete date: YYYY-MM-DD (1997-07-16) Complete date”

D18 · News sitemaps · News sitemap reference

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE · EXACT EXCERPT

“with time zone designator format (YYYY-MM-DDThh:mm:ssTZD). Specify the original date and time when the article was first published on your site. Don't specify the time when you added the article to your sitemap. Google accepts any of the following formats: Complete date: YYYY-MM-DD (1997-07-16) Complete date plus hours and minutes: YYYY-MM-DDThh:mmTZD (1997-07-16T19:20+01:00) Complete date plus”

D18 · News sitemaps · News sitemap reference

QUESTION 175 · D18

Is an empty news sitemap after a quiet week harmful?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

The page says an Empty Sitemap warning may appear to confirm it was intentional, but an empty file does not itself cause problems with Google Search.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“If you choose the method of removing old URLs from your news sitemap, this could mean that your sitemap becomes empty for a period of time (for example, if you haven't published articles in the last few days). You may see an Empty Sitemap warning in Search Console, but this is just to make sure it was intentional on your behalf. It won't cause any problems with Google Search if the file is empty.”

D18 · News sitemaps · News sitemap best practices

QUESTION 176 · D18

What information belongs in news:title and publication metadata?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

Use the on-site article title without the author, publication name, or date. The publication name should match Google News without parentheses; language uses the documented codes.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“<news:title> The title of the news article. Tip: Google may shorten the title of the news article for space reasons when displaying the article on various devices. Include the title of the article as it appears on your site. Don't include the author name, publication name, or publication date in the <news:title> tag. Learn more about creating better titles .”

D18 · News sitemaps · News sitemap reference

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“<news:name> The <news:name> tag is the name of the news publication. It must exactly match the name as it appears on your articles on news.google.com , omitting anything in parentheses.”

D18 · News sitemaps · News sitemap reference

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“<news:language> The <news:language> tag is the language of your publication. Use an ISO 639 language code (two or three letters). Exception : For Simplified Chinese, use zh-cn and for Traditional Chinese, use zh-tw .”

D18 · News sitemaps · News sitemap reference

Video sitemaps and alternatives

Google last updated: 2026-05-20 · Reviewed 6 October 2026

<https://developers.google.com/search/docs/crawling-indexing/sitemaps/video-sitemaps>

Detailed points to revise

- Google recommends video sitemaps and also supports mRSS. Video entries can be in a separate file or extensions within a normal sitemap.
- Videos should relate to the host page's main content. Referenced files must be accessible without login, robots blocks, or firewall blocks; the page describes HTTP/FTP support, not streaming protocols.
- Required information: video:video, thumbnail_loc, title, description, and at least content_loc or player_loc. Prefer content_loc where available for fetching the actual media; embedded-platform examples use player_loc.
- Neither content_loc nor player_loc should be the host-page loc. HTML and Flash are not valid media files for content_loc. The related structured-data equivalents are contentUrl and embedUrl.
- Description has a 2,048-character maximum. The title should match the visible video's title, with proper escaping or CDATA; description should match meaning without requiring word-for-word identity.
- Optional fields: duration (1-28,800 seconds), expiration_date, rating (0-5), view_count, publication_date, family_friendly, restriction, platform, requires_subscription, uploader, live, and tag (up to 32 tags).
- Country/platform restriction values affect Search presentation rather than prevent actual user access. allow and deny have opposite treatment of unlisted locations/platforms.
- Uploader text allows up to 255 characters, and its optional info URL must share the host page's domain. Expiration excludes the video after the date; update it for recurring videos.
- The guide lists deprecated video fields and attributes, including category, gallery_loc, player autoplay/allow_embed, price, and tvshow. Their presence in old examples elsewhere is not a requirement.
- mRSS uses media:content with medium=video and either its url or media:player; required text/thumbnail fields are media:title (100-character maximum), media:description (2,048), and media:thumbnail.
- Optional mRSS fields include dcterms:valid, media:restriction and media:price with the listed attributes. The full video/mRSS tables, examples, namespaces, and exceptions are preserved in the reference.

Complete source section checklist: Video sitemap best practices · Example video sitemap · More examples · Video sitemap reference · Deprecated tags and attributes · Sitemap alternative: mRSS · mRSS Example · mRSS reference · Troubleshooting sitemaps · Additional resources

QUESTION 177 · D19

What is the minimum video sitemap information?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

A video wrapper, thumbnail URL, title, description, and at least a direct content URL or player URL. Use a content URL where possible; the parent loc identifies the host page.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“To make sure Google can use your mRSS feed, you must use the following required tags:”

D19 · Video sitemaps and alternatives · mRSS reference

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE · EXACT EXCERPT

“<video:content_loc> A URL pointing to the actual video media file. The file must be one of the supported formats. It's required to provide either a <video:content_loc> or <video:player_loc> tag. We recommend that your provide the <video:content_loc> tag, if possible. This is the most effective way for Google to fetch your video content files. If <video:content_loc> isn't available, provide <video:player_loc>”

D19 · Video sitemaps and alternatives · Video sitemap reference

QUESTION 178 · D19

How does content_loc differ from player_loc?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

content_loc points to the actual media file; player_loc points to a player for the specific video. Neither should be the host-page loc, and Google recommends content_loc when available.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE · EXACT EXCERPT

“<video:content_loc> A URL pointing to the actual video media file. The file must be one of the supported formats. It's required to provide either a <video:content_loc> or <video:player_loc> tag. We recommend that your provide the <video:content_loc> tag, if possible. This is the most”

D19 · Video sitemaps and alternatives · Video sitemap reference

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“<media:player> You must specify at least one of <media:player> or the url attribute in <media:content> . A URL pointing to a player for a specific video. Usually this is the information in the src attribute of an <embed> tag and must not be the same as the content of the <loc> tag. It can't be the same URL as the <link> tag. The <link> tag points to the URL of the page hosting the video, while this tag points to a player.”

D19 · Video sitemaps and alternatives · mRSS reference

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE · EXACT EXCERPT

“to fetch your video content files. If <video:content_loc> isn't available, provide <video:player_loc> as an alternative. Additional guidelines Must not be the same as the <loc> URL. For Vimeo, YouTube, and other video hosting platforms that allow embedding videos through iframe videos, this value is used rather than video:content_loc . This is the equivalent of VideoObject.embedUrl in structured”

D19 · Video sitemaps and alternatives · Video sitemap reference

QUESTION 179 · D19

Can the media be behind a login or blocked to Googlebot?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

The guide requires every referenced file to be accessible to Googlebot, including no login, robots, or firewall block. Validate legitimate Googlebot access if restricting other bots.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“All files referenced in the video sitemap must be accessible to Googlebot. This means that all URLs in the video sitemap: must not be disallowed for crawling by robots.txt rules, must be accessible without metafiles and without logging in, must not be blocked by firewalls or similar mechanism, and must be accessible on a supported protocol: HTTP and FTP (streaming protocols are not supported). If you want to prevent spammers from accessing your video content at the <player_loc> or <content_loc> URLs, verify that any bots accessing your server are really Googlebot .”

D19 · Video sitemaps and alternatives · Video sitemap best practices

QUESTION 180 · D19

What are the description and duration limits?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

The video description allows up to 2,048 characters. Duration is expressed in seconds and ranges from 1 to 28,800, which is eight hours.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“<media:description> The description of the video. Maximum 2048 characters. All HTML entities must be escaped or wrapped in a CDATA block .”

D19 · Video sitemaps and alternatives · mRSS reference

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“<video:duration> The duration of the video, in seconds. Value must be from 1 to 28800 (8 hours).”

D19 · Video sitemaps and alternatives · Video sitemap reference

QUESTION 181 · D19

Do sitemap country restrictions prevent users playing the video?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

No. The page explicitly says the restriction affects search results, not other ways of finding or playing it. It is not access control.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE · EXACT EXCERPT

“of country codes in ISO 3166 format . If there's no <video:restriction> tag, Google assumes that the video can be shown in all locations. Note that this tag only affects search results; it doesn't prevent a user from finding or playing your video in a restricted location through other means. Learn more about applying country restrictions. Attributes: If the parent tag <video:restriction> is used, the”

D19 · Video sitemaps and alternatives · Video sitemap reference

QUESTION 182 · D19

What is the effect of video:expiration_date?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

If supplied, Search will not show the video after that date. Omit it for non-expiring content and update it appropriately for recurring video at the same URL.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“<video:expiration_date> The date after which the video is no longer be available, in W3C format . Omit this tag if your video doesn't expire. If present, Google Search won't show your video after this date. For recurring videos at the same URL, update the expiration date to the new expiration date. Supported values are complete date (YYYY-MM-DD), or complete date plus hours, minutes and seconds, and timezone (YYYY-MM-DDThh:mm:ss+TZD). Example: 2012-07-16T19:20:30+08:00 .”

D19 · Video sitemaps and alternatives · Video sitemap reference

QUESTION 183 · D19

What alternative to a video sitemap does Google support?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

mRSS feeds. They can be tested, submitted, and updated like sitemaps and use the specified media tags for video location, title, description, and thumbnail.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“While Google recommends using video sitemaps, we also support mRSS feeds.”

D19 · Video sitemaps and alternatives · Sitemap alternative: mRSS

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Google supports mRSS , an RSS module that supplements the element capabilities of RSS 2.0 . mRSS feeds are very similar to video sitemaps and can be tested, submitted, and updated just like sitemaps.”

D19 · Video sitemaps and alternatives · Sitemap alternative: mRSS

QUESTION 184 · D19

Are sitemap price and mRSS media:price the same supported field?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

No. The video sitemap's video:price is in the deprecated list, while the page separately documents media:price for paid mRSS content. Keep the extension and namespace clear.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“We removed the following tags and attributes from our documentation: <video:category> , <video:gallery_loc> , the autoplay and allow_embed attributes of the <video:player_loc> tag, the <video:price> tag and its attributes, and the <video:tvshow> tag and its attributes. See the deprecation announcement for more information.”

D19 · Video sitemaps and alternatives · Deprecated tags and attributes

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE · EXACT EXCERPT

“<media:price> The price to download or view the video. Don't use this tag for videos that are available without payment. More than one <media:price> element can be listed (for example, in order to specify various currencies or purchasing options). Attributes: If the parent”

D19 · Video sitemaps and alternatives · mRSS reference

How to combine sitemap extensions

Google last updated: 2025-12-10 · Reviewed 6 October 2026

<https://developers.google.com/search/docs/crawling-indexing/sitemaps/combine-sitemap-extensions>

Detailed points to revise

- A page may have several content types, such as a localized news article with images and video. Extensions can coexist in one sitemap entry.
- Declare every used extension's namespace on urlset. Google lists image, news, video, and xhtml for hreflang.
- Add each extension's valid tags to the appropriate url element, following that extension's own implementation requirements.
- Extension order does not matter after loc. Combined metadata can make files significantly larger, so enforce the generic size limits.
- The full source retains namespace values and the combined news/video/hreflang XML example.

Complete source section checklist: Namespaces · Declaring multiple namespaces · Combining sitemap extensions · Troubleshooting sitemaps

QUESTION 185 · D20

Can a sitemap combine news, images, videos, and hreflang?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

Yes. Declare the relevant namespaces and add each extension's tags to the applicable url entries according to that extension's rules.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Sitemap extensions are a great way to tell Google about the different kinds of content and their metadata that you're using on your site. Often the content on your pages may fit into multiple kinds of extensions; for example, you might be publishing news articles that embed images and videos. Additionally, your pages may be localized as well, which might mean that you could add hreflang annotations for your localized pages.”

D20 · [How to combine sitemap extensions](#) · [How to combine sitemap extensions](#)

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“For each sitemap extension that you want to use in a sitemap you need to specify the respective namespace that declares the tags the extension supports. This is done with the xmlns attribute of the urlset tag. The namespaces for the sitemap extensions Google supports are:”

D20 · How to combine sitemap extensions · Namespaces

QUESTION 186 · D20

Where are extension namespaces declared?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

In xmlns attributes on the urlset root. The guide lists image, news, video, and xhtml for hreflang.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“For each sitemap extension that you want to use in a sitemap you need to specify the respective namespace that declares the tags the extension supports. This is done with the xmlns attribute of the urlset tag. The namespaces for the sitemap extensions Google supports are:”

D20 · How to combine sitemap extensions · Namespaces

QUESTION 187 · D20

Does the order of extension metadata matter?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

Not after the loc element. However, additional metadata increases file size, so still enforce the general sitemap limits.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“The order of the extension in the sitemap is irrelevant after the <loc> tag. Keep in mind the general sitemap best practices, especially the file size limits. Combining sitemap extensions increases the file size of your sitemap significantly.”

D20 · How to combine sitemap extensions · Combining sitemap extensions

Ask Google to recrawl your URLs

Google last updated: 2025-12-10 · Reviewed 6 October 2026

<https://developers.google.com/search/docs/crawling-indexing/ask-google-to-recrawl>

Detailed points to revise

- A hosted platform may already notify search engines of new content. Check platform documentation.
- You cannot request indexing for a URL you do not manage. Individual URL requests require owner or full-user access to the Search Console property.
- Use URL Inspection for a small number of URLs; use a sitemap for many, especially new sites and migrations.
- Individual submissions have a quota. Requesting the same URL repeatedly does not accelerate crawling.
- Crawling can take days to weeks. A request never guarantees instant inclusion or inclusion at all; monitor progress with the available reports/inspection.

Complete source section checklist: Use the URL Inspection tool (just a few URLs) · Submit a sitemap (many URLs at once)

QUESTION 188 · D21

How do you request recrawling for a few pages versus many pages?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

Use URL Inspection for individual URLs and submit a sitemap for a large number. A hosted CMS may already submit changes automatically.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Use the URL Inspection tool (just a few URLs)”

D21 · Ask Google to recrawl your URLs · Use the URL Inspection tool (just a few URLs)

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Submit a sitemap (many URLs at once)”

D21 · Ask Google to recrawl your URLs · Submit a sitemap (many URLs at once)

QUESTION 189 · D21

Which Search Console permissions are needed to request indexing?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

You must be an owner or full user of the property. You cannot request indexing for unmanaged URLs.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“To request a crawl of individual URLs, use the URL Inspection tool . You must be an owner or full user of the Search Console property to be able to request indexing in the URL Inspection tool.”

D21 · Ask Google to recrawl your URLs · Use the URL Inspection tool (just a few URLs)

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“If you've recently added or made changes to a page on your site, you can request that Google re-index your page using any of the methods listed here. You can't request indexing for URLs that you don't manage.”

D21 · Ask Google to recrawl your URLs · Ask Google to recrawl your URLs

QUESTION 190 · D21 Priority practice

Does repeatedly requesting indexing make it faster?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

No. There is an individual-URL quota, and repeated requests for the same URL do not make it crawl sooner.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Keep in mind that there's a quota for submitting individual URLs and requesting a recrawl multiple times for the same URL won't get it crawled any faster.”

D21 · Ask Google to recrawl your URLs · Use the URL Inspection tool (just a few URLs)

QUESTION 191 · D21

What indexing turnaround should you promise after requesting a crawl?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

Do not promise instant inclusion. The guide says crawling can take days to weeks and a request does not guarantee inclusion even eventually.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Crawling can take anywhere from a few days to a few weeks. Be patient and monitor progress using either the Index Status report or the URL Inspection tool .”

D21 · [Ask Google to recrawl your URLs](#) · [Ask Google to recrawl your URLs](#)

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Requesting a crawl does not guarantee that inclusion in search results will happen instantly or even at all. Our systems prioritize the fast inclusion of high quality, useful content.”

D21 · [Ask Google to recrawl your URLs](#) · [Ask Google to recrawl your URLs](#)

Troubleshoot Google Search crawling errors

Google last updated: 2025-12-18 · Reviewed 6 October 2026

<https://developers.google.com/search/docs/crawling-indexing/troubleshoot-crawling-errors>

Detailed points to revise

- Follow the five-part diagnosis: availability, important uncrawled URLs, update freshness, efficiency, and overcrawling.
- Crawl Stats and URL Inspection expose availability problems and Hostload exceeded warnings. Better availability removes a constraint; it does not automatically increase crawl demand.
- Server logs identify whether a specific URL was crawled; crawl activity and index inclusion are different. The guide's timing examples are expectations, not service-level guarantees.
- Help discovery with current sitemaps/lastmod and real links, including equivalent mobile links. Avoid repeated unchanged sitemap submissions and expecting immediate complete crawling.
- Improve server response and rendering speed, avoid long redirect chains, and block only non-critical unwanted resources. Making low-value pages faster does not by itself encourage more crawling.
- Conditional requests can support 304 for unchanged content and 200 with updated content. Not every crawler sends the same cache headers on every request.
- Avoid waste from facets, sessions, duplicates, soft 404s, hacked/spam pages, infinite spaces, carts, and state-changing pages. Reuse shared resource URLs for caching.
- Do not repeatedly rotate robots rules or sitemaps to redistribute budget. Hiding recrawls reallocates resources only under the documented serving-limit condition.
- Soft 404 can mean an error-like or empty page with a success status, including missing JS or database resources. Inspect rendered content and status before deciding.
- Removed with no replacement: 404/410. Genuine replacement: 301. Still valid: repair missing resources/rendering or the misleading error state. A friendly custom 404 must still return 404.
- Emergency 503/429 responses are temporary only; sustained errors can reduce crawling and remove URLs. AdsBot pressure can stem from Dynamic Search Ad targets; this page describes a three-week recurrence.

Complete source section checklist: See if Googlebot is encountering availability issues on your site · See if any parts of your site are not crawled, but should be · See if updates are crawled quickly enough · Improve your site's crawl efficiency · Increase your page loading speed · Specify content changes with HTTP status codes · Hide URLs that you don't want in search results · soft 404 errors · Fix soft 404 errors · The page and content are no longer available · The page or content is now somewhere else · The page and content still exist · Handle overcrawling of your site (emergencies)

QUESTION 192 · D22

Where do you diagnose site availability constraints on crawling?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

Use Crawl Stats, its host-availability information, and URL Inspection for examples such as Hostload exceeded. Correlate failures with server evidence.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Use the Crawl Stats report to see Googlebot's crawling history for your site. The report shows when Google encountered availability issues on your site. If availability errors or warnings are reported for your site, look for instances in the Host availability graphs where Googlebot requests exceeded the red limit line, click into the graph to see which URLs were failing, and try to correlate those with issues on your site.”

D22 · Troubleshoot Google Search crawling errors · See if Googlebot is encountering availability issues on your site

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Additionally, you can also use the URL Inspection Tool to test a few URLs on your site. If the tool returns Hostload exceeded warnings, that means that Googlebot can't crawl as many URLs from your site as it discovered.”

D22 · Troubleshoot Google Search crawling errors · See if Googlebot is encountering availability issues on your site

QUESTION 193 · D22 Priority practice

Does a faster server automatically increase crawl budget?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

Not necessarily. Availability affects what Google can crawl, while demand also matters. Faster low-quality pages alone do not encourage more crawling.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Improving your site availability won't necessarily increase your crawl budget; Google determines the best crawl rate based on the crawl demand, as described previously. However, availability issues do prevent Google from crawling your site as much as it might want to.”

D22 · Troubleshoot Google Search crawling errors · See if Googlebot is encountering availability issues on your site

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Google's crawling is limited by bandwidth, time, and availability of Googlebot instances. If your server responds to requests quicker, we might be able to crawl more pages on your site. That said, Google only wants to crawl high quality content, so just making low quality pages faster won't encourage Googlebot to crawl more of your site; conversely, if we think that we're missing high-quality content on your site, we'll probably increase your budget to crawl that content.”

D22 · Troubleshoot Google Search crawling errors · Increase your page loading speed

QUESTION 194 · D22

How do you determine whether Googlebot crawled a specific path?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

Inspect server logs. This guide says Search Console does not provide a URL/path-filterable crawl history; whether the crawled URL was indexed is a separate question.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Search Console doesn't provide a crawl history for your site that can be filtered by URL or path, but you can inspect your site logs to see whether specific URLs have been crawled by Googlebot . Whether or not those crawled URLs have been indexed is another story.”

D22 · Troubleshoot Google Search crawling errors · See if any parts of your site are not crawled, but should be

QUESTION 195 · D22 Priority practice

What is a soft 404, and how do you fix it?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

An error-like or empty page returning a success status can be classified as soft 404. Use 404/410 for a removed page with no replacement, 301 for a suitable replacement, or fix rendering/resources if the content should still exist.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“A soft 404 error is when a URL that returns a page telling the user that the page does not exist and also a 200 (success) status code . In some cases, it might be a page with no main content or empty page.”

D22 · Troubleshoot Google Search crawling errors · soft 404 errors

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“If you removed the page and there's no replacement page on your site with similar content, return a 404 (not found) or 410 (gone) response (status) code for the page. These status codes indicate to search engines that the page doesn't exist and you don't want search engines to index the page.”

D22 · Troubleshoot Google Search crawling errors · The page and content are no longer available

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“If your page has moved or has a clear replacement on your site, return a 301 (permanent redirect) to redirect the user. This won't interrupt their browsing experience and it's also a great way to tell search engines about the new location of the page. Use the URL Inspection tool to verify whether your URL is actually returning the correct code.”

D22 · Troubleshoot Google Search crawling errors · The page or content is now somewhere else

QUESTION 196 · D22

Can missing JavaScript cause a valid page to look like a soft 404?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

Yes. Missing critical resources, failed loading, or rendered errors can leave an otherwise valid URL blank or error-like. Inspect the rendered content and returned HTTP status.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE · EXACT EXCERPT

“If an otherwise good page was flagged with a soft 404 error, it's likely it didn't load properly for Googlebot, it was missing critical resources, or it displayed a prominent error message during rendering. Use the URL Inspection tool to examine the rendered content and the returned HTTP code. If the rendered page is blank, nearly blank, or the content has an”

D22 · Troubleshoot Google Search crawling errors · The page and content still exist

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“An unloaded or otherwise missing JavaScript file.”

D22 · Troubleshoot Google Search crawling errors · soft 404 errors

QUESTION 197 · D22

Should you rotate robots.txt blocks to move budget between sections?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

No. The guide discourages repeated block changes or rotating sitemaps as a redistribution strategy. It also says blocking recrawls does not move budget unless the site is already hitting serving limits.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Don't add or remove pages or directories from robots.txt regularly as a way of reallocating crawl budget for your site. Use robots.txt only for pages or resources that you don't want to appear on Google for the long run.”

D22 · Troubleshoot Google Search crawling errors · Hide URLs that you don't want in search results

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Blocking or hiding already crawled pages from recrawls won't shift your crawl budget to another part of your site unless Google is already hitting your site's serving limits.”

D22 · Troubleshoot Google Search crawling errors · Hide URLs that you don't want in search results

QUESTION 198 · D22

How can HTTP caching help crawl efficiency?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

When content has not changed, 304 with no body lets Google reuse the previously fetched version and can save server work. Return current content when it has changed; crawler header use depends on the request.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE · EXACT EXCERPT

“was last crawled. Based on that value, the server may choose to return a 304 (Not Modified) HTTP status code with no response body, in which case Google will reuse the content version it crawled the last time. If the content is newer than the date specified by the crawler in the If-Modified-Since header, the server can return a 200 (OK) HTTP status code with the response body.”

D22 · Troubleshoot Google Search crawling errors · Specify content changes with HTTP status codes

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Independently of the request headers, you can send a 304 (Not Modified) HTTP status code and no response body for any Googlebot request if the content hasn't changed since Googlebot last visited the URL. This will save your server processing time and resources, which may indirectly improve crawl efficiency.”

D22 · Troubleshoot Google Search crawling errors · Specify content changes with HTTP status codes

QUESTION 199 · D22

How would you handle genuine emergency overcrawling?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

The guide recommends temporarily returning 503 or 429, monitoring load, and stopping those responses as the rate falls. Prolonged errors risk URLs being dropped; investigate AdsBot targets if that crawler causes the load.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Return 503 or 429 HTTP response status codes temporarily for Googlebot requests when your server is overloaded. Googlebot will retry these URLs for about 2 days. Note that returning "no availability" codes for more than a few days will cause Google to permanently slow or stop crawling URLs on your site, so follow the additional next steps.”

D22 · Troubleshoot Google Search crawling errors · Handle overcrawling of your site (emergencies)

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“When the crawl rate goes down, stop returning 503 or 429 HTTP response status codes for crawl requests; returning 503 or 429 for more than 2 days will cause Google to drop those URLs from the index.”

D22 · Troubleshoot Google Search crawling errors · Handle overcrawling of your site (emergencies)

Overview of Google crawlers and fetchers (user agents)

Google last updated: 2026-06-12 · Reviewed 6 October 2026

<https://developers.google.com/crawling/docs/crawlers-fetchers/overview-google-crawlers>

Detailed points to revise

- Distinguish common automatic crawlers, special-case product crawlers, and user-triggered fetchers. Common crawlers respect robots.txt for automatic crawls; other categories have product-specific behavior.
- Google uses many machines and datacenters. Requests primarily originate in the US, but other countries may be used when US access is blocked. Do not diagnose bot identity from geography alone.
- Supported protocols include HTTP/1.1 and HTTP/2, with HTTP/1.1 as the default. HTTP/2 can reduce resource costs but provides no product-specific ranking boost. A 421 response is the documented HTTP/2 opt-out mechanism.
- FTP/FTPS crawling is also supported by the infrastructure but rare. gzip, deflate, and Brotli support is advertised through Accept-Encoding.
- The infrastructure's default fetch limit is 15 MB, while individual crawlers/types can override it. Googlebot's specific page gives 2 MB for ordinary files and 64 MB for PDFs; do not conflate these scopes.
- HTTP caching supports ETag/If-None-Match and Last-Modified/If-Modified-Since. ETag takes precedence when both validators are present, and Google recommends it to avoid date-format issues.
- The source recommends considering both headers for other clients, and notes that products may use caching differently. It gives a recommended Last-Modified date format and a max-age suggestion.
- Identification signals are user-agent, source IP, and reverse DNS hostname. Verification details belong to the corresponding guide.

Complete source section checklist: Technical properties of Google's crawlers and fetchers · Supported transfer protocols · Supported content encodings · File size limits · Crawl rate and host load · HTTP Caching · ETag and If-None-Match · Last-Modified and If-Modified-Since · Verify Google's crawlers and fetchers

QUESTION 200 · D23

What are Google's three crawler/fetcher categories?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

Common automatic crawlers, special-case product crawlers, and user-triggered fetchers. Their robots behavior differs; do not assume every Google-labelled request behaves exactly like Googlebot.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Common crawlers The common crawlers used for Google's products (such as Googlebot). They always respect robots.txt rules for automatic crawls.”

D23 · Overview of Google crawlers and fetchers (user agents) · Overview of Google crawlers and fetchers (user agents)

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Special-case crawlers Special-case crawlers are similar to common crawlers, however are used by specific products where there's an agreement between the crawled site and the Google product about the crawl process. For example, AdsBot ignores the global robots.txt user agent (*) with the ad publisher's permission.”

D23 · Overview of Google crawlers and fetchers (user agents) · Overview of Google crawlers and fetchers (user agents)

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“User-triggered fetchers User-triggered fetchers are part of tools and product functions where the end user triggers a fetch. For example, Google Site Verifier acts on the request of a user.”

D23 · Overview of Google crawlers and fetchers (user agents) · Overview of Google crawlers and fetchers (user agents)

QUESTION 201 · D23

Does HTTP/2 crawling improve rankings?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

No. It can save server and crawler resources but the overview explicitly says there is no Google-product-specific benefit such as a ranking boost.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE · EXACT EXCERPT

“resources (for example, CPU, RAM) for your site and Googlebot, but otherwise there's no Google-product specific benefit to the site (for example, no ranking boost in Google Search). To opt out from crawling over HTTP/2, instruct the server that's hosting your site to respond with a 421 HTTP status code when Google attempts to access your site over HTTP/2. If that's not feasible, you can send a”

D23 · Overview of Google crawlers and fetchers (user agents) · Supported transfer protocols

Do all Google clients have a 15 MB limit?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

No. That is the infrastructure default; individual projects and file types can set different limits. Use the Googlebot page for its Search-specific numbers.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“By default, Google's crawlers and fetchers only crawl the first 15MB of a file, and any content beyond this limit is ignored. However, individual projects may set different limits for their crawlers and fetchers, and also for different file types. For example, a Google crawler like Googlebot may have a smaller size limit (for example, 2MB), or specify a larger file size limit for a PDF than for HTML.”

D23 · Overview of Google crawlers and fetchers (user agents) · File size limits

Which compression formats are supported?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

The overview lists gzip, deflate, and Brotli, with support advertised in each request's Accept-Encoding header.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Google's crawlers and fetchers support the following content encodings (compressions): gzip , deflate , and Brotli (br) . The content encodings supported by each Google user agent is advertised in the Accept-Encoding header of each request they make. For example, Accept-Encoding: gzip, deflate, br .”

D23 · Overview of Google crawlers and fetchers (user agents) · Supported content encodings

Which cache validator takes precedence when both are present?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

ETag. The guide supports both validator pairs, recommends ETag for Google crawlers to avoid date-format issues, and notes product-specific caching behavior.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“If both ETag and Last-Modified response header fields are present in the HTTP response, Google's crawlers use the ETag value as required by the HTTP standard . For Google's crawlers specifically, we recommend using ETag instead of the Last-Modified header to indicate caching preference as ETag doesn't have date formatting issues.”

D23 · Overview of Google crawlers and fetchers (user agents) · HTTP Caching

QUESTION 205 · D23

Must every genuine Google request come from a US IP?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

No. US egress is primary, but the overview says Google may try IP addresses in other countries if it detects US blocking. Verify identity with documented DNS/IP methods.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Google's crawlers and fetchers are designed to be run simultaneously by thousands of machines to improve performance and scale as the web grows. To optimize bandwidth usage, these clients are distributed across many datacenters across the world so they're located near the sites that they might access. Therefore, your logs may show visits from several IP addresses. Google egresses primarily from IP addresses in the United States. In case Google detects that a site is blocking requests from the United States, it may attempt to crawl from IP addresses located in other countries.”

D23 · Overview of Google crawlers and fetchers (user agents) · Technical properties of Google's crawlers and fetchers

Googlebot

Google last updated: 2026-02-03 · Reviewed 6 October 2026

<https://developers.google.com/search/docs/crawling-indexing/googlebot>

Detailed points to revise

- Googlebot denotes Smartphone and Desktop web crawlers. Most Search indexing uses mobile content, so smartphone requests generally dominate.
- Their user-agent headers distinguish them, but both obey the same robots product token; robots.txt cannot selectively target one of the two.
- The page describes a typical average request frequency of no more than once every few seconds, with short bursts possible. It is a general description, not a per-server traffic guarantee.
- Search Googlebot fetches the first 2 MB of supported ordinary files and 64 MB for PDFs, measured uncompressed. It forwards only the downloaded portion for indexing consideration.
- CSS/JS references are separate fetches with their own applicable limit. Image/video bots can have different limits. Do not add all resources together into one 2 MB page quota.
- For US source IPs the documented timezone is Pacific Time. The overview covers other infrastructure properties.
- Use robots.txt for crawl prevention, noindex for index exclusion, authentication for private access. Hiding links cannot keep a site secret; referrers can reveal URLs.
- Verify alleged Googlebot requests because user-agent headers can be spoofed; DNS and published IP ranges are the documented methods.

Complete source section checklist: How Googlebot accesses your site · Blocking Googlebot from visiting your site · Verifying Googlebot

QUESTION 206 · D24

Can robots.txt distinguish Googlebot Smartphone from Desktop?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

No. The HTTP user-agent can distinguish them in logs, but they use the same robots.txt product token.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“You can identify the subtype of Googlebot by looking at the HTTP user-agent request header in the request. However, both crawler types obey the same product token (user agent token) in robots.txt, and so you cannot selectively target either Googlebot Smartphone or Googlebot Desktop using robots.txt.”

D24 · Googlebot · Googlebot

QUESTION 207 · D24 Priority practice

What is the current Googlebot file-size limit?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

For Search, this page specifies the first 2 MB of a supported ordinary file and the first 64 MB of a PDF, on uncompressed data. Do not use the infrastructure default as its specific limit.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE · EXACT EXCERPT

“When crawling for Google Search, Googlebot crawls the first 2MB of a supported file type , and the first 64MB of a PDF file. From a rendering perspective, each resource referenced in the HTML (such as CSS and JavaScript) is fetched separately, and each resource fetch is bound by”

D24 · Googlebot · How Googlebot accesses your site

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE · EXACT EXCERPT

“When crawling for Google Search, Googlebot crawls the first 2MB of a supported file type , and the first 64MB of a PDF file. From a rendering perspective, each resource referenced in the HTML (such as CSS and JavaScript) is fetched separately, and each resource fetch is bound by the same file size limit that applies to other files (except”

D24 · Googlebot · How Googlebot accesses your site

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE · EXACT EXCERPT

“is reached, Googlebot stops the fetch and only sends the already downloaded part of the file for indexing consideration. The file size limit is applied on the uncompressed data. Other Google crawlers, for example Googlebot Video and Googlebot Image, may have different limits .”

D24 · Googlebot · How Googlebot accesses your site

QUESTION 208 · D24

Is a page plus all its scripts subject to one combined 2 MB fetch limit?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

No. The page says referenced resources such as CSS and JavaScript are fetched separately, each with the applicable ordinary-file limit. Other Google crawlers may differ.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE · EXACT EXCERPT

“for Google Search, Googlebot crawls the first 2MB of a supported file type , and the first 64MB of a PDF file. From a rendering perspective, each resource referenced in the HTML (such as CSS and JavaScript) is fetched separately, and each resource fetch is bound by the same file size limit that applies to other files (except PDF files). Once the cutoff limit is reached, Googlebot stops the”

D24 · Googlebot · How Googlebot accesses your site

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE · EXACT EXCERPT

“first 64MB of a PDF file. From a rendering perspective, each resource referenced in the HTML (such as CSS and JavaScript) is fetched separately, and each resource fetch is bound by the same file size limit that applies to other files (except PDF files). Once the cutoff limit is reached, Googlebot stops the fetch and only sends the already downloaded part of the file for indexing consideration. The file size limit is”

D24 · Googlebot · How Googlebot accesses your site

QUESTION 209 · D24

Is a Googlebot user-agent enough to establish authenticity?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

No. It is often spoofed. Verify through the documented DNS method or source-IP matching against Google's published ranges.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Before you decide to block Googlebot, be aware that the HTTP user-agent request header used by Googlebot is often spoofed by other crawlers. It's important to verify that a problematic request actually comes from Google. The best way to verify that a request actually comes from Googlebot is to use a reverse DNS lookup on the source IP of the request, or to match the source IP against the Googlebot IP ranges .”

D24 · Googlebot · Verifying Googlebot

QUESTION 210 · D24

Can keeping a site unlinked keep it secret from Googlebot?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

Not reliably. The guide explains that referrer information and other exposure can reveal the URL. Use actual access restrictions for private content.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Googlebot discovers new URLs to crawl primarily from links embedded in previously crawled pages. It's almost impossible to keep a site secret by not publishing links to it. For example, as soon as someone clicks a link from your "secret" site to another site, your "secret" site URL may appear in the referrer tag and can be stored and published by the other site in its referrer log.”

D24 · Googlebot · Blocking Googlebot from visiting your site

Reduce the Google crawl rate

Google last updated: 2025-12-18 · Reviewed 6 October 2026

<https://developers.google.com/crawling/docs/crawlers-fetchers/reduce-crawl-rate>

Detailed points to revise

- Google automatically chooses crawl rates to discover content without overloading infrastructure.
- Investigate recent access logs and hosting evidence first. Common sources of sudden load are facets/sorting, large calendars, and Dynamic Search Ad targets.
- Emergency reduction can use 500, 503, or 429 responses for a few hours or at most about one to two days. Significant error volumes reduce crawling across the hostname, including successful URLs.
- Rate increases again as errors subside. Keeping these codes on the same URLs for days can cause Search index loss and other product effects.
- Tradeoffs include slower discovery, less current prices/availability, delayed removal, and possible advertising interruptions.
- If server responses cannot be changed, submit the exceptional high-crawl report with the desired rate. Evaluation may take days; this is not a way to request an increased rate.

Complete source section checklist: Understand the cause of the sharp increase in crawling · Urgently reduce crawler traffic (for emergencies) · Exceptional requests to reduce crawl rate

QUESTION 211 · D25

What should you check before blaming Google for a crawl spike?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

Verify requests and inspect recent server logs/hosting evidence. The guide highlights faceted filtering, expansive calendars, and Dynamic Search Ad targets as common causes.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Sharp increase in crawling may be caused by inefficiencies in your site's structure or issues with your site otherwise. Based on the reports we've received in the past, the most common causes are:”

D25 · Reduce the Google crawl rate · Understand the cause of the sharp increase in crawling

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“We strongly recommend that you check with your hosting company and look at recent access logs of your server to understand the source of the traffic, and see if it fits in the aforementioned common causes of the sharp increase in crawling. Then, check our guides about managing crawling of faceted navigation URLs and optimizing crawling efficiency.”

D25 · Reduce the Google crawl rate · Understand the cause of the sharp increase in crawling

QUESTION 212 · D25

How can you urgently reduce Google crawler traffic?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

Temporarily return 500, 503, or 429 instead of 200 for crawl requests. This is an emergency measure for hours or about one to two days, not a long-term configuration.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE · EXACT EXCERPT

“If you need to urgently reduce the crawl rate for short period of time (for example, a couple of hours, or 1-2 days), then return 500 , 503 , or 429 HTTP response status code instead of 200 to the crawl requests. Google's crawling infrastructure reduces your site's crawling rate when it encounters a significant number of URLs with 500 , 503 , or 429 HTTP response”

D25 · Reduce the Google crawl rate · Urgently reduce crawler traffic (for emergencies)

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“: We don't recommend that you do this for a long period of time (meaning, longer than 1-2 days) as it may have a negative effect on how your site appears in Google products. For example, in case of Search, if Googlebot observes these status codes on the same URL for multiple days, the URL may be dropped from Google's index.”

D25 · Reduce the Google crawl rate · Urgently reduce crawler traffic (for emergencies)

QUESTION 213 · D25

Does emergency throttling affect only the URLs returning errors?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

No. The documented rate reduction affects the whole hostname, including successful-content URLs.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE · EXACT EXCERPT

“when it encounters a significant number of URLs with 500 , 503 , or 429 HTTP response status codes (for example, if you disabled your website). The reduced crawl rate affects the whole hostname of your site (for example, subdomain.example.com), both the crawling of the URLs that return errors, as well as the URLs that return content. Once the number of these errors is reduced, the crawl rate will”

D25 · Reduce the Google crawl rate · Urgently reduce crawler traffic (for emergencies)

QUESTION 214 · D25

What happens if those responses continue for many days?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

They can negatively affect Google product visibility. For Search, repeated errors on a URL for multiple days may lead to it being dropped from the index.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“: We don't recommend that you do this for a long period of time (meaning, longer than 1-2 days) as it may have a negative effect on how your site appears in Google products. For example, in case of Search, if Googlebot observes these status codes on the same URL for multiple days, the URL may be dropped from Google's index.”

D25 · Reduce the Google crawl rate · Urgently reduce crawler traffic (for emergencies)

QUESTION 215 · D25

Can the exceptional crawl-rate form request faster crawling?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

No. The page says you cannot request an increase and the reduction request may take several days to evaluate and fulfill.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“If serving errors to Google's crawlers is not feasible on your infrastructure, file a special request to report a problem with unusually high crawl rate, mentioning the optimal rate for your site in your request. You cannot request an increase in crawl rate, and it may take several days for the request to be evaluated and fulfilled.”

D25 · Reduce the Google crawl rate · Exceptional requests to reduce crawl rate

Verify requests from Google crawlers and fetchers

Google last updated: 2026-03-20 · Reviewed 6 October 2026

<https://developers.google.com/crawling/docs/crawlers-fetchers/verify-google-requests>

Detailed points to revise

- The verification table distinguishes common crawlers, special-case crawlers, and user-triggered fetchers, with separate DNS masks and JSON IP lists.
- User-triggered fetches ignore robots.txt because a user requested them; special-case requests may or may not obey it. Do not apply common-crawler rules to every category.
- For manual verification: reverse lookup the source IP, validate the appropriate Google-controlled domain, forward lookup that hostname, and ensure it returns the original IP.
- A reverse hostname alone is not the complete method. Check domain boundaries and use the category-specific masks shown in the reference.
- For automated verification, match the source IP against Google's published CIDR ranges in the appropriate category's JSON file.
- The page also links user-triggered agent ranges and a general Google IP list for other requests such as Apps Script. A generic cloud address is not automatically Search Googlebot.
- The complete reference preserves example host commands and every DNS mask/list name.

Complete source section checklist: Use command line tools · Use automatic solutions

QUESTION 216 · D26 Priority practice

How do you manually verify a Googlebot request?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

Reverse-resolve the logged source IP, verify the appropriate Google-controlled hostname, forward-resolve that hostname, and confirm it maps to the original IP. The user-agent alone does not do this.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Run a reverse DNS lookup on the accessing IP address from your logs, using the host command.”

D26 · Verify requests from Google crawlers and fetchers · Use command line tools

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Run a forward DNS lookup on the domain name retrieved in step 1 using the host command on the retrieved domain name.”

D26 · Verify requests from Google crawlers and fetchers · Use command line tools

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Verify that it's the same as the original accessing IP address from your logs.”

D26 · Verify requests from Google crawlers and fetchers · Use command line tools

QUESTION 217 · D26

Why is reverse DNS alone insufficient?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

The documented procedure also requires forward DNS to return the original source IP. Completing both directions checks the relationship rather than trusting an apparent name.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Run a forward DNS lookup on the domain name retrieved in step 1 using the host command on the retrieved domain name.”

D26 · Verify requests from Google crawlers and fetchers · Use command line tools

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Verify that it's the same as the original accessing IP address from your logs.”

D26 · Verify requests from Google crawlers and fetchers · Use command line tools

QUESTION 218 · D26

How do you verify at scale?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

Match the source IP to Google's published ranges for the relevant crawler/fetcher category. The JSON ranges use CIDR format.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Alternatively, you can identify Googlebot by IP address by matching the crawler's IP address to the lists of Google crawlers' and fetchers' IP ranges:”

D26 · Verify requests from Google crawlers and fetchers · Use automatic solutions

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“For other Google IP addresses from where your site may be accessed (for example, Apps Scripts), match the accessing IP address against the general list of Google IP addresses . Note that the IP addresses in the JSON files are represented in CIDR format .”

D26 · Verify requests from Google crawlers and fetchers · Use automatic solutions

QUESTION 219 · D26

Does every request from Google obey robots.txt?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

No. Common automatic crawlers do; special-case crawlers may or may not, and user-triggered fetchers ignore it according to this guide.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Common crawlers The common crawlers used for Google's products (such as Googlebot). They always respect robots.txt rules for automatic crawls. crawl-***_***_***_***.googlebot.com or geo-crawl-***_***_***_***.geo.googlebot.com common-crawlers.json”

D26 · Verify requests from Google crawlers and fetchers · Verify requests from Google crawlers and fetchers

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE · EXACT EXCERPT

“where the end user triggers a fetch. For example, Google Site Verifier acts on the request of a user. Because the fetch was requested by a user, these fetchers ignore robots.txt rules. Fetchers controlled by Google originate from IPs in the user-triggered-fetchers-google.json object and resolve to a google.com hostname. IPs in the user-triggered-fetchers.json object resolve to”

D26 · Verify requests from Google crawlers and fetchers · Verify requests from Google crawlers and fetchers

Introduction to robots.txt

Google last updated: 2025-12-10 · Reviewed 6 October 2026

<https://developers.google.com/search/docs/crawling-indexing/robots/intro>

Detailed points to revise

- robots.txt manages URL crawl access and traffic. It does not enforce privacy and is not reliable web-page/PDF index exclusion.
- Google can index a disallowed URL using external information without fetching its content; the result may appear without a description.
- Embedded media/resources on a blocked page may not be fetched through that page, but other crawlable references can expose them.
- For image/video/audio media, blocking the actual file can prevent it appearing in Search, although links and direct user access remain possible.
- Block unimportant resources only when their absence does not impair page understanding. Do not block critical scripts or CSS blindly.
- Crawlers choose whether to follow robots instructions and can interpret syntax differently. Malicious crawlers need access restrictions rather than voluntary rules.
- Use noindex with access allowed for index exclusion; use authentication for confidential material. Combining contradictory controls can defeat the intended result.
- CMS platforms may expose visibility settings instead of editable robots.txt. The source links creation, update, and specification guides.

Complete source section checklist: What is a robots.txt file used for? · Understand the limitations of a robots.txt file · Create or update a robots.txt file

QUESTION 220 · D27

What does robots.txt control?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

Crawler access to URLs and crawl traffic. It is not a privacy mechanism or reliable method for hiding a web page from Search.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“A robots.txt file tells search engine crawlers which URLs the crawler can access on your site. This is used mainly to avoid overloading your site with requests; it is not a mechanism for keeping a web page out of Google . To keep a web page out of Google, block indexing with noindex or password-protect the page.”

D27 · Introduction to robots.txt · Introduction to robots.txt

Why can a disallowed page still appear in Search?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

Google may find and index the URL through external links without visiting its content. The result can lack a description, so a crawl block is not the same as noindex.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE · EXACT EXCERPT

“PDFs and other text-based formats supported by Google) from Google Search results. If other pages point to your page with descriptive text, Google could still index the URL without visiting the page. If you want to block your page from search results, use another method such as password protection or noindex . If your web page is blocked with a robots.txt file , its URL can still appear in search results, but the”

D27 · Introduction to robots.txt · What is a robots.txt file used for?

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE · EXACT EXCERPT

“method such as password protection or noindex . If your web page is blocked with a robots.txt file , its URL can still appear in search results, but the search result won't have a description . Image files, video files, PDFs, and other non-HTML files embedded in the blocked page will be excluded from crawling, too, unless they're referenced by other pages that are allowed for crawling. If you see this”

D27 · Introduction to robots.txt · What is a robots.txt file used for?

Does robots.txt guarantee that no bot can retrieve private information?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

No. Its instructions cannot enforce crawler behavior. Use access restrictions, such as password protection, for confidential information.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“robots.txt rules may not be supported by all search engines. The instructions in robots.txt files cannot enforce crawler behavior to your site; it's up to the crawler to obey them. While Googlebot and other respectable web crawlers obey the instructions in a robots.txt file, other crawlers might not. Therefore, if you want to keep information secure from web crawlers, it's better to use other blocking methods, such as password-protecting private files on your server .”

D27 · Introduction to robots.txt · Understand the limitations of a robots.txt file

QUESTION 223 · D27

Can robots.txt prevent media appearing in Search?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

The guide distinguishes media from web pages: blocking image, video, or audio files can prevent their Search appearance, but does not stop users or other pages linking to them.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Media file Use a robots.txt file to manage crawl traffic, and also to prevent image, video, and audio files from appearing in Google Search results. This won't prevent other pages or users from linking to your image, video, or audio file. Read more about preventing images from appearing on Google. Read more about how to remove or restrict your video files from appearing on Google.”

D27 · Introduction to robots.txt · What is a robots.txt file used for?

QUESTION 224 · D27

Should you block JavaScript and stylesheets to reduce load?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

Only unimportant resources whose absence does not impair understanding. If the page becomes harder for Google to understand, do not block those resources.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Resource file You can use a robots.txt file to block resource files such as unimportant image, script, or style files, if you think that pages loaded without these resources won't be significantly affected by the loss . However, if the absence of these resources make the page harder for Google's crawler to understand the page, don't block them, or else Google won't do a good job of analyzing pages that depend on those resources.”

D27 · Introduction to robots.txt · What is a robots.txt file used for?

How Google interprets the robots.txt specification

Google last updated: 2026-08-31 · Reviewed 6 October 2026

<https://developers.google.com/crawling/docs/robots-txt/robots-txt-spec>

Detailed points to revise

- Google implements the Robots Exclusion Protocol with the documented exceptions for user-controlled fetches and safety crawling. The reference points to RFC 9309.
- Place robots.txt at the site's root. Scope is host, protocol, and port; subdirectories and unrelated subdomains/protocols are not covered. Standard default ports are equivalent; nonstandard ports have separate scope.
- 2xx: parse the file. 3xx: follow at least five hops, then treat unresolved robots redirection as 404; logical JS/frame/meta redirects are not followed.
- 4xx other than 429: treat the file as absent, with no restrictions. 401/403 are not valid throttling tools. DNS/network failures are treated as server errors.
- For robots 5xx failures: stop site crawling for the first 12 hours while retrying; then use the last good file for the next 30 days if available. Without cache, assume no restrictions. Later behavior depends on general site availability.
- Cache generally lasts up to 24 hours, with exceptions and Cache-Control effects. The file must be UTF-8 plain text; content after 500 KiB is ignored.
- Field names and user-agent matching are case-insensitive; allow/disallow path values are case-sensitive. Valid supported fields are user-agent, allow, disallow, sitemap. crawl-delay is not supported.
- Empty allow/disallow paths are ignored. Comments start with #. Sitemap locations are absolute, can be cross-host, and are not bound to one user-agent group.
- Most-specific matching user-agent group wins; group order is irrelevant. Multiple equally applicable specific groups merge, but the global * group is not merged into a specific group.
- Sitemaps do not break groups for the rules parser. Multiple consecutive user-agent lines can define one group.
- Raw UTF-8 and percent-encoded UTF-8 paths are compared in their encoded form. * matches zero or more characters; \$ anchors the URL end.
- Path matches are prefix-based and case-sensitive: /fish differs from /fish/ and /Fish. The full wildcard matching table is retained in the reference.
- For conflicting path rules, use the most specific rule by path length; equal-specificity conflicts use the least restrictive rule. Do not assume the last-written rule wins.

Complete source section checklist: What is a robots.txt file · File location and range of validity · Examples of valid robots.txt URLs · Handling of errors and HTTP status codes · Caching · File format · Syntax · user-agent · disallow · allow ·

QUESTION 225 · D28 **Priority practice**

Does one robots.txt apply to HTTP, HTTPS, and every subdomain?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

No. Its rules apply to the host, protocol, and port where it is hosted. Default ports are equivalent to their usual forms, but nonstandard ports and other hosts have separate scope.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“The rules listed in the robots.txt file apply only to the host, protocol, and port number where the robots.txt file is hosted.”

D28 · How Google interprets the robots.txt specification · File location and range of validity

QUESTION 226 · D28 **Priority practice**

What happens when robots.txt returns 404 or 403?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

Google treats 4xx responses other than 429 as if no valid robots file exists, with no crawl restrictions. 401/403 should not be used to limit crawl rate.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“4xx (client errors) Google's crawlers treat all 4xx errors, except 429 , as if a valid robots.txt file didn't exist. This means that Google assumes that there are no crawl restrictions. Don't use 401 and 403 status codes for limiting the crawl rate. The 4xx status codes, except 429 , have no effect on crawl rate. Learn how to limit your crawl rate .”

D28 · How Google interprets the robots.txt specification · Handling of errors and HTTP status codes

QUESTION 227 · D28 **Priority practice**

What happens when fetching robots.txt repeatedly fails with 5xx?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

The guide describes stopping crawling for the first 12 hours while retrying, then using the last good version for the next 30 days where available. Without a cached version, it assumes no restrictions; later behavior depends on overall site availability.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE · EXACT EXCERPT

“5xx (server errors) If Google finds a robots.txt file but can't fetch it, Google follows this behavior: For the first 12 hours, Google stops crawling the site but keeps trying to fetch the robots.txt file. If Google can't fetch a new version, for the next 30 days Google will use the last good version, while still trying to fetch a new version.”

D28 · How Google interprets the robots.txt specification · Handling of errors and HTTP status codes

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE · EXACT EXCERPT

“behavior: For the first 12 hours, Google stops crawling the site but keeps trying to fetch the robots.txt file. If Google can't fetch a new version, for the next 30 days Google will use the last good version, while still trying to fetch a new version. A 503 (service unavailable) error results in fairly frequent retrying. If there's no cached version available, Google assumes there's no”

D28 · How Google interprets the robots.txt specification · Handling of errors and HTTP status codes

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE · EXACT EXCERPT

“will use the last good version, while still trying to fetch a new version. A 503 (service unavailable) error results in fairly frequent retrying. If there's no cached version available, Google assumes there's no crawl restrictions. If the errors are still not fixed after 30 days: If the site is generally available to Google, Google will behave as if there is no robots.txt file (but still keep”

D28 · How Google interprets the robots.txt specification · Handling of errors and HTTP status codes

QUESTION 228 · D28

How long is robots.txt cached?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

Generally up to 24 hours, but longer caching can occur when refreshing is impossible, and Cache-Control can influence lifetime.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Google generally caches the contents of robots.txt file for up to 24 hours, but may cache it longer in situations where refreshing the cached version isn't possible (for example, due to timeouts or 5xx errors). The cached response may be shared by different crawlers. Google may increase or decrease the cache lifetime based on max-age Cache-Control HTTP headers.”

D28 · How Google interprets the robots.txt specification · Caching

QUESTION 229 · D28

What is Google's robots.txt file-size limit?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

500 KiB. Anything after the maximum is ignored; consolidate rules or organize excluded content to avoid oversized files.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Google enforces a robots.txt file size limit of 500 kibibytes (KiB). Content which is after the maximum file size is ignored. You can reduce the size of the robots.txt file by consolidating rules that would result in an oversized robots.txt file. For example, place excluded material in a separate directory.”

D28 · How Google interprets the robots.txt specification · File format

QUESTION 230 · D28 Priority practice

Does Google support crawl-delay or noindex in robots.txt?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

This specification's supported fields are user-agent, allow, disallow, and sitemap, and it explicitly says crawl-delay is unsupported. Google's separate noindex guide says noindex in robots.txt is unsupported.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Google supports the following fields (other fields such as crawl-delay aren't supported):”

D28 · How Google interprets the robots.txt specification · Syntax

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“There are two ways to implement noindex : as a <meta> tag and as an HTTP response header. They have the same effect; choose the method that is more convenient for your site and appropriate for the content type. Specifying the noindex rule in the robots.txt file is not supported by Google.”

D40 · Block Search indexing with noindex · Implementing noindex

QUESTION 231 · D28

Are robots rules case-sensitive?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

Field names and user-agent matching are case-insensitive. The URL/path values of allow and disallow are case-sensitive.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“A valid robots.txt line consists of a field, a colon, and a value. Field names are case-insensitive (for example, User-agent and user-agent are treated the same). Spaces are optional, but recommended to improve readability. Space at the beginning and at the end of the line is ignored. To include comments, precede your comment with the # character. Keep in mind that everything after the # character will be ignored. The general format is <field>:<value><#optional-comment>.”

D28 · How Google interprets the robots.txt specification · Syntax

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“The [path] value, if specified, is relative to the root of the website from where the robots.txt file was fetched (using the same protocol, port number, host and domain names). The path value must start with / to designate the root and the value is case-sensitive. Learn more about URL matching based on path values .”

D28 · How Google interprets the robots.txt specification · Syntax

QUESTION 232 · D28 Priority practice

Does Google combine the * group with a specific Googlebot group?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

No. It chooses the most-specific applicable group. Multiple specific groups for the same agent merge, but a specific group and the global group do not.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“If there's more than one specific group declared for a user agent, all the rules from the groups applicable to the specific user agent are combined internally into a single group. User agent specific groups and global groups (*) are not combined.”

D28 · How Google interprets the robots.txt specification · Order of precedence for user agents

QUESTION 233 · D28 Priority practice

Does the last robots rule win when two rules conflict?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

No. The most-specific path rule wins; equal-specificity conflicts use the least restrictive rule. Group ordering is also irrelevant.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“When matching robots.txt rules to URLs, crawlers use the most specific rule based on the length of the rule path. In case of conflicting rules, including those with wildcards, Google uses the least restrictive rule.”

D28 · How Google interprets the robots.txt specification · Order of precedence for rules

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“https://example.com/page.php5 allow: /page disallow: /*.ph Applicable rule : allow: /page , because in case of conflicting rules, Google uses the least restrictive rule.”

D28 · How Google interprets the robots.txt specification · Order of precedence for rules

QUESTION 234 · D28

How do * and \$ work in robots paths?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

The star represents zero or more valid characters; the dollar symbol marks the end of the URL. Prefix and case sensitivity still matter.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“* designates 0 or more instances of any valid character.”

D28 · How Google interprets the robots.txt specification · URL matching based on path values

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“\$ designates the end of the URL.”

D28 · How Google interprets the robots.txt specification · URL matching based on path values

QUESTION 235 · D28

Can a Sitemap line reference another host or sit outside a crawler group?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

Yes. It must be a complete URL, need not share the robots host, and is not tied to a specific user agent. Multiple lines are permitted.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“The [absoluteURL] line points to the location of a sitemap or sitemap index file. It must be a fully qualified URL, including the protocol and host, and doesn't have to be URL-encoded. The URL doesn't have to be on the same host as the robots.txt file. You can specify multiple sitemap fields, with no limit to the number of sitemaps you can include. The sitemap field isn't tied to any specific user agent and may be followed by all crawlers, provided it isn't disallowed for crawling.”

D28 · How Google interprets the robots.txt specification · sitemap

QUESTION 236 · D28

Does /fish block only a directory named fish?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

No. It matches paths beginning /fish, such as /fish.html or /fishheads. /fish/ is narrower, and matching is case-sensitive.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“/fish Matches any path that starts with /fish . Note that the matching is case-sensitive. Matches: /fish /fish.html /fish/salmon.html /fishheads /fishheads/yummy.html /fish.php?id=anything Doesn't match: /Fish.asp /catfish /?id=fish /desert/fish”

D28 · How Google interprets the robots.txt specification · URL matching based on path values

What is canonicalization

Google last updated: 2026-08-20 · Reviewed 6 October 2026

<https://developers.google.com/search/docs/crawling-indexing/canonicalization>

Detailed points to revise

- Canonicalization selects a representative URL from duplicate or very similar content; it is also called deduplication.
- Common duplicate sources: regional same-language versions, mobile/desktop variants, HTTP/HTTPS, sorting/filtering, and accidentally public demo sites.
- Some duplication is normal and not a spam violation, but many duplicate URLs can confuse users and fragment reporting.
- Google identifies primary content, clusters similar pages, and selects the most complete/useful representative using collected signals.
- Canonicals are crawled most regularly; alternates are crawled less frequently to reduce site load.
- HTTPS, redirects, sitemap inclusion, and canonical annotations influence selection. A stated preference is a hint, not a command.
- Genuine translated primary content is not duplicate just because the layout is shared; translating only headers/footers while retaining the same main language is different.
- Same-language regional variants can use canonicalization and hreflang together. Results usually point to the canonical but can select a better-suited alternate.

Complete source section checklist: How Google indexes and chooses the canonical URL

QUESTION 237 · D29

What is canonicalization?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

Google selects a representative canonical URL from duplicate or very similar pages so it can avoid showing redundant versions. It is a deduplication process, not an automatic penalty.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Canonicalization is the process of selecting the representative – canonical – URL of a piece of content. Consequently, a canonical URL is the URL of a page that Google chose as the most representative from a set of duplicate pages. Often called deduplication, this process helps Google show only one version of the otherwise duplicate content in its search results.”

D29 · What is canonicalization · What is canonicalization

QUESTION 238 · D29 Priority practice

Does a canonical declaration force Google's selection?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

No. Your preference is a hint. Google uses multiple collected signals and may choose a different representative.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“There are a handful of factors that play a role in canonicalization: whether the page is served over HTTP or HTTPS, redirects, presence of the URL in a sitemap, and rel="canonical" link annotations. You can indicate your preference to Google using these techniques, but Google may choose a different page as canonical than you do, for various reasons. That is, indicating a canonical preference is a hint, not a rule.”

D29 · What is canonicalization · How Google indexes and chooses the canonical URL

QUESTION 239 · D29

Are fully translated language versions duplicates?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

The guide says language versions count as duplicates only when their primary content is in the same language. Translating just headers and footers does not make unchanged main content distinct.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE · EXACT EXCERPT

“Different language versions of a single page are considered duplicates only if the primary content is in the same language (that is, if only the header, footer, and other non-critical text is translated, but the body remains the same, then the pages are considered to be duplicates). For regional variants in the same language (for example,”

D29 · What is canonicalization · How Google indexes and chooses the canonical URL

QUESTION 240 · D29

Which duplicate version is crawled more frequently?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

The canonical is crawled most regularly; duplicate versions are crawled less often to reduce load.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“When Google indexes a page, it determines the primary content (or centerpiece) of each page. If Google finds multiple pages that seem to be the same or the primary content very similar, it clusters them together. Google then chooses the page that, based on the factors (or signals) the indexing process collected, is objectively the most complete and useful for search users, and marks it as the canonical. The canonical page will be crawled most regularly; duplicates are crawled less frequently in order to reduce the crawling load on sites.”

D29 · What is canonicalization · How Google indexes and chooses the canonical URL

QUESTION 241 · D29

Can Google display an alternate rather than the canonical?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

Yes. Results usually use the canonical, but a duplicate may be better suited to a particular user, such as a mobile version for a mobile user.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Google uses the canonical page as the main source to evaluate content and quality. A Google Search result usually points to the canonical page, unless one of the duplicates is explicitly better suited for a search user. For example, the search result will probably point to the mobile page if the user is on a mobile device, even if the desktop page is the canonical.”

D29 · What is canonicalization · How Google indexes and chooses the canonical URL

How to specify a canonical URL with `rel="canonical"` and other methods

Google last updated: 2026-07-10 · Reviewed 6 October 2026

<https://developers.google.com/search/docs/crawling-indexing/consolidate-duplicate-urls>

Detailed points to revise

- Redirects and `rel=canonical` annotations are strong signals; sitemap inclusion is weak. Consistent methods can reinforce each other, but an explicit preference is not required for every site.
- Benefits: preferred visible URLs, consolidated signals, simpler metrics, and less duplicate crawling.
- Do not use robots.txt, the Removals tool, fragments, or noindex as canonicalization substitutes. Keep signals consistent and link internally to canonical URLs.
- The current guide explicitly recommends a self-referential canonical on the canonical page. hreflang should point to an appropriate same-language canonical, with the documented substitute exception.
- Prefer canonical in original HTML. If JavaScript must supply it, do not contradict or replace a different source-HTML canonical; avoid multiple conflicting declarations.
- An HTML canonical belongs in a valid head. Absolute URLs are recommended even though relative paths are supported.
- A Link HTTP response header can specify canonicals for supported non-HTML documents such as PDFs; this header method is supported for web search results only.
- Do not add alternate-language/media/type attributes to the canonical annotation and assume they set canonicals; use proper alternate annotations for those relationships.
- Prefer choosing either the HTML annotation or HTTP header instead of implementing both inconsistently. Sitemaps nominate preferred URLs but do not explicitly map duplicates to them.
- Use permanent redirects when deprecating duplicate pages. All permanent methods have the same Search effect, but HTTP redirects are generally noticed most quickly.
- HTTPS is usually preferred, but invalid certificates, insecure dependencies, HTTPS-to-HTTP redirects or HTTP canonical signals can override it. HSTS cannot repair conflicting certificate/redirect failures.
- URLs in reciprocal hreflang clusters may be preferred to otherwise similar URLs outside the cluster. The complete implementation comparisons and examples are in the reference.

Complete source section checklist: Reasons to specify a canonical URL · Best practices · Comparison of canonicalization methods · Use `rel="canonical"` link annotations · The `rel="canonical"` link element · The `rel="canonical"` HTTP header · Use a sitemap · Use redirects · Other signals · Prefer HTTPS over HTTP for canonical URLs · Prefer URLs in hreflang clusters

How strong are the main canonicalization signals?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

The guide calls redirects and rel=canonical annotations strong, and sitemap inclusion weak. Consistent combinations can reinforce a preference, but none guarantees Google's final choice.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Redirects : A strong signal that the target of the redirect should become canonical.”

D30 · How to specify a canonical URL with rel="canonical" and other methods · How to specify a canonical URL with rel="canonical" and other methods

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“rel="canonical" link annotations : A strong signal that the specified URL should become canonical.”

D30 · How to specify a canonical URL with rel="canonical" and other methods · How to specify a canonical URL with rel="canonical" and other methods

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Sitemap inclusion : A weak signal that helps the URLs that are included in a sitemap become canonical.”

D30 · How to specify a canonical URL with rel="canonical" and other methods · How to specify a canonical URL with rel="canonical" and other methods

Why not use noindex to choose a canonical?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

It blocks a page from Search rather than simply expressing a preferred duplicate representative. The guide prefers canonical annotations for that purpose.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“We don't recommend using noindex to prevent selection of a canonical page within a single site, because it will completely block the page from Search. rel="canonical" link annotations are the preferred solution.”

D30 · How to specify a canonical URL with rel="canonical" and other methods · Best practices

Should the canonical page have a self-referential canonical?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

Yes. This current version explicitly says to include a canonical link on the canonical page itself. Keep it consistent with other signals.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Do include a rel="canonical" link on the canonical page itself (also known as a self-referential canonical).”

D30 · How to specify a canonical URL with rel="canonical" and other methods · Best practices

How can a PDF or Word document declare its canonical?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

Use a Link HTTP response header with rel=canonical and an absolute target URL. The guide supports that method for web search results, including non-HTML documents.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“If you can change the configuration of your server, you can use a link HTTP response header with a rel="canonical" target attribute as defined by RFC5988 rather than an HTML element to indicate the canonical URL for a document supported by Search, including non-HTML documents such as PDF files.”

D30 · How to specify a canonical URL with rel="canonical" and other methods · The rel="canonical" HTTP header

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Google supports this method for web search results only.”

D30 · How to specify a canonical URL with rel="canonical" and other methods · The rel="canonical" HTTP header

Can JavaScript change a different canonical already in the HTML?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

The guide recommends setting it in source HTML without later contradiction. If source HTML cannot supply it, leave it absent there and set it with JavaScript instead of producing conflicting signals.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“If you're using client-side rendering with JavaScript, it's important to make sure that the information about the canonical URL is as clear as possible. The best way to do this is to specify the canonical URL in the HTML source code and make sure that JavaScript doesn't change the canonical link element. If you can't set the canonical URL in the HTML source code, leave it out and only set it with JavaScript. This ensures that the information about the canonical URL is as clear as possible.”

D30 · How to specify a canonical URL with rel="canonical" and other methods · Best practices

QUESTION 247 · D30

Are relative canonical URLs supported?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

Yes, but absolute URLs are recommended because relative paths can cause errors such as accidentally pointing within a testing environment.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Use absolute paths rather than relative paths with the rel="canonical" link element. Even though relative paths are supported by Google, they can cause problems in the long run (for example, if you unintentionally allow your testing site to be crawled) and thus we don't recommend them.”

D30 · How to specify a canonical URL with rel="canonical" and other methods · The rel="canonical" link element

QUESTION 248 · D30

Does HTTPS always win canonical selection?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

No. It is preferred by default, but certificate errors, insecure dependencies, redirects through HTTP, and an HTTP canonical can create conflicting signals.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Google prefers HTTPS pages over equivalent HTTP pages as canonical, except when there are issues or conflicting signals such as the following:”

D30 · How to specify a canonical URL with rel="canonical" and other methods · Prefer HTTPS over HTTP for canonical URLs

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“The HTTPS page has an invalid SSL certificate.”

D30 · How to specify a canonical URL with rel="canonical" and other methods · Prefer HTTPS over HTTP for canonical URLs

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“The HTTPS page has a rel="canonical" link to the HTTP page.”

D30 · How to specify a canonical URL with rel="canonical" and other methods · Prefer HTTPS over HTTP for canonical URLs

QUESTION 249 · D30

Can robots.txt or the Removals tool be used to consolidate duplicates?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

The guide says not to use either for canonicalization. A crawl-blocked URL may still be indexed without content, while removal hides versions rather than expressing a canonical relationship.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Don't use the robots.txt file for canonicalization purposes. Google may still index URLs that are disallowed in robots.txt without their content.”

D30 · How to specify a canonical URL with rel="canonical" and other methods · Best practices

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Don't use the URL removal tool for canonicalization. It hides all versions of a URL from Search.”

D30 · How to specify a canonical URL with rel="canonical" and other methods · Best practices

Fix canonicalization issues

Google last updated: 2026-08-21 · Reviewed 6 October 2026

<https://developers.google.com/search/docs/crawling-indexing/canonicalization-troubleshooting>

Detailed points to revise

- Inspect the Google-selected canonical in URL Inspection, then consider whether it might actually be the better representative for users.
- If the canonical is in a property you do not own, you cannot see the duplicate's traffic in that property's data.
- Check CMS canonical/redirect errors, server host misconfigurations, missing localized annotations, hacked redirects or cross-domain canonicals, syndication, and external copies.
- When distinct pages were incorrectly clustered, make their primary content clearly and significantly different. Purely cosmetic differentiation is not the advice.
- The current guide says duplicate-cluster reassessment can take up to two weeks; clear content differences may separate faster. This is not a guaranteed resolution deadline for all cases.
- Request indexing for the important corrected URLs within quota.
- Canonical elements are not the recommended way to prevent syndication duplication; the source recommends partners block indexing when that is the objective.
- Copyright removal and host contact are mentioned for unauthorized copies; retain them as source pointers, not legal advice about a specific dispute.

Complete source section checklist: Common canonicalization issues · Language variants without localized annotations · Incorrect canonical elements · Misconfigured servers · Malicious hacking · Syndicated content · A copycat website

QUESTION 250 · D31 Priority practice

How do you investigate an unexpected Google canonical?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

Use URL Inspection, evaluate whether the chosen page serves users better, then check canonical annotations, redirects, localization, server configuration, and possible compromise.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Check which page Google considers to be the canonical page: Use the URL Inspection tool to check which page Google considers canonical and think about whether the Google-selected canonical makes more sense than your preferred canonical URL for your users coming from Google Search. Important: If a canonical URL is in a Search Console property that you don't own, you won't be able to see any of the traffic for your duplicate page.”

D31 · Fix canonicalization issues · Fix canonicalization issues

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Look for technical canonicalization issues: Verify whether an unexpected canonical URL preference is being signaled through technical misconfigurations. Review the common canonicalization issues table to check for issues like incorrect canonical elements, server misconfigurations, or missing localization annotations.”

D31 · [Fix canonicalization issues](#) · [Fix canonicalization issues](#)

QUESTION 251 · D31

What if two genuinely different pages remain clustered?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

Make the main content clearly and significantly different, fix the underlying issue, and request indexing for priority URLs. The guide says re-evaluation can take time and pages can remain clustered for up to two weeks.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Ensure clustered pages are sufficiently different: Fixing canonicalization issues technically boils down to ensuring that the pages that are clustered together are sufficiently different. Things to keep in mind: Re-evaluation takes time: Even after fixing content issues, Google might hold pages in a duplicate cluster for up to two weeks . Content difference matters: Pages will generally split out faster if the difference between the new content and the other clustered pages is clear and significant.”

D31 · [Fix canonicalization issues](#) · [Fix canonicalization issues](#)

QUESTION 252 · D31

Can a server error cause cross-domain canonical selection?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

Yes. The guide describes a server returning one domain's content for requests to another, or unrelated servers producing identical soft 404 pages.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Misconfigured servers Some hosting misconfigurations may cause unexpected cross-domain URL selection. For example: A server may be misconfigured to return content from example.com in response to a request for a URL on other.example Two unrelated web servers may return identical soft 404 pages that Google fails to identify as error pages. If you notice this is the case, get in touch with your hosting provider.”

D31 · [Fix canonicalization issues](#) · [Common canonicalization issues](#)

QUESTION 253 · D31

How can a hacked site lose its preferred canonical?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

Attackers may inject cross-domain canonical annotations or 3xx redirects to malicious/spam pages, which can affect Google's selection.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Malicious hacking Some attacks on websites introduce code that returns an HTTP 3xx redirect or inserts a cross-domain rel="canonical" link annotation into the HTML <head> or HTTP header, usually pointing to a URL hosting malicious or spammy content. In these cases, our algorithms may choose the malicious or spammy URL instead of the URL on the compromised website .”

D31 · Fix canonicalization issues · Common canonicalization issues

QUESTION 254 · D31

Is rel=canonical the recommended protection against syndication duplicates?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

This page says it is not recommended because partner pages can be very different. It describes partner index blocking as the most effective solution for that objective.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Syndicated content The canonical link element is not recommended for those who want to avoid duplication by syndication partners, because the pages are often very different. The most effective solution is for partners to block indexing of your content. For more, see Avoid article duplication in Google News , which also has advice about blocking syndicated content from Google Search.”

D31 · Fix canonicalization issues · Common canonicalization issues

Mobile site and mobile-first indexing best practices

Google last updated: 2025-12-10 · Reviewed 6 October 2026

<https://developers.google.com/search/docs/crawling-indexing/mobile/mobile-sites-mobile-first-indexing>

Detailed points to revise

- Google uses smartphone-crawled mobile content for indexing and ranking. A separate mobile version is not required for inclusion, but mobile friendliness is strongly recommended.
- Configurations: responsive design (same URL/HTML, adaptive display), dynamic serving (same URL, different HTML, user-agent/Vary handling), and separate URLs. Responsive design is recommended as easiest to implement and maintain.
- Keep mobile resources crawlable, robots directives equivalent, and primary content available without click/swipe/type requirements.
- Maintain equivalent content and meaningful headings. Tabs and accordions can save space while preserving content; removing mobile information can reduce what Google knows.
- Keep structured data on both versions, with correct mobile URLs; the guide prioritizes Breadcrumb, Product, and VideoObject if necessary. Keep titles and descriptions equivalent.
- Avoid disruptive mobile ads. Provide high-quality supported images, equivalent alt text/captions, and stable resource URLs. Different mobile image URLs can cause temporary image-traffic effects.
- Videos need supported formats/tags, stable URLs, equivalent markup, and prominent placement.
- For m-dot: match error states, do not collapse distinct desktop pages into one mobile homepage, avoid fragment routes, verify both properties, and allow sufficient host capacity.
- Keep mobile hreflang links between mobile URLs and desktop hreflang links between desktop URLs. In the documented separate-URL setup, desktop remains canonical and mobile is its alternate, even with mobile-first indexing.
- The full source contains every troubleshooting entry: missing markup/images/alt/title/description, noindex, blocked resources, low-quality images, error URLs, fragments, duplicates, mobile-home redirects, ads/content/video quality, and hostload.

Complete source section checklist: Create a mobile-friendly site · Make sure that Google can access and render your content · Make sure that content is the same on desktop and mobile · Check your structured data · Put the same metadata on both versions of your site · Check the placement of your ads · Check visual content · Check your images · Check your videos · Additional best practices for separate URLs · Mobile · Desktop · Mobile · Desktop · Troubleshooting · Missing structured data · noindex tag on pages · Missing image · Blocked image · Low quality image · Missing alt text · Missing page title · Missing meta description · Mobile URL is an error page · Mobile URL has anchor fragment · Mobile page blocked by robots.txt · Duplicate mobile page target · Desktop site redirects to the mobile home page · Page quality issues · Video issues · Hostload issues

QUESTION 255 · D32

Does mobile-first indexing mean Google has a separate mobile index?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

This page defines it as using the mobile version's content, crawled with the smartphone agent, for indexing and ranking. Explain that documented behavior instead of inventing a separate index requirement.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Google uses the mobile version of a site's content, crawled with the smartphone agent , for indexing and ranking. This is called mobile-first indexing .”

D32 · Mobile site and mobile-first indexing best practices · Mobile site and mobile-first indexing best practices

QUESTION 256 · D32

Which mobile configuration does Google recommend?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

Responsive Web Design, because it is the easiest design pattern to implement and maintain. Dynamic serving and separate URLs are also described with their additional implementation requirements.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Responsive design: Serves the same HTML code on the same URL regardless of the users' device (for example, desktop, tablet, mobile, non-visual browser), but can display the content differently based on the screen size. Google recommends Responsive Web Design because it's the easiest design pattern to implement and maintain.”

D32 · Mobile site and mobile-first indexing best practices · Create a mobile-friendly site

QUESTION 257 · D32

Can mobile content live in tabs or accordions?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

Yes, if it remains equivalent to the desktop content. Saving visual space is fine; removing important mobile content reduces the information used for indexing.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE · EXACT EXCERPT

“so that its primary content is equivalent to your desktop site. You can have a different design on mobile to maximize user experience (for example, moving content into accordions or tabs); just make sure that the content is equivalent to the desktop site, since indexing on your site comes from the mobile site. If it's your intention that the mobile page should have less content than the desktop page,”

D32 · Mobile site and mobile-first indexing best practices · Make sure that content is the same on desktop and mobile

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE · EXACT EXCERPT

“to your desktop site. You can have a different design on mobile to maximize user experience (for example, moving content into accordions or tabs); just make sure that the content is equivalent to the desktop site, since indexing on your site comes from the mobile site. If it's your intention that the mobile page should have less content than the desktop page, you can expect some traffic loss when your site”

D32 · Mobile site and mobile-first indexing best practices · Make sure that content is the same on desktop and mobile

QUESTION 258 · D32 Priority practice

What mobile/desktop parity should you audit?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

Primary content, headings, robots instructions, structured data, titles/descriptions, relevant images and alt text, and video details. Mobile resources must also be accessible.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Use the same robots meta tags on the mobile and desktop site. If you use a different robots meta tag on the mobile site (especially the noindex or nofollow tags), Google may fail to crawl and index your page when your site is enabled for mobile-first indexing.”

D32 · Mobile site and mobile-first indexing best practices · Make sure that Google can access and render your content

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Make sure that your mobile and desktop sites have the same structured data. If you have to prioritize which types you add to your mobile site, start with Breadcrumb , Product , and VideoObject structured data.”

D32 · Mobile site and mobile-first indexing best practices · Check your structured data

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Make sure that the title element and the meta description are equivalent across both versions of your site.”

D32 · Mobile site and mobile-first indexing best practices · Put the same metadata on both versions of your site

For m-dot pages, must the mobile URL become canonical?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

The guide's separate-URL configuration keeps the desktop URL canonical and the mobile URL as its alternate. Mobile-first content processing does not change that documented relationship.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE · EXACT EXCERPT

“Use the correct rel=canonical and rel=alternate link elements between your mobile and desktop versions. The desktop URL is always the canonical, and the mobile version is the alternate of that URL. Here's an example of rel=canonical and rel=alternate for a separate URLs site setup. Mobile In this example, the mobile site URL is https://m.example.com/ and”

D32 · Mobile site and mobile-first indexing best practices · Additional best practices for separate URLs

How should hreflang work with separate mobile and desktop URLs?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

Connect mobile alternates to mobile URLs and desktop alternates to desktop URLs, preserving the correct canonical/alternate relationship.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE · EXACT EXCERPT

“hreflang links on separate URLs. When you use rel=hreflang link elements for internationalization , link between mobile and desktop URLs separately. Your mobile URLs' hreflang must point to mobile URLs, and similarly desktop URL hreflang must point to desktop URLs. Here's an example of hreflang for the home page of a site with separate URLs for mobile and desktop. Mobile In this example, the mobile site URL is”

D32 · Mobile site and mobile-first indexing best practices · Additional best practices for separate URLs

Why is redirecting many desktop pages to one mobile homepage dangerous?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

Their distinct content no longer has equivalent mobile destinations; the guide warns those pages can be missing from the index.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Ensure that the desktop versions that serve different contents have equivalent mobile versions. If different URLs redirect to the same URL (for example, to the home page on mobile devices) after your domain is enabled for mobile-first indexing, all these pages will be missing from the index.”

D32 · Mobile site and mobile-first indexing best practices · Additional best practices for separate URLs

QUESTION 262 · D32

Can important content load only after a user clicks or swipes?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

Do not require that. The guide says Google will not load content requiring those user interactions; verify content and resources in the mobile rendered output.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Don't lazy-load primary content upon user interaction. Google won't load content that requires user interactions (for example, swiping, clicking, or typing) to load. Make sure that Google can see lazy-loaded content .”

D32 · Mobile site and mobile-first indexing best practices · Make sure that Google can access and render your content

Understand the JavaScript SEO basics

Google last updated: 2026-03-04 · Reviewed 6 October 2026

<https://developers.google.com/search/docs/crawling-indexing/javascript/javascript-seo-basics>

Detailed points to revise

- JavaScript processing has crawl, render, and index phases. Google checks robots access first, extracts links from initial HTML, and later from rendered HTML.
- The guide says 200 responses queue for rendering unless noindex rules prevent it; non-200 responses may skip rendering. Queue time varies, not a fixed delay.
- Server-side/prerendered content remains useful for performance and clients that do not execute JavaScript.
- JavaScript can set titles/descriptions and canonicals, but avoid changing a different source canonical or creating conflicting multiple canonicals. Prefer original HTML where feasible.
- Use compatible code, feature detection, and appropriate polyfills/fallbacks. Meaningful HTTP status codes communicate missing, restricted, and moved content.
- SPAs should not return indexable successful-looking error pages: redirect to a real server 404 URL or add noindex for the error state.
- Use real a href links and History API routes rather than fragments for distinct views.
- Do not expect JavaScript to remove an initial noindex: Google may skip the rendering required to do so.
- Googlebot/WRS caching can retain old CSS/JS despite cache headers; content-fingerprinted filenames solve version ambiguity.
- JavaScript can inject JSON-LD; test it. Web components are supported by flattening light/shadow DOM, with slot projection where needed. Check actual rendered HTML for meaningful content.
- The full reference preserves examples for SPA routing, API errors, canonical injection, robots rules, and web components.

Complete source section checklist: How Google processes JavaScript · Describe your page with unique titles and snippets · Set the canonical URL · Write compatible code · Use meaningful HTTP status codes · Avoid soft 404 errors in single-page apps · Use the History API instead of fragments · Properly inject the rel="canonical" link tag · Use robots meta tags carefully · Use long-lived caching · Use structured data · Follow best practices for web components · Fix images and lazy-loaded content

QUESTION 263 · D33

Priority practice

How does Google process a JavaScript app?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

It crawls, renders, and indexes. It checks crawl permission, extracts initial HTML links, queues rendering where applicable, and uses rendered HTML for content and another link-discovery pass.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Google processes JavaScript web apps in three main phases:”

D33 · Understand the JavaScript SEO basics · How Google processes JavaScript

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Googlebot queues all pages with a 200 HTTP status code for rendering, unless a robots meta tag or header tells Google not to index the page. The page may stay on this queue for a few seconds, but it can take longer than that. Once Google's resources allow, a headless Chromium renders the page and executes the JavaScript. Googlebot parses the rendered HTML for links again and queues the URLs it finds for crawling. Google also uses the rendered HTML to index the page.”

D33 · Understand the JavaScript SEO basics · How Google processes JavaScript

QUESTION 264 · D33

Does server-side rendering become unnecessary because Google runs JS?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

No. The guide still recommends it as a useful idea for speed and because not all bots run JavaScript.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Keep in mind that server-side or pre-rendering is still a great idea because it makes your website faster for users and crawlers, and not all bots can run JavaScript.”

D33 · Understand the JavaScript SEO basics · How Google processes JavaScript

QUESTION 265 · D33

Priority practice

Can JavaScript remove an initial noindex so Google indexes the page?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

Do not rely on it. When Google sees noindex, it may skip rendering and JS execution, so it may never see the removal.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“tag, it may skip rendering and JavaScript execution, which means using JavaScript to change or remove the”

D33 · Understand the JavaScript SEO basics · Use robots meta tags carefully

QUESTION 266 · D33

How can a client-routed SPA avoid soft 404 errors?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

Use the documented strategies: redirect a missing state to a server URL returning 404, or add noindex to the error page. Do not return a misleading successful indexable state for absent content.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Use a JavaScript redirect to a URL for which the server responds with a 404 HTTP status code (for example /not-found).”

D33 · Understand the JavaScript SEO basics · Avoid soft 404 errors in single-page apps

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Add a <meta name="robots" content="noindex"> to error pages using JavaScript.”

D33 · Understand the JavaScript SEO basics · Avoid soft 404 errors in single-page apps

QUESTION 267 · D33 Priority practice

Why use content fingerprints in JS and CSS filenames?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

WRS can cache aggressively and ignore caching headers. A filename derived from the content changes when the resource changes, avoiding an old resource at an unchanged URL.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Googlebot caches aggressively in order to reduce network requests and resource usage. WRS may ignore caching headers. This may lead WRS to use outdated JavaScript or CSS resources. Content fingerprinting avoids this problem by making a fingerprint of the content part of the filename, like main.2bb85551.js . The fingerprint depends on the content of the file, so updates generate a different filename every time. Check out the web.dev guide on long-lived caching strategies to learn more.”

D33 · Understand the JavaScript SEO basics · Use long-lived caching

QUESTION 268 · D33

Can Google index web component content?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

The guide supports web components and flattens light/shadow DOM during rendering. The relevant content must actually be visible in rendered HTML; test with URL Inspection or Rich Results Test.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Google supports web components. When Google renders a page, it flattens the shadow DOM and light DOM content. This means Google can only see content that's visible in the rendered HTML. To make sure that Google can still see your content after it's rendered, use the Rich Results Test or the URL Inspection Tool and look at the rendered HTML.”

D33 · Understand the JavaScript SEO basics · Follow best practices for web components

QUESTION 269 · D33

Can JavaScript add structured data or page metadata?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

The guide allows generated JSON-LD and title/description changes, with testing. Canonicals need particular care to avoid conflicting source and rendered declarations.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Unique, descriptive <title> elements and meta descriptions help users quickly identify the best result for their goal. You can use JavaScript to set or change the meta description as well as the <title> element.”

D33 · Understand the JavaScript SEO basics · Describe your page with unique titles and snippets

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“When using structured data on your pages, you can use JavaScript to generate the required JSON-LD and inject it into the page . Make sure to test your implementation to avoid issues.”

D33 · Understand the JavaScript SEO basics · Use structured data

Fix Search-related JavaScript problems

Google last updated: 2025-12-18 · Reviewed 6 October 2026

<https://developers.google.com/search/docs/crawling-indexing/javascript/fix-search-javascript>

Detailed points to revise

- WRS may not fetch analytics/reporting resources that do not contribute to main content; client analytics is not a complete measure of crawler activity.
- Use Rich Results Test or URL Inspection to inspect resources, console errors, exceptions, and rendered DOM. Collecting user/Googlebot JS errors can help, but some parse errors are not caught by the example global handler.
- Prevent SPA soft 404s with a real-404 destination or noindex error state. Do not assume browser routing produces meaningful server status codes.
- Googlebot declines user-permission requests. Provide access without mandatory camera or similar permissions.
- Avoid fragments for views; the AJAX crawling scheme has been deprecated since 2015. Use History API routing.
- WRS does not preserve cookies, local storage, or session storage across page loads. Each directly requested URL must work without prior browsing state.
- Fingerprint resources to avoid stale caches. Use feature detection and fallback for unavailable APIs such as WebGL.
- Content retrieval needs HTTP; Googlebot does not support WebSockets/WebRTC connections. Provide HTTP fallback and robust handling.
- Check component flattening and slot projection in rendered HTML. For JS paywalls, do not deliver full content then merely hide it if access protection is intended.
- Retest after fixes and use the official help community for unresolved rendering problems.

QUESTION 270 · D34

Why can analytics undercount Googlebot/WRS activity?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

WRS can skip reporting and error resources that do not contribute essential content, so client-side analytics is not a full representation. The guide recommends Crawl Stats for crawler feedback.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE · EXACT EXCERPT

“that don't contribute to essential page content, and other similar types of requests are unused or unnecessary to extract essential page content. Client-side analytics may not provide a full or accurate representation of Googlebot and WRS activity on your site. Use the crawl stats report in Google Search Console to monitor Googlebot and WRS activity and feedback on your site.”

D34 · [Fix Search-related JavaScript problems](#) · [Fix Search-related JavaScript problems](#)

QUESTION 271 · D34

What tools should be used to investigate JS rendering?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

Rich Results Test or URL Inspection. Inspect loaded resources, console output/exceptions, and rendered DOM, then retest after changes.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE · EXACT EXCERPT

“To test how Google crawls and renders a URL , use the Rich Results Test or the URL Inspection Tool in Search Console. You can see loaded resources, JavaScript console output and exceptions, rendered DOM, and more information. Optionally, we also recommend collecting and auditing JavaScript errors encountered by users, including Googlebot, on your site to identify potential issues that may affect how content is”

D34 · [Fix Search-related JavaScript problems](#) · [Fix Search-related JavaScript problems](#)

QUESTION 272 · D34 Priority practice

Can a site rely on cookies or local storage set on another page?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

Not for WRS rendering. The guide says it clears storage and cookies across page loads, so content should not depend on prior-page state.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Don't rely on data persistence to serve content. WRS loads each URL (refer to How Google Search Works for an overview of how Google discovers content), following server and client redirects, same as a regular browser. However, WRS does not retain state across page loads: Local Storage and Session Storage data are cleared across page loads. HTTP Cookies are cleared across page loads.”

D34 · [Fix Search-related JavaScript problems](#) · [Fix Search-related JavaScript problems](#)

QUESTION 273 · D34

Will Googlebot approve required camera or location permissions?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

The guide says to expect permission requests to be declined. Provide a way to access content without being forced to grant such permissions.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Expect Googlebot to decline user permission requests . Features that require user permission don't make sense for Googlebot, or for all users. For example, if you make the Camera API required, Googlebot can't provide a camera to you. Instead, provide a way for users to access your content without being forced to allow camera access.”

D34 · [Fix Search-related JavaScript problems](#) · [Fix Search-related JavaScript problems](#)

QUESTION 274 · D34

Can critical content be delivered only over WebSockets?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

No. This guide says Googlebot retrieves through HTTP and does not support WebSocket or WebRTC connections; provide an HTTP fallback.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Make sure your content works with HTTP connections. Googlebot uses HTTP requests to retrieve content from your server. It does not support other types of connections, such as WebSockets or WebRTC connections. To avoid problems with such connections, make sure to provide an HTTP fallback to retrieve content and use robust error handling and feature detection .”

D34 · [Fix Search-related JavaScript problems](#) · [Fix Search-related JavaScript problems](#)

QUESTION 275 · D34

Is a JavaScript paywall that sends all content then hides it reliable protection?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

No. The guide explicitly cautions that this is not reliable access limitation and recommends providing full content only after subscription status is confirmed.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“If you're using a JavaScript-based paywall, consider the implementation. Some JavaScript paywall solutions include the full content in the server response, then use JavaScript to hide it until subscription status is confirmed. This isn't a reliable way to limit access to the content. Make sure your paywall only provides the full content once the subscription status is confirmed.”

D34 · [Fix Search-related JavaScript problems](#) · [Fix Search-related JavaScript problems](#)

Fix lazy-loaded content

Google last updated: 2025-12-10 · Reviewed 6 October 2026

<https://developers.google.com/search/docs/crawling-indexing/javascript/lazy-loading>

Detailed points to revise

- Lazy loading can improve performance but must not hide relevant content from crawlers.
- Load when content is visible in the viewport, using native image/iframe lazy loading, IntersectionObserver with suitable fallback, or a compatible library.
- Do not depend on clicks or scroll events as the necessary trigger; Google Search does not interact with the page. Avoid lazy-loading immediately visible content where it delays display.
- Infinite-scroll chunks need persistent unique URLs with stable content, such as fixed page numbers rather than date=yesterday.
- Link chunks sequentially for discovery. Update the visible URL with History API when the new chunk becomes primary.
- Test rendered HTML in URL Inspection. Actual image/video src URLs should be present in the rendered output.

Complete source section checklist: Load content when it's visible in the viewport · Support paginated loading for infinite scroll · Test

QUESTION 276 · D35

How can lazy loading be made crawlable?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

Load relevant content when it becomes visible in the viewport using supported mechanisms without requiring user actions. Then inspect the rendered result.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“To ensure that Google sees all content on your page, make sure that your lazy-loading implementation loads all relevant content whenever it is visible in the viewport. Here are a few methods to implement lazy-loading:”

D35 · Fix lazy-loaded content · Load content when it's visible in the viewport

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“The methods mentioned don't rely on user actions, such as scrolling or clicking, to load content, which is important as Google Search does not interact with your page.”

D35 · Fix lazy-loaded content · Load content when it's visible in the viewport

QUESTION 277 · D35

Should immediately visible content be lazy-loaded?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

The page advises against it because delayed loading of initial visible content can harm the experience.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Don't add lazy-loading to content that is likely to be immediately visible when a user opens a page. That might cause content to take longer to load and show up in the browser, which will be very noticeable to the user.”

D35 · Fix lazy-loaded content · Load content when it's visible in the viewport

QUESTION 278 · D35

Priority practice

How should infinite scroll expose content to Search?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

Give each chunk a persistent unique URL with stable content, link them sequentially, and update the visible URL through History API when a chunk becomes primary.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Give each chunk its own persistent, unique URL.”

D35 · Fix lazy-loaded content · Support paginated loading for infinite scroll

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Link sequentially to the individual URLs so that search engines can discover the URLs in a paginated set. Find out more about best practices when implementing pagination .”

D35 · Fix lazy-loaded content · Support paginated loading for infinite scroll

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“When a new page chunk is loaded in response to the user scrolling, and it becomes the primary visible element for the user, update the displayed URL using the History API . This allows the user to refresh, share, and link to the current URL displayed in the browser.”

D35 · Fix lazy-loaded content · Support paginated loading for infinite scroll

QUESTION 279 · D35

Why is ?date=yesterday a poor pagination URL?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

Its content changes with time. The guide recommends stable URL/content relationships and absolute page identifiers so users and search engines can revisit the same chunk.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Avoid using relative elements like ?date=yesterday in these URLs. This allows search engines and users to consistently find the same content under a given URL, making it easier for search engines to properly index the content, and allowing users to share and reengage with that part of your content.”

D35 · Fix lazy-loaded content · Support paginated loading for infinite scroll

QUESTION 280 · D35

How would you verify lazy-loaded images?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

Use URL Inspection to examine rendered HTML and check that actual image/video URLs appear in the src attributes.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“After you set up your implementation, make sure it works correctly. You can use the URL Inspection Tool in Search Console to see if all content was loaded. Check the rendered HTML to make sure your content is in the rendered HTML by looking for it in URL Inspection Tool. If your image or video URLs appear in the src attribute on the or <video> elements in the rendered HTML, your setup works correctly.”

D35 · Fix lazy-loaded content · Test

Dynamic rendering as a workaround

Google last updated: 2025-12-10 · Reviewed 6 October 2026

<https://developers.google.com/search/docs/crawling-indexing/javascript/dynamic-rendering>

Detailed points to revise

- Dynamic rendering is a workaround, not a recommended long-term solution. Google recommends server-side rendering, static rendering, or hydration instead.
- It detects crawlers with JS problems, routes them to a rendering server, and provides a suitable version while other clients receive the usual client-rendered output.
- Historically relevant cases include rapidly changing public JS content or unsupported features; not every site needs it.
- It adds complexity and resource requirements, and can be enabled per page or across the site.
- Similar content across human and crawler output is generally not cloaking. Completely different content can be cloaking; temporary setup errors are treated as ordinary errors.

Complete source section checklist: Sites that might use dynamic rendering · Understand how dynamic rendering works · Dynamic rendering is not cloaking

QUESTION 281 · D36 Priority practice

Is dynamic rendering Google's recommended long-term JS solution?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

No. The guide calls it a workaround and recommends server-side rendering, static rendering, or hydration instead.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Dynamic rendering was a workaround and not a long-term solution for problems with JavaScript-generated content in search engines. Instead, we recommend that you use”

D36 · Dynamic rendering as a workaround · Dynamic rendering as a workaround

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“server-side rendering , static rendering , or hydration”

D36 · Dynamic rendering as a workaround · Dynamic rendering as a workaround

QUESTION 282 · D36

How does dynamic rendering work?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

Detect crawlers that cannot process the needed JavaScript, route them to a rendering server, and provide suitable rendered content while ordinary clients are served normally.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE · EXACT EXCERPT

“Dynamic rendering requires your web server to detect crawlers (for example, by checking the user agent). When your web server identifies a request from a crawler that does not support JavaScript or the JavaScript features required to render your content, this request is routed to”

D36 · Dynamic rendering as a workaround · Understand how dynamic rendering works

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE · EXACT EXCERPT

“your web server identifies a request from a crawler that does not support JavaScript or the JavaScript features required to render your content, this request is routed to a rendering server. Requests from users and crawlers without JavaScript issues are served normally. The rendering server responds to requests with a version of the content that's suitable to the crawler, for example, it may serve a”

D36 · Dynamic rendering as a workaround · Understand how dynamic rendering works

QUESTION 283 · D36

Is every form of dynamic rendering cloaking?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

No. Google generally does not treat similar rendered content as cloaking. Serving entirely different subject matter to crawlers and users can be cloaking.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Googlebot generally doesn't consider dynamic rendering as cloaking . As long as your dynamic rendering produces similar content, Googlebot won't view dynamic rendering as cloaking.”

D36 · Dynamic rendering as a workaround · Dynamic rendering is not cloaking

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Using dynamic rendering to serve completely different content to users and crawlers can be considered cloaking. For example, a website that serves a page about cats to users and a page about dogs to crawlers is cloaking.”

D36 · Dynamic rendering as a workaround · Dynamic rendering is not cloaking

Why avoid choosing dynamic rendering by default?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

The guide says it creates additional complexity and resource requirements and there are better solutions. Evaluate the actual rendering problem and implementation options.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Dynamic rendering is a workaround and not a recommended solution, because it creates additional complexities and resource requirements.”

D36 · Dynamic rendering as a workaround · Dynamic rendering as a workaround

Use valid HTML to specify page metadata

Google last updated: 2025-12-10 · Reviewed 6 October 2026

<https://developers.google.com/search/docs/crawling-indexing/valid-page-metadata>

Detailed points to revise

- Valid HTML helps Google use metadata as documented. Google can understand some invalid HTML, but that does not make broken metadata harmless.
- Metadata belongs in head, whose permitted elements are title, meta, link, script, style, base, noscript, and template.
- `img` and `iframe` are common invalid head elements. Once one appears, Google assumes head ended and stops reading later metadata.
- The source strongly advises removing invalid elements; if unavoidable, place them after metadata Google should see. Do not interpret tolerance of general malformed HTML as reliable head parsing.

Complete source section checklist: Use valid elements in the `<head>` element · Don't use invalid elements in the `<head>` element

QUESTION 285 · D37 Priority practice

Why can an image inserted in head break a canonical or robots tag?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

`img` is invalid there. Google assumes the head ends at an invalid element and stops reading the metadata that follows, which can hide intended directives.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Using valid HTML for page metadata ensures that Google can use the metadata as documented. Google tries to understand HTML even when it is invalid or inconsistent with the HTML standard, but errors in the markup can cause problems with how your metadata is used in Google Search. The primary element for specifying metadata about a page is the `<head>` element of an HTML document. If you use an invalid element in the `<head>` element, Google ignores any elements that appear after the invalid element.”

D37 · Use valid HTML to specify page metadata · Use valid HTML to specify page metadata

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“We strongly recommend that you don't use these invalid elements in the <head> element, but if you must, place these invalid elements after the ones you want Google to see. Once Google detects one of these invalid elements, it assumes the end of the <head> element and stops reading any further elements in the <head> element.”

D37 · Use valid HTML to specify page metadata · Don't use invalid elements in the <head> element

QUESTION 286 · D37

Which elements are allowed in head in this guide?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

title, meta, link, script, style, base, noscript, and template. Keep other elements such as img and iframe outside it.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“title meta link script style base noscript template”

D37 · Use valid HTML to specify page metadata · Use valid elements in the <head> element

QUESTION 287 · D37

Does Google's tolerance of invalid HTML make metadata validity irrelevant?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

No. The guide explicitly says markup errors can affect how metadata is used. Inspect valid structure rather than rely on recovery behavior.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Using valid HTML for page metadata ensures that Google can use the metadata as documented. Google tries to understand HTML even when it is invalid or inconsistent with the HTML standard , but errors in the markup can cause problems with how your metadata is used in Google Search. The primary element for specifying metadata about a page is the <head> element of an HTML document. If you use an invalid element in the <head> element, Google ignores any elements that appear after the invalid element.”

D37 · Use valid HTML to specify page metadata · Use valid HTML to specify page metadata

meta tags and attributes that Google supports

Google last updated: 2025-12-10 · Reviewed 6 October 2026

<https://developers.google.com/search/docs/crawling-indexing/special-tags>

Detailed points to revise

- Meta tags provide page information to engines and clients; unsupported tags are ignored. Put them in a valid head and inspect through URL Inspection.
- Supported tags listed: description; robots/googlebot; notranslate; nopageread aloud; google-site-verification; Content-Type/charset; refresh; viewport; adult rating.
- Description can be used for snippets in some situations. Robots defaults are index/follow and need not be declared; conflicting instructions use the more restrictive rule.
- google-site-verification values must match the supplied case exactly. Other meta naming/content is generally case-insensitive as documented; semantic values still must be correct.
- UTF-8 is recommended. Quote the Content-Type content value properly to avoid parsing problems.
- notranslate disables translated Search presentation; nopageread aloud addresses Google text-to-speech services. Adult rating supports SafeSearch.
- Server-side 301 redirects are recommended over refresh redirects. Viewport communicates mobile rendering information.
- Relevant HTML attributes include src, href, rel qualifications and data-nosnippet on div/span/section. Language recognition is based on textual content rather than relying on lang annotations.
- Unsupported: meta keywords, HTML lang as a Search language signal, next/prev link values, and nositelinkssearchbox. The underlying user-facing HTML purposes of attributes are not negated.
- JS changes to metadata should be avoided where possible and thoroughly tested when necessary. The source's complete supported-tag table and examples are retained.

Complete source section checklist: meta tags · description · robots and googlebot · notranslate · nopageread aloud · google-site-verification · Content-Type and charset · refresh · viewport · rating · HTML tag attributes · Other points to note · Unsupported tags and attributes · nositelinkssearchbox

QUESTION 288 · D38

Does a meta description always become the snippet?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

No. The guide says the description is used in some situations; provide an accurate short summary rather than promise exact display.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“description <meta name="description" content="A description of the page"> Use this tag to provide a short description of the page. In some situations, this description is used in the snippet shown in search results .”

D38 · meta tags and attributes that Google supports · meta tags

QUESTION 289 · D38

Must index,follow be explicitly declared?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

No. Those are default values and do not need to be specified. A restrictive conflicting rule is not neutralized by adding them.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE · EXACT EXCERPT

“) meta tags, the more restrictive tag applies. For example, if a page has both the max-snippet:50 and nosnippet tags, the nosnippet tag will apply. The default values are index, follow and don't need to be specified. For a full list of values that Google supports, see the list of valid rules . You can also specify this information in the header of your pages using the X-Robots-Tag HTTP header rule. This is particularly useful if”

D38 · meta tags and attributes that Google supports · meta tags

QUESTION 290 · D38

Priority practice

Do meta keywords affect Google indexing or ranking?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

No. The guide says the tag is not used and has no effect on indexing or ranking.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“meta-keyword tag <meta name="keywords" content="..."> The meta-keyword tag is not used by Google Search, and it has no effect on indexing and ranking at all.”

D38 · meta tags and attributes that Google supports · Unsupported tags and attributes

QUESTION 291 · D38

Does Google use lang to determine the Search language of a page?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

This guide says it detects the language from textual content rather than code annotations such as lang. That does not mean lang has no value for accessibility or other clients.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“HTML tag lang attributes Google Search detects the language of a page based on the textual content of the page. It doesn't rely on code annotations such as the lang .”

D38 · meta tags and attributes that Google supports · Unsupported tags and attributes

QUESTION 292 · D38 Priority practice

Are rel=next and rel=prev indexing signals today?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

No. Google no longer uses these HTML link tags and says they have no effect on indexing. Ordinary crawlable pagination links still matter.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“next and prev rel attribute values <link rel="next" href="..."> <link rel="prev" href="..."> Google no longer uses these HTML <link> tags, and they have no effect on indexing.”

D38 · meta tags and attributes that Google supports · Unsupported tags and attributes

QUESTION 293 · D38

What is different about google-site-verification case handling?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

Its name and content values must exactly match those provided, including letter case, while case is generally not important for other meta tags in this guide.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“google-site-verification <meta name="google-site-verification" content="..."> You can use this tag on the top-level page of your site to verify ownership for Search Console . Note that while the values of the name and content attributes must match exactly what is provided to you (including upper and lower case), it doesn't matter if you change the tag from XHTML to HTML or if the format of the tag matches the format of your page.”

D38 · meta tags and attributes that Google supports · meta tags

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“With the exception of google-site-verification , letter case is generally not important in meta tags.”

D38 · meta tags and attributes that Google supports · Other points to note

Can you safely inject all metadata through JavaScript?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

The guide urges caution, recommends avoiding injection or changes when possible, and requires thorough testing when used.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“If you're considering using JavaScript to inject or change meta tags, proceed with caution. We recommend that you avoid using JavaScript to inject or change meta tags whenever possible, and if you must use it, test your implementations thoroughly.”

D38 · meta tags and attributes that Google supports · Other points to note

Robots meta tag, data-nosnippet , and X-Robots-Tag specifications

Google last updated: 2026-03-24 · Reviewed 6 October 2026

<https://developers.google.com/search/docs/crawling-indexing/robots-meta-tag>

Detailed points to revise

- Page-level controls use robots meta tags or X-Robots-Tag headers; text-level exclusions use data-nosnippet. Google must be allowed to access the resource to read them.
- robots applies broadly to crawlers; googlebot and googlebot-news are the Search-specific supported meta tokens. The guide discusses separate handling of non-search clients.
- Place meta in head as best practice, although the spec says Google also respects body robots meta. Headers are suitable for non-HTML documents and can be user-agent qualified.
- Conflicts choose the more restrictive result. Separate applicable tags can combine negative instructions rather than cancel them.
- Valid rules listed: all, noindex, nofollow, none, nosnippet, indexifembedded, max-snippet, max-image-preview, max-video-preview, notranslate, noimageindex, unavailable_after.
- nosnippet suppresses text/video previews, not necessarily static thumbnails. Its documented scope includes preventing direct-content input to AI Overviews/Mode.
- max-snippet uses characters (0 means no snippet; -1 leaves length to Google). max-image-preview uses none/standard/large. max-video-preview uses seconds (0 permits at most a static image; -1 no limit).
- indexifembedded only operates with noindex and permits embedded use. unavailable_after sets a valid timestamp and substantially reduces crawl rate after expiration.
- Historical ignored rules: noarchive, nocache, nositelinkssearchbox. Do not rely on vanished cached-link or search-box features.
- data-nosnippet is a boolean on span/div/section; even a value of false still activates it. Use valid closed tags; avoid JS toggling existing nodes because extraction can occur before or after rendering.
- Structured data remains usable within a data-nosnippet element. Preview controls do not generally replace management of separately supplied schema data; the source identifies description-related exceptions and permissions.
- Apache/NGINX examples show global/file-specific X-Robots headers for PDFs and images. Do not block crawling if those headers must be read.

Complete source section checklist: Using the robots meta tag · Using the X-Robots-Tag HTTP header · Valid indexing and serving rules · all · noindex · nofollow · none · nosnippet · indexifembedded · max-snippet: [number] · max-image-preview: [setting] · max-video-preview: [number] · notranslate · noimageindex · unavailable_after: [date/time] · Reference of historical and other unused rules · noarchive · nocache · nositelinkssearchbox · Handling combined indexing and serving rules · Comma-separated list · Multiple meta tags · Using the data-nosnippet HTML attribute · Using structured

QUESTION 295 · D39 **Priority practice**

When do you use X-Robots-Tag rather than an HTML meta tag?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

Use the response header for non-HTML resources such as PDFs or images, or when server-level control is convenient. The same supported rules can be expressed there, and Google must fetch the response.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“To block indexing of non-HTML resources, such as PDF files, video files, or image files, use the X-Robots-Tag response header instead.”

D39 · Robots meta tag, data-nosnippet , and X-Robots-Tag specifications · Using the robots meta tag

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“The X-Robots-Tag can be used as an element of the HTTP header response for a given URL. Any rule that can be used in a robots meta tag can also be specified as an X-Robots-Tag . Here's an example of an HTTP response with an X-Robots-Tag instructing crawlers not to index a page:”

D39 · Robots meta tag, data-nosnippet , and X-Robots-Tag specifications · Using the X-Robots-Tag HTTP header

QUESTION 296 · D39 **Priority practice**

What wins if one robots rule permits a snippet and another forbids it?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

The more restrictive rule. For example, nosnippet overrides max-snippet:50, and separate negative tags can combine.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Conflicting robots rules: In the case of conflicting robots rules, the more restrictive rule applies. For example, if a page has both max-snippet:50 and nosnippet rules, the nosnippet rule will apply.”

D39 · Robots meta tag, data-nosnippet , and X-Robots-Tag specifications · Using the X-Robots-Tag HTTP header

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“For situations where multiple crawlers are specified along with different rules, the search engine will use the sum of the negative rules. For example:”

D39 · Robots meta tag, data-nosnippet , and X-Robots-Tag specifications · Multiple meta tags

QUESTION 297 · D39

How do noindex and nosnippet differ?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

noindex prevents the resource appearing in Search. nosnippet keeps a page potentially eligible but suppresses text snippets/video previews and prevents the documented direct-content use in AI Overviews/Mode; a static thumbnail can still appear.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“noindex Do not show this page, media, or resource in search results. If you don't specify this rule, the page, media, or resource may be indexed and shown in search results. To remove information from Google, follow our step-by-step guide .”

D39 · Robots meta tag, data-nosnippet , and X-Robots-Tag specifications · Valid indexing and serving rules

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE · EXACT EXCERPT

“nosnippet Do not show a text snippet or video preview in the search results for this page. A static image thumbnail (if available) may still be visible, when it results in a better user experience. This applies to all forms of search results (at Google:”

D39 · Robots meta tag, data-nosnippet , and X-Robots-Tag specifications · Valid indexing and serving rules

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE · EXACT EXCERPT

“nosnippet Do not show a text snippet or video preview in the search results for this page. A static image thumbnail (if available) may still be visible, when it results in a better user experience. This applies to all forms of search results (at Google: web search, Google Images, Discover, AI Overviews, AI Mode) and will also”

D39 · Robots meta tag, data-nosnippet , and X-Robots-Tag specifications · Valid indexing and serving rules

QUESTION 298 · D39 Priority practice

What does indexifembedded do?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

With noindex, it permits Google to index the content when embedded in another page through an iframe or similar tag. Alone it has no effect.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“indexifembedded Google is allowed to index the content of a page if it's embedded in another page through iframes or similar HTML tags, in spite of a noindex rule. indexifembedded only has an effect if it's accompanied by noindex .”

D39 · Robots meta tag, data-nosnippet , and X-Robots-Tag specifications · Valid indexing and serving rules

QUESTION 299 · D39

What units and special values does max-snippet use?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

Characters: 0 means no snippet and is equivalent to nosnippet; -1 lets Google choose the effective length. It does not govern image or video previews.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE · EXACT EXCERPT

“max-snippet: [number] Use a maximum of [number] characters as a textual snippet for this search result. (Note that a URL may appear as multiple search results within a search results page.) This does not affect image or video previews. This applies to all forms of search results (such as Google”

D39 · Robots meta tag, data-nosnippet , and X-Robots-Tag specifications · Valid indexing and serving rules

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE · EXACT EXCERPT

“[number] is specified. If you don't specify this rule, Google will choose the length of the snippet. Special values: 0 : No snippet is to be shown. Equivalent to nosnippet . -1 : Google will choose the snippet length that it believes is most effective to help users discover your content and direct users to your site. Examples: To stop a snippet from displaying in search results: <meta”

D39 · Robots meta tag, data-nosnippet , and X-Robots-Tag specifications · Valid indexing and serving rules

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE · EXACT EXCERPT

“don't specify this rule, Google will choose the length of the snippet. Special values: 0 : No snippet is to be shown. Equivalent to nosnippet . -1 : Google will choose the snippet length that it believes is most effective to help users discover your content and direct users to your site. Examples: To stop a snippet from displaying in search results: <meta name="robots" content="max-snippet:0"> To allow”

D39 · Robots meta tag, data-nosnippet , and X-Robots-Tag specifications · Valid indexing and serving rules

QUESTION 300 · D39

What values does max-image-preview accept?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

none, standard, and large. They control the maximum permitted preview size, subject to the separately granted-permission exceptions documented in the guide.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE · EXACT EXCERPT

“in search results. If you don't specify the max-image-preview rule, Google may show an image preview of the default size. Accepted [setting] values: none : No image preview is to be shown. standard : A default image preview may be shown. large : A larger image preview, up to the width of the viewport, may be shown. This applies to all forms of search results (such as Google web search,”

D39 · Robots meta tag, data-nosnippet , and X-Robots-Tag specifications · Valid indexing and serving rules

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE · EXACT EXCERPT

“the max-image-preview rule, Google may show an image preview of the default size. Accepted [setting] values: none : No image preview is to be shown. standard : A default image preview may be shown. large : A larger image preview, up to the width of the viewport, may be shown. This applies to all forms of search results (such as Google web search, Google Images, Discover, Assistant). However, this”

D39 · Robots meta tag, data-nosnippet , and X-Robots-Tag specifications · Valid indexing and serving rules

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE · EXACT EXCERPT

“preview of the default size. Accepted [setting] values: none : No image preview is to be shown. standard : A default image preview may be shown. large : A larger image preview, up to the width of the viewport, may be shown. This applies to all forms of search results (such as Google web search, Google Images, Discover, Assistant). However, this limit does not apply in cases where a publisher”

D39 · Robots meta tag, data-nosnippet , and X-Robots-Tag specifications · Valid indexing and serving rules

QUESTION 301 · D39

What units and special values does max-video-preview use?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

Seconds. Zero permits at most a static image subject to image-preview settings; -1 means no limit. An unparseable number makes the rule ignored.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE · EXACT EXCERPT

“max-video-preview: [number] Use a maximum of [number] seconds as a video snippet for videos on this page in search results. If you don't specify the max-video-preview rule, Google may show a video snippet in search results, and you leave it up to Google to decide how long the preview may be.”

D39 · Robots meta tag, data-nosnippet , and X-Robots-Tag specifications · Valid indexing and serving rules

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE · EXACT EXCERPT

“rule, Google may show a video snippet in search results, and you leave it up to Google to decide how long the preview may be. Special values: 0 : At most, a static image may be used, in accordance to the max-image-preview setting. -1 : There is no limit. This applies to all forms of search results (at Google: web search, Google Images, Google Videos, Discover, Assistant). This rule is”

D39 · Robots meta tag, data-nosnippet , and X-Robots-Tag specifications · Valid indexing and serving rules

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE · EXACT EXCERPT

“-1 : There is no limit. This applies to all forms of search results (at Google: web search, Google Images, Google Videos, Discover, Assistant). This rule is ignored if no parseable [number] is specified. Example: < meta name= "robots" content= "max-video-preview:-1" >”

D39 · Robots meta tag, data-nosnippet , and X-Robots-Tag specifications · Valid indexing and serving rules

Does data-nosnippet=false disable the exclusion?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

No. It is a boolean HTML attribute, so the value is ignored. Presence on a valid span, div, or section is what matters.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“You can designate textual parts of an HTML page not to be used as a snippet. This can be done on an HTML-element level with the data-nosnippet HTML attribute on span , div , and section elements. The data-nosnippet is considered a boolean attribute . As with all boolean attributes, any value specified is ignored. To ensure machine-readability, the HTML section must be valid HTML and all appropriate tags must be closed accordingly.”

D39 · Robots meta tag, data-nosnippet , and X-Robots-Tag specifications · Using the data-nosnippet HTML attribute

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“<p>This text can be shown in a snippet and this part would not be shown.</p>
<div data-nosnippet>not in snippet</div> <div data-nosnippet="true">also not in snippet</div> <div data-nosnippet="false">also not in snippet</div> <!-- all values are ignored --> <div data-nosnippet>some text</html> <!-- unclosed "div" will include all content afterwards --> <mytag data-nosnippet>some text</mytag> <!-- NOT VALID: not a span, div, or section --> <p>This text can be shown in a snippet.</p> <div data-nosnippet> <p>However, this is not in snippet.</p> Stuff not in snippet More stuff not in snippet </div>”

D39 · Robots meta tag, data-nosnippet , and X-Robots-Tag specifications · Using the data-nosnippet HTML attribute

Does data-nosnippet prevent all use of structured data in that region?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

No. The guide explicitly says structured data inside such an element remains usable for Search. Manage the data itself if you do not want it supplied.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“To manage the use of structured data for your web pages, modify the structured data types and values themselves, adding or removing information in order to provide only the data you want to make available. Also note that structured data remains usable for search results when declared within a data-nosnippet element.”

D39 · Robots meta tag, data-nosnippet , and X-Robots-Tag specifications · Using structured data

QUESTION 304 · D39

Are noarchive and nositelinkssearchbox useful controls today?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

No. The page lists them as ignored historical rules because the corresponding cached-link and search-box features no longer exist. nocache is also not used.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“noarchive The noarchive rule is no longer used by Google Search to control whether a cached link is shown in search results, as the cached link feature no longer exists.”

D39 · Robots meta tag, data-nosnippet , and X-Robots-Tag specifications · Reference of historical and other unused rules

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“nocache The nocache rule isn't used by Google Search.”

D39 · Robots meta tag, data-nosnippet , and X-Robots-Tag specifications · Reference of historical and other unused rules

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“nositelinkssearchbox The nositelinkssearchbox rule is no longer used by Google Search to control whether the sitelink search box is shown for a given page, as the feature no longer exists.”

D39 · Robots meta tag, data-nosnippet , and X-Robots-Tag specifications · Reference of historical and other unused rules

QUESTION 305 · D39

Why does robots.txt disallow conflict with header-level noindex?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

If the URL cannot be crawled, its metadata or headers cannot be read. The page says indexing/serving rules cannot be followed on a disallowed resource.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“robots meta tags and X-Robots-Tag HTTP headers are discovered when a URL is crawled. If a page is disallowed from crawling through the robots.txt file, then any information about indexing or serving rules will not be found and will therefore be ignored. If indexing or serving rules must be followed, the URLs containing those rules cannot be disallowed from crawling.”

D39 · Robots meta tag, data-nosnippet , and X-Robots-Tag specifications · Combining robots.txt rules with indexing and serving rules

Block Search indexing with noindex

Google last updated: 2025-12-10 · Reviewed 6 October 2026

<https://developers.google.com/search/docs/crawling-indexing/block-indexing>

Detailed points to revise

- noindex can be delivered through an HTML meta tag or HTTP response header; both have the same effect for Google when fetched.
- It removes the page from Search regardless of incoming links after Google processes it. It does not prevent direct user access.
- Crawl access is essential: robots.txt blocks or other access failures can prevent seeing the rule. noindex in robots.txt is unsupported.
- robots targets supporting search engines; googlebot limits the meta instruction to Google web crawlers. Other engines can interpret instructions differently.
- X-Robots-Tag can express noindex or none and is useful for PDFs, images, and videos.
- A page may persist until it is recrawled; revisit time can be months depending on importance. URL Inspection can request a recrawl, and urgent cases use the removal procedure.
- Debug access/robots, the actual HTML or response seen by Googlebot, and Page Indexing's extracted noindex cases.

Complete source section checklist: Implementing noindex · <meta> tag · HTTP response header · Debugging noindex issues

QUESTION 306 · D40

How do you implement noindex for HTML versus PDFs?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

For HTML, use an appropriate robots meta tag; an X-Robots-Tag response header also works and is suitable for non-HTML files such as PDFs. Both methods have the same effect when Google fetches them.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“There are two ways to implement noindex : as a <meta> tag and as an HTTP response header. They have the same effect; choose the method that is more convenient for your site and appropriate for the content type. Specifying the noindex rule in the robots.txt file is not supported by Google.”

D40 · Block Search indexing with noindex · Implementing noindex

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Instead of a <meta> tag, you can return an X-Robots-Tag HTTP header with a value of either noindex or none in your response. A response header can be used for non-HTML resources, such as PDFs, video files, and image files. Here's an example of an HTTP response with an X-Robots-Tag header instructing search engines not to index a page.”

D40 · Block Search indexing with noindex · HTTP response header

QUESTION 307 · D40

Is noindex supported inside robots.txt?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

No. This page explicitly says that implementation is unsupported.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“There are two ways to implement noindex : as a <meta> tag and as an HTTP response header. They have the same effect; choose the method that is more convenient for your site and appropriate for the content type. Specifying the noindex rule in the robots.txt file is not supported by Google.”

D40 · Block Search indexing with noindex · Implementing noindex

QUESTION 308 · D40 Priority practice

Why might a correctly written noindex not remove a page yet?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

Google may not have recrawled since it was added, or robots/access restrictions can prevent seeing it. Inspect the response Google actually receives and request recrawling where appropriate.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“We have to crawl your page in order to see <meta> tags and HTTP headers. If a page is still appearing in results, it's probably because we haven't crawled the page since you added the noindex rule. Depending on the importance of the page on the internet, it may take months for Googlebot to revisit a page. You can request that Google recrawl a page using the URL Inspection tool .”

D40 · Block Search indexing with noindex · Debugging noindex issues

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Another reason could also be that the robots.txt file is blocking the URL from Google web crawlers, so they can't see the tag. To unblock your page from Google, you must edit your robots.txt file .”

D40 · Block Search indexing with noindex · Debugging noindex issues

QUESTION 309 · D40

Do backlinks override a processed noindex?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

No. Google says the page is dropped from results after it sees the tag/header, regardless of other sites linking to it.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“noindex is a rule set with either a <meta> tag or HTTP response header and is used to prevent indexing content by search engines that support the noindex rule, such as Google. When Googlebot crawls that page and extracts the tag or header, Google will drop that page entirely from Google Search results, regardless of whether other sites link to it.”

D40 · Block Search indexing with noindex · Block Search indexing with noindex

QUESTION 310 · D40

Is noindex a privacy control?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

It controls Search appearance, not who can directly visit or retrieve the content. For confidentiality use access restrictions, as Google's sharing guide explains.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“noindex is a rule set with either a <meta> tag or HTTP response header and is used to prevent indexing content by search engines that support the noindex rule, such as Google. When Googlebot crawls that page and extracts the tag or header, Google will drop that page entirely from Google Search results, regardless of whether other sites link to it.”

D40 · Block Search indexing with noindex · Block Search indexing with noindex

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Password-protect your files Applicable: all content types If you have confidential or private content on your site, you need to password protect it to ensure only authorized users can access it. This will also prevent that content from appearing in Google Search, or if it already appears, it will eventually remove that content from our search results.”

D42 · Control what you share with Google · How to block content

Qualify your outbound links to Google

Google last updated: 2025-12-10 · Reviewed 6 October 2026

<https://developers.google.com/search/docs/crawling-indexing/qualify-outbound-links>

Detailed points to revise

- Normal editorial links need no qualification solely because they are external.
- sponsored identifies advertisements and paid placements; nofollow remains acceptable for those links but sponsored is preferred.
- ugc is recommended for forum/comment user contributions. The guide allows removing it for consistently trusted contributors as an editorial choice.
- nofollow applies when other values do not fit and you do not want association or following from your site.
- Multiple values can be space- or comma-separated. These link attributes generally discourage following but do not prevent discovery through other routes.
- Use appropriate robots disallow to prevent your own URL being crawled; allow crawling and use noindex to prevent indexing. Link qualifiers are not privacy or universal index controls.

Complete source section checklist: rel="sponsored" · rel="ugc" · rel="nofollow" · Multiple values

QUESTION 311 · D41

How do sponsored, ugc, and nofollow differ?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

sponsored marks paid placements; ugc marks user-generated links; nofollow fits other non-endorsed relationships. Ordinary editorial links need no rel qualification.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“rel="sponsored" Mark links that are advertisements or paid placements (commonly called paid links) with the sponsored value. Read more about Google's stance on paid links . Appenzeller Note: The nofollow attribute was previously recommended for these types of links and is still an acceptable way to flag them, though sponsored is preferred.”

D41 · [Qualify your outbound links to Google](#) · [Qualify your outbound links to Google](#)

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“rel="ugc" We recommend marking user-generated content (UGC) links, such as comments and forum posts, with the ugc value. Appenzeller If you want to recognize and reward trustworthy contributors, you might remove this attribute from links posted by members or users who have consistently made high-quality contributions over time. Read more about how to prevent user-generated spam on your site and platform .”

D41 · Qualify your outbound links to Google · Qualify your outbound links to Google

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“rel="nofollow" Use the nofollow value when other values don't apply, and you'd rather Google not associate your site with, or crawl the linked page from, your site. For links within your own site, use the robots.txt disallow rule . Appenzeller”

D41 · Qualify your outbound links to Google · Qualify your outbound links to Google

QUESTION 312 · D41

Is nofollow still acceptable for a paid link?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

Yes. The guide says it remains acceptable, although sponsored is preferred.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“rel="sponsored" Mark links that are advertisements or paid placements (commonly called paid links) with the sponsored value. Read more about Google's stance on paid links . Appenzeller Note: The nofollow attribute was previously recommended for these types of links and is still an acceptable way to flag them, though sponsored is preferred.”

D41 · Qualify your outbound links to Google · Qualify your outbound links to Google

QUESTION 313 · D41

Can a link have ugc and nofollow together?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

Yes. Multiple rel values can be separated by spaces or commas.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Multiple values You may specify multiple rel values as a space- or comma-separated list. Examples: <p>I love Appenzeller cheese.</p><p>I hate Blue cheese.</p>”

D41 · Qualify your outbound links to Google · Qualify your outbound links to Google

QUESTION 314 · D41

Priority practice

Does nofollow guarantee that the target is never crawled or indexed?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

No. Destinations can be found through other links or sitemaps. Use the destination's appropriate crawl/index controls for those objectives.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Links marked with these rel attributes will generally not be followed. Remember that the linked pages may be found through other means, such as sitemaps or links from other sites, and thus they may still be crawled. These rel attributes are used only in <a> elements that Google can crawl , except nofollow , which is also available as robots meta tag .”

D41 · Qualify your outbound links to Google · Qualify your outbound links to Google

Control what you share with Google

Google last updated: 2025-12-10 · Reviewed 6 October 2026

<https://developers.google.com/search/docs/crawling-indexing/control-what-you-share>

Detailed points to revise

- Reasons to limit exposure include confidential/restricted data, low-value or spam user material, and unnecessary duplicate crawling on large sites.
- Remove content if it should not be public. Password protection restricts actual access to confidential material.
- noindex suppresses Search appearance while leaving content accessible through links or direct requests.
- For images and videos, robots disallow can prevent indexing by blocking file fetching; this is not the same behavior as web-page URL exclusion.
- The page links opt-outs for selected Google products, such as Shopping, Hotels, and rentals, which differ from removing all Search presence.
- For already visible material, follow the page-removal procedure. Ensure metadata and supposedly redacted content are genuinely removed.

Complete source section checklist: How to block content · Remove the content from your site · Password-protect your files · Disallow crawling with robots.txt · Remove existing content from Google

QUESTION 315 · D42

How do you choose between removal, authentication, and noindex?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

Remove content that must not be public; use authentication for restricted access; use noindex for public material that should not appear in Search. These objectives are different.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Remove the content from your site Applicable: all content types Removing content from your site is the best way to ensure that it won't appear in Google Search and anywhere else on the Internet.”

D42 · Control what you share with Google · How to block content

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Password-protect your files Applicable: all content types If you have confidential or private content on your site, you need to password protect it to ensure only authorized users can access it. This will also prevent that content from appearing in Google Search, or if it already appears, it will eventually remove that content from our search results.”

D42 · Control what you share with Google · How to block content

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“noindex rule Applicable: all content types The noindex robots meta tag is a rule that tells Google not to index your content or let it appear in Google search results. Your content can still be linked to and visited through other web pages, or directly visited by users with a link, but the content will not appear in Google search results.”

D42 · Control what you share with Google · How to block content

QUESTION 316 · D42

Does noindex stop people opening the page directly?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

No. The sharing guide says it can still be reached directly or through links; noindex controls Search appearance rather than confidentiality.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“noindex rule Applicable: all content types The noindex robots meta tag is a rule that tells Google not to index your content or let it appear in Google search results. Your content can still be linked to and visited through other web pages, or directly visited by users with a link, but the content will not appear in Google search results.”

D42 · Control what you share with Google · How to block content

QUESTION 317 · D42

Can exposure be limited in one Google product rather than everywhere?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

The page describes opt-outs for selected properties such as Shopping, Hotels, and vacation rentals. Check the product-specific method instead of assuming one directive controls every service.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Opt out of specific Google properties Applicable: web pages You can tell Google not to include content from your site in specific Google properties, such as Google Shopping , Google Hotels , and vacation rentals.”

D42 · Control what you share with Google · How to block content

Remove a page hosted on your site from Google

Google last updated: 2025-12-10 · Reviewed 6 October 2026

<https://developers.google.com/search/docs/crawling-indexing/remove-information>

Detailed points to revise

- For quick removal of an owned page, use the Removals tool; the guide describes removal within a day. Cover every URL variation that exposes the content.
- Tool requests last about six months. Permanent exclusion additionally requires removing/updating the content, restricting access, or implementing crawlable noindex.
- robots.txt is not the method for permanently removing a web page from Search.
- A noindex page can remain accessible to users and to engines that ignore it; remove the content or protect access when confidentiality matters.
- Other Google products have separate procedures for business details, knowledge panels, Shopping and related surfaces. For a page you do not own, use the relevant personal-information help route.

Complete source section checklist: Make your removal permanent · Remove an image from search results · Remove information from other Google properties · How do I remove content from a site that I don't own?

QUESTION 318 · D43

How do you quickly remove an owned page from Google?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

Use the Removals tool, which the guide describes as working within a day. Protect or remove every exposing URL variation, not just one case or parameter version.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“For quick removals, use the Removals tool to remove a page hosted on your site from Google's search results within a day.”

D43 · Remove a page hosted on your site from Google · Remove a page hosted on your site from Google

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Protect or remove all variations of the URL for the content that you want to remove. In many cases, different URLs can point to the same page. For example: example.com/puppies , example.com/PUPPIES , and example.com/petchchooser?pet=puppies . Learn how to find the right URL to block .”

D43 · Remove a page hosted on your site from Google · Remove a page hosted on your site from Google

How long does a Removals-tool request last?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

About six months. For permanence, remove/update the content, protect it with access restrictions, or apply accessible noindex.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Requests made in the Removals tool last for about 6 months. To permanently block a page from Google Search results, take one of the following actions:”

D43 · Remove a page hosted on your site from Google · Make your removal permanent

Can robots.txt make a web-page removal permanent?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

No. The removal guide explicitly says not to use robots.txt as the blocking method for a page.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Don't use robots.txt as a way to block your page. Learn more about the”

D43 · Remove a page hosted on your site from Google · Make your removal permanent

Is removing a Search result the same as deleting the public content?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

No. A noindex or temporary Search removal does not erase public access. The guide explains that removing/updating or protecting content is necessary for the corresponding access objective.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Add a noindex tag to your page . A noindex tag only blocks your page from showing up in Google search results. Users and other search engines that don't support noindex can still access your page.”

D43 · Remove a page hosted on your site from Google · Make your removal permanent

Remove images hosted on your site from search results

Google last updated: 2025-12-10 · Reviewed 6 October 2026

<https://developers.google.com/search/docs/crawling-indexing/prevent-images-on-your-page>

Detailed points to revise

- Urgent image removal uses the Removals tool, with a permanent measure as well to prevent reappearance after expiry.
- Non-emergency methods are blocking the actual image with robots.txt or providing noindex in its X-Robots-Tag. They have the same documented removal effect, but headers require crawling; combining them is counterproductive.
- Apply robots.txt on the image-host domain, including any CDN host. The guide gives single-image, repeated-rule, wildcard, all-image, and file-extension examples.
- Googlebot-Image targets Google Images; the source says Googlebot excludes from all Google searches. Verify the actual objective and relevant client.
- With a noindex image header, permit fetching. A page-level noimageindex does not stop another page exposing the same image; a header on the image addresses that file wherever embedded.
- If the image host or CMS cannot provide these controls, deleting the hosted image may be needed. Images on sites you do not control use different help routes.

Complete source section checklist: For emergency image removal · For non-emergency image removal · Remove images using robots.txt rules · Remove images with the noindex X-Robots-Tag HTTP header · How do I remove images from properties that I don't own?

QUESTION 322 · D44

How do you remove a particular image from Search permanently?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

Apply a robots disallow to the image URL on its host, or serve a noindex X-Robots-Tag on the image with crawling allowed. Emergency tool removal should be backed by a lasting measure.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“There are two ways to remove images from your site from Google's search results:”

D44 · Remove images hosted on your site from search results · For non-emergency image removal

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“The two methods have the same effect, choose the method that is more convenient for your site. Keep in mind that Googlebot has to crawl the URLs to extract the HTTP headers, so implementing both methods at the same time doesn't make sense.”

D44 · Remove images hosted on your site from search results · For non-emergency image removal

QUESTION 323 · D44

Should an image have both robots disallow and a noindex header?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

Not as a combined strategy: Google must fetch it to read the header, so disallow prevents that. The page says using both does not make sense.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“The two methods have the same effect, choose the method that is more convenient for your site. Keep in mind that Googlebot has to crawl the URLs to extract the HTTP headers, so implementing both methods at the same time doesn't make sense.”

D44 · Remove images hosted on your site from search results · For non-emergency image removal

QUESTION 324 · D44

Where should the robots file for a CDN image live?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

At the root of the site that hosts the actual image, not merely on a page that embeds it.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“To prevent images from your site appearing in Google's search results, add a robots.txt file to the root of the site that hosts the image, for example <https://yoursite.example.com/robots.txt> . While it takes longer to remove an image from Google's search results using robots.txt rules than it does to use the Removals tool, it gives you more flexibility and control through the use of wildcards or subpath blocking. It also applies to all search engines, whereas the Removals tool only applies to Google.”

D44 · Remove images hosted on your site from search results · Remove images using robots.txt rules

Does page-level noimageindex guarantee an image disappears everywhere?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

No. The image can still be indexed through other pages. The source recommends a noindex X-Robots-Tag on the image itself to block it regardless of where it appears.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Note that adding the noimageindex robots tag to a particular page will also prevent that images embedded in that page from getting indexed. However, if the same images also appear in other pages, they might get indexed through those pages. To make sure a particular image is blocked no matter where it appears, use the noindex X-Robots-Tag HTTP response header.”

D44 · Remove images hosted on your site from search results · Remove images with the noindex X-Robots-Tag HTTP header

Why might an urgently removed image reappear?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

If the temporary request expires without the image being removed or blocked by a durable method, it may resurface.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“To quickly remove images hosted on your site from Google's search results, use the Removals tool . Keep in mind that unless you also remove the images from your site or otherwise block the images as described in the non-emergency image removal section , the images may resurface in Google's search results once the removal request expires.”

D44 · Remove images hosted on your site from search results · For emergency image removal

Keep redacted information out of Google Search

Google last updated: 2025-12-10 · Reviewed 6 October 2026

<https://developers.google.com/search/docs/crawling-indexing/keep-redacted-information-out>

Detailed points to revise

- Visual concealment is not complete redaction: tiny text, matching background colors, overlays, history, uncropped originals, metadata, OCR and assistive technologies can reveal it.
- Redact images before embedding them in documents. Crop/remove unwanted areas, remove undesired metadata, and export flattened non-vector formats such as PNG/WebP.
- Delete unwanted text before publishing in a format that does not retain previous history. Use actual redaction tools rather than black rectangles placed over live text.
- Review the exported public file's metadata and format-specific redaction behavior; conversion alone may preserve sensitive information.
- Avoid sensitive names/emails in URLs or filenames. Use hashes in parameters instead, and consider authentication with an appropriately noindexed login page.
- Verify the site in Search Console so urgent removal can be requested when necessary.
- If exposed: remove the live original, request removal, host the genuinely redacted version at a different URL, update links, and seek removal of copies from other hosts. The guide references the Outdated Content tool as another update path.
- Temporary Search removal and actual public-data removal remain separate tasks; the complete source's steps are preserved.

Complete source section checklist: Edit and export images before embedding them · Edit or remove unwanted text before moving to a public file format · What to do if unredacted or improperly redacted documents are indexed in Search

QUESTION 327 · D45

Is putting a black rectangle over sensitive PDF text enough?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

No. The underlying text can remain in the public document. Use proper redaction and verify the final file, including metadata and history.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Use proper document redacting tools if a file needs to have information redacted. For example, avoid placing black rectangles over text as a redaction method, as this can result in the text still being included in the public document.”

D45 · Keep redacted information out of Google Search · Edit or remove unwanted text before moving to a public file format

QUESTION 328 · D45

Why edit an image before embedding it in Word or a slide deck?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

Document tools may retain the uncropped original, and the image may be indexed independently. Redact/crop first, remove metadata, then export a flattened image before embedding.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Google Search lists images that it finds across the web, both those that are on web pages or those that are embedded into various document formats. Embedded images are sometimes edited using only the containing document's editing tools. This can cause this redaction to fail when an image is indexed apart from the document. That is why it's best to edit images before embedding them into a document, not after. In particular:”

D45 · Keep redacted information out of Google Search · Edit and export images before embedding them

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Crop out unwanted information from images before embedding them into documents. Some document editing tools (such as word processors or slide creation tools) will maintain any uncropped images that you use in the public version of the document, so be sure to review the tool's documentation thoroughly.”

D45 · Keep redacted information out of Google Search · Edit and export images before embedding them

QUESTION 329 · D45

Can document conversion alone remove sensitive history and metadata?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

Do not assume so. The guide says hidden information can survive export or conversion; completely remove it and check the public file.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“All of this information can remain even when a document is exported or converted from one format to another. If you need to remove information from a file, it's critical that the information is removed completely from the file before that file is made public.”

D45 · Keep redacted information out of Google Search · Keep redacted information out of Google Search

QUESTION 330 · D45

What should happen if an improperly redacted document is indexed?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

Remove the exposed original, request Search removal, publish the properly redacted version at a different URL, update links, and address other copies as described in the guide.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Remove the live document from the website or location where you published it.”

D45 · Keep redacted information out of Google Search · What to do if unredacted or improperly redacted documents are indexed in Search

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Host the properly redacted document under a different URL. This makes sure that any newly indexed version is of the new document, and not an older version of the document (since recrawling of URLs and updating them in a search index can take a bit of time). Update any links to those documents.”

D45 · Keep redacted information out of Google Search · What to do if unredacted or improperly redacted documents are indexed in Search

QUESTION 331 · D45

Why avoid personal data in filenames and URL parameters?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

Even a crawl-blocked URL can be indexed without its content, revealing the sensitive URL string. The source recommends hashes rather than names/emails in parameters.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Consider information in the URL or file name itself. Even if a part of a website is blocked by robots.txt , the URLs may be indexed in search (without their content). Use hashes in URL parameters instead of email addresses or names.”

D45 · Keep redacted information out of Google Search · Edit or remove unwanted text before moving to a public file format

Redirects and Google Search

Google last updated: 2026-04-14 · Reviewed 6 October 2026

<https://developers.google.com/search/docs/crawling-indexing/301-redirects>

Detailed points to revise

- Redirects resolve an existing URL to a different location. Uses include domain moves, merging sites, selecting a preferred URL, and sending users from replaced content to its successor.
- Permanent redirects signal the target as canonical; temporary redirects do not provide that same canonicalization signal. Other signals can still lead to target indexing.
- Server-side redirects have the highest chance of correct interpretation. Use 301 or 308 for a permanent move and 302, 303 or 307 for a temporary one.
- The guide shows PHP, Apache and NGINX implementations. In PHP, set redirect headers before sending output. Keep implementation syntax from the full source examples rather than memorizing flattened snippets.
- A meta refresh or HTTP Refresh with zero delay is interpreted as permanent; a positive delay is temporary. The HTML meta refresh belongs in the head.
- Use JavaScript location redirects only when server-side or meta refresh methods are unavailable. Google must render the page to detect them, and rendering failure can prevent detection.
- A crypto redirect is explanatory text plus a link rather than a conventional automatic redirect. It is the weakest listed option and should not be relied on when alternatives exist.
- An old URL may temporarily appear as an alternate name in results after a move, helping users recognize the destination. This can be normal and fades over time.

Complete source section checklist: Overview of redirect types · Server-side redirects · Permanent server-side redirects · Temporary server-side redirects · Implement server-side redirects · meta refresh and its HTTP equivalent · JavaScript location redirects · Crypto redirects · Alternate versions of a URL

QUESTION 332 · D46

How do permanent and temporary redirects affect canonicalization?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

A permanent redirect is a signal that the target should be canonical. A temporary redirect does not supply that signal; other canonicalization signals can still cause the target to be indexed.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE · EXACT EXCERPT

“Permanent Googlebot follows the redirect, and the indexing pipeline uses the redirect as a signal that the redirect target should be canonical . Use permanent redirects when you're sure that the redirect won't be reverted. HTTP 301 (moved permanently) Set up server-side redirects . HTTP 308 (moved permanently) meta”

D46 · Redirects and Google Search · Overview of redirect types

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Temporary Googlebot follows the redirect, but the indexing pipeline doesn't use the redirect as a signal that the redirect target should be canonical. The target page might still be indexed if other canonicalization signals are present. HTTP 302 (found) Set up server-side redirects . HTTP 303 (see other) HTTP 307 (temporary redirect) meta refresh (more than 0 seconds) Set up meta refresh redirects . HTTP refresh (more than 0 seconds)”

D46 · Redirects and Google Search · Overview of redirect types

QUESTION 333 · D46 Priority practice

Which HTTP codes would you choose for a permanent versus temporary move?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

Use a permanent server-side 301 or 308 when the change is lasting. Temporary server-side options include 302, 303 and 307. Match the choice to the intended duration and preferred Search URL.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“If you need to change the URL of a page as it is shown in search engine results, we recommend that you use a permanent server-side redirect whenever possible. This is the best way to ensure that Google Search and people are directed to the correct page. The 301 and 308 status codes mean that a page has permanently moved to a new location.”

D46 · Redirects and Google Search · Permanent server-side redirects

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Temporary Googlebot follows the redirect, but the indexing pipeline doesn't use the redirect as a signal that the redirect target should be canonical. The target page might still be indexed if other canonicalization signals are present. HTTP 302 (found) Set up server-side redirects . HTTP 303 (see other) HTTP 307 (temporary redirect) meta refresh (more than 0 seconds) Set up meta refresh redirects . HTTP refresh (more than 0 seconds)”

D46 · Redirects and Google Search · Overview of redirect types

QUESTION 334 · D46

Why are server-side redirects preferred to JavaScript redirects?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

Google is most likely to interpret a server-side redirect correctly. JavaScript detection depends on rendering, so a rendering failure can prevent Google seeing the redirect.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“The following table explains the various ways you can use to set up permanent and temporary redirects, ordered by how likely Google is able to interpret correctly (for example, a server side redirect has the highest chance of being interpreted correctly by Google). Choose the redirect type that works for your situation and site.”

D46 · Redirects and Google Search · Overview of redirect types

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“redirects. While Google attempts to render every URL Googlebot crawled, rendering may fail for various reasons. This means that if you set a JavaScript redirect, Google might never see it if rendering of the content failed.”

D46 · Redirects and Google Search · JavaScript location redirects

QUESTION 335 · D46 **Priority practice**

Are all meta refresh redirects temporary?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

No. Google interprets an instant refresh as permanent and a delayed refresh as temporary; HTTP Refresh behaves similarly.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Instant meta refresh redirect : Triggers as soon as the page is loaded in a browser. Google Search interprets instant meta refresh redirects as permanent redirects.”

D46 · Redirects and Google Search · meta refresh and its HTTP equivalent

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Delayed meta refresh redirect : Triggers only after an arbitrary number of seconds set by the site owner. Google Search interprets delayed meta refresh redirects as temporary redirects.”

D46 · Redirects and Google Search · meta refresh and its HTTP equivalent

QUESTION 336 · D46

When should you use JavaScript location redirects?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

Only when server-side or meta refresh redirects cannot be used. The source presents them as a fallback with a rendering dependency.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE · EXACT EXCERPT

“permanently) meta refresh (0 seconds) Set up meta refresh redirects . HTTP refresh (0 seconds) JavaScript location Set up JavaScript redirects . Only use JavaScript redirects if you can't do server-side or meta refresh redirects. Crypto redirect Learn more about crypto redirects . Don't rely on crypto redirects for letting search engines know that your content has moved unless you have no other choice.”

D46 · Redirects and Google Search · Overview of redirect types

QUESTION 337 · D46

What is a crypto redirect, and is it a dependable migration method?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

It tells users that content moved using explanatory text and a link. Google advises against relying on it to communicate a move unless no other option exists.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE · EXACT EXCERPT

“redirects . Only use JavaScript redirects if you can't do server-side or meta refresh redirects. Crypto redirect Learn more about crypto redirects . Don't rely on crypto redirects for letting search engines know that your content has moved unless you have no other choice.”

D46 · Redirects and Google Search · Overview of redirect types

QUESTION 338 · D46

Why might Google still show the old URL as an alternate name after a move?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

Google can temporarily show alternate names to help users recognize and trust the new destination. The guide describes this as a normal transition that fades as users become familiar with the new name.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“When you redirect a URL, Google keeps track of both the redirect source (the old URL) and the redirect target (the new URL). One of the URLs will be the canonical ; which one, depends on signals such as whether the redirect was temporary or permanent. The other URL becomes an alternate name of the canonical URL. Alternate names are different versions of a canonical URL that users might recognize and trust more. Alternate names may appear in search results when a user’s query hints that they might trust the old URL more.”

D46 · Redirects and Google Search · Alternate versions of a URL

QUESTION 339 · D46

What is an easy PHP redirect implementation mistake?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

Sending output before setting the HTTP headers. Google's PHP example explicitly requires headers before anything is sent to the screen.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“To set up a permanent redirect with PHP, use the header() function. You must set the headers before sending anything to the screen:”

D46 · Redirects and Google Search · Implement server-side redirects

Changing your hosting

Google last updated: 2025-12-10 · Reviewed 6 October 2026

<https://developers.google.com/search/docs/crawling-indexing/site-move-no-url-changes>

Detailed points to revise

- This guide covers a hosting, infrastructure or CDN change without changing user-visible URLs; a domain/path/protocol change needs the URL-migration guide.
- Copy and test the new infrastructure. For a temporary hostname, prevent indexing during testing; test Googlebot access, including firewalls and denial-of-service protections, and keep verification working.
- Lower DNS TTL, for example to a few hours, at least a week ahead so old entries expire sooner during the switch.
- Check that Search Console verification methods continue to work on the new site and remove temporary crawl/index restrictions before the public move.
- Update DNS to the new hosting provider. If content changes meanwhile, ensure the new infrastructure also has those updates.
- Monitor old/new server logs, DNS resolution and Search Console. A temporary crawl-rate dip followed by an increase can be expected while Google assesses the new host.
- Retire old hosting once its logs show no remaining traffic; the move is not complete merely because DNS was edited.

Complete source section checklist: Overview · Prepare the new hosting infrastructure · Copy and test your new site · Check that Googlebot is able to access the new hosting infrastructure · Lower the TTL value for your DNS records · Review Search Console verification · Start the move · Monitor traffic · A note about Googlebot's crawl rate · Shut down old hosting

QUESTION 340 · D47

How does a hosting migration differ from a URL migration?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

In this guide, the public URLs stay the same while hosting or infrastructure changes. A domain or URL change needs the separate URL-move process.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Follow this guide to minimize the impact of changing your site's hosting infrastructure on the site's performance in Google Search. A change in hosting infrastructure means switching hosting providers or moving to a content distribution network (CDN). This guide is only for migrations that don't affect the user-visible URL.”

D47 · Changing your hosting · Changing your hosting

QUESTION 341 · D47

Why reduce DNS TTL before changing hosting?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

A lower TTL helps old DNS records expire sooner during the move. Google suggests doing this at least a week in advance, with a TTL such as a few hours.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“You can help make your site move go faster if you lower your site DNS records' TTL value, which will allow the new settings to propagate to ISPs faster. DNS settings are usually cached by ISPs based on the specified Time to Live (TTL) setting . Consider lowering the TTL to a conservative low value (for example, a few hours) at least a week in advance of the move to refresh DNS caches faster.”

D47 · Changing your hosting · Lower the TTL value for your DNS records

QUESTION 342 · D47 **Priority practice**

What needs checking before switching DNS?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

Test the copied site and Googlebot access, preserve Search Console verification, and remove temporary crawl blocks. Then update DNS to point at the new provider.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Make sure your Search Console verification will continue to work after the hosting move.”

D47 · Changing your hosting · Review Search Console verification

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Remove any temporary blocks to crawling . While building the new copy of a site, some site owners use a robots.txt file to disallow all crawling by Googlebot and other crawlers, or use noindex meta tags or HTTP headers to block indexing of content. Be sure to remove any such blocks from the new copy of the site when you're ready to start the move.”

D47 · Changing your hosting · Start the move

QUESTION 343 · D47

Is a short crawl-rate dip after changing hosting automatically a failure?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

No. Google says a temporary drop is normal immediately after the move, followed by an increase over the next days, potentially above the prior rate.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“When you change hosting infrastructure, it’s normal to see a temporary drop in Googlebot’s crawl rate immediately after the launch, followed by a steady increase over the next few days, potentially to rates that may be higher than before the move.”

D47 · Changing your hosting · A note about Googlebot’s crawl rate

QUESTION 344 · D47

When can you shut down the old hosting?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

Monitor access logs on both providers and retire the old infrastructure after its traffic reaches zero.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Check the server logs on the old provider and, once the traffic to the old provider reaches zero, you can shut down your old hosting infrastructure. This completes the hosting change.”

D47 · Changing your hosting · Shut down old hosting

How to move a site

Google last updated: 2026-08-20 · Reviewed 6 October 2026

<https://developers.google.com/search/docs/crawling-indexing/site-move-with-url-changes>

Detailed points to revise

- This process covers HTTP-to-HTTPS, domain changes, site merges, and URL-path restructuring. Plan the move, prepare the new site, map URLs, implement redirects, update links, and monitor both sites.
- Change one major thing at a time, consider a low-traffic period, and expect temporary ranking fluctuations. Small/medium sites can move together; large sites may move in sections, with test sections not proving full-site outcomes.
- The move is processed per URL, not with a fixed site-wide deadline. The guide gives a few weeks for most pages of a small/medium site, with larger sites taking longer. Permanent redirects do not cause PageRank loss by themselves.
- Prepare content, assets, server capacity, valid TLS for HTTPS, analytics, and Search Console verification for relevant old/new properties. Check a purchased domain's manual actions and prior removal history and carry over applicable disavow settings.
- Inventory old URLs from CMS, logs, analytics, sitemaps and link reports, including media and supporting resources. Map each useful old URL to its correct new counterpart; intentionally removed content should return 404 or 410 rather than an irrelevant destination.
- New pages need consistent self-referencing canonicals, updated hreflang annotations and internal links, and a new sitemap. Remove temporary noindex/robots restrictions before launch.
- Use direct permanent server-side 301/308 redirects. Avoid chains: the guide says Googlebot can follow up to 10 hops, but recommends direct destinations and short unavoidable chains, ideally no more than 3 and fewer than 5.
- Do not redirect many unrelated URLs to the home page: this can confuse users and be treated as soft 404. A genuine consolidated replacement is different.
- Use Change of Address where appropriate for a domain/subdomain move. It is not required for HTTP-to-HTTPS, www/non-www switches, or path-only changes. Verify and handle relevant old domain properties.
- Retain redirects generally for at least one year; keeping them longer can help users. Update important external/profile/ad links as well as internal links.
- Submit the new sitemap. The article also describes old/new sitemap comparisons for monitoring; it does not make retaining an old sitemap a permanent requirement.
- Monitor clicks, impressions, indexed counts, crawler/user traffic, redirects and errors. Old-site traffic should decline as new-site traffic rises. Investigate forgotten noindex/robots rules, wrong destinations, crawl errors, inadequate capacity and stale sitemaps.
- Legacy wording: the article still mentions a manual Search Console crawl-rate setting. That tool was retired on January 8, 2024; use the current reduce-crawl-rate guidance instead. The original wording is preserved in the reference and flagged rather than silently rewritten.

Complete source section checklist: Overview · General best practices for site moves · Prepare the new site · Prepare URL mapping · Determine your old URLs · Create a mapping of old to new URLs · Update all URL details on the new site · Plan your redirect strategy · Start the site move · Update links · Monitor traffic · Use Search Console to monitor traffic · Use other tools to monitor traffic · More resources · Troubleshooting your site move · noindex or robots.txt blocks · Incorrect redirects · Other crawl errors · Insufficient server capacity · Not updating sitemaps

QUESTION 345 · D48

What are the main stages of an SEO migration with URL changes?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

Prepare the new site, inventory and map old URLs, update canonical/hreflang/internal-link signals, implement permanent redirects, submit the new sitemap, update remaining links, and monitor old/new traffic and indexing.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Prepare the new site and test it thoroughly.”

D48 · How to move a site · Overview

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Prepare URL mapping”

D48 · How to move a site · Prepare URL mapping

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Monitor traffic”

D48 · How to move a site · Monitor traffic

QUESTION 346 · D48

Would you change the domain, CMS, and site design at the same time?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

Google recommends changing only one thing at a time. Staging major changes makes it easier to identify the cause of problems and measure the move.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Change only one thing at a time Plan your changes to your site one after the other, not everything at the same time. For example, if you want to move your site to a new domain name, change your content management system (CMS), and update your site to use a new layout, do them one at a time: move to a new domain, then change your site's layout.”

D48 · How to move a site · General best practices for site moves

Does a 301 migration automatically lose PageRank?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

No. Google explicitly says 301 and other permanent redirects do not cause PageRank loss. Traffic can still fluctuate while URLs are recrawled and processed, and migration mistakes can cause problems.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Don't worry about link credit. 301 and other permanent redirects don't cause a loss in PageRank.”

D48 · How to move a site · General best practices for site moves

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE · EXACT EXCERPT

“Expect temporary fluctuation in site ranking during the move. With any significant change to a site, you may experience ranking fluctuations while Google recrawls and reindexes your site. As a general rule: for medium-sized websites, it can take a few weeks or”

D48 · How to move a site · General best practices for site moves

How long does Google take to process a move?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

There is no single guaranteed deadline. It happens per URL; a small/medium site may take a few weeks for most pages, while larger sites take longer, depending on URLs and server performance.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Be patient, give it time To consider a site move complete, Googlebot will have to visit every URL on your old and new site at least once. There are no fixed crawl frequencies; how fast Googlebot crawls depends on the size of your site, and the speed of crawling that's possible. The move takes place on a per-URL basis.”

D48 · How to move a site · General best practices for site moves

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“The time it takes Googlebot and our systems to discover and process all URLs in the site move depends on how fast your servers are and how many URLs are involved. As a general rule, a small to medium-sized website can take a few weeks for most pages to move, and larger sites take longer. The speed at which Googlebot and our systems discover and process moved URLs depends on the number of URLs and the server speed.”

D48 · How to move a site · Start the site move

QUESTION 349 · D48

How do you build a reliable old-to-new URL map?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

Collect old URLs from the CMS, sitemaps, server logs, analytics and link data, include important assets, and assign the appropriate new counterpart. Removed content with no replacement should not be forced to an unrelated page.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Determine your old URLs”

D48 · How to move a site · Determine your old URLs

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Include images and videos —Make sure that you include URLs of embedded content in your site move plans: videos, images, JavaScript, and CSS files. These URLs need to be moved in the same way as all other content on your website.”

D48 · How to move a site · Determine your old URLs

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Provide errors for deleted or merged content if you're not moving to the new site all your old content, make sure those URLs correctly return an HTTP 404 or 410 error response code on the new site.”

D48 · How to move a site · Prepare the new site

QUESTION 350 · D48

What canonical and hreflang changes are needed on the destination site?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

Use self-referencing canonicals on new URLs and update hreflang and internal links to the new locations. Conflicting old references undermine consistent migration signals.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Update annotations to point to the new URLs in the HTML or sitemaps entry for each page: Each new URL should have a self-referencing rel="canonical" <link> tag. If the site you moved has multilingual or multinational pages annotated using rel-alternate-hreflang annotations , be sure to update the annotations to use the new URLs.”

D48 · How to move a site · Update all URL details on the new site

QUESTION 351 · D48

Can Googlebot follow a long redirect chain?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

The migration guide says it can follow up to 10 hops, but recommends direct redirects; unavoidable chains should be short, ideally no more than 3 and fewer than 5. This is not permission to design long chains.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Avoid chaining redirects. While Googlebot can follow up to 10 hops in a "chain" of multiple redirects (for example, Page 1 > Page 2 > Page 3), we advise redirecting to the final destination directly. If this is not possible, keep the number of redirects in the chain low, ideally no more than 3 and fewer than 5. Chaining redirects adds latency for users, and not all user agents and browsers support long redirect chains.”

D48 · How to move a site · Plan your redirect strategy

QUESTION 352 · D48 Priority practice

Why not redirect every retired URL to the new home page?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

An irrelevant common destination can confuse users and be treated as a soft 404. Redirect to a relevant equivalent or genuine consolidated replacement; otherwise return the appropriate not-found response.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE · EXACT EXCERPT

“this might mean you push an update to your server configuration files or you update your CMS, likely with custom code. Avoid irrelevant redirects Don't redirect many old URLs to one irrelevant single URL destination, such as the home page of the new site. This can confuse users and might be treated as a soft 404 error . However, if you have consolidated content previously hosted on multiple pages to a new single page, you can”

D48 · How to move a site · Start the site move

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE · EXACT EXCERPT

“many old URLs to one irrelevant single URL destination, such as the home page of the new site. This can confuse users and might be treated as a soft 404 error . However, if you have consolidated content previously hosted on multiple pages to a new single page, you can redirect the older URLs to that new, consolidated page.”

D48 · How to move a site · Start the site move

How long should old-to-new redirects remain active?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

Generally at least one year, according to Google. Keeping them indefinitely can also help users arriving through old links.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Keep the redirects for as long as possible , generally at least 1 year. This timeframe allows Google to transfer all signals to the new URLs, including recrawling and reassigning links on other sites that point to your old URLs. From users' perspective, consider keeping redirects indefinitely. However, redirects are slow for users, so try to update your own links and any high-volume links from other websites to point to the new URLs.”

D48 · How to move a site · Start the site move

Do all migrations require Change of Address in Search Console?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

No. Use it for an appropriate domain/subdomain move. The guide says it is not needed for HTTP-to-HTTPS, www/non-www switching, or moving pages around without user-visible domain changes.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE · EXACT EXCERPT

“only need this tool when moving from one domain or subdomain to another (such as example.com to example.net , or a.example.com to b.example.com). You don't need it for HTTP to HTTPS moves, switching between www and non-www on the same domain, or moving paths within the same domain. For domain migrations : If you're moving to a new domain name, make sure to submit Change of Address requests for all”

D48 · How to move a site · Start the site move

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE · EXACT EXCERPT

“domain or subdomain to another (such as example.com to example.net , or a.example.com to b.example.com). You don't need it for HTTP to HTTPS moves, switching between www and non-www on the same domain, or moving paths within the same domain. For domain migrations : If you're moving to a new domain name, make sure to submit Change of Address requests for all verified variants of the old domain”

D48 · How to move a site · Start the site move

QUESTION 355 · D48

What would you check first if organic visibility drops after migration?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

Check temporary noindex/robots rules, incorrect redirects, new-site crawl errors, capacity under increased crawling, and sitemaps that still contain old URLs. Compare old/new logs and Search Console trends.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Common mistakes”

D48 · How to move a site · Troubleshooting your site move

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Insufficient server capacity After a migration, Google will crawl your new site more heavily than usual. This is because your site redirects traffic from the old to the new site, and any crawls of the old site will be redirected to the new site, in addition to any other crawling. Ensure that your site has sufficient capacity to handle the increased traffic from Google.”

D48 · How to move a site · Troubleshooting your site move

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Not updating sitemaps Be sure that your sitemaps are all updated with the new URLs.”

D48 · How to move a site · Troubleshooting your site move

QUESTION 356 · D48

Priority practice

Should you follow this article's manual Search Console crawl-rate setting instruction?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

No. That wording is stale: Google's official retirement notice says the crawl-rate limiter was deprecated on January 8, 2024. Use current server-response and crawler-management guidance instead.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE · EXACT EXCERPT

“Friday, November 24, 2023 The crawl rate limiter tool in Search Console is being deprecated on Jan 8th, 2024. This tool has been available for over a decade , but with the improvements we've made to our crawling logic and other tools available to publishers, its usefulness has dissipated. Googlebot reacts to how the site—or”

S1 · Upcoming deprecation of Crawl Rate Limiter Tool in Search Console · Official retirement notice

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE · EXACT EXCERPT

“If you need to urgently reduce the crawl rate for short period of time (for example, a couple of hours, or 1-2 days), then return 500 , 503 , or 429 HTTP response status code instead of 200 to the crawl requests. Google's crawling infrastructure reduces your site's crawling rate when it”

D25 · Reduce the Google crawl rate · Urgently reduce crawler traffic (for emergencies)

Minimize A/B testing impact in Google Search

Google last updated: 2025-12-10 · Reviewed 6 October 2026

<https://developers.google.com/search/docs/crawling-indexing/website-testing>

Detailed points to revise

- A/B tests compare two or more variations of a change; multivariate tests examine multiple changes and their combinations. Tests can use separate URLs or dynamically vary one URL.
- Small layout, color, image placement or call-to-action variations may greatly affect users while having little or no effect on snippets or ranking.
- Do not cloak: Googlebot and humans must not be deliberately sent fundamentally different test URL sets. Googlebot generally does not support cookies and may see the version accessible without them.
- For test variants with separate URLs, point rel=canonical to the original. This expresses the duplicate/variant intent better than noindex and avoids unintended indexing effects.
- Use temporary 302 redirects for experiment routing, rather than permanent 301. The guide also permits JavaScript-based test redirects.
- Run a test only as long as needed for reliable conclusions, based on traffic/conversion data. Then deploy the chosen version and remove alternate URLs, scripts and markup promptly.
- Prolonged experiments designed to deceive search engines can lead to action. The source is SEO guidance, not a statistical test-design tutorial.

Complete source section checklist: Overview of testing · Best practices when testing · Don't cloak your test pages · Use rel="canonical" links · Use 302 redirects, not 301 redirects · Run the experiment only as long as necessary · More information about testing

QUESTION 357 · D49 Priority practice

How would you protect SEO when A/B testing separate URLs?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

Keep the original as canonical using rel=canonical on variants, use temporary 302 redirects when routing users, avoid cloaking, and clean up variants after the experiment concludes.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE · EXACT EXCERPT

"URLs, you can use the rel="canonical" link attribute on all of your alternate URLs to indicate that the original URL is the preferred version. We recommend using rel="canonical" rather than a noindex meta tag because it more closely matches your intent in this situation. For instance, if you are testing variations of your home page, you don't want search engines not to index your home page; you just want them to understand"

D49 · Minimize A/B testing impact in Google Search · Use rel="canonical" links

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“If you're running a test that redirects users from the original URL to a variation URL, use a 302 (temporary) redirect, not a 301 (permanent) redirect. This tells search engines that this redirect is temporary—it will only be in place as long as you're running the experiment— and that they should keep the original URL in their index rather than replacing it with the target of the redirect (the test page). JavaScript-based redirects are also fine.”

D49 · Minimize A/B testing impact in Google Search · Use 302 redirects, not 301 redirects

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE · EXACT EXCERPT

“gathered enough data to draw a reliable conclusion. Once you've concluded the test, update your site with the desired content variation(s) and remove all elements of the test as soon as possible, such as alternate URLs or testing scripts and markup. If we discover a site running an experiment for an unnecessarily long time, we may interpret this as an attempt to deceive search engines and take action”

D49 · Minimize A/B testing impact in Google Search · Run the experiment only as long as necessary

QUESTION 358 · D49

Why does Google recommend canonical rather than noindex for test variants?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

The intent is to group close variants with the original as the preferred URL, rather than suppress indexing. The guide warns noindex can have unexpected effects in this situation.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE · EXACT EXCERPT

“of your alternate URLs to indicate that the original URL is the preferred version. We recommend using rel="canonical" rather than a noindex meta tag because it more closely matches your intent in this situation. For instance, if you are testing variations of your home page, you don't want search engines not to index your home page; you just want them to understand that all the test URLs are close duplicates”

D49 · Minimize A/B testing impact in Google Search · Use rel="canonical" links

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE · EXACT EXCERPT

“should be grouped together, with the original URL as the canonical. Using noindex rather than rel="canonical" in such a situation can sometimes have unexpected bad effects.”

D49 · Minimize A/B testing impact in Google Search · Use rel="canonical" links

QUESTION 359 · D49

Can you show Googlebot a different test URL set from humans?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

No. The guide calls that cloaking, whether done through server logic, robots.txt or another method, and says it violates spam policies.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Don't show one set of URLs to Googlebot, and a different set to humans. This is called cloaking , and is against our spam policies , whether you're running a test or not. Remember that infringing our spam policies can get your site demoted or removed from Google search results—probably not the desired outcome of your test.”

D49 · Minimize A/B testing impact in Google Search · Don't cloak your test pages

QUESTION 360 · D49

What should you remember about cookie-based experiments?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

Googlebot generally does not support cookies, so it will normally see the version available to users whose browsers do not accept them.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“If you're using cookies to control the test, keep in mind that Googlebot generally doesn't support cookies. This means it will only see the content version that's accessible to users with browsers that don't accept cookies.”

D49 · Minimize A/B testing impact in Google Search · Don't cloak your test pages

QUESTION 361 · D49

When should you end and clean up a test?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

Once there is enough evidence for a reliable conclusion, deploy the chosen version and remove experimental URLs/scripts/markup as soon as possible. There is no universal SEO-safe number of days.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE · EXACT EXCERPT

“The amount of time required for a reliable test will vary depending on factors like your conversion rates, and how much traffic your website gets; a good testing tool tells you when you've gathered enough data to draw a reliable conclusion. Once you've concluded the test,”

D49 · Minimize A/B testing impact in Google Search · Run the experiment only as long as necessary

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE · EXACT EXCERPT

“gathered enough data to draw a reliable conclusion. Once you've concluded the test, update your site with the desired content variation(s) and remove all elements of the test as soon as possible, such as alternate URLs or testing scripts and markup. If we discover a site running an experiment for an unnecessarily long time, we may interpret this as an attempt to deceive search engines and take action”

D49 · Minimize A/B testing impact in Google Search · Run the experiment only as long as necessary

Temporarily pause or disable a website

Google last updated: 2025-12-10 · Reviewed 6 October 2026

<https://developers.google.com/search/docs/crawling-indexing/pause-online-business>

Detailed points to revise

- For a temporary inability to fulfill orders, keep the site accessible and limit functionality, such as disabling checkout. Let people still find product information, reviews and wishlists.
- Explain delays or closure with a clear banner; data-nosnippet can exclude its text from snippets. Update Product availability, cancelled events, Local Business hours and Merchant Center availability as applicable.
- Ask for recrawling of a few changed pages through Search Console; use sitemaps for larger sets. Do not remove out-of-stock products merely to express availability.
- Completely disabling a site is an extreme measure with uncertain recovery. It can reduce public business information, affect Knowledge Panels and verification/report access, and make recovery harder.
- For an urgent 1-2 day shutdown, the guide describes an informational 503 page. For longer closure, provide an indexable 200-status home-page placeholder rather than serving indefinite 503 responses everywhere.
- If using 503, keep robots.txt valid and accessible, use Retry-After with a best-effort estimate, and provide a light static page with reopening information and contact guidance.
- Returning 503 prevents Google's systems refreshing that page's titles, descriptions, metadata and structured data. Test actual HTTP responses rather than assuming the visible page communicates the status.
- Do not use site-wide robots disallow, 403/404/410, noindex, or temporary removal as the routine closure strategy. Those controls can remove visibility that customers need.
- The guide mentions crawl-rate reduction and resetting a setting, but the Search Console manual limiter was retired in 2024. Current reduction guidance should be used; reducing crawl rate can delay freshness.
- Regional access needs care. This page emphasizes US-origin crawling; the newer crawler overview says Google may use other countries if needed. Do not assume that blocking the US guarantees all Google crawlers are blocked; test verified crawler access and favor limiting local functionality.

Complete source section checklist: Limit your site's functionality (recommended) · Not recommended: Disable the whole website · Best practices for disabling a site · FAQs · What if I only close the site for a few weeks? · What if I want to exclude all non-essential products? · Can I ask Google to crawl less while my site is temporarily closed? · How do I get a page indexed or updated quickly? · What if I block a specific region from accessing my site? · Should I use the Removals Tool to remove out-of-stock products?

How would you handle an online shop that cannot accept orders for several weeks?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

Keep the site online and disable checkout or other unavailable functions. Display accurate status, update availability/hours/structured data and feeds, and ask Google to recrawl changes.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“If your situation is temporary and you plan to reopen your online business, we recommend that you keep your site online and limit the functionality. This is the recommended approach since it minimizes any negative effects on your site's presence in Search. People can still find your products, read reviews, or add wishlists so they can purchase at a later time. We recommend doing the following:”

D50 · Temporarily pause or disable a website · Limit your site's functionality (recommended)

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Disable the cart functionality : Disabling the cart functionality is the simplest approach, and doesn't change anything for your site's visibility in Search.”

D50 · Temporarily pause or disable a website · Limit your site's functionality (recommended)

Should out-of-stock product pages be removed with Search Console's Removals tool?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

No. Keep useful product information available and mark the item out of stock. Removing it can leave customers without first-hand information.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“No. If you do this, customers won't be able to find first-hand information about your products on Search, and there might still be third-party information for the product that may be incorrect or incomplete. It's better to still allow that page, and mark it out of stock. That way people can still understand what's going on, even if they can't purchase the item. If you remove the product from Search, people don't know why it's gone.”

D50 · Temporarily pause or disable a website · Should I use the Removals Tool to remove out-of-stock products?

QUESTION 364 · D50

What HTTP response fits an urgent 1–2 day site shutdown?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

The guide describes an informational 503 page. For a longer shutdown, it recommends an indexable home-page placeholder returning 200 instead.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“If you need to urgently disable the site for 1-2 days, then return an informational error page with a 503 HTTP response status code instead of all content. Make sure to follow the best practices for disabling a site .”

D50 · Temporarily pause or disable a website · Not recommended: Disable the whole website

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“If you need to disable the site for a longer time, then provide an indexable home page as a placeholder for users to find in Search by using the 200 HTTP status code.”

D50 · Temporarily pause or disable a website · Not recommended: Disable the whole website

QUESTION 365 · D50

Priority practice

Should robots.txt also return 503 during temporary maintenance?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

No. Keep it valid and allow crawling. Google warns that a 503 for robots.txt blocks all crawling.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Continue to allow crawling through the robots.txt file. Don't return a 503 HTTP response status code for the robots.txt file because this blocks all crawling .”

D50 · Temporarily pause or disable a website · Best practices for disabling a site

QUESTION 366 · D50

What should a temporary 503 page include?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

Use Retry-After with a best-effort date/duration, lightweight static HTML, minimal external resources, and clear status/reopening/contact guidance for users.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“To minimize the server-side and client-side load of a 503 error page, follow these best practices: Use the retry-after HTTP header with a best effort date or duration. Use static HTML. Minimize off-page resources; use inline CSS stylesheets and base-64-encoded images.”

D50 · Temporarily pause or disable a website · Best practices for disabling a site

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Give your users clear guidance on future steps within the content of the error page. This could include: Links to more information The date when you expect the website to be online again, or when the information will be updated How to contact customer service”

D50 · Temporarily pause or disable a website · Best practices for disabling a site

QUESTION 367 · D50

Will Google refresh new titles or structured data while the page returns 503?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

No. The guide says its systems cannot refresh those details while the page returns 503.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“: Keep in mind that it's not possible for Google's systems to refresh titles, descriptions, metadata, or structured data included on a website if a page returns a”

D50 · Temporarily pause or disable a website · Best practices for disabling a site

QUESTION 368 · D50

Can you promise a quick recovery after fully removing a site from the index?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

No. The guide gives no fixed recovery time or acceleration mechanism, and warns a full removal can be a significant, slow-to-recover change.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“: Google's systems are designed to be robust and to help websites recover from temporary issues. However, removing a site completely from Google's index is a significant change that can take quite some time to recover from. There's no fixed time for a recovery from a complete removal, and there's no mechanism to speed that up. This is why we strongly recommend limiting functionality instead of removing the site from Search.”

D50 · Temporarily pause or disable a website · Not recommended: Disable the whole website

Is blocking one country a reliable way to block all Google crawling?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

No blanket claim is safe. This closure page emphasizes US crawling, but Google's newer crawler overview says it may try other countries when access is blocked. Diagnose actual verified requests and access instead.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Google's crawlers and fetchers are designed to be run simultaneously by thousands of machines to improve performance and scale as the web grows. To optimize bandwidth usage, these clients are distributed across many datacenters across the world so they're located near the sites that they might access. Therefore, your logs may show visits from several IP addresses. Google egresses primarily from IP addresses in the United States. In case Google detects that a site is blocking requests from the United States, it may attempt to crawl from IP addresses located in other countries.”

D23 · Overview of Google crawlers and fetchers (user agents) · Technical properties of Google's crawlers and fetchers

Overview of Search appearance topics

Google last updated: 2026-09-16 · Reviewed 6 October 2026

<https://developers.google.com/search/docs/appearance>

Detailed points to revise

- This overview maps Search appearance topics: AI, business information, dates, favicons, featured snippets, paywalls, Discover, images, preferred sources, regional features, profiles, site names, sitelinks, snippets, titles, places, translations, video, visual elements and Web Stories.
- It explains that structured data helps Google understand a page and can support richer displays; it is a topic directory rather than a complete eligibility specification.
- Its feature list includes Article, Breadcrumb, Carousel, Course list, Dataset, Discussion forum, Education Q&A, Employer aggregate rating, Event, Image metadata, Job posting, Local business, Math solver, Movie carousel, Organization, Practice problem, Product and its listed commerce subfeatures, Profile page, Q&A, Recipe, Review snippet, Software app, Speakable, paywalled content, Vacation rental and Video.
- The current list is different from older SEO checklists. Do not assume every schema.org type has a supported Google rich result; consult the current search gallery and feature guide.
- Package tracking and structured-data carousels beta appear under the Early Adopters Program, which pilots features with limited organizations.

Complete source section checklist: Using structured data · Features that use structured data · Early Adopters Program

QUESTION 370 · D51

What does the Search appearance overview cover?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

It maps ways a site can influence its presentation in Search, including snippets, titles, media, business information and structured-data features. Detailed requirements belong to the linked feature guides.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“The topics in this section describe how you can influence how your website appears in Google Search.”

D51 · Overview of Search appearance topics · Overview of Search appearance topics

QUESTION 371 · D51

Does every schema.org type automatically create a Google rich result?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

No. This overview lists supported feature areas; use the current Search gallery and individual documentation to identify Google support rather than equating all schema.org vocabulary with a Search feature.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“List of structured data markup that Google Search supports Understand how structured data works Generate structured data with JavaScript General structured data guidelines Enriched search results”

D51 · Overview of Search appearance topics · Using structured data

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Google uses structured data to understand the content on the page and show that content in a richer appearance in search results, which is called a rich result . To make your site eligible for appearance as one of these rich results, follow the guide to learn how to implement structured data on your site. If you're just getting started, visit Understand how structured data works .”

D86 · Structured data markup that Google Search supports · Structured data markup that Google Search supports

QUESTION 372 · D51

What does an Early Adopters listing imply?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

Google is piloting the feature with a limited number of organizations. It does not mean every site can enable it immediately by adding markup.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“To ensure the best experience for users, Google pilots some features with a limited number of organizations. Here are the features that are in the Early Adopters Program:”

D51 · Overview of Search appearance topics · Early Adopters Program

AI features and your website

Google last updated: 2025-12-10 · Reviewed 6 October 2026

<https://developers.google.com/search/docs/appearance/ai-features>

Detailed points to revise

- AI Overviews summarize complex topics with supporting links. AI Mode supports deeper exploration, reasoning and comparisons. They can use different models and produce different responses and links.
- Query fan-out can issue related searches across subtopics and data sources; AI Overviews do not trigger for every query.
- A supporting-link page must be indexed and eligible for a Search snippet, meeting ordinary Search technical requirements. Eligibility and compliance do not guarantee serving.
- Existing SEO fundamentals apply: accessible crawling/CDNs, internal discovery, useful text, page experience, relevant images/video, visible-content-consistent markup and current business/merchant information.
- No special AI schema, AI text file, or extra technical requirement is specified for these features.
- The captured 2025 article says AI traffic is included in the Web Performance report. Newer Google documentation also provides a dedicated generative AI impressions report; the update note supplies the current context.
- The page lists Googlebot access and nosnippet/data-nosnippet/max-snippet/noindex as Search controls; Google-Extended has a different training/grounding scope. Newer Search Console generative-AI controls are covered in the update note.
- Diagnose preview controls in the HTML received by Googlebot and allow time for recrawling and processing; this page gives days to months, not a fixed deadline.
- Evaluate conversion quality and engagement alongside visibility. Google's observed higher-quality AI clicks are not a guarantee for every site.

Complete source section checklist: How AI features work in Search · How to appear in AI features · Technical requirements for appearing in AI features · SEO best practices · Measuring the performance of your site · Controlling your content in AI features in Search · Troubleshooting preview controls

QUESTION 373 · D52 **Priority practice**

Is a special AI file or schema required to appear in AI Overviews or AI Mode?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

No. Google says ordinary Search SEO and technical requirements apply; there is no special schema or new machine-readable AI file requirement.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“You don't need to create new machine readable files, AI text files, or markup to appear in these features. There's also no special schema.org structured data that you need to add.”

D52 · AI features and your website · SEO best practices

QUESTION 374 · D52 Priority practice

What is the technical eligibility for an AI supporting link?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

The page must be indexed and eligible to appear in Search with a snippet, while meeting ordinary Search technical requirements. Eligibility does not guarantee that it will be shown.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“To be eligible to be shown as a supporting link in AI Overviews or AI Mode, a page must be indexed and eligible to be shown in Google Search with a snippet, fulfilling the Search technical requirements . There are no additional technical requirements.”

D52 · AI features and your website · Technical requirements for appearing in AI features

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Just because a page meets all requirements, best practices, and complies with the policies, doesn't mean that Google will crawl, index, or serve its content. Indexing and serving isn't guaranteed. Learn more about”

D52 · AI features and your website · Technical requirements for appearing in AI features

QUESTION 375 · D52

What is query fan-out?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

AI Overviews or AI Mode may run multiple related searches across subtopics and data sources while forming a response, which can reveal additional supporting pages.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Both AI Overviews and AI Mode may use a "query fan-out" technique — issuing multiple related searches across subtopics and data sources — to develop a response. While responses are being generated, our advanced models identify more supporting web pages, allowing us to display a wider and more diverse set of helpful links associated with the response than with a classic web search, enabling new opportunities for exploration.”

D52 · AI features and your website · How AI features work in Search

QUESTION 376 · D52

Do AI Overviews appear for every query, with the same sources as AI Mode?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

No. Overviews appear when the system judges them additive to classic Search. Different models and techniques can produce different responses and supporting links.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“AI Mode and AI Overviews may use different models and techniques, so the set of responses and links they show will vary. AI Overviews are only shown when our systems determine that it is additive to classic Search, and as such, often don't trigger.”

D52 · AI features and your website · How AI features work in Search

QUESTION 377 · D52

How should you explain AI performance measurement today?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

The supplied article includes AI traffic in the overall Web report. Google's June 2026 announcement adds dedicated generative AI reports showing impressions and dimensions; these supplement the overall report, rather than promising a separate AI clicks metric.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Just like the rest of the search results page, sites appearing in AI features (such as AI Overviews and AI Mode) are included in the overall search traffic in Search Console . In particular, they're reported on in the Performance report , within the "Web" search type . Learn more about how AI Overviews and AI Mode are counted towards the overall data in Search Console, how to analyze traffic changes overall, and how to combine Search Console and Analytics data .”

D52 · AI features and your website · Measuring the performance of your site

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“The new Search Console reports are designed to give you dedicated views of your impressions within generative AI features on Search, such as AI Overviews and AI Mode, as well as generative AI features in Discover. This data is included in the overall performance report, where it will continue to be tracked to give site owners an overview of the overall visibility of their site in Google Search. Today, we are launching a separate view dedicated to visibility from generative AI features.”

S2 · Introducing Search Generative AI performance reports in Search Console · Introduction

QUESTION 378 · D52

How would you diagnose a preview-control change that has not taken effect?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

Check that the control is correct and visible in the HTML Googlebot received, then allow recrawling and processing. The page says this can take days to months; request recrawling where appropriate.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Make sure that the preview control is correct and visible to Googlebot. To test if your implementation is correct, use the URL Inspection tool to see the HTML that Googlebot received while crawling the page.”

D52 · AI features and your website · Troubleshooting preview controls

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Allow time for Google to recrawl and process the change in preview controls. Remember that crawling can take anywhere from several days to several months, depending on how often our systems determine a page needs to be refreshed. If you've made changes, you can request that Google recrawl your pages .”

D52 · AI features and your website · Troubleshooting preview controls

QUESTION 379 · D52

Is Google-Extended the crawler control for AI Overviews in Search?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

This guide identifies Googlebot for Search access and Google-Extended for some other training/grounding systems. Newer Search Console AI controls also exist; consult the update note before presenting the 2025 article as exhaustive.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“AI is built into Search and integral to how Search functions, which is why robots.txt directives for Googlebot is the control for site owners to manage access to how their sites are crawled for Search. To limit the information shown from your pages in Search, use nosnippet , data-nosnippet , max-snippet , or noindex controls.”

D52 · AI features and your website · Controlling your content in AI features in Search

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“To limit AI training and grounding in some of Google's other systems, read more about Google-Extended .”

D52 · AI features and your website · Controlling your content in AI features in Search

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE · EXACT EXCERPT

“Search generative AI control”

S3 · Search generative AI control · Search generative AI control

QUESTION 380 · D52 Additional practice

A page is indexed, but its important answers exist only inside images. What would you improve for AI-feature visibility?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

Make important content available as text, supported by relevant images or videos. Also check internal discovery and Googlebot access through the CDN. The guide recommends these ordinary SEO fundamentals and does not promise inclusion after the fix.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Making sure that important content is available in textual form”

D52 · AI features and your website · SEO best practices

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Ensuring that crawling is allowed in robots.txt, and by any CDN or hosting infrastructure”

D52 · AI features and your website · SEO best practices

QUESTION 381 · D52 Additional practice

What would you measure beyond clicks when evaluating AI-search visitors?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

Track conversions and engagement, such as time spent, alongside Search Console visibility. Google reports an observation of higher-quality AI Overview clicks; use your own analytics to assess business value rather than assuming every site's clicks behave identically.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“In addition to Search Console, you could also track conversions and time spent on your site in other tools, such as Google Analytics. We've seen that when people click from search results pages with AI Overviews, these clicks are higher quality (meaning, users are more likely to spend more time on the site).”

D52 · AI features and your website · Measuring the performance of your site

Influence your byline dates in Google Search

Google last updated: 2025-12-10 · Reviewed 6 October 2026

<https://developers.google.com/search/docs/appearance/publication-dates>

Detailed points to revise

- A byline date is Google's estimate of publication or significant update time and is displayed when useful. No single date signal is definitive and display is not guaranteed.
- Show a prominent human-visible date, correctly labeled Published or Last updated.
- Add `datePublished`/`dateModified` on a `CreativeWork` subtype such as `Article`, `BlogPosting` or `VideoObject`, following structured-data rules.
- A date is required; time is optional. Including time and the correct timezone in markup improves precision, including daylight-saving handling.
- Keep visible and structured dates/times consistent; visible time/timezone may be omitted even if markup supplies them.
- Dates should describe the page's publication/update, not a future date or the date of an event discussed on the page. Event markup can describe the event separately.
- If Google chooses the wrong date, reduce competing dates. Google News has additional linked guidance; code examples are preserved in the source reference.

Complete source section checklist: How to provide date information to Google · Best practices for influencing byline dates

QUESTION 382 · D53 Priority practice

How do you help Google show the correct publication date?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

Provide a prominent labeled visible date and matching `datePublished`/`dateModified` in suitable `CreativeWork` structured data. Google uses multiple signals and does not guarantee a displayed date.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE · EXACT EXCERPT

“Add a user-visible date to the page and feature it prominently. Label your dates appropriately with text like “Publish” or “Last updated”. Here are some examples of how you can highlight date information about a web page: Posted Feb 4, 2019”

D53 · Influence your byline dates in Google Search · How to provide date information to Google

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE · EXACT EXCERPT

“dates with structured data . We recommend that you add a subtype of CreativeWork (such as Article , BlogPosting , or VideoObject) , and specify the datePublished and/or dateModified fields. Be sure to follow Google's structured data guidelines to help our crawlers understand your article dates. < html > < head > < title>Analyzing Google Search traffic drops < / title > < script type =”

D53 · Influence your byline dates in Google Search · How to provide date information to Google

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“While Google doesn't guarantee that a byline date, whether visible or in structured data, will be shown in search results, following these guidelines does help our algorithms find and process the information.”

D53 · Influence your byline dates in Google Search · Best practices for influencing byline dates

QUESTION 383 · D53 Priority practice

Should an article use an event's future date as its publication date?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

No. The date should describe when the page was published or updated; an event's date belongs in separate Event markup where appropriate.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Don't specify future dates, or the date of the action described on the page. The dates must describe the publication or update date of the page, not the stories or events described therein. You can add Event markup to the page to describe the activities listed on the page, if you like.”

D53 · Influence your byline dates in Google Search · Best practices for influencing byline dates

QUESTION 384 · D53

Is time and timezone mandatory in byline markup?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

The date is required and the time is not. Google recommends time and timezone for precision, correctly accounting for daylight saving when applicable.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“The date is required; the time is not: However, we recommend you provide a time and timezone in markup for added precision.”

D53 · Influence your byline dates in Google Search · Best practices for influencing byline dates

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“If you choose to specify the timezone, provide the correct timezone , taking into account daylight saving time as appropriate.”

D53 · Influence your byline dates in Google Search · Best practices for influencing byline dates

QUESTION 385 · D53

What would you check if Google shows the wrong byline date?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

Check consistency of visible and structured dates, correct publication/update meaning and timezone, then consider removing other competing dates.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Make your dates and times consistent. Ensure that the date (and optional time and timezone) match between the equivalent user-visible and structured values. Time and timezone are optional in user-visible data even if provided in structured data.”

D53 · Influence your byline dates in Google Search · Best practices for influencing byline dates

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Minimize the presence of other dates on the page: If you've followed the best practices and find incorrect dates are being selected, consider removing some or all other dates that appear on the page.”

D53 · Influence your byline dates in Google Search · Best practices for influencing byline dates

QUESTION 386 · D53 Additional practice

An article's timestamp changes incorrectly during daylight saving time. What should you check?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

Use the correct timezone and account for daylight saving where applicable. Keep equivalent visible dates/times and structured values consistent; a timezone value should describe the actual publication or update time.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“If you choose to specify the timezone, provide the correct timezone , taking into account daylight saving time as appropriate.”

D53 · Influence your byline dates in Google Search · Best practices for influencing byline dates

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Make your dates and times consistent. Ensure that the date (and optional time and timezone) match between the equivalent user-visible and structured values. Time and timezone are optional in user-visible data even if provided in structured data.”

D53 · Influence your byline dates in Google Search · Best practices for influencing byline dates

QUESTION 387 · D53

Additional practice

If markup contains an exact time and timezone, must the visible byline display both?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

No. The visible date must be consistent with the equivalent structured value, but the guide explicitly permits omitting time and timezone from user-visible data even when both appear in the markup.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Make your dates and times consistent. Ensure that the date (and optional time and timezone) match between the equivalent user-visible and structured values. Time and timezone are optional in user-visible data even if provided in structured data.”

D53 · Influence your byline dates in Google Search · Best practices for influencing byline dates

Define a favicon to show in search results

Google last updated: 2026-08-28 · Reviewed 6 October 2026

<https://developers.google.com/search/docs/appearance/favicon-in-search>

Detailed points to revise

- Organic Search favicon guidance differs from the separate Google Ads logo specifications.
- Add a supported icon link to the home-page head. Supported rel values include icon, shortcut icon, apple-touch-icon and apple-touch-icon-precomposed.
- The href may be relative or absolute and may point to a CDN. The home page must be crawlable by Googlebot and the icon by Googlebot-Image.
- One favicon is supported per hostname: a domain and a subdomain can differ, but individual subdirectories cannot have separate Search favicons.
- The current August 2026 rule is square 1:1, at least 8×8 px; Google recommends larger than 48×48 px for various surfaces. Do not repeat an older multiple-of-48 rule as the current requirement.
- Current supported file formats are BMP, GIF, ICO, PNG, JPEG, PPM and TIFF; use this specific list rather than assuming the general image list applies.
- Keep the favicon URL stable and imagery representative and appropriate. Inappropriate symbols may be replaced by a default icon.
- Recrawl the home page after a change; processing may take days to weeks and appearance is not guaranteed. The feedback form supports system improvement, not guaranteed individual action.

Complete source section checklist: Implementation · Guidelines · Submit feedback about favicons in search results

QUESTION 388 · D54 Priority practice

What are the current favicon dimensions for Google Search?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

The current page requires a square 1:1 icon of at least 8×8 px and recommends larger than 48×48 px. Check the current guide rather than repeating an old size rule.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Your favicon must be a square (1:1 aspect ratio) that's at least 8x8px. While the minimum size requirement is 8x8px, we recommend using a favicon that's larger than 48x48px so that it looks good on various surfaces. Google Search supports the following favicon file formats: BMP, GIF, ICO, PNG, JPEG, PPM, and TIFF.”

D54 · Define a favicon to show in search results · Guidelines

QUESTION 389 · D54

Priority practice

Can /shop and /blog have separate Search favicons on the same hostname?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

No. Google supports one favicon per hostname, not per subdirectory. A separate subdomain can have its own favicon.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Google Search only supports one favicon per site, where a site is defined by the hostname. For example, <https://www.example.com/> and <https://code.example.com/> are two different hostnames, and therefore can have two different favicons. However, <https://www.example.com/sub-site> is a subdirectory of a site, and you can only set one favicon for <https://www.example.com/>, which applies to the site and its subdirectories. Supported : <https://example.com> (this is a domain-level home page) Supported : <https://news.example.com> (this is a subdomain-level home page) Not supported : <https://example.com/news> (this is a subdirectory-level home page)”

D54 · Define a favicon to show in search results · Guidelines

QUESTION 390 · D54

Which resources must Google crawl to update a favicon?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

Googlebot must reach the home page and Googlebot-Image the favicon file. The icon URL can be on a CDN, and a home-page indexing request can help initiate processing.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Googlebot-Image must be able to crawl the favicon file and Googlebot must be able to crawl the home page; they cannot be blocked for crawling.”

D54 · Define a favicon to show in search results · Guidelines

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE · EXACT EXCERPT

“be a relative path (/smile.ico) or absolute path (https://example.com/smile.ico). The URL doesn't need to be hosted on your site (for example, your favicon could be hosted on a content delivery network (CDN)).”

D54 · Define a favicon to show in search results · Implementation

QUESTION 391 · D54

Does a correct icon link guarantee immediate display?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

No. Recrawl and processing take time, and the guide explicitly says appearance is not guaranteed even when its rules are met.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“A favicon isn't guaranteed to appear in Google Search results, even if all guidelines are met.”

D54 · Define a favicon to show in search results · Guidelines

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Allow time for Google to recrawl and process the new information on your home page. Remember that crawling can take anywhere from several days to several weeks, depending on how often our systems determine content needs to be refreshed. You can request indexing of your site's home page by using the URL Inspection tool.”

D54 · Define a favicon to show in search results · Implementation

QUESTION 392 · D54

Are all general Google image formats automatically valid favicon formats?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

No. Use the favicon-specific list: BMP, GIF, ICO, PNG, JPEG, PPM and TIFF.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Your favicon must be a square (1:1 aspect ratio) that's at least 8x8px. While the minimum size requirement is 8x8px, we recommend using a favicon that's larger than 48x48px so that it looks good on various surfaces. Google Search supports the following favicon file formats: BMP, GIF, ICO, PNG, JPEG, PPM, and TIFF.”

D54 · Define a favicon to show in search results · Guidelines

Can the favicon live on a CDN rather than the website's own domain?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

Yes. The homepage link can use a relative or absolute URL, and the favicon can be hosted elsewhere, including a CDN. Keep that URL stable and ensure Google can crawl the required homepage and image resources.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE · EXACT EXCERPT

“documentation . href The URL of the favicon. The URL can be a relative path (/smile.ico) or absolute path (https://example.com/smile.ico). The URL doesn't need to be hosted on your site (for example, your favicon could be hosted on a content delivery network (CDN)).”

D54 · Define a favicon to show in search results · Implementation

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“The favicon URL must be stable (don't change the URL frequently).”

D54 · Define a favicon to show in search results · Guidelines

Why might Google show a default icon despite a correctly sized favicon?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

Google may replace a favicon it considers inappropriate, including pornography or hate symbols, with a default icon. Dimensions and a valid link alone do not establish compliance or guarantee display.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Google won't show any favicon that it deems inappropriate, including pornography or hate symbols (for example, swastikas). If this type of imagery is discovered within a favicon, Google replaces it with a default icon.”

D54 · Define a favicon to show in search results · Guidelines

Featured snippets and your website

Google last updated: 2025-12-10 · Reviewed 6 October 2026

<https://developers.google.com/search/docs/appearance/featured-snippets>

Detailed points to revise

- Featured snippets reverse the ordinary result layout by placing the descriptive extract first and can also appear in People Also Ask.
- There is no markup that designates a page as a featured snippet; Google's systems choose it for a query.
- `nosnippet` blocks both ordinary and featured snippets. `data-nosnippet` excludes marked text from both; when both exist, `nosnippet` takes priority.
- To retain ordinary snippets while discouraging featured snippets, experiment with shorter max-snippet values. Google supplies no universal minimum and low values do not guarantee exclusion.
- Use `nosnippet` when guaranteed snippet exclusion is required, accepting its broader effect.
- A featured-snippet click can scroll to the quoted section automatically. If browser support or precise section identification fails, the click goes to the top of the page.

Complete source section checklist: How can I opt out of featured snippets? · Block all snippets · Block featured snippets only · How can I mark my page as a featured snippet? · What happens when a user clicks a featured snippet?

QUESTION 395 · D55 Priority practice

Can structured data mark a page as the featured snippet?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

No. Google's systems select whether a page is a useful featured snippet for a user's query; publishers cannot designate it.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“How can I mark my page as a featured snippet?”

D55 · Featured snippets and your website · How can I mark my page as a featured snippet?

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“You can't. Google systems determine whether a page would make a good featured snippet for a user's search request, and if so, elevates it.”

D55 · Featured snippets and your website · How can I mark my page as a featured snippet?

How can you block featured snippets while retaining ordinary snippets?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

Experiment with lower max-snippet values. There is no guaranteed cutoff; use nosnippet only if you accept blocking ordinary snippets too.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Google does not provide an exact minimum length required to appear as a featured snippet. This is because the minimum length is variable based on a number of factors, including—but not limited to—the information in the snippet, the language, and the platform (mobile device, app, or desktop).”

D55 · Featured snippets and your website · Block featured snippets only

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Using a low max-snippet setting doesn't guarantee that Google will stop showing featured snippets for your page. If you need a guaranteed solution, use the”

D55 · Featured snippets and your website · Block featured snippets only

How do nosnippet and data-nosnippet interact?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

nosnippet suppresses all snippets for the page and takes priority; data-nosnippet excludes only its marked text from ordinary and featured snippets.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“If both nosnippet and data-nosnippet rules appear in a page, nosnippet takes priority, and snippets won't be shown for the page.”

D55 · Featured snippets and your website · Block all snippets

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Text marked by the data-nosnippet HTML attribute won't appear in featured snippets or regular snippets either.”

D55 · Featured snippets and your website · Block all snippets

QUESTION 398 · D55

Do snippet jump links require publishers to add special section markup?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

No additional annotation is needed. Google may scroll to the quoted section automatically; unsupported browsers or uncertain positioning fall back to the page top.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Clicking a featured snippet takes the user directly to the section of the page that appeared in the featured snippet. Scrolling to the position that appeared in the snippet happens automatically, without any additional annotation by the site. If a browser doesn't support the underlying technology needed, or if our systems can't confidently determine exactly where within a page to direct a click, clicking a featured snippet will take a user to the top of the source web page.”

D55 · Featured snippets and your website · What happens when a user clicks a featured snippet?

QUESTION 399 · D55 Additional practice

Can you guarantee that max-snippet:30 blocks featured snippets but preserves ordinary snippets?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

No. Google gives no exact minimum for a useful featured snippet; it varies with content, language and platform. Shortening max-snippet reduces likelihood but does not guarantee exclusion. nosnippet is the documented guaranteed snippet-blocking solution.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Google does not provide an exact minimum length required to appear as a featured snippet. This is because the minimum length is variable based on a number of factors, including—but not limited to—the information in the snippet, the language, and the platform (mobile device, app, or desktop).”

D55 · Featured snippets and your website · Block featured snippets only

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“setting doesn't guarantee that Google will stop showing featured snippets for your page. If you need a guaranteed solution, use the”

D55 · Featured snippets and your website · Block featured snippets only

A featured-snippet click opens the page at the top rather than at the quoted passage. Is special markup necessarily missing?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

No. The automatic jump can fall back to the top when the browser lacks support or Google cannot confidently identify the destination. The guide says the jump requires no additional site annotation.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Clicking a featured snippet takes the user directly to the section of the page that appeared in the featured snippet. Scrolling to the position that appeared in the snippet happens automatically, without any additional annotation by the site. If a browser doesn't support the underlying technology needed, or if our systems can't confidently determine exactly where within a page to direct a click, clicking a featured snippet will take a user to the top of the source web page.”

D55 · Featured snippets and your website · What happens when a user clicks a featured snippet?

Flexible Sampling general guidance

Google last updated: 2025-12-10 · Reviewed 6 October 2026

<https://developers.google.com/search/docs/appearance/flexible-sampling>

Detailed points to revise

- Flexible Sampling covers subscription-content exposure and its effects on users, referrals and conversion. Experiment cautiously rather than treat one quota as universally optimal.
- Metering allows a quota of full articles before a subscription/login barrier. Lead-in exposes part of an article without offering all of it.
- The guide generally favors monthly over daily quotas for flexibility, concentrating barriers on engaged users while letting newcomers experience value.
- For many daily news publishers it suggests 6-10 articles per user per month, with 10 as a starting experiment. These are recommendations, not universal ranking eligibility requirements.
- Exposing the opening sentences after the meter is exhausted can help users understand value and encourage subscription.
- Track referral/conversion effects and how often search visitors hit paywalls. The source reports satisfaction degrading above about 10% paywall views, roughly 3% of the audience exposed; treat this as its study observation, not a ranking threshold.
- Advanced publishers can vary allowances for highly engaged users while preserving more access for others.
- Mark paywalled content with suitable structured data so Google can distinguish it from cloaking. If content must not reach the browser, choose an implementation that does not deliver it merely to hide it client-side.

Complete source section checklist: Metering · How much content? · Lead-in · Making Changes · How to indicate paywalled content

QUESTION 401 · D56

Priority practice

What is the difference between metering and lead-in?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

Metering offers a quota of full articles before login/subscription is required; lead-in offers only the beginning or another portion of an article.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“There are two types of sampling we advise: metering , which provides users with a quota of articles to consume before requiring users to subscribe or log in, after which paywalls will start appearing; and lead-in , which offers a portion of an article's content without it being shown in full.”

D56 · Flexible Sampling general guidance · Flexible Sampling general guidance

QUESTION 402 · D56 Priority practice

Is ten free articles per month mandatory for SEO?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

No. The page suggests ten as a starting experiment for many news publishers and gives publishers discretion. It explicitly says there is no universally optimal sampling number.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“There is no single value for optimal sampling across different businesses. However, for most daily news publishers, we expect the value to fall between 6 and 10 articles per user per month. We think most publishers will find a number in that range that preserves a good user experience for new potential subscribers while driving conversion opportunities among the most engaged users.”

D56 · Flexible Sampling general guidance · How much content?

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“As a starting point for your explorations, we encourage you to provide 10 articles per month to Google search users and iterate from there. We leave the exact number to the discretion of individual publishers, who are best positioned to understand the particular demands of their businesses. We encourage publishers to analyze the current percentage of search users who land on their paywalls, and select a monthly number that achieves a similar result. You can always lower the value later, after you have some confidence that you are on a stable footing.”

D56 · Flexible Sampling general guidance · How much content?

QUESTION 403 · D56

Why does the guide favor monthly metering?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

It provides more flexibility, focuses barriers on engaged users most likely to subscribe, and gives less-engaged visitors time to learn the value of the content.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE · EXACT EXCERPT

“In general, we think that monthly, rather than daily metering provides more flexibility and a safer environment for testing. The user impact of changing from one integer value to the next is less significant at, say, 10 monthly samples than at 3 daily samples. Monthly metering”

D56 · Flexible Sampling general guidance · Metering

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE · EXACT EXCERPT

“one integer value to the next is less significant at, say, 10 monthly samples than at 3 daily samples. Monthly metering also has the advantage of focusing paywall views on your most engaged users, who are those most likely to subscribe, while allowing your newer and less engaged users to become acquainted with the value of your content before experiencing a paywall. (“Paywall,” in this context, applies equally”

D56 · Flexible Sampling general guidance · Metering

QUESTION 404 · D56

How does Google distinguish paywalls from cloaking?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

Use the documented paywalled-content structured data. For genuine browser access protection, avoid sending the full restricted content only to hide it afterward.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Enclose paywalled content with structured data in order to help Google differentiate paywalled content from the practice of cloaking, where the content served to Googlebot is different from the content served to users. If you don't want the content to be accessible to the browser at the time of serving, choose a paywall implementation that doesn't supply the paywalled content to the browser.”

D56 · Flexible Sampling general guidance · How to indicate paywalled content

QUESTION 405 · D56

What should you monitor when reducing free sampling?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

Track referral traffic, conversion and the proportion hitting paywalls, and make cautious user-focused experiments. The study's 10% observation is not stated as a Google ranking formula.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Publishers will want to experiment with different sampling values to determine their effect on referral traffic and conversion.”

D56 · Flexible Sampling general guidance · Making Changes

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Bear in mind that our user studies have shown that when users who have experienced only a small amount of content are required to subscribe, their interest in the product diminishes greatly. Our analysis shows that general user satisfaction starts to degrade significantly when paywalls are shown more than 10% of the time (which generally means that about 3% of the audience has been exposed to the paywall). We recommend caution in approaching that limit, because you may start to alienate users who have not yet become convinced of the value of your content.”

D56 · Flexible Sampling general guidance · Making Changes

QUESTION 406 · D56 Additional practice

Is a free registration wall treated as a paywall in this sampling guide?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

Yes. The guide uses paywall for barriers requiring either a subscription or registration. Evaluate the effect on readers and sampling rather than assuming a free signup barrier is outside the guidance.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE · EXACT EXCERPT

“acquainted with the value of your content before experiencing a paywall. (“Paywall,” in this context, applies equally to barriers that require either subscription or merely registration for content access.)”

D56 · Flexible Sampling general guidance · Metering

QUESTION 407 · D56 Additional practice

How would you design a sampling experiment that protects new readers while targeting likely subscribers?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

The guide suggests identifying engaged users who regularly exhaust the monthly allowance, then testing lower sampling for that segment while allowing more liberal access for others. Monitor referral traffic, conversion and satisfaction; this is an experiment, not a guaranteed revenue improvement.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Publishers with more advanced technical resources may want to focus their efforts more narrowly on those specific users in the engaged segment. By identifying users who consistently use up the monthly allotment, publishers could then target them by reducing the sample allowance for that audience specifically, and, by allowing more liberal consumption for other users, reduce the risk that overall user behavior and satisfaction is degraded.”

D56 · Flexible Sampling general guidance · Making Changes

Discover and your website

Google last updated: 2026-03-09 · Reviewed 6 October 2026

<https://developers.google.com/search/docs/appearance/google-discover>

Detailed points to revise

- Discover recommends content by interests and Web/App Activity rather than requiring a keyword query. Indexed policy-compliant content is automatically eligible, with no special markup and no display guarantee.
- Older content can appear if relevant and useful. Violations may generate Discover manual actions in Search Console.
- Helpful people-first content, accurate non-clickbait headlines, timely stories or unique insights and good page experience are recommended.
- Large images: at least 1,200 px wide, more than 300,000 total pixels, recommended 16:9 aspect ratio, and max-image-preview:large or AMP. Crop thoughtfully rather than distort or lose essential detail.
- Use relevant representative schema.org images or og:image to influence the thumbnail; avoid generic logos and text-heavy imagery.
- Interest feeds may not recommend forms, petitions, job applications, code repositories or satire without context; Discover also filters shocking/unexpected content beyond SafeSearch.
- Treat Discover visits as supplemental and volatile. Interest changes, content mix and Search updates can affect traffic without proving a publishing-quality problem.
- The Discover performance report covers clicks, impressions and CTR for up to 16 months when the impression threshold is met, including Chrome Discover surfaces.

Complete source section checklist: How content appears in Discover · Why Discover traffic might change over time · Monitor your performance on Discover

QUESTION 408 · D57

Priority practice

Does Discover require special structured data or only new articles?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

No special tags or markup are required. Indexed policy-compliant content can be eligible, and older content can appear when helpful and relevant; eligibility does not guarantee display.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Content is automatically eligible to appear in Discover if it is indexed by Google and meets Discover's content policies . No special tags or structured data are required. Note that being eligible to appear in Discover is not a guarantee of appearing.”

D57 · Discover and your website · How content appears in Discover

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Content that may appear in Discover includes a wide range of topics that aligns with a person's interests. Older content may appear if it's helpful and relevant to individuals based on their interests.”

D57 · Discover and your website · How content appears in Discover

QUESTION 409 · D57 Priority practice

What image specifications does the current Discover guide recommend?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

At least 1,200 px wide, over 300,000 total pixels and 16:9, enabled for large previews with max-image-preview:large or AMP. Preserve important content when cropping.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE · EXACT EXCERPT

“especially large images that are more likely to generate visits from Discover. We recommend using images that meet the following specifications: At least 1200 px wide High resolution of more than 300,000 total pixels (for example, a 16:9 image that's 1280x720 pixels would have 921,600 total pixels and satisfies this specification) 16x9 aspect ratio Google tries to automatically crop”

D57 · Discover and your website · How content appears in Discover

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE · EXACT EXCERPT

“likely to generate visits from Discover. We recommend using images that meet the following specifications: At least 1200 px wide High resolution of more than 300,000 total pixels (for example, a 16:9 image that's 1280x720 pixels would have 921,600 total pixels and satisfies this specification) 16x9 aspect ratio Google tries to automatically crop the image for use in Discover. If you choose to”

D57 · Discover and your website · How content appears in Discover

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE · EXACT EXCERPT

“into 16x9 aspect ratio, be sure the important details are included in the cropped version that you specify in the og:image meta tag). Enabled by the max-image-preview:large setting , or by using AMP”

D57 · Discover and your website · How content appears in Discover

QUESTION 410 · D57

Does og:image guarantee the Discover thumbnail?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

No. It can influence selection. Use a relevant large representative image and avoid generic logos or text-heavy images.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Use either schema.org markup or the og:image meta tag to specify a large image that's relevant and representative of the web page, as this can influence which image is chosen as the thumbnail in Discover. Learn more about how to specify your preferred image . Avoid using generic images (for example, your site logo) in the schema.org markup or og:image meta tag. For best results, avoid using text-heavy images in the schema.org markup or og:image meta tag.”

D57 · Discover and your website · How content appears in Discover

QUESTION 411 · D57

Why can Discover traffic fall without a clear content-quality problem?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

Personal interests, recommended content types and Search system changes can shift its traffic. The guide calls it less predictable than query-driven Search and supplemental to that traffic.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Traffic from Discover is less predictable or dependable when compared to keyword-driven search visits. Given its serendipitous nature, you should consider traffic from Discover as supplemental to your keyword-driven search traffic. Here are some reasons why Discover traffic may fluctuate:”

D57 · Discover and your website · Why Discover traffic might change over time

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE · EXACT EXCERPT

“nothing you need to do after an update. Our ongoing work to improve Discover's user experience means sites may see changes in their traffic that are unrelated to the quality or publishing frequency of their content.”

D57 · Discover and your website · Why Discover traffic might change over time

QUESTION 412 · D57

How do you measure Discover performance?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

Use its Performance report for impressions, clicks and CTR for up to 16 months, subject to the impression threshold. The guide says Chrome Discover traffic is included.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“If you have content on Discover, you can monitor your performance using the Performance report for Discover . This report shows impressions, clicks, and CTR for any of your content that has appeared on Discover in the last 16 months, as long as your data reaches a minimum threshold of impressions. The Discover performance report includes traffic from Chrome , and fully tracks a site's Discover traffic across all surfaces where users interact with Discover.”

D57 · Discover and your website · Monitor your performance on Discover

QUESTION 413 · D57

Can Discover policy violations produce manual actions?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

Yes. The guide points to Discover manual actions in Search Console's Security and Manual actions area.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“If your site violates one or more Discover content policies, Discover manual actions may appear in your Search Console under Security and Manual actions. Learn more about the”

D57 · Discover and your website · How content appears in Discover

QUESTION 414 · D57 Additional practice

Would withholding the main fact in a headline to force a click follow Discover guidance?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

No. Google advises against misleading or exaggerated previews and withholding crucial information needed to understand the content. Use a headline that captures the content's essence rather than manipulating curiosity or outrage.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Avoid clickbait and similar tactics to artificially inflate engagement by using misleading or exaggerated details in preview content (title, snippets, or images) to increase appeal, or by withholding crucial information required to understand what the content is about.”

D57 · Discover and your website · How content appears in Discover

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Use page titles and headlines that capture the essence of the content.”

D57 · Discover and your website · How content appears in Discover

QUESTION 415 · D57 Additional practice

Should every indexed job application or petition be expected to appear in Discover?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

No. Eligibility does not guarantee appearance, and Discover filters for an interest-based feed. The guide specifically says job applications, petitions, forms and code repositories might not be recommended.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“To deliver a good user experience, Discover seeks to present content that's suitable for interest-based feeds, such as articles and videos, as well as filter out content that's not wanted or that might confuse readers. For example, Discover might not recommend job applications, petitions, forms, code repositories, or satirical content without any context. Discover makes use of SafeSearch but beyond that filters out content that might be seen as shocking or unexpected.”

D57 · Discover and your website · How content appears in Discover

QUESTION 416 · D57 Additional practice

A vertical hero image is automatically cropped to 16:9 and loses the subject. What would you change?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

Create a deliberate landscape crop retaining the important details, then specify that appropriate image through metadata. The guide warns against applying an aspect ratio automatically without considering the resulting composition.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE · EXACT EXCERPT

“positioned for landscape usage, and avoid automatically applying an aspect ratio. For example, if you crop a vertical image into 16x9 aspect ratio, be sure the important details are included in the cropped version that you specify in the og:image meta tag). Enabled by the max-image-preview:large setting , or by using AMP”

D57 · Discover and your website · How content appears in Discover

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE · EXACT EXCERPT

“image for use in Discover. If you choose to crop your images yourself, be sure your images are well-cropped and positioned for landscape usage, and avoid automatically applying an aspect ratio. For example, if you crop a vertical image into 16x9 aspect ratio, be sure the important details are included in the cropped version that you specify in the og:image meta tag). Enabled by the max-image-preview:large”

D57 · Discover and your website · How content appears in Discover

Google image SEO best practices

Google last updated: 2026-03-02 · Reviewed 6 October 2026

<https://developers.google.com/search/docs/appearance/google-images>

Detailed points to revise

- Images can surface in text results, Discover and Google Images; follow crawl/index eligibility as well as image-specific implementation requirements.
- Use `img src` for discoverability, including inside `picture`. Google does not index CSS background images. Responsive `srcset/picture` implementations need an `img src` fallback.
- Image sitemaps can list images on other domains; verify a CDN host in Search Console where possible and diagnose image access separately from page access.
- Supported image formats: BMP, GIF, JPEG, PNG, WebP, SVG and AVIF. Match extensions to type. Base64 data URLs are possible but can significantly enlarge HTML.
- Balance sharp high-quality images with optimized size and responsive delivery; use PageSpeed Insights and appropriate performance techniques.
- Preferred previews can be influenced through `primaryImageOfPage`, image attached to the main entity, or `og:image`. Choice is automated, not guaranteed; use representative high-resolution non-logo images without extreme ratios or excessive text.
- Landing-page titles, descriptions, captions, nearby relevant text and structured data help Google understand an image and its Search presentation. Follow each supported feature's image and markup requirements.
- Filenames provide light clues: concise descriptive names beat generic camera IDs. Translate localized filenames with suitable URL encoding.
- Helpful descriptive alt text supports accessibility and Google's understanding; avoid keyword stuffing. Image-link alt text can act as anchor text. Inline SVG accessibility can use a `title` element.
- Reuse a consistent URL for an image across pages to permit caching and avoid unnecessary crawling.
- To opt out of full-size Images inline linking, inspect the referrer and respond to Google-domain requests as documented with 200 or 204 and no content. Google can still show a crawl-time thumbnail; the guide says this is not image cloaking.
- Full index exclusion is a different control. Label explicit content appropriately for SafeSearch, which can show, blur or block explicit results according to user settings.

Complete source section checklist: Help us discover and index your images · Use HTML image elements to embed images · Use an image sitemap · Responsive images · Use supported image formats · Optimize for speed and quality · Optimize the image landing pages · Specify a preferred image with metadata · Check your page title and description · Add structured data · Use descriptive filenames, titles, and alt text · Opt out of Google Images inline linking · Optimize for SafeSearch

QUESTION 417 · D58

Priority practice

Can Google Images index a CSS background image?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

The guide says no. Use a standard `img` element with a discoverable `src` for images intended for indexing, including when using `picture`.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Using standard HTML image elements helps crawlers find and process images. Google can find images in `src` attribute of `<img>` element (even when it's a child of other elements, such as the `<picture>` element). Google doesn't index CSS images.”

D58 · Google image SEO best practices · Use HTML image elements to embed images

QUESTION 418 · D58

Priority practice

Does responsive `srcset` replace the need for `img src`?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

No. Google recommends an `img src` fallback because some clients do not understand `srcset` or `picture`.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Web pages use the `<picture>` element or the `srcset` attribute of an `img` element to specify responsive images. However, some browsers and crawlers don't understand these attributes. We recommend that you always specify a fallback URL using the `src` attribute.”

D58 · Google image SEO best practices · Responsive images

QUESTION 419 · D58

What does image alt text do for SEO?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

It supplies contextual descriptive information used with computer vision and page content, and supports accessibility. For linked images it can also serve as anchor text; avoid keyword stuffing.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Google uses alt text along with computer vision algorithms and the contents of the page to understand the subject matter of the image. Also, alt text in images is useful as anchor text if you decide to use an image as a link.”

D58 · Google image SEO best practices · Use descriptive filenames, titles, and alt text

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“When writing alt text, focus on creating useful, information-rich content that uses keywords appropriately and is in context of the content of the page. Avoid filling alt attributes with keywords (also known as keyword stuffing) as it results in a negative user experience and may cause your site to be seen as spam.”

D58 · Google image SEO best practices · Use descriptive filenames, titles, and alt text

QUESTION 420 · D58

How can you influence the preferred Search image?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

Use relevant representative primaryImageOfPage, an image on the main entity, or og:image. Selection is automated, so these are inputs rather than a display guarantee.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Google's selection of an image preview is completely automated and takes into account a number of different sources to select which image on a given page is shown on Google (for example, a text result image or the preview image in Discover).”

D58 · Google image SEO best practices · Specify a preferred image with metadata

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Specify the schema.org primaryImageOfPage property with a URL or ImageObject . < script type = "application/ld+json" > { "@context" : "https://schema.org", "@type" : "WebPage", "url" : "https://example.com/url", "primaryImageOfPage" : "https://example.com/images/cat.png" } < / script > Or specify an image URL or ImageObject property and attach it to the main entity (using the schema.org mainEntity or mainEntityOfPage properties): < script type = "application/ld+json" > { "@context" : "https://schema.org", "@type" : "BlogPosting", "mainEntityOfPage" : "https://example.com/url", "image" : "https://example.com/images/cat.png" } < / script >”

D58 · Google image SEO best practices · Specify a preferred image with metadata

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Specify the og:image meta tag. <meta property="og:image" content="https://example.com/images/cat.png">”

D58 · Google image SEO best practices · Specify a preferred image with metadata

QUESTION 421 · D58

Can an image sitemap contain CDN URLs on another domain?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

Yes. Image sitemaps differ from ordinary ones in permitting other-domain image locations. The guide encourages verifying the CDN domain to receive crawl-error information.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Unlike regular sitemaps, you can include URLs from other domains in the <image:loc> elements of the image sitemaps. This lets you use CDNs (content delivery networks) to host images. If you're using a CDN, we encourage you to verify ownership of the CDN's domain name in Search Console so that we can inform you of any crawl errors that we may find.”

D58 · Google image SEO best practices · Use an image sitemap

QUESTION 422 · D58

Do descriptive filenames provide a powerful independent ranking boost?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

The page describes filenames as very light clues. Use concise meaningful names, relevant page context and good alt text rather than promise a specific ranking improvement.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Likewise, the filename can give Google very light clues about the subject matter of the image. When possible, use filenames that are short, but descriptive. For example, my-new-black-kitten.jpg is better than IMG00023.JPG . Avoid using generic filenames like image1.jpg , pic.gif , 1.jpg when possible. If your site has thousands of images, you might want to consider automating the naming of the images. If you localize your images, remember to also translate the filenames, keeping in mind the URL encoding guidelines if you're using non-latin or special characters.”

D58 · Google image SEO best practices · Use descriptive filenames, titles, and alt text

QUESTION 423 · D58

Should the same image use a new URL on every page?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

Prefer a consistent URL across references so Google can cache and reuse it without repeated fetching.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“If an image is referenced on multiple pages within a larger website, consider the site's overall crawl budget . In particular, consistently reference the image with the same URL, so that Google can cache and reuse the image without needing to request it multiple times.”

D58 · Google image SEO best practices · Use descriptive filenames, titles, and alt text

QUESTION 424 · D58

Is disabling full-size Google Images inline linking the same as removing the image from Search?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

No. The documented opt-out can leave a crawl-time thumbnail visible. Entire Search exclusion requires a separate removal/blocking approach.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Google will still crawl your page and see the image, but will display a thumbnail image generated at crawl time in search results. This opt-out is possible at any time, and doesn't require re-processing of a website's images. This behavior isn't considered image cloaking and won't result in manual actions.”

D58 · [Google image SEO best practices](#) · [Opt out of Google Images inline linking](#)

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Alternatively, you can prevent the image from appearing in search results entirely.”

D58 · [Google image SEO best practices](#) · [Opt out of Google Images inline linking](#)

QUESTION 425 · D58 Additional practice

Are Base64 data-URI images allowed, and what is the tradeoff?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

Yes, the image guide permits data URIs in img src. They can reduce HTTP requests but considerably increase page size, so assess performance rather than embedding every image automatically. This permission is specific to images; the video guide rejects data URIs.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“You can also inline images as Data URIs. Data URIs provide a way to include a file, such as an image, inline by setting the src attribute of an img element as a Base64-encoded string using the following format:”

D58 · [Google image SEO best practices](#) · [Use supported image formats](#)

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“While inlining images can reduce HTTP requests, carefully judge when to use them since it can considerably increase the size of the page. For more on this, refer to the section on the advantage and disadvantages of inlining images on our web.dev page .”

D58 · [Google image SEO best practices](#) · [Use supported image formats](#)

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Data URLs aren't supported.”

D90 · Video SEO best practices · Use a supported video file type

QUESTION 426 · D58 Additional practice

What SEO role does alt text have when an image is the only content of a link?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

The image guide says alt text is useful as anchor text when the image is a link. Write an informative description in context, and preserve accessibility rather than substituting a list of repeated keywords.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Google uses alt text along with computer vision algorithms and the contents of the page to understand the subject matter of the image. Also, alt text in images is useful as anchor text if you decide to use an image as a link.”

D58 · Google image SEO best practices · Use descriptive filenames, titles, and alt text

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“When writing alt text, focus on creating useful, information-rich content that uses keywords appropriately and is in context of the content of the page. Avoid filling alt attributes with keywords (also known as keyword stuffing) as it results in a negative user experience and may cause your site to be seen as spam.”

D58 · Google image SEO best practices · Use descriptive filenames, titles, and alt text

QUESTION 427 · D58 Additional practice

How should an inline SVG communicate its accessible description?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

The guide distinguishes an img element's alt attribute from an inline svg element, for which a title element can be used. Test accessibility as well as visual rendering.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Also consider the accessibility of your alt text, per W3 guidelines . For the element, you can add the alt attribute of the element, while for inline <svg> elements, you can use the <title> element. For example:”

D58 · Google image SEO best practices · Use descriptive filenames, titles, and alt text

A high-quality image appears on a page with unrelated text. What would you investigate?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

The embedding page's content and metadata influence image visibility and relevance. Place images near relevant text, keep the landing page relevant to the subject, and check its title and description as well as the image itself.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Google extracts information about the subject matter of the image from the content of the page, including captions and image titles. Wherever possible, make sure images are placed near relevant text and on pages that are relevant to the image subject matter.”

D58 · Google image SEO best practices · Use descriptive filenames, titles, and alt text

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“While not immediately obvious, the content and metadata of the pages where an image is embedded can have a great influence on how and where the image may appear in Google's search results.”

D58 · Google image SEO best practices · Optimize the image landing pages

Establish your business details with Google

Google last updated: 2025-12-10 · Reviewed 6 October 2026

<https://developers.google.com/search/docs/appearance/establish-business-details>

Detailed points to revise

- Establish an official business presence through verified Business Profile and Search Console ownership; these verify different assets and serve different purposes.
- Business Profile supports address, contact details, business type and photos in Maps and related business displays.
- A verified official representative can request edits to a knowledge panel, while algorithms also collect public-web entity information.
- Organization markup can identify the preferred logo; Breadcrumb markup clarifies site hierarchy. Structured data does not replace verification or guarantee a panel.
- Make accurate customer-support contact routes available; the page links its dedicated best-practices guide.
- Troubleshoot by testing markup, allowing roughly a week for processing after crawling, and suggesting corrections through the knowledge-panel feedback/edit routes.

Complete source section checklist: Claim your local business · Register your website with Search Console · Update your site's Google knowledge panel · Add structured data · Highlight your customer support methods · Troubleshooting

QUESTION 429 · D59 **Priority practice**

How do Business Profile and Search Console help establish a business?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

Claim and verify the local Business Profile to manage Maps/Search business details, and verify website ownership in Search Console to monitor its Search presence. They are distinct verification processes.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Manage how your business appears on Google Maps and Google Search by claiming your Business Profile . Once you verify yourself as the owner of a listing, you can provide or edit your address, contact info, business type, and photos. This enables your local business information to show up in Google Maps and Google knowledge panel.”

D59 · Establish your business details with Google · Claim your local business

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“The first step in establishing your website as an official presence is to verify website ownership in Search Console . This process verifies the owners and operators of the site. Once you've verified your website, you can use Search Console to understand and monitor how Google displays information about your site.”

D59 · Establish your business details with Google · Register your website with Search Console

QUESTION 430 · D59 Priority practice

Which markup can help identify an organization's logo and site hierarchy?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

Organization structured data can nominate a preferred logo; Breadcrumb structured data can describe hierarchy. Markup supports understanding and eligibility rather than guaranteeing a specific display.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE · EXACT EXCERPT

“You can specify which image that you want Google to use for your organization's logo in Search results and your Google knowledge panel. To do this, add Organization structured data to your official website that identifies the location of your preferred logo . Breadcrumbs : Breadcrumb trails on a page indicate the page's position in the site hierarchy. A user can navigate all the way up in the”

D59 · Establish your business details with Google · Update your site's Google knowledge panel

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE · EXACT EXCERPT

“hierarchy, one level at a time, by starting from the last breadcrumb in the breadcrumb trail. To help Google understand your breadcrumbs, you can add Breadcrumb structured data to your site. Highlight your customer support methods Customers are often looking for ways to contact businesses, and Google works to show the best available information to help them in a variety of ways . You can”

D59 · Establish your business details with Google · Update your site's Google knowledge panel

QUESTION 431 · D59

How can a business correct an inaccurate knowledge panel?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

Use the official representative/feedback edit routes, test relevant markup, and allow processing time. The guide suggests checking after at least a week since the marked-up page was crawled.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE · EXACT EXCERPT

“available on the web. You can update or provide more information for your site for broader reach and recognition in Search results. If you're verified as an official representative, you can update your Google knowledge panel to override the information Google finds automatically. Add structured data Google Search works hard to understand the content of a page. You can help us by providing”

D59 · Establish your business details with Google · Update your site's Google knowledge panel

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE · EXACT EXCERPT

“with your site's information, try the following troubleshooting tips: Make suggested changes to your Google knowledge panel. If you have waited at least one week since your marked-up page was last crawled by Google, report information that you believe is incorrect in a Google knowledge panel, by clicking the Feedback link at the bottom of the Google knowledge panel. If you are a recognized authority or the site or”

D59 · Establish your business details with Google · Update your site's Google knowledge panel

QUESTION 432 · D59 Additional practice

How can a verified local business owner improve Google's address and contact details?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

Claim and verify the Business Profile, then provide or edit address, contact information, business type and photos. Search Console ownership serves a separate website-monitoring purpose.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Manage how your business appears on Google Maps and Google Search by claiming your Business Profile . Once you verify yourself as the owner of a listing, you can provide or edit your address, contact info, business type, and photos. This enables your local business information to show up in Google Maps and Google knowledge panel.”

D59 · Establish your business details with Google · Claim your local business

QUESTION 433 · D59 Additional practice

What timing does this guide suggest before reporting incorrect knowledge-panel information after markup was crawled?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

It suggests waiting at least one week after Google last crawled the marked-up page, then using the knowledge panel's Feedback route. Also test the markup and use the appropriate verified-representative editing options.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE · EXACT EXCERPT

“issues with your site’s information, try the following troubleshooting tips: Make suggested changes to your Google knowledge panel. If you have waited at least one week since your marked-up page was last crawled by Google, report information that you believe is incorrect in a Google knowledge panel, by clicking the Feedback link at the bottom of the Google knowledge panel. If you are a recognized authority or the site or”

D59 · Establish your business details with Google · Update your site's Google knowledge panel

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE · EXACT EXCERPT

“since your marked-up page was last crawled by Google, report information that you believe is incorrect in a Google knowledge panel, by clicking the Feedback link at the bottom of the Google knowledge panel. If you are a recognized authority or the site or entity represented in the Google knowledge panel, you can view more options for providing specific edits. Learn more about”

D59 · Establish your business details with Google · Update your site's Google knowledge panel

Top Places List

Google last updated: 2025-12-10 · Reviewed 6 October 2026

<https://developers.google.com/search/docs/appearance/top-places-list>

Detailed points to revise

- Top Places List can show independent lists that mention a business with a physical location, such as restaurant recommendation lists.
- A listing must be editorially curated, genuine, independent and unsponsored.
- Automated data/metric templates and vulgar or offensive language fail the stated listing requirements.
- Search appearance is illustrative, not guaranteed. Publishers can opt their lists out using the linked local/property opt-out mechanism.

Complete source section checklist: Requirements for the listing site · Prevent your website's lists from appearing in a Top Places List feature

QUESTION 434 · D60

What qualifies a list for Top Places List?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

A genuine independent unsponsored list curated by its publisher, avoiding automated templated sentences and offensive language. The feature concerns businesses with physical locations.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“If your business is mentioned in any "top places" lists online, Google might show a rich result that shows the lists that mention your business. For example, if your restaurant appears in a "Top 10 Chinese restaurants in NYC" list and a "Best restaurants in the city" list on qualified websites, these lists would be shown in your business's search result. This feature is only for businesses with a physical location.”

D60 · Top Places List · Top Places List

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“The list must be curated by the content provider, be genuine, independent, and not sponsored.”

D60 · Top Places List · Requirements for the listing site

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“The list must not consist of templated sentences built from data or automated metrics.”

D60 · Top Places List · Requirements for the listing site

QUESTION 435 · D60

How can a publisher stop its lists appearing in Top Places List?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

Use the documented opt-out for local search results and other Google properties. This is different from making the entire website noindex.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“To prevent lists from your site from appearing in a Top Places List, opt out of display in local search results and other Google properties .”

D60 · Top Places List · Prevent your website's lists from appearing in a Top Places List feature

QUESTION 436 · D60 Additional practice

Could an online-only business use Top Places List simply because it appears in a best-businesses article?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

This guide restricts the feature to businesses with a physical location. Mention in an article does not override that condition; the publisher's list must also meet the independent, genuine, nonsponsored criteria.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“If your business is mentioned in any "top places" lists online, Google might show a rich result that shows the lists that mention your business. For example, if your restaurant appears in a "Top 10 Chinese restaurants in NYC" list and a "Best restaurants in the city" list on qualified websites , these lists would be shown in your business's search result. This feature is only for businesses with a physical location.”

D60 · Top Places List · Top Places List

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“The list must be curated by the content provider, be genuine, independent, and not sponsored.”

D60 · Top Places List · Requirements for the listing site

Opt out of display on local search results and other Google properties

Google last updated: not stated · Reviewed 6 October 2026

<https://support.google.com/webmasters/answer/3035947>

Detailed points to revise

- Applies to Googlebot-fetched material in Shopping, Flights, Hotels/vacation rentals and specialized local results.
- Existing displays are removed within 30 days.
- Set it for a whole domain, including subdomains; other domains need separate settings. Individual paths or subdomains cannot be selected.
- Local suppression is worldwide; the other listed properties are covered on google.com.
- Manage the setting in Search Console. This is a property-specific display control.

QUESTION 437 · D61 **Priority practice**

What scope does the local/property opt-out use?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

Whole-domain scope, including subdomains. Configure other domains separately; individual paths or subdomains are not selectable.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE · EXACT EXCERPT

“applies on a domain name basis”

D61 · Opt out of display on local search results and other Google properties · Opt out of display on local search results and other Google properties

QUESTION 438 · D61 **Priority practice**

When and where does this opt-out apply?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

Existing displays are removed within 30 days. Local results are covered worldwide; the other listed properties apply on google.com.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE · EXACT EXCERPT

“removed within 30 days”

D61 · Opt out of display on local search results and other Google properties · Opt out of display on local search results and other Google properties

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE · EXACT EXCERPT

“applies globally”

D61 · Opt out of display on local search results and other Google properties · Opt out of display on local search results and other Google properties

Understanding page experience in Google Search results

Google last updated: 2026-09-22 · Reviewed 6 October 2026

<https://developers.google.com/search/docs/appearance/page-experience>

Detailed points to revise

- Assess page experience holistically: Core Web Vitals, secure delivery, mobile display, ad interference, intrusive overlays and clear distinction between main and secondary content.
- The current September 2026 FAQ says there is no single page-experience signal; core ranking uses a variety of signals.
- It explicitly says Core Web Vitals are used by ranking systems, while other page-experience aspects do not directly make a site rank higher. Those improvements still help users and align with desired experience.
- A perfect score in a report or third-party tool is not a ranking guarantee or necessarily the best SEO use of time.
- Evaluation is generally per page, with some site-wide assessments. Relevant content may rank despite poor experience; good experience can help when many useful answers compete.
- Resources include the CWV report/guides, secure-connection checks, interstitial guidance, Lighthouse and experimental CrUX ad-count/density/weight metrics. The article still mentions an HTTPS report; use current Search Console availability rather than assuming every historic report persists.

Complete source section checklist: Self-assess your content's page experience · Page experience resources · FAQ · Is there a single "page experience signal" that Google Search uses for ranking? · What aspects of page experience are used in ranking? · Is page experience evaluated on a site-wide or page-specific basis? · How important is page experience to ranking success? · Recent updates on our blog

QUESTION 439 · D62 **Priority practice**

Is page experience a single Google ranking signal?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

No. The current FAQ says core ranking systems use a variety of signals aligned with overall experience; there is no single page-experience signal.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“There is no single signal. Our core ranking systems look at a variety of signals that align with overall page experience.”

D62 · Understanding page experience in Google Search results · Is there a single “page experience signal” that Google Search uses for ranking?

QUESTION 440 · D62 Priority practice

Do all page-experience improvements directly raise rankings?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

The current article says Core Web Vitals are used in ranking and other page-experience aspects do not directly make a site rank higher. Improve the broader experience for users without promising a ranking increment for each item.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE · EXACT EXCERPT

“Core Web Vitals are used by our ranking systems. We recommend site owners achieve good Core Web Vitals for success with Search and to ensure a great user experience generally. Keep in mind that getting good results in reports like Search Console’s Core Web Vitals”

D62 · Understanding page experience in Google Search results · What aspects of page experience are used in ranking?

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Beyond Core Web Vitals, other page experience aspects don’t directly help your website rank higher in search results. However, they can make your website more satisfying to use, which is generally aligned with what our ranking systems seek to reward. Therefore it’s still worth working to improve page experience overall.”

D62 · Understanding page experience in Google Search results · What aspects of page experience are used in ranking?

QUESTION 441 · D62

Does a perfect Core Web Vitals or Lighthouse score guarantee top rankings?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

No. The guide explicitly warns that good scores do not guarantee the top of Search and a perfect score pursued only for SEO may not be the best use of time.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE · EXACT EXCERPT

“great user experience generally. Keep in mind that getting good results in reports like Search Console's Core Web Vitals report or third-party tools doesn't guarantee that your pages will rank at the top of Google Search results; there's more to great page experience than Core Web Vitals scores alone. These scores are meant to help you to improve your site for your users overall, and trying to get a perfect score just”

D62 · Understanding page experience in Google Search results · What aspects of page experience are used in ranking?

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE · EXACT EXCERPT

“experience than Core Web Vitals scores alone. These scores are meant to help you to improve your site for your users overall, and trying to get a perfect score just for SEO reasons may not be the best use of your time.”

D62 · Understanding page experience in Google Search results · What aspects of page experience are used in ranking?

QUESTION 442 · D62

Is page experience evaluated only at domain level?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

No. Core systems generally assess content and experience per page, although some site-wide assessments exist.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Our core ranking systems generally evaluate content on a page-specific basis, including when understanding aspects related to page experience. However, we do have some site-wide assessments.”

D62 · Understanding page experience in Google Search results · Is page experience evaluated on a site-wide or page-specific basis?

QUESTION 443 · D62

Can a relevant page with poor experience still rank?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

Yes. Google says it seeks the most relevant content even with sub-par experience, while good experience can contribute when multiple useful results are available.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Google Search always seeks to show the most relevant content, even if the page experience is sub-par. But for many queries, there is lots of helpful content available. Having a great page experience can contribute to success in Search, in such cases.”

D62 · Understanding page experience in Google Search results · How important is page experience to ranking success?

Which experience issues would you audit beyond the three CWV numbers?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

Check secure delivery, mobile display, distracting ads, intrusive interstitials and whether the main content is easy to distinguish. The checklist is broader than CWV and is not exhaustive; do not equate every item with a separate direct ranking boost.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Are your pages served in a secure fashion?”

D62 · Understanding page experience in Google Search results · Self-assess your content's page experience

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Is your page designed so visitors can easily distinguish the main content from other content on your page?”

D62 · Understanding page experience in Google Search results · Self-assess your content's page experience

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“These questions don't encompass all page experience aspects to consider. However, questions like these, and consulting the following resources, may help you align with providing an overall good page experience.”

D62 · Understanding page experience in Google Search results · Self-assess your content's page experience

Which cited resource helps assess real users' ad experience?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

The page links experimental CrUX ad metrics for ad count, density and weight. These provide insight into real users' ad experience; the guide does not label each of them a separate Search ranking signal.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“CrUX ad metrics : These experimental CrUX metrics from Chrome can help you understand your site's ad count, ad density, and ad weight metrics. They provide insight into real users' ad experiences on your site, as seen and reported by Chrome.”

D62 · Understanding page experience in Google Search results · Page experience resources

Avoid intrusive interstitials and dialogs

Google last updated: 2025-12-10 · Reviewed 6 October 2026

<https://developers.google.com/search/docs/appearance/avoid-intrusive-interstitials>

Detailed points to revise

- Full-page interstitials and partial-page dialogs can obstruct content, frustrate users and impede search-engine understanding.
- Use small banners for promotional notices, newsletter prompts or app installation instead of blocking the whole screen. Browser-native or standard HTML banners are examples.
- Common maintained CMS libraries can distribute improvements, but their use does not by itself guarantee compliance.
- Avoid covering the whole page or sending visitors to a separate page for consent/input unless legally required.
- Legally mandatory gates are exempt from these general guidelines; where possible overlay the original content rather than redirect all URLs to one gate page.
- Redirecting every incoming URL to a single consent page can leave only that page fetchable and present in Search.
- For mandatory adult age gates, the guide recommends permitting verified Googlebot access without triggering the gate; verify requests rather than trust a spoofable user-agent.

Complete source section checklist: Create unintrusive dialogs · Use banners instead of interstitials · Use common libraries · Avoid common mistakes · Mandatory interstitials

QUESTION 446 · D63 **Priority practice**

How would you implement a newsletter prompt without obstructing SEO content?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

Use a small banner or unintrusive dialog that leaves the main content accessible when users and crawlers land. Avoid a full-page promotional overlay or a separate redirect page.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Instead of full page interstitials, use banners that take up only a small fraction of the screen to grab your users' attention. Banners ensure that users and search engines can get to the content as soon as they land on the page.”

D63 · Avoid intrusive interstitials and dialogs · Use banners instead of interstitials

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Don't obscure the entire page with interstitials.”

D63 · Avoid intrusive interstitials and dialogs · Avoid common mistakes

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Don't redirect the user to a separate page for their consent or input.”

D63 · Avoid intrusive interstitials and dialogs · Avoid common mistakes

QUESTION 447 · D63 Priority practice

Are legally mandatory age/consent interstitials treated like promotional popups?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

No. They are exempt from this guide's general restrictions, but Google still recommends overlaying the content and avoiding redirects that make all URLs resolve to one gate.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Mandatory interstitials are exempted from the guidelines discussed in this document; however, if possible, we recommend that sites follow these best practices:”

D63 · Avoid intrusive interstitials and dialogs · Mandatory interstitials

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Ensure that the content is overlaid with the interstitial. This will ensure that Google can still at least index some of the content and potentially show it in search results.”

D63 · Avoid intrusive interstitials and dialogs · Mandatory interstitials

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Don't redirect the incoming HTTP requests to a different page for collecting consent or providing data. Redirecting all URLs to a single page will remove all but that one page from search results, as Googlebot can only fetch that page.”

D63 · Avoid intrusive interstitials and dialogs · Mandatory interstitials

QUESTION 448 · D63

Why is redirecting every page to one consent URL dangerous?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

Googlebot can fetch only that common destination, and the guide warns other URLs can disappear from Search. Preserve access to the original content wherever the mandatory-gate design permits.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Don't redirect the incoming HTTP requests to a different page for collecting consent or providing data. Redirecting all URLs to a single page will remove all but that one page from search results, as Googlebot can only fetch that page.”

D63 · Avoid intrusive interstitials and dialogs · Mandatory interstitials

QUESTION 449 · D63

What is the documented recommendation for Googlebot behind an adult age gate?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

Allow verified Googlebot to crawl content without triggering the age gate. Verification is part of the recommendation, not simply checking a user-agent string.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“For content behind a mandatory age gate for adult users, we recommend allowing Googlebot to crawl your content without triggering the age gate. You can do this by verifying Googlebot requests and serving the content without age gate.”

D63 · Avoid intrusive interstitials and dialogs · Mandatory interstitials

QUESTION 450 · D63 Additional practice

How does this guide distinguish an interstitial from a dialog?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

An interstitial overlays the whole page; a dialog overlays only part of it. Either can still obstruct content, so assess how quickly users and Google can reach the main content rather than judging the name alone.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Intrusive interstitials and dialogs are page elements that obstruct users' view of the content, usually for promotional purposes. Interstitials are overlays on the whole page and dialogs are overlays only on a part of the page, sometimes also obfuscating the underlying content.”

D63 · Avoid intrusive interstitials and dialogs · Avoid intrusive interstitials and dialogs

Why might a maintained CMS dialog plugin be preferable to an improvised implementation?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

The guide says common libraries can help because developers can deploy improvements at scale. The implementation must still follow the guidance on accessible content; using a plugin is not an automatic exemption.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Many CMSes have plugins that create standard dialogs and interstitials for the most common use cases, such as newsletter sign-up prompts. For example, if you are using WordPress, search for "newsletter signup wordpress". Using such plugins can be helpful for Google, other search engines, and the internet in general, as the plugin developers can deploy improvements at scale.”

D63 · Avoid intrusive interstitials and dialogs · Use common libraries

Understanding Core Web Vitals and Google search results

Google last updated: 2025-12-10 · Reviewed 6 October 2026

<https://developers.google.com/search/docs/appearance/core-web-vitals>

Detailed points to revise

- Core Web Vitals measure real-world loading, responsiveness and visual stability: LCP, INP and CLS respectively.
- The Search page recommends LCP within 2.5 seconds, INP below 200 ms and CLS below 0.1. The linked Web Vitals guide defines good thresholds as $LCP \leq 2.5$ s, $INP \leq 200$ ms and $CLS \leq 0.1$.
- Google's measurement guide evaluates the 75th percentile separately for mobile and desktop; passing requires all three good metrics. This detail comes from the linked supplementary Web Vitals source.
- Use the Search Console CWV report and appropriate measurement/debugging tools. Lab diagnostics and real-user field measurements have different purposes and should not be treated as identical.
- Good metrics support users and Search, but the page-experience FAQ explicitly rejects a guaranteed top ranking or a perfect-score-only SEO strategy.
- Full optimization instructions for each metric are linked resources, not invented prescriptions in this short overview.

Complete source section checklist: Core Web Vitals metrics · Optimizing your Core Web Vitals · Recent updates on our blog

QUESTION 452 · D64

Priority practice

What are the current Core Web Vitals and good thresholds?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

LCP measures loading, with a good threshold at 2.5 seconds or less; INP measures responsiveness at 200 ms or less; CLS measures stability at 0.1 or less. The Search article uses stricter aspirational wording for INP/CLS; the linked Web Vitals source defines the inclusive boundaries.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Largest Contentful Paint (LCP) : Measures loading performance. To provide a good user experience, strive to have LCP occur within the first 2.5 seconds of the page starting to load.”

D64 · Understanding Core Web Vitals and Google search results · Core Web Vitals metrics

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Interaction To Next Paint (INP) : Measures responsiveness. To provide a good user experience, strive to have an INP of less than 200 milliseconds .”

D64 · Understanding Core Web Vitals and Google search results · Core Web Vitals metrics

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Cumulative Layout Shift (CLS) : Measures visual stability. To provide a good user experience, strive to have a CLS score of less than 0.1 .”

D64 · Understanding Core Web Vitals and Google search results · Core Web Vitals metrics

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Interaction to Next Paint (INP) : measures interactivity . To provide a good user experience, pages should have a INP of 200 milliseconds or less.”

S4 · Web Vitals · Core Web Vitals

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Cumulative Layout Shift (CLS) : measures visual stability . To provide a good user experience, pages should maintain a CLS of 0.1. or less.”

S4 · Web Vitals · Core Web Vitals

QUESTION 453 · D64

Priority practice

What percentile should be used to assess CWV compliance?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

The linked Google Web Vitals guidance uses the 75th percentile, segmented by mobile and desktop, and requires all three metrics to meet their targets.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“To ensure you're hitting the recommended target for these metrics for most of your users, a good threshold to measure is the 75th percentile of page loads, segmented across mobile and desktop devices.”

S4 · Web Vitals · Core Web Vitals

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Tools that assess Core Web Vitals compliance should consider a page passing if it meets the recommended targets at the 75th percentile for all three of the Core Web Vitals metrics.”

S4 · Web Vitals · Core Web Vitals

QUESTION 454 · D64

Can a Lighthouse lab run replace real-user CWV monitoring?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

No. Lab tools are useful for diagnosis and regression testing, while CWV represent field user experience. The linked measurement guidance explains that lab measurement does not substitute for field measurement.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Core Web Vitals is a set of metrics that measure real-world user experience for loading performance, interactivity, and visual stability of the page. We highly recommend site owners achieve good Core Web Vitals for success with Search and to ensure a great user experience generally. This, along with other page experience aspects, aligns with what our core ranking systems seek to reward. Learn more in Understanding page experience in Google Search results .”

D64 · Understanding Core Web Vitals and Google search results · Understanding Core Web Vitals and Google search results

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“While lab measurement is an essential part of delivering great experiences, it is not a substitute for field measurement.”

S4 · Web Vitals · Lab tools to measure Core Web Vitals

QUESTION 455 · D64

Does passing CWV guarantee a first-place result?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

No. Google's page-experience FAQ explicitly says good report scores do not guarantee top ranking; relevance and other systems still matter.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE · EXACT EXCERPT

“great user experience generally. Keep in mind that getting good results in reports like Search Console's Core Web Vitals report or third-party tools doesn't guarantee that your pages will rank at the top of Google Search results; there's more to great page experience than Core Web Vitals scores alone. These scores are meant to help you to improve your site for your users overall, and trying to get a perfect score just”

D62 · Understanding page experience in Google Search results · What aspects of page experience are used in ranking?

Does a page pass the Web Vitals assessment if only LCP and CLS meet the recommended targets?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

No. Google's linked Web Vitals reference says assessment tools should consider a pass when all three metrics meet the targets at the 75th percentile. A good result for two metrics does not replace the third.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Tools that assess Core Web Vitals compliance should consider a page passing if it meets the recommended targets at the 75th percentile for all three of the Core Web Vitals metrics.”

S4 · Web Vitals · Core Web Vitals

Should mobile and desktop Web Vitals be pooled into one percentile to hide a slow mobile experience?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

No. The linked reference describes assessing the 75th percentile segmented across mobile and desktop. Check each segment rather than relying only on a blended number that could obscure one group's experience.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“To ensure you're hitting the recommended target for these metrics for most of your users, a good threshold to measure is the 75th percentile of page loads, segmented across mobile and desktop devices.”

S4 · Web Vitals · Core Web Vitals

Help your readers find your site through preferred sources in Google Search

Google last updated: 2026-09-18 · Reviewed 6 October 2026

<https://developers.google.com/search/docs/appearance/preferred-sources>

Detailed points to revise

- Users can select a publication as a preferred source, making its content more likely in Top Stories and enabling a preferred badge. AI Mode/Overviews can also highlight it for users who selected it.
- Current availability is global for Top Stories in Search-supported languages, and for AI features in their supported locales/languages.
- Sites must be included in Search generative AI features in Search Console to qualify for the described displays. Domain/subdomain sites qualify; individual subdirectories do not.
- Check whether the publication appears in the source-preferences tool. Publisher promotion methods help readers opt in but are not mandatory eligibility markup.
- Recommended standard implementation loads Google's publisher.js library and adds a google-add-preferred-source-btn div; Google localizes and styles the button and returns readers to their page.
- Optional data-theme sets light/dark; data-lang overrides the default browser-derived language.
- Advanced SDK integration supports equivalent ES Module and standard script/IIFE capabilities with init and addPreferredSource. For manual script control, use preferred-sources-control=manual and the PREFERRED_SOURCE callback queue.
- Without JavaScript, link to the source-preferences deeplink with the publication domain in q; text/image links can also be promoted in newsletters or social posts.
- Custom or downloaded official badge assets are possible. This is user choice and personalization, not a publisher-controlled general ranking guarantee.

Complete source section checklist: Feature availability · How to help users find your site as a preferred source · Standard JavaScript implementation (recommended) · Set the button theme · Override the button language · Advanced JavaScript implementation with custom design assets · ES Module imports · Standard script callback queues · Deeplink implementation · Example text link · Example clickable image link · Button image assets

What happens when a reader selects a preferred source?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

Its content becomes more likely in that reader's Top Stories with a preferred badge, and can carry a badge in supported AI features. This is tied to the user's selection, not a blanket ranking boost for everyone.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

"If you're a website owner, you can help your audience find your publication as a preferred source in Google Search. When a user selects your site as a preferred source, your content is more likely to appear in "Top Stories", highlighted with a "preferred" badge. In AI Mode and AI Overviews, your content can be highlighted with a "preferred" badge for users who have selected your site as a preferred source."

D65 · Help your readers find your site through preferred sources in Google Search · Help your readers find your site through preferred sources in Google Search

Are preferred sources restricted to one country or English today?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

The current page says global Top Stories availability in all Search languages, with AI support where the AI features are available.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

"The preferred sources feature is available globally for the "Top Stories" feature in all languages where Google Search is available."

D65 · Help your readers find your site through preferred sources in Google Search · Feature availability

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

"Preferred sources can also appear in AI Mode and AI Overviews in all languages and locales where those features are available. To make your site eligible for display as a preferred source in these features, you must make sure your site is included in Search generative AI features in Search Console."

D65 · Help your readers find your site through preferred sources in Google Search · Feature availability

Can a site's /blog subdirectory be selected independently?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

No. The current tool supports domain- and subdomain-level sites, not subdirectories.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Only domain-level and subdomain-level sites are eligible to appear in the source preferences tool . For example, <https://www.example.com/> and <https://code.example.com/> are eligible for preferred sources, but the subdirectory <https://www.example.com/blog> isn't eligible.”

D65 · [Help your readers find your site through preferred sources in Google Search](#) · [Feature availability](#)

QUESTION 461 · D65

Is adding a preferred-source button required for eligibility?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

No. The page calls the promotion methods optional. Check tool eligibility and the current Search generative-AI inclusion requirement; a button helps readers make their selection.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“These methods are examples of how you can build your audience and help people find your site as a preferred source. It's not required to do them in order to appear as a preferred source.”

D65 · [Help your readers find your site through preferred sources in Google Search](#) · [How to help users find your site as a preferred source](#)

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Preferred sources can also appear in AI Mode and AI Overviews in all languages and locales where those features are available. To make your site eligible for display as a preferred source in these features, you must make sure your site is included in Search generative AI features in Search Console .”

D65 · [Help your readers find your site through preferred sources in Google Search](#) · [Feature availability](#)

QUESTION 462 · D65

Which implementation does Google recommend?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

The standard publisher.js script plus a google-add-preferred-source-btn container. It handles styling/localization and supports optional theme and language settings; the exact code is in the reference.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Standard JavaScript implementation (recommended) : Embed an interactive button to your web pages, which lets readers seamlessly add your site as a preferred source and returns them to your page. By adding only two lines to your HTML, this option renders an automatically localized, Google-styled button that supports device and language customization.”

D65 · Help your readers find your site through preferred sources in Google Search · How to help users find your site as a preferred source

QUESTION 463 · D65

How can a CMS without JavaScript promote preferred-source selection?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

Use a deeplink to the source-preferences tool with the publication domain in the q parameter, through a text or image link.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“If you can't use JavaScript on your website, you can alternatively use a deeplink to direct your users to the source preferences tool , where they can add your site as a preferred source and confirm their selection.”

D65 · Help your readers find your site through preferred sources in Google Search · Deeplink implementation

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Use the following URL format and replace example.com with your publication's domain name, which takes users directly to your site in the source preferences tool :”

D65 · Help your readers find your site through preferred sources in Google Search · Deeplink implementation

QUESTION 464 · D65

What changes for a custom SDK integration?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

Use the documented ES Module or IIFE callback approach to initialize options and bind addPreferredSource to your trigger. The manual script attribute prevents automatic badge initialization.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“When integrating the preferred sources library into custom user interfaces, application milestones, or modern framework applications, you can take full programmatic control over runtime settings and flow initiation using our JavaScript SDK. We provide two distinct integration approaches depending on your tooling and architecture: ES Module imports (ESM) and standard script callback queues (IIFE). Both distribution models expose identical capabilities and methods.”

D65 · Help your readers find your site through preferred sources in Google Search · Advanced JavaScript implementation with custom design assets

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“For standard script tag integrations, load the following script in the <head> of your document with the preferred-sources-control="manual" attribute to prevent automatic button rendering:”

D65 · Help your readers find your site through preferred sources in Google Search · Standard script callback queues

QUESTION 465 · D65 Additional practice

A reader selected a site as preferred, but the site is excluded from Search AI features. What prerequisite would you check for an AI preferred badge?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

The preferred-sources guide requires the site to be included in Search generative AI features through Search Console for eligibility in those AI experiences. Reader selection alone does not override that choice or guarantee display.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Preferred sources can also appear in AI Mode and AI Overviews in all languages and locales where those features are available. To make your site eligible for display as a preferred source in these features, you must make sure your site is included in Search generative AI features in Search Console .”

D65 · Help your readers find your site through preferred sources in Google Search · Feature availability

A guide to Google Search ranking systems

Google last updated: 2025-12-10 · Reviewed 6 October 2026

<https://developers.google.com/search/docs/appearance/ranking-systems-guide>

Detailed points to revise

- Ranking is primarily page-level, using many signals and systems. Site-wide classifiers also contribute; strong or weak site-wide signals do not force every page to perform identically.
- BERT helps understand word combinations and intent; neural matching relates query/page concepts; RankBrain relates words to concepts even without exact-term overlap.
- MUM understands and generates language but is not described as a general Search ranking system here; it is used for specified applications such as vaccine information and featured-snippet callouts.
- Crisis systems surface personal-crisis resources and SOS authority information during disasters. Reliable-information systems elevate authoritative sources/journalism and may display uncertainty/content advisories.
- Deduplication reduces similar listings. A page promoted to a featured snippet is not repeated as an ordinary listing later on the first results page.
- Exact-match-domain handling prevents query-matching domain words receiving too much credit. Freshness systems respond to query need, not a universal preference for recently edited pages.
- Link analysis and evolved PageRank remain part of core ranking; local-news systems identify useful local sources.
- Original-content systems help surface original reporting/content over copies or mere citations. Canonical annotations can assist primary-page understanding for duplicated versions.
- Removal-based demotions can arise from substantial legal or personal-information removal patterns. These are documented mechanisms, not a diagnosis that any individual ranking loss proves legal wrongdoing.
- Passage ranking helps understand sections of a page's relevance; the guide does not describe a separately controlled passage index.
- The reviews system seeks insightful expert/enthusiast analysis and original research. Spam detection, including SpamBrain, targets content/behaviors violating spam policies.
- Site diversity generally limits one site's top listings to two, but relevant exceptions exist. Subdomains usually count with the root, with exceptions.
- Historical systems: helpful content became part of core ranking in March 2024; Hummingbird marks a 2013 major improvement; Panda joined core in 2015 and Penguin in 2016. Do not present them all as standalone current updates.

Complete source section checklist: BERT · Crisis information systems · Deduplication systems · Exact match domain system · Freshness systems · Link analysis systems and PageRank · Local news systems · MUM · Neural matching · Original content systems · Removal-based demotion systems · Passage ranking system · RankBrain · Reliable information systems · Reviews system · Site diversity system · Spam detection systems · Retired systems · Helpful content system · Hummingbird · Panda system · Penguin system

Is Google ranking purely page-level or purely site-wide?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

Neither absolute is accurate. The guide says systems work at page level and also use site-wide signals/classifiers; those do not force every page on a site to rank equally.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Our ranking systems are designed to work on the page level, using a variety of signals and systems to understand how to rank individual pages. Site-wide signals and classifiers are also used and contribute to our understanding of pages. Having some good site-wide signals does not mean that all content from a site will always rank highly, just as having some poor site-wide signals does not mean all the content from a site will rank poorly.”

D66 · A guide to Google Search ranking systems · A guide to Google Search ranking systems

How do BERT, neural matching and RankBrain differ in this guide?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

BERT interprets word combinations and intent, neural matching relates query/page concepts, and RankBrain connects words with concepts to find relevance beyond exact wording. Avoid inventing published signal weights.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Bidirectional Encoder Representations from Transformers (BERT) is an AI system Google uses that allows us to understand how combinations of words express different meanings and intent.”

D66 · A guide to Google Search ranking systems · BERT

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Neural matching is an AI system that Google uses to understand representations of concepts in queries and pages and match them to one another.”

D66 · A guide to Google Search ranking systems · Neural matching

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“RankBrain is an AI system that helps us understand how words are related to concepts. It means we can better return relevant content even if it doesn't contain all the exact words used in a search, by understanding the content is related to other words and concepts.”

D66 · A guide to Google Search ranking systems · RankBrain

QUESTION 468 · D66

Is MUM used for general Search ranking?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

This guide says it is not currently used for general ranking; it lists specific applications such as vaccine-related searches and featured-snippet callouts.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Multitask Unified Model (MUM) is an AI system capable of both understanding and generating language. It's not currently used for general ranking in Search but rather for some specific applications such as to improve searches for COVID-19 vaccine information and to improve featured snippet callouts we display .”

D66 · A guide to Google Search ranking systems · MUM

QUESTION 469 · D66

Is PageRank obsolete?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

No. The guide says its operation has evolved and it remains part of core ranking alongside other link-analysis systems.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“We have various systems that understand how pages link to each other as a way to determine what pages are about and which might be most helpful in response to a query. Among these is PageRank, one of our core ranking systems used when Google first launched. Those curious can learn more by reading the original PageRank research paper and patent . How PageRank works has evolved a lot since then, and it continues to be part of our core ranking systems.”

D66 · A guide to Google Search ranking systems · Link analysis systems and PageRank

QUESTION 470 · D66

Does a keyword-exact domain guarantee a strong ranking advantage?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

No. The exact-match-domain system is designed to prevent over-crediting domains chosen to exactly match queries.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Our ranking systems consider the words in domain names as one of many factors to determine if content is relevant to a search. However, our exact match domain system works to ensure we don't give too much credit for content hosted under domains designed to exactly match particular queries. For example, someone might create a domain name containing the words "best-places-to-eat-lunch" in hopes all those words in the domain name would propel content high in the rankings. Our system adjusts for this.”

D66 · A guide to Google Search ranking systems · Exact match domain system

QUESTION 471 · D66

Does every query favor freshly updated content?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

No. Freshness systems serve queries where fresher information is expected, such as recent events or newly released products. The guide describes query-dependent freshness.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“We have various "query deserves freshness" systems designed to show fresher content for queries where it would be expected. For example, if someone is searching about a movie that's just been released, they probably want recent reviews rather than older articles from when production began. For another example, ordinarily a search for "earthquake" might bring back material about preparation and resources. However, if an earthquake happened recently, then news articles and fresher content might appear.”

D66 · A guide to Google Search ranking systems · Freshness systems

QUESTION 472 · D66

What happens to the ordinary listing when a page is selected as a featured snippet?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

The guide says it is not repeated later on the first results page; this is deduplication, not a removal penalty.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Deduplication also happens with featured snippets . If a web page listing is elevated to become a featured snippet, we don't repeat the listing later on the first page of results. This declutters the results and helps people locate relevant information more easily.”

D66 · A guide to Google Search ranking systems · Deduplication systems

QUESTION 473 · D66

What is passage ranking?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

An AI system identifies sections of a page to better understand that page's relevance to a query. This guide does not specify special passage markup or a publisher-selected passage index.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Passage ranking is an AI system we use to identify individual sections or "passages" of a web page to better understand how relevant a page is to a search.”

D66 · A guide to Google Search ranking systems · Passage ranking system

QUESTION 474 · D66

Is two results per domain an absolute cap?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

No. Site diversity generally aims for two in top results but permits exceptions. Subdomains usually count with the root, with relevant exceptions too.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE · EXACT EXCERPT

“Our site diversity system works so that we generally won't show more than two web page listings from the same site in our top results, so that no single site tends to dominate all the top results. However, we may still show more than two listings in cases where our systems determine it's”

D66 · A guide to Google Search ranking systems · Site diversity system

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE · EXACT EXCERPT

“show more than two web page listings from the same site in our top results, so that no single site tends to dominate all the top results. However, we may still show more than two listings in cases where our systems determine it's especially relevant to do so for a particular search. Site diversity generally treats subdomains as part of a root domain. IE: listings from a subdomain (subdomain.example.com)”

D66 · A guide to Google Search ranking systems · Site diversity system

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE · EXACT EXCERPT

“IE: listings from a subdomain (subdomain.example.com) and the root domain (example.com) will all be considered from the same single site. However, sometimes subdomains are treated as separate sites for diversity purposes when deemed relevant to do so.”

D66 · A guide to Google Search ranking systems · Site diversity system

QUESTION 475 · D66

Is the helpful content system still a separate current update?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

The guide lists it among retired systems: it evolved into core ranking in March 2024. Panda and Penguin were also incorporated into core in 2015 and 2016 respectively.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Announced in 2022 as the "Helpful Content Update", this was a system designed to better ensure people see original, helpful content written by people, for people, in search results, rather than content made primarily to gain search engine traffic. In March 2024, it evolved and became part of our core ranking systems, as our systems use a variety of signals and systems to present helpful results to users.”

D66 · A guide to Google Search ranking systems · Helpful content system

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“This was a system designed to better ensure high-quality and original content was appearing in our search results. Announced in 2011 and given the nickname of the "Panda," it evolved and became part of our core ranking systems in 2015.”

D66 · A guide to Google Search ranking systems · Panda system

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“This was a system designed to combat link spam. Announced in 2012 and given the nickname of the "Penguin Update", it was integrated into our core ranking systems in 2016.”

D66 · A guide to Google Search ranking systems · Penguin system

QUESTION 476 · D66

What does SpamBrain do?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

It is one of the systems Google uses to detect spam content and behaviors that violate its spam policies; the broader spam-detection systems are continually updated.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“No one wants their email inbox filled with spam, which is why spam filters are so helpful. Search faces a similar challenge, because the internet includes huge amounts of spam that, if not dealt with, would prevent us from showing the most helpful and relevant results. We employ a range of spam detection systems , including SpamBrain , to deal with content and behaviors that violate our spam policies . These systems are constantly updated to keep up with the latest ways that the spam threat evolves.”

D66 · A guide to Google Search ranking systems · Spam detection systems

QUESTION 477 · D66

How does Google surface reliable information during crises or uncertainty?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

The guide describes dedicated crisis resources/SOS authority alerts and reliable-information systems that can surface authoritative content and display advisories when confidence is low or topics change rapidly.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Google has developed systems to provide helpful and timely information during times of crisis, whether those involve personal crisis situations, natural disasters, or other wide-spread crisis situations:”

D66 · [A guide to Google Search ranking systems](#) · [Crisis information systems](#)

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“SOS Alerts: During times of natural disasters or wide-spread crisis situations, our SOS Alerts system works to show updates from local, national, or international authorities. These updates may include emergency phone numbers and websites, maps, translations of useful phrases, donation opportunities, and more. Learn more about how SOS Alerts work and how they're part of Google's crisis alerts that help in times of floods, wildfires, earthquakes, hurricanes, and other disasters.”

D66 · [A guide to Google Search ranking systems](#) · [Crisis information systems](#)

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Multiple systems work in various ways to show the most reliable information possible, such as to help surface more authoritative pages and demote low-quality content and to elevate quality journalism . In cases where reliable information might be lacking, our systems automatically display content advisories about rapidly-changing topics or when our systems don't have high confidence in the overall quality of the results available for the search. These provide tips on how to search in ways that might lead to more helpful results. Learn more about our approach to delivering high-quality information in Search .”

D66 · [A guide to Google Search ranking systems](#) · [Reliable information systems](#)

QUESTION 478 · D66 Additional practice

Are original reporting and articles that merely cite it treated identically by the systems guide?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

The guide describes systems intended to surface original content, including original reporting, ahead of pages merely citing it. It also mentions canonical markup to help identify the primary page when content is duplicated; neither statement guarantees a specific ranking.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“We have systems to help ensure we are showing original content prominently in search results, including original reporting , ahead of those who merely cite it. This includes support of a special canonical markup creators can use to help us better understand what is the primary page if a page has been duplicated in several places.”

D66 · A guide to Google Search ranking systems · Original content systems

QUESTION 479 · D66 Additional practice

Can a pattern of valid removal requests affect more than the individual removed URLs?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

Yes. The guide describes removal-based demotion, including signals from a significant volume of valid copyright removals and certain personal-information removal patterns that can affect other content on a site. Do not equate every isolated request with a sitewide demotion.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE · EXACT EXCERPT

“Legal removals: When we receive a significant volume of valid copyright removal requests involving a given site, we are able to use that to demote other content from the site in our results. This way, if there is other infringing content, people are less likely to encounter it versus the original content.”

D66 · A guide to Google Search ranking systems · Removal-based demotion systems

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Personal information removals: If we process a significant volume of personal information removals involving a site with exploitative removal practices , we demote other content from the site in our results. We also look to see if the same pattern of behavior is happening with other sites and, if so, apply demotions to content on those sites. We may apply similar demotion practices for sites that receive a significant volume of removals of content involving doxxing content , explicit personal imagery created or shared without consent , or explicit non-consensual fake content .”

D66 · A guide to Google Search ranking systems · Removal-based demotion systems

QUESTION 480 · D66 Additional practice

Would splitting content across many subdomains necessarily bypass the site-diversity system?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

No. Subdomains are generally treated as part of the root domain for diversity. Google can sometimes treat a subdomain separately when relevant, so this is not a guaranteed way to gain extra listings.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE · EXACT EXCERPT

“However, we may still show more than two listings in cases where our systems determine it’s especially relevant to do so for a particular search. Site diversity generally treats subdomains as part of a root domain. IE: listings from a subdomain (subdomain.example.com) and the root domain (example.com) will all be considered from the same single site. However, sometimes subdomains are treated as separate sites for diversity”

D66 · A guide to Google Search ranking systems · Site diversity system

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE · EXACT EXCERPT

“IE: listings from a subdomain (subdomain.example.com) and the root domain (example.com) will all be considered from the same single site. However, sometimes subdomains are treated as separate sites for diversity purposes when deemed relevant to do so.”

D66 · A guide to Google Search ranking systems · Site diversity system

QUESTION 481 · D66 Additional practice

Should Panda, Penguin and Hummingbird be presented as three current standalone update programs?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

The guide lists them under retired systems for historical context. Panda became part of core systems in 2015; Penguin was integrated in 2016; Hummingbird was an overall-system improvement in 2013 followed by continuing evolution.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Retired systems”

D66 · A guide to Google Search ranking systems · Retired systems

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“This was a system designed to better ensure high-quality and original content was appearing in our search results. Announced in 2011 and given the nickname of the "Panda," it evolved and became part of our core ranking systems in 2015.”

D66 · A guide to Google Search ranking systems · Panda system

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“This was a system designed to combat link spam. Announced in 2012 and given the nickname of the "Penguin Update", it was integrated into our core ranking systems in 2016.”

D66 · A guide to Google Search ranking systems · Penguin system

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“This was a major improvement to our overall ranking systems made in August 2013. Our ranking systems have continued to evolve since then, just as they had been evolving before.”

D66 · A guide to Google Search ranking systems · Hummingbird

Google Search's reviews system and your website

Google last updated: 2025-12-10 · Reviewed 6 October 2026

<https://developers.google.com/search/docs/appearance/reviews-system>

Detailed points to revise

- The reviews system rewards substantial insightful analysis and original research by knowledgeable experts/enthusiasts, rather than thin summaries.
- It covers first-party standalone recommendation/opinion/analysis content, not customer reviews posted in a product or service review section.
- Eligible subjects include products, media, services and businesses; formats include single reviews, comparisons and ranked recommendations.
- Evaluation is primarily page-level, but sites with substantial review content may receive wider evaluation. It improves regularly and continuously.
- The documented language list is English, Spanish, German, French, Italian, Vietnamese, Indonesian, Russian, Dutch, Portuguese and Polish, globally.
- Product structured data can help identify a product review, but the system does not solely depend on markup.
- Improvements may support recovery over time, but review assessment is only one ranking factor and results can change for other reasons. The linked high-quality-review guide supplies further content advice.

Complete source section checklist: How the reviews system works · What does this system mean for my site?

QUESTION 482 · D67

Priority practice

Does the reviews system evaluate product-page customer review comments?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

This guide says it does not evaluate those third-party user reviews. It targets first-party standalone recommendation, opinion and analysis content.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“The reviews system is designed to evaluate articles, blog posts, pages or similar first-party standalone content written with the purpose of providing a recommendation, giving an opinion, or providing analysis. It does not evaluate third-party reviews, such as those posted by users in the reviews section of a product or services page.”

D67 · [Google Search's reviews system and your website](#) · [How the reviews system works](#)

QUESTION 483 · D67 Priority practice

Is it only a product-review system?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

No. The page includes media, services and businesses as well as products, with single-item, comparison and ranked-list formats.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Reviews can be about a single thing, or head-to-head comparisons, or ranked-lists of recommendations. Reviews can be about any topic. There can be reviews of products such as laptops or winter jackets, pieces of media such as movies or video games, or services and businesses such as restaurants or fashion brands.”

D67 · [Google Search's reviews system and your website](#) · [How the reviews system works](#)

QUESTION 484 · D67

Is the reviews-system assessment always restricted to a single page?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

It is primarily page-level, but sites with a substantial volume of review content may have other site content evaluated as well.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“The reviews system primarily evaluates review content on a page-level basis. However, for sites that have a substantial amount of review content, any content within a site might be evaluated by the system. If you don't have a lot of reviews, a site-wide evaluation is not likely to happen.”

D67 · [Google Search's reviews system and your website](#) · [How the reviews system works](#)

QUESTION 485 · D67

Does Product markup alone make a review high quality?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

No. It can help identify a review, but Google does not solely depend on it. The objective is original insightful research rather than thin summaries.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“In the case of products, product structured data might help us better identify if something is a product review, but we don't solely depend on it.”

D67 · Google Search's reviews system and your website · How the reviews system works

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“The reviews system works to ensure that people see reviews that share in-depth research, rather than thin content that simply summarizes a bunch of products, services or other things. The reviews system is improved at a regular and ongoing pace.”

D67 · Google Search's reviews system and your website · How the reviews system works

QUESTION 486 · D67

What recovery timeline should you promise after improving reviews?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

No fixed outcome. The guide says improvement can support recovery over time and review assessment is one of many ranking factors.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Content impacted by the reviews system may recover over time, if you've made improvements to your content. However, note that our automated assessment of review content is only one of many factors used in ranking content, so changes can happen at any time for various reasons.”

D67 · Google Search's reviews system and your website · What does this system mean for my site?

QUESTION 487 · D67

Additional practice

Does a ranked list or head-to-head comparison fall within the reviews system's scope?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

Yes. First-party review content can analyze one item, compare items or rank recommendations. The guide rewards insightful research and expertise rather than a thin summary of several products or services.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Reviews can be about a single thing, or head-to-head comparisons, or ranked-lists of recommendations. Reviews can be about any topic. There can be reviews of products such as laptops or winter jackets, pieces of media such as movies or video games, or services and businesses such as restaurants or fashion brands.”

D67 · Google Search's reviews system and your website · How the reviews system works

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“The reviews system works to ensure that people see reviews that share in-depth research, rather than thin content that simply summarizes a bunch of products, services or other things. The reviews system is improved at a regular and ongoing pace.”

D67 · Google Search's reviews system and your website · How the reviews system works

QUESTION 488 · D67 Additional practice

What language limitation should you mention when explaining this reviews-system page?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

The captured guide lists English, Spanish, German, French, Italian, Vietnamese, Indonesian, Russian, Dutch, Portuguese and Polish globally. Describe that documented scope rather than claiming the page says every language is covered.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Currently, this system applies to the following languages globally: English, Spanish, German, French, Italian, Vietnamese, Indonesian, Russian, Dutch, Portuguese, Polish.”

D67 · Google Search's reviews system and your website · How the reviews system works

Google Search's core updates and your website

Google last updated: 2025-12-10 · Reviewed 6 October 2026

<https://developers.google.com/search/docs/appearance/core-updates>

Detailed points to revise

- Core updates are broad improvements to systems serving helpful reliable results; they do not target individual sites or specific pages as a penalty.
- Verify rollout completion and dates in the Search Status Dashboard before attributing a traffic change to an update.
- Wait at least a full week after completion, then compare that period with a week before rollout began. Inspect affected pages/queries and separate Web, Images, Video and News patterns.
- A small positional change such as 2 to 4 does not justify drastic alteration. A sustained large change such as 4 to 29 calls for deeper objective assessment.
- Review the whole site's helpfulness and the most affected pages; independent unaffiliated feedback can reduce bias.
- Avoid rumor-driven quick fixes. Improve content meaningfully for readers through better substance, organization and navigation.
- Deleting is a last resort for unsalvageable material; removal of search-first sections can be considered when they cannot be improved.
- Effects can take days or months and may or may not wait for another major update. Smaller unannounced updates also occur; there is no guaranteed recovery or fixed ranking position.

Complete source section checklist: How core updates work · Check if there's a traffic drop in Search Console · Assessing a large drop in position · Things to keep in mind when making changes · How long does it take to see an effect in Search results

QUESTION 489 · D68 Priority practice

Does a drop after a core update prove a penalty against that site?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

No. Google describes core updates as broad changes, not actions targeted at specific pages or sites. Relative usefulness and other competing content can change.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Core updates are designed to ensure that overall, we're delivering on our mission to present helpful and reliable results for searchers. These changes are broad in nature, and don't target specific sites or individual web pages. As content on the web changes, we assess and update our systems to keep pace, as a whole.”

D68 · [Google Search's core updates and your website](#) · [How core updates work](#)

QUESTION 490 · D68 Priority practice

When should you analyze a suspected core-update traffic decline?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

Confirm rollout completion, wait at least one full week, and compare the post-update week with a week before rollout began. Then inspect pages, queries and separate search types.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Compare the right dates : We recommend waiting at least a full week after a core update completes before analyzing your site in Search Console. After a week, try comparing this week with a week before the core update started rolling out; this way you'll be able to better pinpoint what exactly has changed.”

D68 · [Google Search's core updates and your website](#) · [Check if there's a traffic drop in Search Console](#)

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Analyze different search types separately : This can help you understand whether the drop you've seen happened in Web Search, Google Images, Video mode, or the News tab.”

D68 · [Google Search's core updates and your website](#) · [Check if there's a traffic drop in Search Console](#)

QUESTION 491 · D68

Would you rewrite a strong page after a position change from two to four?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

The guide advises against drastic action for a small decline and against changing content that already performs well. A sustained large drop deserves deeper assessment.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Review your top pages and queries. Assess how they were ranking before and after the core update: is the drop small or large? Small drop in position (dropping from position 2 to 4) : There's no need to take drastic action (in fact, we recommend avoiding making changes to content that's already performing well). Large drop in position (dropping from position 4 to 29) : Do a deeper assessment .”

D68 · [Google Search's core updates and your website](#) · [Check if there's a traffic drop in Search Console](#)

QUESTION 492 · D68

What is a sound response to a sustained large core-update loss?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

Assess the whole site's helpfulness objectively, review the most affected pages, get independent input and make durable reader-focused improvements rather than a rumor-driven quick fix.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

"If you're seeing a sustained, large drop in position for your site as a whole, read through the self-assessment to check if your site overall (not just individual pages) is delivering content that's helpful, reliable, and people first. Specifically, we recommend keeping the following in mind:"

D68 · Google Search's core updates and your website · Assessing a large drop in position

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

"Take a close look at your site as a whole, and try to be objective. You might also ask others you trust (that are unaffiliated with your site) to do an assessment using the questions ."

D68 · Google Search's core updates and your website · Assessing a large drop in position

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

"Avoid doing "quick fix" changes (like removing some page element because you heard it was bad for SEO). Instead, focus on making changes that make sense for your users and are sustainable in the long term."

D68 · Google Search's core updates and your website · Things to keep in mind when making changes

QUESTION 493 · D68

Should you delete all declining content to recover?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

No. Google says deletion is a last resort when content cannot be salvaged. First consider meaningful improvements; unsalvageable search-first sections may be candidates for removal.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

"Deleting content is a last resort, and only to be considered if you think the content can't be salvaged. In fact, if you're considering deleting entire sections of your site, that's likely a sign those sections were created for search engines first, and not people. If that's the case for your site, then deleting the unhelpful content can help the good content on your site perform better."

D68 · Google Search's core updates and your website · Things to keep in mind when making changes

QUESTION 494 · D68

Must recovery wait until the next major core update?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

Not necessarily. Some effects can appear in days or months and smaller ongoing updates can reflect improvements. Google gives no guaranteed impact.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“However, you don't necessarily have to wait for a major core update to see the effect of your improvements. We're continually making updates to our search algorithms, including smaller core updates. These updates are not announced because they aren't widely noticeable, but they are another way that your content can see a rise in position (if you've made improvements).”

D68 · Google Search's core updates and your website · How long does it take to see an effect in Search results

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Keep in mind that there's no guarantee that changes you make to your website will result in noticeable impact in search results, and that positions in Google Search results aren't static or fixed in place. Google's search results are dynamic in nature because user expectations evolve and the open web itself is constantly changing with new and updated content. This constant change can cause both gains and drops in organic Search traffic.”

D68 · Google Search's core updates and your website · How long does it take to see an effect in Search results

QUESTION 495 · D68 Additional practice

How would you distinguish an Image Search decline from an ordinary Web decline after a core update?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

Analyze search types separately in Search Console, then compare affected pages and queries using appropriate completed-update dates. The guide specifically separates Web, Images, Video mode and News rather than treating total traffic as one diagnosis.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Analyze different search types separately : This can help you understand whether the drop you've seen happened in Web Search, Google Images, Video mode, or the News tab.”

D68 · Google Search's core updates and your website · Check if there's a traffic drop in Search Console

Why can an independent reviewer help assess a large core-update loss?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

Google recommends an objective review of the site as a whole and suggests asking trusted people unaffiliated with the site to use the self-assessment questions. This can challenge assumptions before making sustainable user-focused changes.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Take a close look at your site as a whole, and try to be objective. You might also ask others you trust (that are unaffiliated with your site) to do an assessment using the questions .”

D68 · Google Search's core updates and your website · Assessing a large drop in position

What would you say to a client demanding an exact recovery date after a content improvement?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

The guide allows effects in days or several months, and gives no guarantee of noticeable impact. Explain the completed-update comparisons and improvement work, then monitor outcomes without promising a fixed recovery date.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“If you've made improvements, it may take time to see an effect in Search results: some changes can take effect in a few days, but it could take several months for our systems to learn and confirm that the site as a whole is now producing helpful, reliable, people-first content in the long term. If it's been a few months and you still haven't seen any effect, that could mean waiting until the next core update.”

D68 · Google Search's core updates and your website · How long does it take to see an effect in Search results

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Keep in mind that there's no guarantee that changes you make to your website will result in noticeable impact in search results, and that positions in Google Search results aren't static or fixed in place. Google's search results are dynamic in nature because user expectations evolve and the open web itself is constantly changing with new and updated content. This constant change can cause both gains and drops in organic Search traffic.”

D68 · Google Search's core updates and your website · How long does it take to see an effect in Search results

Google Search spam updates and your site

Google last updated: 2025-12-10 · Reviewed 6 October 2026

<https://developers.google.com/search/docs/appearance/spam-updates>

Detailed points to revise

- Automated spam detection operates continuously; announced spam updates are notable improvements to those systems.
- SpamBrain is an AI-based prevention system that is improved to identify new spam patterns.
- Sites affected should assess compliance with the actual spam policies, not assume a generic content rewrite addresses every spam mechanism.
- Policy violations may reduce ranking or remove Search presence. Systems may learn improved compliance over months.
- When link-spam benefits are neutralized, the old benefits cannot be regained by merely cleaning up; compliant improvement is not a promise to restore artificial link-driven positions.

QUESTION 498 · D69 Priority practice

How does a spam update differ from continuous spam detection?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

Detection runs all the time; a spam update is a notable improvement announced by Google. SpamBrain is one example of the underlying system.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“While Google's automated systems to detect search spam are constantly operating, we occasionally make notable improvements to how they work. When we do, we refer to this as a spam update and share when they happen on our list of Google Search ranking updates .”

D69 · [Google Search spam updates and your site](#) · [Google Search spam updates and your site](#)

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“For example, SpamBrain is our AI-based spam-prevention system. From time-to-time, we improve that system to make it better at spotting spam and to help ensure it catches new types of spam.”

D69 · [Google Search spam updates and your site](#) · [Google Search spam updates and your site](#)

What should an affected site review after a spam update?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

Its compliance with Google's spam policies. Reassessment can take months and violations can reduce or eliminate visibility.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Sites that see a change after a spam update should review our spam policies to ensure they are complying with those. Sites that violate our policies may rank lower in results or not appear in results at all. Making changes may help a site improve if our automated systems learn over a period of months that the site complies with our spam policies.”

D69 · [Google Search spam updates and your site](#) · [Google Search spam updates and your site](#)

Does removing link spam restore its former ranking benefit?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

No. The guide says the benefit from spammy links, once removed by the systems, cannot be regained. Cleanup is not a promise to recover an artificial advantage.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“In the case of a link spam update (an update that specifically deals with link spam), making changes might not generate an improvement. This is because when our systems remove the effects spammy links may have, any ranking benefit the links may have previously generated for your site is lost. Any potential ranking benefits generated by those links cannot be regained.”

D69 · [Google Search spam updates and your site](#) · [Google Search spam updates and your site](#)

If a site removes a spam practice today, should recovery be promised at the end of the current rollout?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

No. The spam guide says automated systems may need months to learn that the site complies. Link-spam benefits have the additional limitation that neutralized benefits cannot be regained; neither case supports an immediate recovery promise.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Sites that see a change after a spam update should review our spam policies to ensure they are complying with those. Sites that violate our policies may rank lower in results or not appear in results at all. Making changes may help a site improve if our automated systems learn over a period of months that the site complies with our spam policies.”

D69 · [Google Search spam updates and your site](#) · [Google Search spam updates and your site](#)

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“In the case of a link spam update (an update that specifically deals with link spam), making changes might not generate an improvement. This is because when our systems remove the effects spammy links may have, any ranking benefit the links may have previously generated for your site is lost. Any potential ranking benefits generated by those links cannot be regained.”

D69 · [Google Search spam updates and your site](#) · [Google Search spam updates and your site](#)

Regional differences in Search experience

Google last updated: 2026-09-18 · Reviewed 6 October 2026

<https://developers.google.com/search/docs/appearance/aggregator-features>

Detailed points to revise

- This directory routes regional Search features by business region and query category; it does not describe globally identical Search displays.
- EEA aggregator and supplier units cover hotels, flights, ground transportation, local businesses and products.
- The EEA ecosystem carousel covers finance, weather, sports and translation. EEA job-site features cover job searches.
- Places-site carousel/refinement features in the current directory apply to Türkiye local-business and hotel queries.
- South African badge/refinement features target the specified local platforms and travel/commerce categories.
- Structured-data host carousels are region/category-specific across EEA, Türkiye and South Africa; the dedicated beta page contains exact requirements and query lists.
- A refinement chip, multi-provider aggregator unit and a single-site structured-data carousel are distinct experiences with different participation requirements.

QUESTION 502 · D70

Are all the regional features available to every site worldwide?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

No. The directory maps each feature to regions and query categories. Assess the dedicated requirements for the relevant feature and market.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“To find the features relevant to your website, select where your company is based and the query types that are most relevant to your business.”

D70 · Regional differences in Search experience · Regional differences in Search experience

QUESTION 503 · D70

How do you choose between the regional feature guides?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

Identify whether the site is a direct provider, aggregator or specialist source, the users' market and the query category, then use the corresponding feature's guide rather than assume one generic markup solution.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Google is evolving the search results page for certain types of queries to provide new opportunities for Vertical Search Services (VSS), Comparison Shopping Services (CSS), direct suppliers, and content providers.”

D70 · Regional differences in Search experience · Regional differences in Search experience

QUESTION 504 · D70

Additional practice

Are the regional carousel and badge categories identical in every country?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

No. The overview maps different features and query categories to EEA, South Africa and Türkiye. Use that region/category mapping and the exact feature guide rather than applying one country's eligibility to every regional experience.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Feature Region Queries”

D70 · Regional differences in Search experience · Regional differences in Search experience

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“South Africa”

D70 · Regional differences in Search experience · Regional differences in Search experience

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Türkiye”

D70 · Regional differences in Search experience · Regional differences in Search experience

Aggregator unit in Google Search

Google last updated: 2026-09-18 · Reviewed 6 October 2026

<https://developers.google.com/search/docs/appearance/aggregator-unit>

Detailed points to revise

- The aggregator unit is a multi-provider experience for approved VSSs such as OTAs, metasearch services, comparison-shopping providers and directories.
- For a relevant query, the top-ranked provider is expanded by default; users can switch eligible providers, and only one aggregator unit is expanded at a time. Clicks lead to that provider's website.
- The documented user market is EEA, for hotels, flights, long-distance trains/buses, products and local businesses; the supplier unit can appear alongside it.
- Participation requires approved VSS status, relevant content, required data, quality standards and Search content-policy compliance. Express interest using the appropriate form; product/CSS contact routes differ from other categories.
- Flights and transport use real-time APIs; lodging and local businesses use direct feeds. The source links each category's exact feed/API documentation.
- Provide meaningful entity descriptions, images, verified ratings/counts, precise categories, amenities and hours where relevant.
- Use factual descriptive titles; avoid promotional words, ALL CAPS, excessive punctuation or emoji. Prefer clear high-resolution original images without watermarks or promotional badges.
- Keep prices and availability consistent with landing pages, refresh feeds and remove expired/out-of-stock listings. Use Search Console to monitor overall Search performance.

Complete source section checklist: How the aggregator unit works · Feature availability · Eligibility criteria · Aggregator unit best practices

QUESTION 505 · D71

Priority practice

How does the aggregator unit work?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

It displays eligible aggregator data for a relevant query, with the top-ranked provider expanded initially. Users can switch providers, and clicks go directly to the selected aggregator.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“In this unit, eligible aggregators populate their unit with results relevant to the user’s query. The top-ranked provider’s results are expanded by default. For example, if a user searched for “hotels in paris”, they may see a list of top-ranked hotels with photos, prices, or star ratings from an eligible provider. User clicks within the unit lead directly to that aggregator’s website.”

D71 · Aggregator unit in Google Search · How the aggregator unit works

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Users have the ability to select a different provider from a list of alternative aggregators, if available, expanding a unit populated with results from the new aggregator. Only one aggregator unit will show at a time.”

D71 · Aggregator unit in Google Search · How the aggregator unit works

QUESTION 506 · D71 Priority practice

Does ordinary ItemList markup alone enroll a site in this unit?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

No. The guide requires approval as a VSS, relevant content, required data integrations and quality/policy compliance. Express interest through the correct category’s route.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Businesses are eligible to appear in the aggregator unit when they are approved as a Vertical Search Service (VSS), they provide the necessary data, and they meet the established quality standards to participate.”

D71 · Aggregator unit in Google Search · Eligibility criteria

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“People in European Economic Area (EEA) countries who are searching for things like “hotels near me” may notice that the experience has changed. These experiences include the aggregator units and supplier units . This page explains how the aggregator unit works and how businesses that serve users in EEA can express interest in the aggregator unit.”

D71 · Aggregator unit in Google Search · Aggregator unit in Google Search

QUESTION 507 · D71

Which data integrations are used by the unit?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

Flights and transport use real-time APIs; lodging and local-business queries use direct feeds. Consult the specific linked integration specification.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“The unit is designed to help users connect with aggregators when it is helpful for the query. For flight and transport queries, the unit is populated by real-time APIs. For lodging and local business queries, the unit is populated by direct data feed integrations. Just like all of our search features, we show information in the unit based on what is most helpful to users for their queries. To learn more about how we think about Search quality, you can view the Search Quality Raters guidelines, as outlined in our blog .”

D71 · Aggregator unit in Google Search · Aggregator unit best practices

QUESTION 508 · D71

What would you audit in an aggregator feed?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

Entity detail completeness, factual titles, clean high-quality images, current prices/availability and consistency with landing pages, plus eligibility and policy compliance.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Include rich entity details : Where available, providing more comprehensive attributes helps users better evaluate options. Depending on your business type, consider including: Images of the entity Detailed descriptions and specifications Verified user ratings and review counts Specific categories (for example, "Boutique hotel" or "Eco-resort" instead of just a generic "Hotel") Key amenities, features, and operating hours”

D71 · Aggregator unit in Google Search · Aggregator unit best practices

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Use accurate titles : Factual, descriptive titles formatted in title case are easier for users to read. We recommend avoiding all caps, excessive punctuation, emoji, or promotional text (such as "BEST DEALS" or "Free shipping") in entity names.”

D71 · Aggregator unit in Google Search · Aggregator unit best practices

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Keep pricing and availability up to date : Accurate data helps prevent frustrating experiences for users. Ensure prices and availability in feeds match the landing page as closely as possible, and refresh feeds regularly to remove expired or out-of-stock listings.”

D71 · Aggregator unit in Google Search · Aggregator unit best practices

Do approved comparison services each receive a separate aggregator unit on the same results page?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

The guide says only one aggregator unit shows at a time, and describes it as a multi-provider experience. Do not promise a separate simultaneous unit for every participating aggregator.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Users have the ability to select a different provider from a list of alternative aggregators, if available, expanding a unit populated with results from the new aggregator. Only one aggregator unit will show at a time.”

D71 · Aggregator unit in Google Search · How the aggregator unit works

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“The aggregator unit is a multi-provider feature designed for Vertical Search Services (VSSs), including Online Travel Agencies (OTAs), Comparison Shopping Services, metasearch engines, and directories. Aggregator units allow users to more easily see results from aggregators for queries related to hotels, flights, long-distance trains, products, and local businesses.”

D71 · Aggregator unit in Google Search · How the aggregator unit works

Is the product-query application route identical to the hotel, flight and local-business route?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

No. The guide directs product-query participants to the comparison shopping services contact form, and the other listed categories to the Google Search Aggregator Features form. Use the applicable integration and eligibility requirements afterward.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Express interest : If your business serves users in EEA, and you would like to express interest in participating in the aggregator units, you can start by filling out the applicable form: For ground transportation, flight, hotel, and local business queries, fill out the Google Search Aggregator Features form . For product queries, contact us through the comparison shopping services contact form .”

D71 · Aggregator unit in Google Search · Eligibility criteria

Supplier unit in Google Search

Google last updated: 2026-09-18 · Reviewed 6 October 2026

<https://developers.google.com/search/docs/appearance/supplier-unit>

Detailed points to revise

- The supplier unit gives visibility to direct providers such as hotels, airlines, shops and service providers, alongside the aggregator unit.
- It appears only when the aggregator unit appears, for the documented EEA categories.
- The site must serve EEA users and represent a relevant direct provider.
- Additional data beyond web-crawl-accessible information is not required; optional feeds can enhance supplier results. Do not confuse its requirements with the aggregator's mandatory integrations.

Complete source section checklist: How the supplier unit works · Feature availability · How to participate in the supplier unit

QUESTION 511 · D72

How does a supplier unit differ from an aggregator unit?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

It highlights relevant direct providers rather than VSS aggregators and appears alongside the aggregator unit, only when that unit appears.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“The supplier unit is a dedicated feature for direct providers (for example, individual hotels or airlines, brick-and-mortar business owners, or providers of services like plumbing) that appears alongside the aggregator unit . The supplier unit only appears if the aggregator unit appears.”

D72 · Supplier unit in Google Search · How the supplier unit works

QUESTION 512 · D72

Is a feed mandatory for the supplier unit?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

No. The guide says crawled website data is enough for eligibility, although available feeds can enhance the results.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“: You don't need to provide additional data beyond what's accessible through web crawling to appear in this feature. However, supplier results can be enhanced with data feeds, if available.”

D72 · Supplier unit in Google Search · How to participate in the supplier unit

QUESTION 513 · D72 Additional practice

Can a direct supplier's unit appear independently when no aggregator unit is shown?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

This guide says the supplier unit appears only if the aggregator unit appears. Being a direct provider with crawlable content is not a guarantee of an independent unit on every matching query.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“The supplier unit is a dedicated feature for direct providers (for example, individual hotels or airlines, brick-and-mortar business owners, or providers of services like plumbing) that appears alongside the aggregator unit . The supplier unit only appears if the aggregator unit appears.”

D72 · Supplier unit in Google Search · How the supplier unit works

Ecosystem carousel in Google Search

Google last updated: 2026-09-08 · Reviewed 6 October 2026

<https://developers.google.com/search/docs/appearance/ecosystem-carousel>

Detailed points to revise

- The ecosystem carousel offers alternative sources for queries benefiting from interactive data or visualization: finance, weather, sports and translation.
- It is available in EEA on desktop/mobile. A tile links directly to its source site.
- Ordering uses Search ranking algorithms with location/language relevance and the stated non-discriminatory principles.
- Eligibility requires serving EEA users, relevant content and authoritative or specialist provider status.
- This specific feature needs no new structured data or special feed. Eligible providers can express interest through the linked form.

Complete source section checklist: Feature availability · Requirements · Express interest

QUESTION 514 · D73

What is the ecosystem carousel for?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

It gives additional relevant sources for finance, weather, sports or translation queries benefiting from data visualization or interaction, with tiles linking directly to those sites.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“To provide additional, relevant sources of information, the ecosystem carousel may appear when people search for specific information that benefit from data visualizations or interactivity with data (for example, stock charts, weather information, sports scores, translation).”

D73 · Ecosystem carousel in Google Search · Ecosystem carousel in Google Search

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“After clicking a tile in the carousel, the searcher is taken directly to that website. The order of websites in the carousel is determined by Search ranking algorithms based on non-discriminatory ranking principles designed to ensure users see the most relevant results for their location and language. To be eligible to appear in the carousel, check to see if you meet the requirements, and if you do, express interest in the feature.”

D73 · Ecosystem carousel in Google Search · Ecosystem carousel in Google Search

QUESTION 515 · D73

Does it require a new feed or structured-data type?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

No. The page explicitly says no new markup or special feed is required for this feature, but EEA service, relevant content and authoritative/specialist eligibility still apply.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“: No new structured data markup or special feeds are required for this specific feature.”

D73 · Ecosystem carousel in Google Search · Requirements

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Your website must be an authoritative source or a specialized provider in your respective domains (for example, major media outlets, or commercial weather services).”

D73 · Ecosystem carousel in Google Search · Requirements

QUESTION 516 · D73 Additional practice

Beyond relevant topics and EEA service, what kind of provider is eligible for the ecosystem carousel?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

The site must be an authoritative source or specialized provider in the relevant domain. The guide gives examples such as major media outlets and commercial weather services and provides an interest form; topic coverage alone is insufficient.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Your website must be an authoritative source or a specialized provider in your respective domains (for example, major media outlets, or commercial weather services).”

D73 · Ecosystem carousel in Google Search · Requirements

Job sites: aggregator carousel and refinement chip

Google last updated: 2026-09-11 · Reviewed 6 October 2026

<https://developers.google.com/search/docs/appearance/job-sites>

Detailed points to revise

- Job-site features consist of an aggregator carousel and a refinement chip for job queries in EEA.
- The carousel offers top aggregator results and More sites; the chip focuses results on aggregator text listings.
- No added markup is required for these two features. This page is separate from JobPosting rich-result requirements.
- Businesses serving EEA users can express interest through the linked form; that step is not an automatic appearance guarantee.

Complete source section checklist: Feature availability · Learn more and express interest

QUESTION 517 · D74

Does the Job sites aggregator carousel require JobPosting markup?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

This specific page says no added markup is needed for its aggregator carousel/refinement chip. JobPosting rich results have separate rules and should not be confused with this experience.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“This page describes features for job sites in Google Search, including the aggregator carousel and refinement chips for job-related queries in European Economic Area (EEA) countries. Publishers don't need to add any markup to be eligible for the aggregator carousel or refinement chips.”

D74 · Job sites: aggregator carousel and refinement chip · Job sites: aggregator carousel and refinement chip

QUESTION 518 · D74

What does the Job sites refinement chip do, and where is it available?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

It narrows the Search page to aggregator text results for job queries in the EEA; it can be activated at the top or through More sites.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“The "Job sites" refinement chip can help users focus the Search page on aggregator text results. Searchers can activate the refinement chips at the top of the Search results page or by clicking More sites on the aggregator carousel.”

D74 · Job sites: aggregator carousel and refinement chip · Job sites: aggregator carousel and refinement chip

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“These experiences are available to users in the EEA who are searching for job-related queries.”

D74 · Job sites: aggregator carousel and refinement chip · Feature availability

QUESTION 519 · D74 Additional practice

What does More sites do in the Job sites carousel?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

It lets users find additional relevant aggregators and provides a route to activating the refinement experience. The guide describes filtering aggregator text results, not guaranteed placement of every individual job.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“The "Job sites" aggregator carousel lets users easily see the top aggregator results for their query. Users can also click More sites to see additional relevant aggregator sites for their query.”

D74 · Job sites: aggregator carousel and refinement chip · Job sites: aggregator carousel and refinement chip

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“The "Job sites" refinement chip can help users focus the Search page on aggregator text results. Searchers can activate the refinement chips at the top of the Search results page or by clicking More sites on the aggregator carousel.”

D74 · Job sites: aggregator carousel and refinement chip · Job sites: aggregator carousel and refinement chip

Places sites: aggregator carousel and refinement chip

Google last updated: 2026-09-11 · Reviewed 6 October 2026

<https://developers.google.com/search/docs/appearance/places-sites>

Detailed points to revise

- The current Places sites guide describes an aggregator carousel and refinement chip for Türkiye hotel and local-business queries.
- The carousel links to relevant aggregator sites and More sites; the chip narrows the view to aggregator text results.
- No added markup is required for this particular carousel/chip experience.
- Businesses serving Türkiye users can express interest through the documented route. Avoid carrying over an old region assumption from another feature.

Complete source section checklist: Feature availability · Learn more and express interest

QUESTION 520 · D75

Where are the Places sites carousel and chip available in this guide?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

The current guide specifies Türkiye for hotel and local-business queries. This is separate from EEA supplier/aggregator-unit rules.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“This page describes features for Places sites in Google Search, including the aggregator carousel and refinement chips for local business and hotel queries in Türkiye. Publishers don't need to add any markup to be eligible for the aggregator carousel or refinement chips.”

D75 · Places sites: aggregator carousel and refinement chip · Places sites: aggregator carousel and refinement chip

QUESTION 521 · D75

Does the Places sites refinement feature require new markup?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

No. The guide explicitly says publishers do not need to add markup for its carousel or refinement chips.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“This page describes features for Places sites in Google Search, including the aggregator carousel and refinement chips for local business and hotel queries in Türkiye. Publishers don't need to add any markup to be eligible for the aggregator carousel or refinement chips.”

D75 · Places sites: aggregator carousel and refinement chip · Places sites: aggregator carousel and refinement chip

QUESTION 522 · D75

Additional practice

How can a Türkiye user activate the Places sites refinement experience?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

Through the refinement chip at the top of results or More sites in the aggregator carousel. It focuses the view on aggregator text results for the documented local-business/hotel queries.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“The "Places sites" refinement chip can help users focus the Search page on aggregator text results. Searchers can activate the refinement chips at the top of the Search results page or by clicking More sites on the aggregator carousel.”

D75 · Places sites: aggregator carousel and refinement chip · Places sites: aggregator carousel and refinement chip

Search experiences in South Africa: badge and refinement chip

Google last updated: 2026-09-08 · Reviewed 6 October 2026

<https://developers.google.com/search/docs/appearance/south-africa-features>

Detailed points to revise

- The South African badge and refinement chip aim to help users find eligible South African platforms.
- The badge can appear for applicable organic web results and ads; it explicitly does not change ranking.
- Organic badge categories include travel, car hire, bus booking, products and food delivery. Ad support covers travel and shopping for eligible platforms.
- The refinement chip filters toward eligible South African travel/shopping platforms; they need no added markup for the chip.
- These features are limited to eligible South African sites; the interest form is a participation route rather than a worldwide SEO tactic.

Complete source section checklist: "South African" badge · "South African" refinement chip · Learn more and express interest

QUESTION 523 · D76

Does a South African badge itself improve ranking?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

No. The guide explicitly says the badge does not change result ranking; it identifies applicable eligible platforms.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

"A "South African" badge is shown on the search results page, for applicable web results and advertisements from eligible South African platforms. This badge doesn't change the ranking of results. This badge is available for web results for travel, car hire, bus booking, products, and food delivery queries in South Africa. It's also available for advertisements in travel and shopping for eligible South African platforms."

D76 · Search experiences in South Africa: badge and refinement chip · "South African" badge

QUESTION 524 · D76

Is the badge limited to organic results?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

No. It can appear on applicable organic web results and advertisements, with the documented query/category eligibility.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“A "South African" badge is shown on the search results page, for applicable web results and advertisements from eligible South African platforms. This badge doesn't change the ranking of results. This badge is available for web results for travel, car hire, bus booking, products, and food delivery queries in South Africa. It's also available for advertisements in travel and shopping for eligible South African platforms.”

D76 · Search experiences in South Africa: badge and refinement chip · "South African" badge

QUESTION 525 · D76

Do eligible platforms need markup for the South African refinement chip?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

No. The current guide says no added markup is needed for chip inclusion, while the regional/site eligibility still applies.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Refinement chips can help users focus the Search page on specific types of web results. Searchers in South Africa can activate the "South African" refinement chip at the top of the Search results page to refine their view to eligible South African travel and shopping platforms. Eligible South African platforms don't need to add any markup to appear using the refinement chip.”

D76 · Search experiences in South Africa: badge and refinement chip · "South African" refinement chip

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“These experiences are launched to eligible sites in South Africa only. If your business is based in South Africa, you think you're eligible for these experiences, and you'd like to express interest, you can start by filling out this interest form .”

D76 · Search experiences in South Africa: badge and refinement chip · Learn more and express interest

Are the documented categories for South African organic badges and ad badges exactly the same?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

No. Organic badge categories include travel, car hire, bus booking, products and food delivery; the guide identifies travel and shopping for ad badges. Eligibility remains limited to the relevant South African platforms.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“A "South African" badge is shown on the search results page, for applicable web results and advertisements from eligible South African platforms. This badge doesn't change the ranking of results. This badge is available for web results for travel, car hire, bus booking, products, and food delivery queries in South Africa. It's also available for advertisements in travel and shopping for eligible South African platforms.”

D76 · Search experiences in South Africa: badge and refinement chip · "South African" badge

Structured data carousels (beta)

Google last updated: 2026-09-11 · Reviewed 6 October 2026

<https://developers.google.com/search/docs/appearance/structured-data/carousels-beta>

Detailed points to revise

- This beta is a single-site horizontal host carousel, distinct from a multi-provider aggregator unit. It uses ItemList with LocalBusiness/subtypes, Product or Event entities.
- Current regions are EEA, Türkiye and South Africa on desktop/mobile, with category-specific lists. Türkiye covers hotels/vacation rentals/local businesses; other markets have broader listed travel, event and commerce categories.
- Participation routes vary by category/region: general aggregator-interest, flight-interest, CSS program or South African feature-interest forms.
- Use one summary/category page listing at least three entities and linking to standalone detail pages. An all-in-one page with only anchor destinations is unsupported.
- Put the required markup on the summary page; detail-page markup is not mandatory for this beta. Include every listed item and every detail URL in the summary markup.
- For paginated categories, add an ItemList for the items on each page. For infinite scroll, mark the entities initially loaded in the viewport.
- ItemList requires itemListElement entries, item objects of an accepted type and 1-based position values. The declared order controls tile order.
- Each item requires image, name and a canonical detail-page url. URLs must be unique and within the documented same-domain/subdomain/superdomain relationship.
- Images must represent the item, be crawlable/indexable and use supported formats. Do not use logos; recommended multiple high-resolution crops are 16:9, 4:3 and 1:1 with at least 50K pixels.
- Ratings are recommended, not common required properties. Numeric scales default to five points; use the documented best/worst values for other scales, fractions/percentages imply their scale, and decimal values use a dot.
- LocalBusiness priceRange must be shorter than 12 characters to display. LodgingBusiness can use amenityFeature, and servesCuisine is for restaurants only. Generic types are permitted, but type-specific recommended properties require their appropriate type.
- Product/Event offers can use Offer or AggregateOffer: a single price uses price, a range uses lowPrice/highPrice; do not provide incompatible single/range representations together.
- priceCurrency uses three-letter ISO 4217; this guide defaults missing currency to USD. Event prices include required fees/charges, stay current and use zero for genuinely free events.
- Validate technical markup with Rich Results Test, verify deployed access and rendered output with URL Inspection, then allow recrawl. Syntax validation cannot prove all content/policy quality.

- Supported types and every property table/example are preserved in the source reference. Extra fields are allowed but might not display. A structured-data manual action can suppress the rich presentation without necessarily removing ordinary Search eligibility.

Complete source section checklist: Feature availability · Add structured data · Guidelines · Examples · Structured data type definitions · ItemList · Common list item properties (LocalBusiness , Product, or Event) · Additional type-specific properties definitions · LocalBusiness (and subtypes) · Product · Event · Examples for common scenarios · Restaurant example · Lodging (Hotels and VacationRental) example · Things to do example example · Product example · Troubleshooting

QUESTION 527 · D77 Priority practice

How is this beta carousel different from the aggregator unit?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

It is a host carousel showing multiple entities from one site with ItemList plus supported item types. The aggregator unit is a separate multi-provider experience with its own approval/data requirements.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Google uses structured data to understand the content on the page and show that content in a richer appearance in search results, which is called a rich result . This guide focuses on a new carousel rich result that's in beta , which is a list-like rich result that people can scroll horizontally to see more entities from a given site (also known as a host carousel). Each tile in the carousel may have information from your site about the price, rating, and images for entities on the page.”

D77 · Structured data carousels (beta) · Structured data carousels (beta)

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“To be eligible for this beta rich result, add ItemList structured data in combination with at least one one of the following supported structured data items:”

D77 · Structured data carousels (beta) · Structured data carousels (beta)

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“The aggregator unit is a multi-provider feature designed for Vertical Search Services (VSSs), including Online Travel Agencies (OTAs), Comparison Shopping Services, metasearch engines, and directories. Aggregator units allow users to more easily see results from aggregators for queries related to hotels, flights, long-distance trains, products, and local businesses.”

D71 · Aggregator unit in Google Search · How the aggregator unit works

Is this carousel globally available?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

No. The current beta lists EEA, Türkiye and South Africa, with different query categories, and requirements can change during beta.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE · EXACT EXCERPT

“This feature is in beta and you may see changes in requirements or guidelines, as we develop this feature. This feature is also only available in European Economic Area (EEA) countries, Türkiye, and South Africa, on both desktop and mobile devices. In EEA countries, this experience is available for queries related to hotels, vacation rentals, ground transportation, flights, local businesses, things to do (events, tours, and”

D77 · Structured data carousels (beta) · Feature availability

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE · EXACT EXCERPT

“This feature is in beta and you may see changes in requirements or guidelines, as we develop this feature. This feature is also only available in European Economic Area (EEA) countries, Türkiye, and South Africa, on both desktop and mobile devices. In EEA countries, this experience is available”

D77 · Structured data carousels (beta) · Feature availability

What page architecture and minimum item count are required?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

A summary/category page with at least three entities linking to standalone detail pages; a single page using anchor-only details is not supported.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“The markup must be on a summary or category page, which is a list-like page that contains information about at least three entities and then links out to other pages on your site for more information on those entities. While you don't need to add markup to the detail pages, you must include the detail page URLs in your summary page's markup.”

D77 · Structured data carousels (beta) · Guidelines

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Your site must have a summary page and multiple detail pages. Currently, this feature isn't designed to support other scenarios, such as an all-in-one page where the "details" are anchor points within the same page.”

D77 · Structured data carousels (beta) · Guidelines

QUESTION 530 · D77

Must every detail page carry this beta markup?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

No. The summary page needs the required markup and its item detail URLs; separate detail-page markup is not required for this particular beta.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“The markup must be on a summary or category page, which is a list-like page that contains information about at least three entities and then links out to other pages on your site for more information on those entities. While you don't need to add markup to the detail pages, you must include the detail page URLs in your summary page's markup.”

D77 · Structured data carousels (beta) · Guidelines

QUESTION 531 · D77

How should you mark pagination and infinite scroll?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

Mark all listed items on each paginated category page with its own `ItemList`; for infinite scroll, focus on entities initially loaded in the viewport.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Mark up all items that are on the summary or category page. For paginated categories, add an `ItemList` to each subsequent page and include the entities that are listed on that page. For infinite scroll, focus on marking up the entities that are initially loaded in the viewport.”

D77 · Structured data carousels (beta) · Guidelines

QUESTION 532 · D77

Which common item properties are required?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

image, name and the canonical detail-page URL, alongside the `ItemList/ListItem` structure and position. Images must be appropriate and accessible, and detail URLs unique within the documented domain relationship.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“itemListElement.item Subtype of LocalBusiness , Product , or Event An individual item in a list. Populate this object with: The general properties that all carousels must have (image , url , name) Any other properties required for this data type, as described for your content type: LocalBusiness and its subtypes Product Event Example : For a hotel, provide priceRange and amenityFeature properties.”

D77 · Structured data carousels (beta) · ItemList

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“itemListElement.position Integer The item's position in the carousel. This is a 1-based number.”

D77 · Structured data carousels (beta) · ItemList

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“url URL The canonical URL of the item detail page (for example, the standalone page for a single hotel or vacation listing that was referenced in the summary page). All URLs in the list must be unique, but live on the same domain (the same domain, or sub or super domain as the summary page). Anchor links within a summary or category page aren't supported; your site must have standalone detail pages for each item in the list.”

D77 · Structured data carousels (beta) · Common list item properties (LocalBusiness , Product, or Event)

QUESTION 533 · D77

Can every carousel item point to a different anchor on the same category page?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

No. The guide requires standalone detail pages and explicitly rejects anchor-only item URLs within the summary.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“url URL The canonical URL of the item detail page (for example, the standalone page for a single hotel or vacation listing that was referenced in the summary page). All URLs in the list must be unique, but live on the same domain (the same domain, or sub or super domain as the summary page). Anchor links within a summary or category page aren't supported; your site must have standalone detail pages for each item in the list.”

D77 · Structured data carousels (beta) · Common list item properties (LocalBusiness , Product, or Event)

QUESTION 534 · D77

Does adding more fields guarantee they appear on carousel tiles?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

No. Extra fields are allowed but may not display. Generic types can be used, but type-specific recommended properties require their relevant types.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Use of additional or extra fields is allowed, but may not appear in the rich result.”

D77 · Structured data carousels (beta) · Guidelines

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Use of generic types is allowed. However, to use recommended properties, you must use the respective types. For example, to use amenityFeature , use the LodgingBusiness type.”

D77 · Structured data carousels (beta) · Guidelines

QUESTION 535 · D77

How do Offer and AggregateOffer prices differ here?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

Use price for a single price and lowPrice/highPrice for a range, with an applicable Offer or AggregateOffer and ISO currency. The guide says not to combine the price property with a range.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“offers.price Number The offer price of a product, or of a price component when attached to PriceSpecification and its subtypes. If you're specifying a price range with lowPrice and highPrice , don't include the price property.”

D77 · Structured data carousels (beta) · Product

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“offers.priceCurrency Text The currency used to describe the event price, in three-letter ISO 4217 format. If a currency is not provided, Google defaults to USD .”

D77 · Structured data carousels (beta) · Event

QUESTION 536 · D77

What currency is assumed if this guide's priceCurrency is absent?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

The guide defaults it to USD. Explicitly supply the correct ISO 4217 currency for the actual offer rather than relying on that default.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“offers.priceCurrency Text The currency used to describe the event price, in three-letter ISO 4217 format. If a currency is not provided, Google defaults to USD .”

D77 · Structured data carousels (beta) · Event

QUESTION 537 · D77

How should free-event ticket prices be represented?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

Set the price to zero only when the event is available without payment, fees or service charges. For paid events, include required charges and update prices as availability changes.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“offers.price Number The price for your tickets, including service charges and fees. Don't forget to update it as prices change or tickets sell out. If you're specifying a price range with lowPrice and highPrice , don't include the price property. If the event is available without payment, fees, or service charges, set the price to 0 . "offers" : { "@type" : "Offer" , "price" : 0 }”

D77 · Structured data carousels (beta) · Event

QUESTION 538 · D77

Can a passing Rich Results Test rule out every reason a carousel is missing?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

No. It checks supported technical issues, but does not establish all content/policy compliance or guarantee serving. Inspect access, required properties, region/category eligibility and manual actions as well.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Review the guidelines again to identify if your content isn't compliant with the guidelines. The problem can be caused by either spammy content or spammy markup usage. However, the issue may not be a syntax issue, and so the Rich Results Test won't be able to identify these issues.”

D77 · Structured data carousels (beta) · Troubleshooting

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Google does not guarantee that features that consume structured data will show up in search results. For a list of common reasons why Google may not show your content in a rich result, see the General Structured Data Guidelines .”

D77 · Structured data carousels (beta) · Troubleshooting

QUESTION 539 · D77 Additional practice

Can an entity's logo satisfy the beta carousel's recommended item-image guidance?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

The guide says not to use logos in the item image property. Provide representative crawlable/indexable images; for best results it recommends at least 50K pixels and multiple 16:9, 4:3 and 1:1 versions.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE · EXACT EXCERPT

“image Repeated URL or ImageObject One or more images of the entity or item (for example, an image of the hotel). Don't include logos in this image property. Additional image guidelines: Image URLs must be crawlable and indexable. To check if Google can access your URLs, use the URL Inspection tool . Images must represent the marked up content. Images must be in a file”

D77 · Structured data carousels (beta) · Common list item properties (LocalBusiness , Product, or Event)

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE · EXACT EXCERPT

“Images must be in a file format that's supported by Google Images . For best results, we recommend providing multiple high-resolution images (minimum of 50K pixels when multiplying width and height) with the following aspect ratios: 16x9, 4x3, and 1x1. For example: "image": ["https://example.com/photos/1x1/photo.jpg", "https://example.com/photos/4x3/photo.jpg",

D77 · Structured data carousels (beta) · Common list item properties (LocalBusiness , Product, or Event)

QUESTION 540 · D77 Additional practice

How should a carousel rating of eight out of ten be distinguished from a default numeric rating?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

A plain number defaults to a five-point scale. Supply bestRating/worstRating for another numeric scale, or use a documented fraction/percentage whose scale is implied. Decimal numeric values use a dot, not a comma.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE · EXACT EXCERPT

“, or 6 / 10). Google understands the scale for fractions and percentages, since the scale is implied in the fraction itself or the percentage. The default scale for numbers is a 5-point scale, where 1 is the lowest value and 5 is the highest value. If another scale is intended, use bestRating and worstRating . For decimal numbers, use a dot instead of a comma to specify the value (for example 4.4 instead of”

D77 · Structured data carousels (beta) · Common list item properties (LocalBusiness , Product, or Event)

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE · EXACT EXCERPT

“in the fraction itself or the percentage. The default scale for numbers is a 5-point scale, where 1 is the lowest value and 5 is the highest value. If another scale is intended, use bestRating and worstRating . For decimal numbers, use a dot instead of a comma to specify the value (for example 4.4 instead of 4,4). In Microdata and RDFa, you can use content attributes to override the visible content. That way, you can show”

D77 · Structured data carousels (beta) · Common list item properties (LocalBusiness , Product, or Event)

QUESTION 541 · D77 Additional practice

Why might a verbose LocalBusiness priceRange disappear from a beta carousel?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

The guide specifies a relative price range and says the field must be shorter than 12 characters. Use the documented short price-level/range format; a long explanatory price sentence does not follow that display guidance.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“priceRange Text The relative price range of a business, commonly specified by a normalized number of currency signs. Provide the price range in either of the following formats: Price level: for example, "\$", "\$\$", "\$\$\$\$" Range: for example, "\$-\$ \$" This field must be shorter than 12 characters. If it's longer than 12 characters, Google won't show a price range for the business.”

D77 · Structured data carousels (beta) · LocalBusiness (and subtypes)

QUESTION 542 · D77 Additional practice

Can servesCuisine be attached indiscriminately to hotels and every LocalBusiness subtype?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

No. This beta guide lists servesCuisine for restaurants only. Use properties appropriate to the supported entity subtype rather than copying every recommendation into every item.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“servesCuisine Text For restaurants only : The type of cuisine the restaurant serves.”

D77 · Structured data carousels (beta) · LocalBusiness (and subtypes)

Add a Search profile badge to your website

Google last updated: 2026-09-16 · Reviewed 6 October 2026

<https://developers.google.com/search/docs/appearance/search-profiles>

Detailed points to revise

- A Search profile collects a publisher/creator's linked website and social-platform content in one Google destination.
- Users following the profile may see more of its linked content on Discover; this differs from a Preferred Sources badge for Top Stories/AI features.
- Claim the profile, obtain its profile.google.com/@handle URL and link from the site with the supplied badge or a text alternative.
- Preserve official icon colors/proportions/orientation and consistent monochrome/color styling; downloaded assets and brand rules apply.
- Touch targets should be at least 48×48 dp on Android and 44×44 px on iOS/web.
- When using both profile and Preferred Sources promotions, use the higher-emphasis labeled profile button, not the bare Super G icon, to keep their functions clear.
- The page gives an official help-community troubleshooting route; adding the badge is reader navigation, not a stated general ranking signal.

Complete source section checklist: How Search profiles work on Google · Add a Search profile badge to your website · Follow brand guidelines and best practices · Troubleshooting

QUESTION 543 · D78

How does following a Search profile affect discovery?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

The page says linked content from the profile, including websites and social platforms, becomes more likely to appear for that audience in Discover. This differs from the Preferred Sources feature.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“A Search profile brings together your content from across the web and social platforms into a single destination on Google. When readers follow your Search profile, it makes your content that's linked on your Search profile (such as your content on Instagram, TikTok, YouTube, X, Facebook, and your website) more likely to appear for your audience on Google Discover.”

D78 · Add a Search profile badge to your website · How Search profiles work on Google

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“If you're a website owner, you can help your audience find your publication as a preferred source in Google Search. When a user selects your site as a preferred source, your content is more likely to appear in "Top Stories", highlighted with a "preferred" badge. In AI Mode and AI Overviews, your content can be highlighted with a "preferred" badge for users who have selected your site as a preferred source.”

D65 · Help your readers find your site through preferred sources in Google Search · Help your readers find your site through preferred sources in Google Search

QUESTION 544 · D78

How do you add a Search profile badge to a site?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

Claim the profile, use its profile.google.com/@handle link, and add the documented official badge or accessible text-link alternative while respecting brand guidelines.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“After you've claimed your Search profile, you can encourage your audience to find your content from across the web by adding a Search profile badge to your website:”

D78 · Add a Search profile badge to your website · Add a Search profile badge to your website

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Find your Search profile URL. Use the following URL pattern, replacing handle with your profile handle: <https://profile.google.com/@handle>”

D78 · Add a Search profile badge to your website · Add a Search profile badge to your website

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Add the following HTML snippet to your site: `< a href = "https://profile.google.com/@ example " aria - label = "Find us on Google Search" > < img src = "/path/to/google-search-badge.svg" alt = "Google Search" > < / a >`

Alternative option: If you prefer a text link in article bylines, newsletters, or bio links, use the following snippet: `< a href = "https://profile.google.com/@ example " > Find us on Google Search < / a >`”

D78 · Add a Search profile badge to your website · Add a Search profile badge to your website

QUESTION 545 · D78

What design requirements apply to the profile badge?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

Preserve official artwork and use sufficiently large touch targets: 48×48 dp on Android and 44×44 px on iOS/web. When pairing with Preferred Sources, use the labeled profile button for distinction.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Ensure accessible touch targets: Keep the clickable target at least 48 × 48 dp on Android and 44 × 44 px on iOS and web.”

D78 · Add a Search profile badge to your website · Follow brand guidelines and best practices

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Preserve logo integrity: If you're using the official assets from Google, don't stretch, distort, rotate, or alter the colors of the "Super G" icon and Search profile button.”

D78 · Add a Search profile badge to your website · Follow brand guidelines and best practices

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Maintain badge clarity: If you want to use both the Search profile badge and Preferred Sources badge together, use the higher emphasis Search profile button with the label for clarity and distinction from the Preferred Sources badge. Don't use the "Super G" icon for the Search profile paired with the Preferred Sources badge.”

D78 · Add a Search profile badge to your website · Follow brand guidelines and best practices

QUESTION 546 · D78 Additional practice

Could a creator use a simple byline link instead of the graphical Search profile badge?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

Yes. The guide offers a text-link alternative for bylines, newsletters or bio links, pointing to the claimed profile URL. Following the profile relates to linked-content discovery; the visual badge is not mandatory for that text-link route.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Add the following HTML snippet to your site: < a href = "https://profile.google.com/@ example " aria - label = "Find us on Google Search" > < img src = "/path/to/google-search-badge.svg" alt = "Google Search" > < / a >
Alternative option: If you prefer a text link in article bylines, newsletters, or bio links, use the following snippet:
< a href = "https://profile.google.com/@ example " > Find us on Google Search < / a >”

D78 · Add a Search profile badge to your website · Add a Search profile badge to your website

Provide a site name to Google Search

Google last updated: 2025-12-10 · Reviewed 6 October 2026

<https://developers.google.com/search/docs/appearance/site-names>

Detailed points to revise

- A site name identifies the whole site; a title link describes an individual page. Names are automated from homepage information and references elsewhere on the web.
- Available in all Search languages on mobile and desktop, with one name per domain or subdomain. Subdirectories cannot have separate names; www and m subdomains are generally treated as equivalent to the domain.
- WebSite structured data on the root homepage is the most important preference signal. Google also considers og:site_name, the title element, headings and other homepage text.
- Choose a unique, accurate, concise, commonly recognized name; avoid misleading or generic keyword names. Keep homepage signals consistent. Long names can truncate; there is no documented fixed character limit.
- Required WebSite properties are name and url, with url set to the canonical root homepage. Do not place the markup only on an interior page or repeat it unnecessarily on every page.
- The homepage must be accessible to Google. Use identical site-name markup on duplicate HTTP/HTTPS or www/non-www homepages, and add these properties to an existing WebSite node rather than creating a second one.
- alternateName is optional and can contain multiple alternatives in preference order, including acronyms, shorter brands and a lowercase domain/subdomain fallback.
- Use Schema Markup Validator for syntax and URL Inspection for Google's access/rendering. Rich Results Test does not support site names. Request recrawling and allow days to weeks; internal pages also need processing.
- If the chosen name differs: verify required markup, content policies, consistency, root location, crawlability and redirects. An accessible redirect target determines the name; a domain name can be a last-resort preference. There is no manual change or guaranteed selection.
- Without subdomain homepage markup, the domain name may be used as fallback. The Google help community is the final documented troubleshooting route.

Complete source section checklist: Feature availability · How site names in Google Search are created · Choosing your site name · How to add a site name with structured data · Follow the guidelines · Technical guidelines · Add required site name properties · JSON-LD · Microdata · Add an alternative site name · JSON-LD · Microdata · Test structured data · What to do if your preferred site name isn't selected

How do site names differ from title links?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

The site name identifies the entire domain or subdomain; a title link identifies a particular web page. They have distinct signals and implementation guidance.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“When Google lists a page in search results, it shows the name of the site the page comes from. This is called the site name. Note that the site name is different from the per-page title links (title links are specific to each web page, whereas the site name is for the entire site).”

D79 · Provide a site name to Google Search · Provide a site name to Google Search

Can example.com/news have its own Google site name?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

No. Separate site names are supported at domain and subdomain level, not subdirectory level. www and m subdomains are generally treated as equivalent to the domain.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE · EXACT EXCERPT

“one name per site: Currently, Google Search only supports one site name per site, where a site is defined by the domain or subdomain. Google Search does not support site names at the subdirectory level. Note that subdomain names starting with www or m are generally considered as being equivalent. Supported : https://example.com (this is a domain-level home page) Supported : https://www.example.com (this is also”

D79 · Provide a site name to Google Search · Technical guidelines

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE · EXACT EXCERPT

“where a site is defined by the domain or subdomain. Google Search does not support site names at the subdirectory level. Note that subdomain names starting with www or m are generally considered as being equivalent. Supported : https://example.com (this is a domain-level home page) Supported : https://www.example.com (this is also considered to be a domain-level home page) Supported :”

D79 · Provide a site name to Google Search · Technical guidelines

QUESTION 549 · D79

What is the main way to express a site-name preference?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

Add WebSite structured data on the root homepage, with required name and canonical-homepage url. Keep the name consistent with og:site_name, titles, headings and visible homepage text.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“To indicate your site name preference, add WebSite structured data to your home page. Our site name system will also consider content in og:site_name , <title> , heading elements, and other text on a home page. However, WebSite structured data is most important, if you want to specify a preference.”

D79 · Provide a site name to Google Search · How site names in Google Search are created

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“url URL The URL of the home page of the site. Set this to the canonical home page of your site's domain or subdomain. For example, https://example.com/ or https://news.example.com/ .”

D79 · Provide a site name to Google Search · Add required site name properties

QUESTION 550 · D79

Where should site-name markup go if there are duplicate homepages?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

On all duplicate homepages with consistent values, including HTTP/HTTPS and www/non-www copies. Add the name properties to an existing WebSite node when present.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“For sites with duplicate home pages: If you have duplicate home pages for the same content (for example, HTTP and HTTPS versions of your home page, or www and non-www), make sure that you're using the same structured data on all page duplicates, not just on the canonical page.”

D79 · Provide a site name to Google Search · Technical guidelines

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“If you already have WebSite structured data on your site , make sure that you nest the site name properties in the same node. In other words, avoid creating an additional WebSite structured data block on your home page if you can help it.”

D79 · Provide a site name to Google Search · Technical guidelines

QUESTION 551 · D79

Why does Rich Results Test not confirm my site name?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

Site names are not supported by that tool. Use a schema validator for syntax, then URL Inspection to check access and rendering; recrawl and processing may take days to weeks.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Validate your markup with a schema testing tool (for example, Schema Markup Validator) to make sure there are no syntax errors. Site names aren’t supported in the Rich Results Test.”

D79 · Provide a site name to Google Search · Test structured data

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“If the page looks okay, you can ask Google to recrawl your URL . Allow time for re-crawling and re-indexing. Remember that it can take anywhere from a few days to a few weeks after publishing a page for Google to find and crawl it.”

D79 · Provide a site name to Google Search · Test structured data

QUESTION 552 · D79

What does alternateName do?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

It supplies optional alternative site-name preferences, such as an acronym or shorter brand, in preferred order. A lowercase domain can be included as a fallback; selection remains automated.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE · EXACT EXCERPT

“for your site), if applicable. Make sure the name meets the guidelines for choosing your site name . You can list more than one alternative name. Specify them in order of your preference, with the most important one listed first. For example: < script type = "application/ld+json" > { "@context" : "https://schema.org" , "@type" : "WebSite" , "name" : "Burnt Toast" , "alternateName" : ["BT" , "B-T" ,

D79 · Provide a site name to Google Search · Add an alternative site name

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE · EXACT EXCERPT

“To provide your domain or subdomain as a backup option, add your domain or subdomain name as your alternative name . Your domain or subdomain needs to be in all lowercase (for example, example.com not Example.com) for our system to detect this as a site name preference. Our system will strongly consider using it if your preferred name isn't selected. In this example, Burnt Toast is the”

D79 · Provide a site name to Google Search · What to do if your preferred site name isn't selected

QUESTION 553 · D79

How would you investigate an incorrect site name after a redirect?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

Check that Googlebot can access the intended target, that its homepage markup and visible branding agree, and that all variants are consistent. The displayed name reflects the accessible redirect target; request recrawling and allow processing.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Make sure your redirects are working as intended and that Googlebot can access the redirect target. Then request a recrawl of that page . If your page redirects to a page that's visible to Googlebot, the site name will reflect the redirect target.”

D79 · Provide a site name to Google Search · What to do if your preferred site name isn't selected

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE · EXACT EXCERPT

“) to make sure that there are no syntax errors (the Rich Results Test doesn't support site names). Your structured data follows our guidelines . Confirm that other sources on your home page also use the preferred name for your site. Confirm that you're not trying to set up a site name for a subdirectory. Site names aren't supported for subdirectories (for example, <https://example.com/news> is a”

D79 · Provide a site name to Google Search · What to do if your preferred site name isn't selected

QUESTION 554 · D79 Additional practice

The homepage shows the new site name but inner results still show the old one. What timing distinction matters?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

Google also needs time to recrawl and process internal pages. A corrected homepage preference does not guarantee all internal result displays update immediately; verify consistency and allow that separate processing.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“If you've updated your site name structured data, allow time for Google to recrawl and process the new information. Remember that crawling can take anywhere from several days to several weeks, depending on how often our systems determine content needs to be refreshed. You can request a recrawl of a page by using the URL Inspection tool . Not seeing your preferred site name for internal pages? If your home page is already showing your preferred site name, remember to also allow time for Google to recrawl and process your internal pages.”

D79 · Provide a site name to Google Search · What to do if your preferred site name isn't selected

What fallback may be used when a subdomain homepage has no site-name markup?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

The guide says the domain-level site name may be used for the subdomain. Add the appropriate WebSite preference on the subdomain root homepage if a distinct eligible name is intended.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Structured data must be on the home page of a site: The WebSite structured data must be on the home page of the site. By home page, we mean the domain or subdomain level root URI. For example, <https://example.com> is the home page of the domain, while <https://example.com/de/index.html> isn't the home page. Note : If there's no structured data on the subdomain's home page, then the domain-level site name may be used for the subdomain as a fallback.”

D79 · Provide a site name to Google Search · Technical guidelines

Sitelinks

Google last updated: 2025-12-10 · Reviewed 6 October 2026

<https://developers.google.com/search/docs/appearance/sitelinks>

Detailed points to revise

- Sitelinks are same-domain links clustered under a text result, selected automatically from site link structure to help users find shortcuts.
- They appear only when Google judges them useful and query-relevant; unsuitable structure or weak relevance can mean none are shown.
- Improve informative, relevant, compact page titles and headings; maintain logical navigation; link important pages from relevant pages; use concise relevant anchors; avoid repetitive content.
- There is no documented manual selection mechanism. To remove an unwanted destination, Google suggests removing the page or applying noindex; consider the effect on that page's ordinary Search visibility as well.

Complete source section checklist: Sitelinks best practices

QUESTION 556 · D80 Priority practice

Can an SEO manually choose Google sitelinks?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

The current guide says sitelinks are automated. Google evaluates site structure and query usefulness; these practices influence quality rather than guaranteeing chosen links.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“At the moment, sitelinks are automated. We're always working to improve our sitelinks algorithms, and we may incorporate site owner input in the future. There are best practices you can follow, however, to improve the quality of your sitelinks.”

D80 · Sitelinks · Sitelinks best practices

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“We only show sitelinks for results when we think they'll be useful to the user. If the structure of your site doesn't allow our algorithms to find good sitelinks, or we don't think that the sitelinks for your site are relevant for the user's query, we won't show them.”

D80 · Sitelinks · Sitelinks

Which site changes can improve sitelink quality?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

Use compact informative titles/headings, logical navigation, links to important pages from relevant pages, concise relevant internal anchors and less repeated content.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Create a logical site structure that is easy for users to navigate, and make sure you link to your important pages from other relevant pages.”

D80 · Sitelinks · Sitelinks best practices

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Ensure that your internal links' anchor text is concise and relevant to the page they're pointing to.”

D80 · Sitelinks · Sitelinks best practices

How does Google suggest removing an unwanted sitelink?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

Remove the destination page or use noindex. Treat these as changes to the page itself, not as a harmless sitelink-only preference.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“If you need to remove a sitelink, consider removing the page from your site or using noindex .”

D80 · Sitelinks · Sitelinks best practices

Why might clear site navigation still produce no sitelinks for a particular query?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

Google only shows sitelinks when useful and relevant to that query. Good structure helps its systems find shortcuts but does not guarantee sitelinks on every result or query.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“We only show sitelinks for results when we think they'll be useful to the user. If the structure of your site doesn't allow our algorithms to find good sitelinks, or we don't think that the sitelinks for your site are relevant for the user's query, we won't show them.”

D80 · Sitelinks · Sitelinks

Control your snippets in search results

Google last updated: 2026-04-20 · Reviewed 6 October 2026

<https://developers.google.com/search/docs/appearance/snippet>

Detailed points to revise

- Snippets summarize a result. They are automated primarily from page content, vary by query, and may use the meta description when it provides a better description; Google cannot manually change individual snippets.
- nosnippet suppresses snippets, max-snippet supplies a maximum text length, and data-nosnippet excludes specified page portions.
- Meta descriptions should summarize the specific page accurately and persuasively. There is no Google-mandated fixed character limit; displayed snippets can truncate to device width.
- Prefer unique page descriptions; a broader site description fits a homepage or aggregation page. If time is limited, prioritize the homepage and other important/popular URLs.
- Descriptions can contain relevant labeled facts such as author, publication date, price, manufacturer or book length; they need not be written as a single sentence.
- Database-driven sites can generate descriptions programmatically using actual page-specific data. They should be human-readable, diverse and useful; long keyword lists are poor substitutes.
- The examples contrast keyword lists, repeated generic news copy, unrelated personal anecdotes and overly brief product text with specific summaries and helpful details.
- A Read more deep link can lead from a snippet to a page section. Keep the target content immediately visible, avoid forced scroll position on load, and preserve URL hash fragments when using History API or window.location.hash.

Complete source section checklist: How snippets are created · How to prevent snippets or adjust snippet length · Best practices for creating quality meta descriptions · Create unique descriptions for each page on your site · Include relevant information about the content in the description · Programmatically generate descriptions · Use quality descriptions · Best practices for "Read more" deep links in Google Search

QUESTION 560 · D81

Priority practice

Why can one page have different snippets for different searches?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

Google builds snippets primarily from page content to suit the query, and sometimes uses the meta description when it is more accurate. The description is a preference, not a fixed rendered snippet.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Snippets are automatically created from page content. Snippets are designed to emphasize and preview the page content that best relates to a user's specific search. This means that Google Search might show different snippets for different searches.”

D81 · Control your snippets in search results · How snippets are created

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Snippets are primarily created from the page content itself. However, Google sometimes uses the meta description HTML element if it might give users a more accurate description of the page than content taken directly from the page.”

D81 · Control your snippets in search results · How snippets are created

QUESTION 561 · D81 Priority practice

Does Google require meta descriptions to be exactly 155 or 160 characters?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

No. This guide specifies no length limit and says displayed snippets truncate as needed, typically to fit device width. Write a useful concise summary rather than treating a common tooling target as Google's rule.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE · EXACT EXCERPT

“relevant summary of what a particular page is about. They are like a pitch that convince the user that the page is exactly what they're looking for. There's no limit on how long a meta description can be, but the snippet is truncated in Google Search results as needed, typically to fit the device width.”

D81 · Control your snippets in search results · Best practices for creating quality meta descriptions

QUESTION 562 · D81

How can you control an entire snippet versus one sensitive passage?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

Use nosnippet to prevent a snippet, max-snippet for a maximum length, or data-nosnippet on the specific content to exclude that portion.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“You can prevent snippets from being created and shown for your site in search results, or let Google know about the maximum lengths that you want your snippets to be. To prevent Google from displaying a snippet for your page in search results, use the nosnippet meta tag . To specify the maximum length for your snippets, use the max-snippet: [number] meta tag. You can also prevent certain parts of the page from being shown in a snippet by using the data-nosnippet attribute.”

D81 · Control your snippets in search results · How to prevent snippets or adjust snippet length

QUESTION 563 · D81

Are automatically generated meta descriptions acceptable?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

Yes, particularly for large database-driven sites, if based on page-specific data and written to be accurate, diverse and human-readable. Keyword strings are less helpful and less likely to be used.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“For some sites, like news media sources, generating an accurate and unique description for each page is easy: since each article is hand-written, it takes minimal effort to also add a one-sentence description. For larger database-driven sites, like product aggregators, hand-written descriptions can be impossible. In the latter case, however, programmatic generation of the descriptions can be appropriate and are encouraged. Good descriptions are human-readable and diverse. Page-specific data is a good candidate for programmatic generation.”

D81 · Control your snippets in search results · Programmatically generate descriptions

QUESTION 564 · D81

What should you prioritize when thousands of descriptions are missing?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

Create accurate descriptions for critical URLs first, including the homepage and popular pages, and use specific page-level descriptions rather than one generic description everywhere.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Identical or similar descriptions on every page of a site aren't helpful when individual pages appear in search results. Wherever possible, create descriptions that accurately describe the specific page. Use site-level descriptions on the main home page or other aggregation pages, and use page-level descriptions everywhere else. If you don't have time to create a description for every single page, try to prioritize your content; at the very least, create a description for the critical URLs like your home page and popular pages.”

D81 · Control your snippets in search results · Create unique descriptions for each page on your site

QUESTION 565 · D81

Does a good meta description have to be a sentence?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

No. Useful labeled facts, such as author, date, price or manufacturer, can bring important scattered information together if they accurately describe the page.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“The meta description doesn't just have to be in sentence format; it's also a great place to include information about the page. For example, news or blog postings can list the author, date of publication, or byline information. This can give potential visitors very relevant information that might not be displayed in the snippet otherwise. Similarly, product pages might have the key bits of information—price, age, manufacturer—scattered throughout a page. A good meta description can bring all this data together.”

D81 · Control your snippets in search results · Include relevant information about the content in the description

QUESTION 566 · D81

What can prevent a Read more snippet deep link from working?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

Hidden accordion/tab content, JavaScript that forces the scroll position, or page-load History API/hash changes that remove the URL fragment. Make the target immediately visible and preserve the deep link.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Make sure content is immediately visible on the page to a human (and not hidden behind an expandable section or tabbed interface, for example).”

D81 · Control your snippets in search results · Best practices for “Read more” deep links in Google Search

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Avoid using JavaScript to control the user's scroll position on page load (for example, don't force the user's scroll position to the top of the page).”

D81 · Control your snippets in search results · Best practices for “Read more” deep links in Google Search

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“If you make history API calls or window.location.hash modifications on page load, make sure you don't remove the hash fragment from the URL, as this breaks deep linking behavior.”

D81 · Control your snippets in search results · Best practices for “Read more” deep links in Google Search

What can an SEO do when a CMS does not expose raw HTML for meta descriptions?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

Check the CMS's search-engine settings or supported mechanism for editing metadata, and use its documented head/meta-tag implementation. The Google guide notes that direct HTML editing is not always available or necessary.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

"If you use a CMS, such as Wix, WordPress, or Blogger , you might not be able to edit your HTML directly, or you might prefer not to. Instead, your CMS might have a search engine settings page or some other mechanism to tell search engines about meta tags."

D81 · Control your snippets in search results · Best practices for creating quality meta descriptions

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

"If you want to add a meta tag to your website, search for instructions about modifying the <head> of your page on your CMS (for example, search for "wix add meta tags")."

D81 · Control your snippets in search results · Best practices for creating quality meta descriptions

Which is the better description for a cooking tutorial: a personal story about eggs or a summary of the methods taught?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

Summarize the actual tutorial and its useful scope. Google's examples favor a complete cooking-method summary over an unrelated anecdote; the description should explain the page, not merely mention the topic.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

"Better (summarizes the whole page) :"

D81 · Control your snippets in search results · Use quality descriptions

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

"Bad (doesn't summarize the page) :"

D81 · Control your snippets in search results · Use quality descriptions

Introduction to structured data markup in Google Search

Google last updated: 2025-12-10 · Reviewed 6 October 2026

<https://developers.google.com/search/docs/appearance/structured-data/intro-structured-data>

Detailed points to revise

- Structured data provides standardized page information and can help Google understand entities/content and enable richer result appearances. Google's case studies are examples, not guaranteed performance lifts.
- Put accurate markup on the page it describes; do not use a blank or content-invisible page as a container. Include all required properties and suitable recommended properties; fewer complete accurate fields beat inaccurate expansion.
- Google Search Central documentation is definitive for Google's Search behavior even though most vocabulary comes from schema.org. Not every vocabulary property is needed for Google; data-vocabulary.org support is retired.
- JSON-LD, Microdata and RDFa are supported. JSON-LD is recommended for easier maintenance, and Google can read dynamically injected JSON-LD in rendered content; properly implemented supported formats work.
- Structured data must reflect visible content and meet general plus feature-specific policies. Passing tests cannot guarantee a rich result.
- Develop with Rich Results Test, check deployed URLs and rich-result status reports in Search Console, and monitor errors/valid items.
- A business experiment can compare selected stable pages before/after adding markup using Performance reports; pick nonseasonal pages, keep other changes limited and allow enough time, potentially several months, to reduce misleading comparisons.
- The recipe example demonstrates how marked ingredients and preparation details give Google context; the complete original examples are retained in the reference.

Complete source section checklist: Why add structured data to a page? · How structured data works in Google Search · Structured data vocabulary and format · Supported formats · Structured data guidelines · Get started with structured data · Measuring the effect of structured data

QUESTION 569 · D82 Priority practice

What does structured data do for Google Search?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

It provides standardized information about the page and its content so Google can understand it and potentially enable supported rich appearances. Case-study improvements are examples, not a universal expected lift.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Google uses structured data that it finds on the web to understand the content of the page, as well as to gather information about the web and the world in general, such as information about the people, books, or companies that are included in the markup. For example, when a recipe page has JSON-LD structured data (describing the title of the recipe, the author of the recipe, and other details), Google Search can use that information to display a rich result for the recipe.”

D82 · Introduction to structured data markup in Google Search · How structured data works in Google Search

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Adding structured data can enable search results that are more engaging to users and might encourage them to interact more with your website, which are called rich results . Here are some case studies of websites that have implemented structured data for their site:”

D82 · Introduction to structured data markup in Google Search · Why add structured data to a page?

QUESTION 570 · D82 Priority practice

Which structured-data documentation takes priority for Google behavior?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

Google Search Central's feature documentation is definitive for Google Search; schema.org supplies broader vocabulary, and not all of its properties are necessary or supported for a particular Google result.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“This documentation describes which properties are required, recommended, or optional for structured data with special meaning to Google Search. Most Search structured data uses schema.org vocabulary, but you should rely on the Google Search Central documentation as definitive for Google Search behavior, rather than the schema.org documentation. There are more attributes and objects on schema.org that aren't required by Google Search; they may be useful for other search engines, services, tools, and platforms.”

D82 · Introduction to structured data markup in Google Search · Structured data vocabulary and format

QUESTION 571 · D82

Which structured-data formats does Google support and recommend?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

JSON-LD, Microdata and RDFa are supported. JSON-LD is recommended for easier maintenance, while correctly implemented supported formats are usable; JavaScript-generated JSON-LD can be read when present in rendered content.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Google Search supports structured data in the following formats, unless documented otherwise. In general, we recommend using a format that's easiest for you to implement and maintain (in most cases, that's JSON-LD); all 3 formats are equally fine for Google, as long as the markup is valid and properly implemented per the feature's documentation.”

D82 · Introduction to structured data markup in Google Search · Supported formats

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“In general, Google recommends using JSON-LD for structured data if your site's setup allows it, as it's the easiest solution for website owners to implement and maintain at scale (in other words, less prone to user errors).”

D82 · Introduction to structured data markup in Google Search · Supported formats

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“JSON-LD * (Recommended) A JavaScript notation embedded in a <script> tag in the <head> and <body> elements of an HTML page. The markup is not interleaved with the user-visible text, which makes nested data items easier to express, such as the Country of a PostalAddress of a MusicVenue of an Event . Also, Google can read JSON-LD data when it is dynamically injected into the page's contents , such as by JavaScript code or embedded widgets in your content management system.”

D82 · Introduction to structured data markup in Google Search · Supported formats

QUESTION 572 · D82

Should you add many speculative recommended fields or fewer accurate ones?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

Meet every required property and add applicable accurate recommendations. The guide prefers fewer complete accurate properties to a larger set of missing, incomplete or inaccurate values.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“You must include all the required properties for an object to be eligible for appearance in Google Search with enhanced display. In general, defining more recommended features can make it more likely that your information can appear in Search results with enhanced display. However , it is more important to supply fewer but complete and accurate recommended properties rather than trying to provide every possible recommended property with less complete, badly-formed, or inaccurate data.”

D82 · Introduction to structured data markup in Google Search · Structured data vocabulary and format

QUESTION 573 · D82

Can you put all structured data on a separate blank page?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

No. Mark up the relevant visible content on the page it describes. Do not create blank pages solely to hold markup or describe information users cannot see.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Structured data is coded using in-page markup on the page that the information applies to. The structured data on the page describes the content of that page. Don't create blank or empty pages just to hold structured data, and don't add structured data about information that is not visible to the user, even if the information is accurate. For more technical and quality guidelines, see the Structured data general guidelines .”

D82 · Introduction to structured data markup in Google Search · How structured data works in Google Search

QUESTION 574 · D82

How would you measure a structured-data implementation's business impact?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

Choose suitable stable pages, compare their Search Console Performance before and after implementation, avoid seasonal noise and allow sufficient time. This is a practical evaluation design; an observed change does not by itself prove markup caused it.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Take some pages on your site that are not using any structured data, and have several months of data in Search Console. Be sure to choose pages that won't be affected by the time of year or timeliness of the page content; use pages that won't change much, but are still popular enough to be read often enough to generate meaningful data.”

D82 · Introduction to structured data markup in Google Search · Measuring the effect of structured data

QUESTION 575 · D82 Additional practice

Does recommended JSON-LD have to appear in the head, or can it appear in the body?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

The supported-format description allows a JSON-LD script in either head or body. Keep it on the relevant content page, valid and consistent with the feature documentation; head placement alone is not the deciding eligibility condition.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“JSON-LD * (Recommended) A JavaScript notation embedded in a <script> tag in the <head> and <body> elements of an HTML page. The markup is not interleaved with the user-visible text, which makes nested data items easier to express, such as the Country of a PostalAddress of a MusicVenue of an Event . Also, Google can read JSON-LD data when it is dynamically injected into the page's contents , such as by JavaScript code or embedded widgets in your content management system.”

D82 · Introduction to structured data markup in Google Search · Supported formats

QUESTION 576 · D82 Additional practice

Why should deployed structured data be monitored even after a successful development test?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

Templating or serving changes can break markup after deployment. The guide pairs Rich Results Test during development with Search Console rich-result status reports afterward, so validation is an ongoing deployment concern.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Be sure to check your structured data using the Rich Results Test during development, and the Rich result status reports after deployment, to monitor the validity of your pages, which might break after deployment due to templating or serving issues.”

D82 · Introduction to structured data markup in Google Search · Structured data vocabulary and format

General structured data guidelines

Google last updated: 2026-07-10 · Reviewed 6 October 2026

<https://developers.google.com/search/docs/appearance/structured-data/sd-policies>

Detailed points to revise

- General guidelines plus the relevant feature guide determine rich-result eligibility. A passing Rich Results Test is insufficient because many quality/content issues are not easily testable.
- A structured-data manual action can remove rich-result eligibility without changing ordinary web Search ranking; validate the distinction before describing it as a universal ranking penalty.
- Valid markup may not show because context, user/location/device/history, page focus, hidden/misleading content, feature guidelines or other quality considerations affect display. Rich results are not guaranteed.
- Use JSON-LD, Microdata or RDFa and keep relevant pages accessible: no robots blocking, noindex or login requirement that prevents Google from seeing them.
- Content must be original where appropriate, relevant, current and visible. Avoid fake or misleading reviews, impersonation, deceptive engagement, spam and markup of irrelevant/off-topic content.
- Include every required property and useful applicable recommendations; choose the most specific appropriate schema.org type. More fields alone do not prove compliance.
- Put markup on the relevant page, including duplicate versions of that page, and use crawlable/indexable relevant image URLs when a feature requires images.
- Multiple items can be nested or supplied separately. Related items can be connected with @id; supply the main content type and complete markup for visible items rather than describing a peripheral item alone.
- Google checks spam/content policies and feature-specific restrictions in addition to syntax. The full list of quality headings and example cases remains in the reference.

Complete source section checklist: Technical guidelines · Format · Access · Quality guidelines · Content · Relevance · Completeness · Location · Specificity · Images · Multiple items on a page · Nesting · Individual items · Additional tips

QUESTION 577 · D83 Priority practice

Does valid structured data guarantee a rich result?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

No. Google also evaluates quality, page relevance, feature policies and search context. Some quality issues cannot be detected by Rich Results Test.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Important: Google does not guarantee that your structured data will show up in search results, even if your page is marked up correctly according to the Rich Results Test . Here are some common reasons why:”

D83 · General structured data guidelines · General structured data guidelines

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“These quality guidelines are not easily testable using an automated tool. Violating a quality guideline can prevent syntactically correct structured data from being displayed as a rich result in Google Search, or possibly cause it to be marked as spam .”

D83 · General structured data guidelines · Quality guidelines

QUESTION 578 · D83 Priority practice

Does a structured-data manual action automatically lower ordinary web ranking?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

The general guide says it affects rich-result eligibility and doesn't affect how the page ranks in Google web search. Diagnose the actual manual action and Search appearance effect precisely.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“If your page contains a structured data issue , it can result in a manual action. A structured data manual action means that a page loses eligibility for appearance as a rich result; it doesn't affect how the page ranks in Google web search. To check if you have a manual action, open the Manual Actions report in Search Console .”

D83 · General structured data guidelines · General structured data guidelines

QUESTION 579 · D83

What quality problems can invalidate otherwise syntactically correct markup?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

Hidden, misleading, stale or unrelated data; fake reviews; impersonation; spam or failure to satisfy the feature's content rules. Mark up the real visible current focus of the page.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Don't mark up content that is not visible to readers of the page. For example, if the JSON-LD markup describes a performer, the HTML body must describe that same performer.”

D83 · General structured data guidelines · Content

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Don't mark up irrelevant or misleading content, such as fake reviews or content unrelated to the focus of a page.”

D83 · General structured data guidelines · Content

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Provide up-to-date information. We won't show a rich result for time-sensitive content that is no longer relevant.”

D83 · General structured data guidelines · Content

QUESTION 580 · D83

Where does structured data belong on duplicate pages?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

On the page it describes and on duplicate versions of the same content, rather than only the canonical version. Match visible content and the relevant feature requirements.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“If you have duplicate pages for the same content, we recommend placing the same structured data on all page duplicates, not just on the canonical page.”

D83 · General structured data guidelines · Location

QUESTION 581 · D83

How should multiple related items on a page be represented?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

They may be nested or separate. Connect related entities with @id where needed, include the main focus type, and provide complete markup for visible items rather than only an incidental entity.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Google Search understands multiple items on a page, whether you nest the items or specify each item individually.”

D83 · General structured data guidelines · Multiple items on a page

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Individual items : When each item is a separate block on the same page. If there are items that are more helpful when they are linked together (for example, a recipe and a video), use @id in both the recipe and the video items to specify that the video is about the recipe on the page. If you didn't link the items together, Google Search may not know that it can show the video as a Recipe rich result.”

D83 · General structured data guidelines · Multiple items on a page

QUESTION 582 · D83

What technical access conditions apply to structured-data images and pages?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

Google must be able to access the markup and relevant image URLs. Avoid robots/noindex/login restrictions that block eligibility, and use images relevant to the marked item.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Don't block your structured data pages to Googlebot using robots.txt, noindex , or any other access control methods.”

D83 · General structured data guidelines · Access

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“All image URLs specified in structured data must be crawlable and indexable. Otherwise, Google Search can't find and display them on the search results page. To check if Google can access your URLs, use the URL Inspection tool .”

D83 · General structured data guidelines · Images

QUESTION 583 · D83 Additional practice

A recipe page marks up only its video. What Search understanding could be missing?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

The policy guide recommends the main type reflecting the page's primary focus as well as relevant secondary types. Without Recipe data, Google may lack enough information to show it as a recipe rich result even if Video data is present.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE · EXACT EXCERPT

“is, include the main type of structured data that reflects the main focus of the page. For example, if a page is mainly about a recipe, make sure to include Recipe structured data in addition to Video and Review structured data. This is an opportunity for that page to be eligible for multiple search appearances (recipe rich results, video search, and review snippets). If the page only contained Video structured”

D83 · General structured data guidelines · Additional tips

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE · EXACT EXCERPT

“search appearances (recipe rich results, video search, and review snippets). If the page only contained Video structured data, Google Search wouldn't know enough about the page to also display it as a recipe rich result.”

D83 · General structured data guidelines · Additional tips

QUESTION 584 · D83 Additional practice

Can valid Event or JobPosting markup rescue information that is no longer current?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

No. The general policy requires up-to-date information and says time-sensitive content no longer relevant will not receive a rich result. Follow the exact feature guide as well; technical validity alone is insufficient.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Provide up-to-date information. We won't show a rich result for time-sensitive content that is no longer relevant.”

D83 · General structured data guidelines · Content

Enriched search results

Google last updated: 2025-12-10 · Reviewed 6 October 2026

<https://developers.google.com/search/docs/appearance/enriched-search-results>

Detailed points to revise

- Enriched search is a subset of rich results with added interaction, such as filtering job, recipe or event lists through supported attributes.
- Each applicable result is a complete main content item on a leaf/detail page rather than a category/listing page. This instruction is feature-specific; the regional beta host carousel instead requires a summary page.
- Include all required properties. Completeness is explicitly called one of the most important enriched-search ranking signals. More appropriate accurate recommendations can improve that experience; do not invent values to make a record look complete.
- Keep markup and content genuine, visible and complete, and avoid unrelated ancillary markup masquerading as a main result. Follow general structured-data and feature-specific content guidelines.
- Duplicates and large-scale poor-quality records can harm eligibility: Google may exclude an entire site from enriched results if a large proportion of its data is deficient.
- An identical job offered at multiple real locations is not automatically duplicate content simply because the descriptions match; preserve genuine location distinctions.
- These requirements concern eligibility/ranking within enriched features, not a promised boost to ordinary web rankings or a guarantee of display.

Complete source section checklist: Implementing enriched search · Enriched search types · Enriched search quality guidelines

QUESTION 585 · D84

Priority practice

What is an enriched search result?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

It is a richer subset of rich results that can support interactive filtering, such as jobs, recipes or events, using relevant structured attributes.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“In addition to standard rich results, Google Search supports a more interactive and enhanced class of rich result called enriched search results . Enriched search results often include an immersive experience or other advanced interaction feature. For example, here is a Jobs enriched result that might appear if a user searched for "jobs in United States":”

D84 · Enriched search results · Enriched search results

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Enriched search enables the user to search across the various properties of a structured data item; for example, a user might search for chicken soup recipes under 200 calories, or recipes that take less than 1 hour of preparation time.”

D84 · Enriched search results · Enriched search results

QUESTION 586 · D84 Priority practice

Does every structured-data feature need a detail page rather than a category page?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

No. This enriched-search guide calls for a main item on a leaf page; the regional beta carousel specifically uses a summary/category page. Apply the architecture for the exact feature, not one universal rule.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Leaf content: Enriched search is only available for leaf pages, not for listing pages. A leaf page is a page that describes the detailed properties of an item. A listing page, on the other hand, is a category page that links to multiple leaf pages. The following are examples of listing pages: A page that describes "10 best ideas for cooking turkey" with links out to each recipe. A page listing all the jobs at Mountain View, CA, with links to individual jobs.”

D84 · Enriched search results · Enriched search quality guidelines

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Your site must have a summary page and multiple detail pages. Currently, this feature isn't designed to support other scenarios, such as an all-in-one page where the "details" are anchor points within the same page.”

D77 · Structured data carousels (beta) · Guidelines

QUESTION 587 · D84

Can poor structured data affect an entire site's enriched eligibility?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

Yes. This guide says a large percentage of quality problems can lead to excluding the entire site from enriched results. A few valid records do not excuse a predominantly poor implementation.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“You must follow these spam policies to be eligible for enriched search. If the enriched search ranking algorithm decides that a large part of a site is not meeting the quality bar, it can exclude the entire site from enriched search results.”

D84 · Enriched search results · Enriched search quality guidelines

QUESTION 588 · D84

Are the same job descriptions in different locations always duplicates?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

No. The guide distinguishes identical jobs offered in multiple locations from inappropriate duplicate records. Use accurate location and job details rather than treating repeated wording alone as disqualifying.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“: Structured data is typically duplicated across many pages within a site, and for good reason. For example, you might post several Job listings for the same opening in multiple locations. These listings would have identical description values but different location values. The enriched search algorithm takes this into account, and these objects are not considered to be duplicates.”

D84 · Enriched search results · Implementing enriched search

QUESTION 589 · D84 Additional practice

What does this enriched-search guide say about completeness as a ranking consideration?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

It explicitly calls completeness one of the most important ranking signals for enriched search. Accurate additional fields can improve that feature's usefulness; do not turn this scoped statement into a guarantee of higher ordinary web rankings.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Completeness: The more additional (recommended) properties you provide, the higher quality the item is to our users. For a job posting, users prefer jobs with explicitly stated salaries than those without, and enriched search ranking also takes this into consideration. If your recipes have actual user reviews and genuine star ratings, that is also valuable to users of your site and enriched search. Completeness is one of the most important ranking signals for enriched search.”

D84 · [Enriched search results](#) · [Enriched search quality guidelines](#)

Generate structured data with JavaScript

Google last updated: 2025-12-10 · Reviewed 6 October 2026

<https://developers.google.com/search/docs/appearance/structured-data/generate-structured-data-with-javascript>

Detailed points to revise

- Google can process structured data present in the rendered DOM. Supported approaches include Google Tag Manager, custom JavaScript, server-side rendering and a CMS/plugin implementation.
- In GTM, a custom HTML tag can inject a JSON-LD script. Use variables populated from the page data to avoid maintaining separate hard-coded values that diverge from visible content; publish after testing.
- Custom JavaScript can fetch page-specific structured information and append a script element containing the returned structured-data text to the document. The source includes an API-fetch implementation example.
- JavaScript-generated Product markup can make shopping crawls less frequent or reliable, especially for rapidly changing price/availability. Plan server resources and implementation accordingly rather than assuming all JS markup performs identically.
- Rich Results Test URL input is recommended for JavaScript implementations; code-input testing has JavaScript/CORS and browser-context limitations.
- Test the deployed rendered page and resolve missing/incorrect properties and syntax errors. A valid/eligible message does not guarantee that a feature will show; unsupported types may require rendered-DOM inspection instead of rich-result validation.

Complete source section checklist: Use Google Tag Manager to generate JSON-LD dynamically · Using variables in Google Tag Manager · Generate structured data with custom JavaScript · Using server-side rendering · Test your implementation

QUESTION 590 · D85 Priority practice

Can Google read structured data added by JavaScript?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

Yes, when it is available in the rendered DOM. The guide covers GTM, custom JavaScript and other approaches; validate Google's rendered version rather than assuming the initial HTML contains it.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Another way you can generate structured data is by using JavaScript to either generate all of your structured data or add more information to the server-side rendered structured data. Either way, Google Search can understand and process structured data that's available in the DOM when it renders the page. To learn more about how Google Search processes JavaScript, check out the JavaScript basics guide .”

D85 · [Generate structured data with JavaScript](#) · [Generate structured data with custom JavaScript](#)

QUESTION 591 · D85 Priority practice

Why should GTM structured data use page variables instead of hard-coded duplicates?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

Separate static copies increase mismatch risk when the page changes. Variables based on the actual content help keep markup consistent with the information visible to users.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Google Tag Manager (GTM) supports variables to use information on the page as part of your structured data. Use variables to extract the structured data from the page instead of duplicating the information in GTM. Duplicating the information in GTM increases the risk of having a mismatch between page content and the structured data inserted using GTM.”

D85 · [Generate structured data with JavaScript](#) · [Using variables in Google Tag Manager](#)

QUESTION 592 · D85

What special concern applies to JavaScript Product markup?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

Dynamically generated Product data can make shopping crawls less frequent or reliable, which matters for fast-changing price and availability and server load. Test the real implementation and its freshness.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Be aware that dynamically-generated markup can make Shopping crawls less frequent and less reliable, which can be an issue for fast-changing content like product availability and price. If you're a merchant optimizing for all types of shopping results, make sure your server has enough computing resources to handle increased traffic from Google.”

D85 · [Generate structured data with JavaScript](#) · [Generate structured data with JavaScript](#)

QUESTION 593 · D85

Should you prefer URL or code input in Rich Results Test for JavaScript markup?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

Prefer URL input. Code input has JavaScript limitations, including CORS-related restrictions, and can miss behavior of the deployed page.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Enter the URL that you want to test. We recommend that you use the URL input instead of the code input because there are JavaScript limitations when using the code input (for example, CORS restrictions).”

D85 · Generate structured data with JavaScript · Test your implementation

QUESTION 594 · D85

What does a successful Rich Results Test actually establish?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

It establishes supported technical validity/eligibility checks for the tested markup, not guaranteed display. Fix reported errors and use rendered-output checks for types the tool does not support.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Important: Google does not guarantee that your structured data will show up in search results, even if your page is marked up correctly according to the Rich Results Test . Here are some common reasons why:”

D83 · General structured data guidelines · General structured data guidelines

QUESTION 595 · D85

Additional practice

A Recipe type is pasted into GTM with placeholders that have never been defined. What would you check?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

Define the variables supplying actual page values, install/publish the container and test the deployed rendered result. The example explicitly assumes recipe_name, recipe_image and recipe_author already exist; copying placeholder syntax alone does not supply the data.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“The previous sample assumes that you defined the variables”

D85 · Generate structured data with JavaScript · Using variables in Google Tag Manager

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“To add the tag to your website, publish your container in the Google Tag Manager interface.”

D85 · Generate structured data with JavaScript · Use Google Tag Manager to generate JSON-LD dynamically

QUESTION 596 · D85 Additional practice

Can server-rendered structured data and JavaScript-generated additions be used together?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

Yes. The guide describes JavaScript that generates all the data or adds to server-rendered data, and a separate SSR approach. Check the final rendered DOM and ensure the combined data is valid and matches the page.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Another way you can generate structured data is by using JavaScript to either generate all of your structured data or add more information to the server-side rendered structured data. Either way, Google Search can understand and process structured data that's available in the DOM when it renders the page. To learn more about how Google Search processes JavaScript, check out the JavaScript basics guide .”

D85 · Generate structured data with JavaScript · Generate structured data with custom JavaScript

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“If you are using server-side rendering , you can also include the structured data in the rendered output. Check the documentation of your framework to find out how to generate the JSON-LD for the type of structured data you're interested in.”

D85 · Generate structured data with JavaScript · Using server-side rendering

Structured data markup that Google Search supports

Google last updated: 2026-06-15 · Reviewed 6 October 2026

<https://developers.google.com/search/docs/appearance/structured-data/search-gallery>

Detailed points to revise

- The Search gallery is the current feature directory, with preview images and links to detailed implementation guides. Most supported features can be validated with Rich Results Test; not every schema.org type or Google appearance feature is supported by that tool.
- Current listed features are Article, Breadcrumb, Carousel, Course list, Dataset, Discussion forum, Education Q&A, Employer aggregate rating, Event, Image metadata, Job posting, Local business, Math solver, Movie, Organization, Product, Profile page, Q&A, Recipe, Review snippet, Software app, Speakable, Subscription/paywalled content, Vacation rental and Video.
- The traditional Carousel entry describes Recipe, Course list, Restaurant and Movie markup; this is distinct from the separate regional beta ItemList carousel guide.
- Product can surface price, availability and review information. Organization can support identification/logos/administrative details; Profile page concerns creator profiles and is not the same as adding a Search profile follow badge.
- FAQ and HowTo are not in this current gallery. Do not prepare from an old supported-feature checklist; absence alone is not a claim that every corresponding schema.org type is invalid vocabulary.
- Use the detailed linked guide for each feature's required/recommended properties, content rules and availability; this gallery does not reproduce every subguide's specification.

QUESTION 597 · D86

Priority practice

How do you check whether Google supports a particular structured-data search feature?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

Consult the current Search gallery, then the feature's official guide. Valid schema.org syntax alone is insufficient, and the gallery says most, rather than all, features can use Rich Results Test.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Google uses structured data to understand the content on the page and show that content in a richer appearance in search results, which is called a rich result . To make your site eligible for appearance as one of these rich results, follow the guide to learn how to implement structured data on your site. If you're just getting started, visit Understand how structured data works .”

D86 · Structured data markup that Google Search supports · Structured data markup that Google Search supports

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“: The actual appearance in search results might be different. You can preview most features with the Rich Results Test”

D86 · Structured data markup that Google Search supports · Structured data markup that Google Search supports

QUESTION 598 · D86

Priority practice

Which content types does the gallery's traditional Carousel entry list?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

Recipe, Course list, Restaurant and Movie. Do not confuse this entry with the separate regional beta host-carousel requirements.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Carousel Rich results that display in a sequential list or gallery from a single site. This feature must be combined with one of the following features: Recipe , Course list , Restaurant , Movie . Get started Food and Drink, Education and Science, Entertainment”

D86 · Structured data markup that Google Search supports · Structured data markup that Google Search supports

QUESTION 599 · D86

What useful attributes can Product results show?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

The gallery lists price, availability and review ratings, among other product information. Detailed eligibility belongs to the Product feature documentation, not a guarantee based only on adding the type.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Product Information about a product, including price, availability, and review ratings. Get started Ecommerce”

D86 · Structured data markup that Google Search supports · Structured data markup that Google Search supports

QUESTION 600 · D86

Is Profile page markup the same feature as a Search profile follow badge?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

No. The gallery's Profile page describes a person/organization-focused creator page, while the badge links readers to a claimed Search profile to follow it. Use each feature's own implementation guidance.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Profile page A page that primarily focuses on information about a single person or organization that is somehow affiliated with the overall website. Get started”

D86 · Structured data markup that Google Search supports · Structured data markup that Google Search supports

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“After you've claimed your Search profile , you can encourage your audience to find your content from across the web by adding a Search profile badge to your website:”

D78 · Add a Search profile badge to your website · Add a Search profile badge to your website

QUESTION 601 · D86 Additional practice

What is the purpose of the gallery's subscription/paywall structured-data entry?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

It helps Google distinguish genuine paywalled content from cloaking. Use that feature's detailed implementation rules rather than assuming a payment barrier alone tells Google how the content is served.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Subscription and paywalled content Indicate paywalled content on your site to help Google differentiate paywalled content from the practice of cloaking , which violates our spam policies . Get started News”

D86 · Structured data markup that Google Search supports · Structured data markup that Google Search supports

Influencing your title links in search results

Google last updated: 2025-12-10 · Reviewed 6 October 2026

<https://developers.google.com/search/docs/appearance/title-link>

Detailed points to revise

- Title links identify a result and influence how users understand relevance and decide to click. Google generates them automatically; the title element expresses a preference rather than an exact display instruction.
- Give every page a descriptive concise title. Avoid vague Home/Profile labels, unnecessary verbosity, keyword repetition, whole-site boilerplate and micro-boilerplate that hides distinctions such as seasons or product variants.
- There is no documented fixed title-element character limit; displayed title links truncate as needed for device width. Concise branding with a delimiter is useful, but a repeated brand may be omitted when already shown as the site name.
- Make the main visual title distinct and prominent, with a clear main heading. Multiple equally prominent titles can cause confusion and Google may choose the first.
- Keep the title's language and writing system aligned with primary page content; a mismatch, including transliteration, can lead Google to choose different text.
- Google considers title element, visible title, headings, og:title, prominent other text, on-page anchors, incoming link text and WebSite structured data.
- Crawling access matters: robots.txt can block content yet leave the URL indexed, causing Google to rely on off-page anchors. Use noindex when the goal is preventing indexing and ensure Google can see the rule.
- Flight prices change rapidly, so Google recommends omitting them from title elements and likely suppresses them in generated title links.
- Common rewrite reasons: half-empty title, obsolete dates, inaccurate scope, duplicate micro-boilerplate, no clear main title, language/script mismatch and repeated site names.
- Updates require recrawling and processing, often days to weeks. Google cannot manually change an individual site's title links; investigate page issues, query relevance and the help community if needed.

Complete source section checklist: Best practices for influencing title links · How title links in Google Search are created · Common issues and how Google manages them · Half-empty <title> elements · Obsolete <title> elements · Inaccurate <title> elements · Micro-boilerplate text in <title> elements · No clear main title · Mismatch of writing system or language used in <title> elements · Duplication of the site name in the <title> element · Submitting feedback about title links

Is the HTML title element guaranteed to be the title link?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

No. Google generates title links automatically from multiple sources, including visible titles, headings, og:title, other prominent text, anchors and WebSite data.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Google Search uses the following sources to automatically determine title links:”

D87 · Influencing your title links in search results · How title links in Google Search are created

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Content in og:title meta tags”

D87 · Influencing your title links in search results · How title links in Google Search are created

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“WebSite structured data”

D87 · Influencing your title links in search results · How title links in Google Search are created

Does Google impose a 60-character title limit?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

No. The guide says there is no limit on title-element length, while displayed title links truncate to fit the device. A concise descriptive title is a usability practice, not a universal character rule.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Write descriptive and concise text for your <title> elements. Avoid vague descriptors like "Home" for your home page, or "Profile" for a specific person's profile. Also avoid unnecessarily long or verbose text in your <title> elements. While there's no limit on how long a <title> element can be, the title link is truncated in Google Search results as needed, typically to fit the device width.”

D87 · Influencing your title links in search results · Best practices for influencing title links

QUESTION 604 · D87

Why might Google rewrite an old year in a title?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

An obsolete title can conflict with the updated prominent heading. Google may use the visible current date to better represent the page; update both sources consistently.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Obsolete <title> elements When the same page is used year-after-year for recurring information, but the <title> element didn't get updated to reflect the latest date. For example: <title> 2020 admissions criteria - University of Awesome </title> In this example, the page has a large, visible title that says "2021 admissions criteria", and the <title> element wasn't updated to the current date. Google Search may detect this inconsistency and uses the right date from the visible title on the page in the title link: 2021 admissions criteria - University of Awesome”

D87 · Influencing your title links in search results · Common issues and how Google manages them

QUESTION 605 · D87

How would you reduce rewrites on a large templated site?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

Provide page-specific descriptive titles, reduce boilerplate/keyword repetition, distinguish the main visual heading, and keep visible content, title language and dates consistent. Recrawl after fixing sources.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE · EXACT EXCERPT

“Avoid repeated or boilerplate text in <title> elements . It's important to have distinct text that describes the content of the page in the <title> element for each page on your site. Titling every page on a commerce site "Cheap products for sale", for”

D87 · Influencing your title links in search results · Best practices for influencing title links

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Make it clear which text is the main title for the page. Google looks at various sources when creating title links , including the main visual title, heading elements, and other large and prominent text, and it can be confusing if multiple headings carry the same visual weight and prominence. Consider ensuring that your main title is distinctive from other text on a page and stands out as being the most prominent on the page (for example, using a larger font, putting the title text in the first visible <h1> element on the page, etc).”

D87 · Influencing your title links in search results · Best practices for influencing title links

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE · EXACT EXCERPT

“Use the same language and writing system (meaning, the script or alphabet for a given language) as the primary content on your pages. For example, if a page is written in Hindi, make sure to also write the <title> element in Hindi (don't write title text in”

D87 · Influencing your title links in search results · Best practices for influencing title links

QUESTION 606 · D87

Can blocking crawling prevent the URL from getting a title link?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

No. The URL can still be indexed through links, and Google may build its title from external anchors if content is inaccessible. A noindex rule addresses indexing; robots.txt alone does not.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE · EXACT EXCERPT

“disallowing search engines from crawling your pages. Using the robots.txt protocol on your site can stop Google from crawling your pages, but it may not always prevent them from being indexed. For example, Google may index your page if we discover it by following a link from someone else's site. If we don't have access to the content on your page, we will rely on off-page content to generate the title link,”

D87 · Influencing your title links in search results · Best practices for influencing title links

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE · EXACT EXCERPT

“may index your page if we discover it by following a link from someone else's site. If we don't have access to the content on your page, we will rely on off-page content to generate the title link, such as anchor text from other sites. To prevent a URL from being indexed, you can use the noindex rule.”

D87 · Influencing your title links in search results · Best practices for influencing title links

QUESTION 607 · D87

Why should flight prices usually be omitted from titles?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

They can change every few minutes, leaving the displayed title price inconsistent with the landing page. Google says its systems will likely not show flight price information in title links.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Avoid including flight price information in <title> elements. Our systems will likely not show price information when generating title links for flight pages. This is because pricing for flights can change so fast (sometimes every few minutes), that what's shown in title links may not correspond to the actual price on the landing page.”

D87 · Influencing your title links in search results · Best practices for influencing title links

QUESTION 608 · D87

Why might the brand disappear from a title link?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

Google may omit a repeated domain-level site name when that name already appears separately in the result. Check the full result before assuming missing branding is a problem.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Duplication of the site name in the <title> element In the case of domain-level site names, Google may omit the site name from the title link, if it's repetitive with the site name that's already shown in the search result .”

D87 · Influencing your title links in search results · Common issues and how Google manages them

QUESTION 609 · D87

How quickly should a corrected title appear, and can Google manually set it?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

The guide gives days to weeks for recrawling/reprocessing, not an immediate deadline. Google cannot manually change individual title links; request recrawling and investigate source/query fit.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Keep in mind that Google has to recrawl and reprocess the page to notice updates to these sources, which may take a few days to a few weeks. If you've made changes, you can request that Google recrawl your pages .”

D87 · Influencing your title links in search results · How title links in Google Search are created

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“While we can't manually change title links for individual sites, we're always working to make them as relevant as possible. You can help improve the quality of the title link that's displayed for your page by following the best practices .”

D87 · Influencing your title links in search results · How title links in Google Search are created

If a title is only a separator and brand, what alternate source may Google use?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

For a half-empty title, the guide says Google can use header elements or other prominent page text to generate a useful title link. Supply a complete page-specific title and a clear visible heading.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Half-empty <title> elements When part of the title text is missing. For example: <title> | Site Name </title> Google Search looks at information in header elements or other large and prominent text on the page to produce a title link: Product Name | Site Name”

D87 · Influencing your title links in search results · Common issues and how Google manages them

A TV site gives every season the same title. How does this differ from an ordinary shared brand suffix?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

This is micro-boilerplate that omits an important page distinction. Google may insert the season from prominent visible text; include that distinction in each page's title while keeping the shared brand concise.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE · EXACT EXCERPT

“Micro-boilerplate text in <title> elements When there are repeated boilerplate text in <title> elements for a subset of pages within a site. For example, a television website has multiple pages that share the same <title> element that omits”

D87 · Influencing your title links in search results · Common issues and how Google manages them

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE · EXACT EXCERPT

“My so-called amazing TV show </title> <title> My so-called amazing TV show </title> <title> My so-called amazing TV show </title> Google Search can detect the season number used in large, prominent title text and insert the season number in the title link: Season 1 - My so-called amazing TV show Season 2 - My so-called amazing TV show Season 3 - My so-called amazing TV show”

D87 · Influencing your title links in search results · Common issues and how Google manages them

Translated results in Google Search

Google last updated: 2025-12-10 · Reviewed 6 October 2026

<https://developers.google.com/search/docs/appearance/translated-results>

Detailed points to revise

- Google can translate title links/snippets to fill local-language content gaps. Clicking a translated result opens a machine-translated version, with options to access the original result/page.
- Available on mobile and desktop in Arabic, Bengali, English, French, German, Gujarati, Hindi, Indonesian, Kannada, Korean, Malayalam, Marathi, Persian, Portuguese, Spanish, Tamil, Telugu, Thai, Turkish, Urdu and Vietnamese.
- Google says it does not host translated pages; the behavior is similar to opening through Google Translate or browser translation. JavaScript and embedded images usually work, but ad networks may need URL handling changes.
- No opt-in action is needed; applicability depends on user language. Monitor clicks/impressions with the Search Appearance filter in Search Console Performance.
- To opt out of all Google Search translation features, use `notranslate` in robots/googlebot metadata or an X-Robots-Tag HTTP header. This is a translation control, not an indexing block.

Complete source section checklist: Feature availability · How translated results work · Monitor performance in Search Console · Opting in or out of translated results

QUESTION 612 · D88 Priority practice

Do translated results require a publisher opt-in?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

No. Google can apply the feature across pages/results based on the user's language. Users can open a translated page or access the original.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“This feature is applicable across all pages and results based on the user's language. You don't need to do anything to opt in.”

D88 · Translated results in Google Search · Opting in or out of translated results

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“If the user clicks the translated title link, they’re presented with a page that’s been machine translated. Users also have an option to view the original search result, and access the entire page in the original language.”

D88 · Translated results in Google Search · How translated results work

QUESTION 613 · D88

Priority practice

Does a translated result mean Google permanently hosts a translated copy?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

The guide says Google does not host translated pages; opening one resembles using Google Translate or browser translation. JavaScript and embedded images are usually supported.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Google doesn’t host any translated pages. Opening a page through a translated result is no different than opening the original search result through Google Translate or using Chrome in-browser translation . This means that Javascript on the page is usually supported, as well as embedded images and other page features.”

D88 · Translated results in Google Search · How translated results work

QUESTION 614 · D88

How can you measure translated-result traffic?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

Use the Search Appearance filter in the Search Console Performance report to monitor clicks and impressions.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“To monitor clicks and impressions for translated results, you can use the Search Appearance filter in the Performance report .”

D88 · Translated results in Google Search · Monitor performance in Search Console

QUESTION 615 · D88

How do you opt out of Search translation features?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

Use notranslate in robots/googlebot metadata or the X-Robots-Tag response header. The guide says this opts out of all translation features in Google Search.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Translated results are like other translation-related features in Google Search. To opt out of all translation features in Google Search, use the notranslate rule , which can be implemented as a meta tag or an HTTP header:”

D88 · Translated results in Google Search · Opting in or out of translated results

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“HTTP/1.1 200 OK Date: Tue, 25 May 2010 21:42:43 GMT (...) X-Robots-Tag: notranslate (...)”

D88 · Translated results in Google Search · Opting in or out of translated results

QUESTION 616 · D88 Additional practice

Is Persian included in the documented translated-result languages, and is the feature desktop-only?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

Persian is in this page's supported list, and the feature is available on mobile and desktop. Availability does not mean every result in every query will be translated.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Currently, Google may translate results into the following languages: Arabic, Bengali, English, French, German, Gujarati, Hindi, Indonesian, Kannada, Korean, Malayalam, Marathi, Persian, Portuguese, Spanish, Tamil, Telugu, Thai, Turkish, Urdu, Vietnamese. It's available on mobile and desktop.”

D88 · Translated results in Google Search · Feature availability

Enabling your ad network to work with translation-related Google Search features

Google last updated: 2025-12-10 · Reviewed 6 October 2026

<https://developers.google.com/search/docs/appearance/ad-network-and-translation>

Detailed points to revise

- This implementation guide is for ad networks whose rendering or attribution depends on publisher URLs after Google Translate rewrites them.
- Decode the translated hostname: remove `.translate.goog`, split `_x_tr_enc` into its comma-delimited encodings, and prepend `_x_tr_hp` when present.
- If encoding 1 is listed and the name starts 1-, remove that prefix. If encoding 0 is listed and it starts 0-, remove it and set the internationalized-domain flag.
- Restore single hyphen word boundaries to dots, then double hyphens to literal hyphens. For an internationalized domain prepend `xn--`; Unicode conversion is optional. The exact regular expression and complete JavaScript example remain in the source.
- Reconstruct the source URL with the decoded hostname and remove `_x_tr_*` translation parameters. Preserve the original path, hash fragment and original query parameters.
- The test table includes ordinary domains, subdomains, literal hyphens, IDNs/emoji, combined encodings and long-hostname prefixes. It tests hostname decoding only, so URL preservation needs separate verification.

Complete source section checklist: Our approach · Convert the Google Translate URL to the original URL · Sample JavaScript code for decoding the hostname from a Google Translate URL · Reconstruct the URL · Test your code

QUESTION 617 · D89

Why might translated-page visits break an ad network's attribution?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

The network may rely on the publisher's original source URL, while the translation flow rewrites it. Decode the translated hostname and reconstruct the original URL for that integration.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

"If you run an ad network that relies on the publisher's source URL, you'll need to convert the Google Translate URL to make sure your ads are working properly. Follow these steps to decode the publisher's hostname:"

D89 · Enabling your ad network to work with translation-related Google Search features · Convert the Google Translate URL to the original URL

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“When users access translated content provided by Google Translate from within search results, Google retrieves the page from the publisher, rewrites the source URL, and translates the web page after the user clicks the translated result.”

D89 · Enabling your ad network to work with translation-related Google Search features · Our approach

QUESTION 618 · D89

What translation-specific fields must the decoder handle?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

The .translate.goog hostname transformation, `_x_tr_enc` encoding list and optional `_x_tr_hp` prefix. Follow the documented prefix/hyphen/IDN decoding order rather than replacing every hyphen indiscriminately.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE · EXACT EXCERPT

“Extract the domain prefix from the hostname, by removing the .translate.goog suffix. Split the `_x_tr_enc` parameter by the , (comma) character and save it as `encoding_list` . Prepend the value of the `_x_tr_hp` parameter to the domain prefix, if it exists. If `encoding_list` contains 1 and the output begins with 1- , remove the 1- prefix”

D89 · Enabling your ad network to work with translation-related Google Search features · Convert the Google Translate URL to the original URL

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE · EXACT EXCERPT

“the .translate.goog suffix. Split the `_x_tr_enc` parameter by the , (comma) character and save it as `encoding_list` . Prepend the value of the `_x_tr_hp` parameter to the domain prefix, if it exists. If `encoding_list` contains 1 and the output begins with 1- , remove the 1- prefix from the output of step 2. If `encoding_list` contains 0 and the output begins with 0- , remove the 0-”

D89 · Enabling your ad network to work with translation-related Google Search features · Convert the Google Translate URL to the original URL

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE · EXACT EXCERPT

“(regex) with the . (dot) character. Replace the -- (double hyphen) character with the - (hyphen) character. If `is_idn` is set to true , add the punycode prefix xn-- . Optional : Convert to Unicode.”

D89 · Enabling your ad network to work with translation-related Google Search features · Convert the Google Translate URL to the original URL

QUESTION 619 · D89

After decoding a hostname, what URL components must you preserve?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

Keep the original path, fragment and original query parameters, replace only the translated hostname and remove `_x_tr_*` translation parameters. The sample table alone does not verify this full reconstruction.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Remove all `_x_tr_*` parameters.”

D89 · Enabling your ad network to work with translation-related Google Search features · Reconstruct the URL

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“The following table can only be used to test the hostname decoding. You’ll need to ensure that the path, fragment, and original parameters of the URL are preserved as is.”

D89 · Enabling your ad network to work with translation-related Google Search features · Test your code

QUESTION 620 · D89

What does the source's proxyUrl test table actually validate?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

Hostname decoding, including subdomains, hyphens, IDNs and prefix cases. Additional checks must ensure the full reconstructed URL preserves path, query and fragment.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“The following table can only be used to test the hostname decoding. You’ll need to ensure that the path, fragment, and original parameters of the URL are preserved as is.”

D89 · Enabling your ad network to work with translation-related Google Search features · Test your code

QUESTION 621 · D89 Additional practice

Why should an ad network not decode every hyphen in a translated hostname into a dot?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

The guide distinguishes single-hyphen word boundaries from doubled hyphens representing literal hyphens, and also handles encoding prefixes and internationalized domains. Use its ordered decoding procedure and test fixtures instead of a blanket replacement.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE · EXACT EXCERPT

“begins with o- , remove the o- prefix from the output of step 3. If you removed the prefix, set is_idn to true . Otherwise, set is_idn to false . Replace /\b-\b/ (regex) with the . (dot) character. Replace the -- (double hyphen) character with the - (hyphen) character. If is_idn is set to true , add the punycode prefix xn-- . Optional : Convert to Unicode.”

D89 · Enabling your ad network to work with translation-related Google Search features · Convert the Google Translate URL to the original URL

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE · EXACT EXCERPT

“of step 3. If you removed the prefix, set is_idn to true . Otherwise, set is_idn to false . Replace /\b-\b/ (regex) with the . (dot) character. Replace the -- (double hyphen) character with the - (hyphen) character. If is_idn is set to true , add the punycode prefix xn-- . Optional : Convert to Unicode.”

D89 · Enabling your ad network to work with translation-related Google Search features · Convert the Google Translate URL to the original URL

Video SEO best practices

Google last updated: 2025-12-18 · Reviewed 6 October 2026

<https://developers.google.com/search/docs/appearance/video>

Detailed points to revise

- Videos can appear in main Search, Video mode, Images and Discover. Discovery, watch-page indexing, video indexing and specific rich-feature serving are separate stages.
- Use recognizable video/embed/iframe/object containers. JavaScript videos must exist in rendered HTML; keep a container even when media APIs fail. Do not require clicks/swipes/typing to load the video or fragment-only URLs to locate it.
- Structured data, video sitemaps and Open Graph metadata help discovery. An indexed well-performing watch page does not automatically mean its embedded video is indexed.
- A watch page's main purpose is viewing one video. News video pages, episodes and highlights fit; complementary product demos, review trailers or categories of equal videos do not. Non-watch pages can still qualify for text/image results with a video badge.
- Give each watch page a unique title/description. A video can appear on both a watch page and a complementary article; third-party embeds can be indexed on both the publisher page and the host's own page if each qualifies.
- Google lists 3GP, 3G2, ASF, AVI, DivX, M2V, M3U, M3U8, M4V, MKV, MOV, MP4, MPEG, OGV, QVT, RAM, RM, VOB, WebM, WMV and XAP. Data URLs are unsupported.
- Use a unique stable thumbnail URL per video; stable file URLs support previews/key moments and processing. Expiring CDN URLs can prevent indexing. Verified Googlebot can receive stable access where needed.
- Distinguish watch-page URL (sitemap loc), player URL (embedUrl/player_loc) and actual file URL (contentUrl/content_loc). They describe different resources.
- Thumbnail preferences can come from poster, thumbnail_loc/media:thumbnail, thumbnailUrl or og:video:image; keep the same URL across sources. Supported images: BMP/GIF/JPEG/PNG/WebP/SVG/AVIF, at least 60×30 pixels, preferably larger, accessible to Googlebot and Googlebot Images. At least 80% of pixels need alpha greater than 250.
- Structured metadata must match the real video and other metadata; provide unique thumbnailUrl, name and description. Paid access should use appropriate paywall markup so Google can find the video.
- Video previews require fetching actual video bytes; max-video-preview controls maximum preview duration. Markup does not guarantee a feature on every query.
- Key moments may be automatic. Publisher Clip segments give labels/start/end times in all Search languages; SeekToAction supplies a timestamp URL pattern in the listed 12 languages. YouTube descriptions can supply timestamps/labels. nosnippet opts out of key moments, including automatic ones.
- BroadcastEvent can enable a LIVE badge. For previews/key moments allow file/stream crawling, including M3U8, use stable supported contentUrl, and ensure both page host and video server have capacity. Verify CDN ownership if seeking crawl-error reports for its URL space.

- For urgent removal request removal of the watch page; make it permanent with 404, noindex or authentication. Other embedding pages require their own actions. A past expires/expiration_date suppresses video results while the page can remain a text result; omit expiry for nonexpiring videos.
- Geographic restrictions use regionsAllowed or ineligibleRegion, or one sitemap restriction with ISO country codes. allow with no countries means nowhere; deny with none means everywhere. Omit restrictions when none apply.
- SafeSearch depends on correct explicit-content labeling. Monitor Video indexing (video indexing reasons), Video rich results (markup), and Performance with Videos Search appearance (visibility); troubleshoot with the relevant report and URL Inspection.

Complete source section checklist: Help Google find your videos · Ensure your videos can be indexed · Use a supported video file type · Use stable URLs · Create a dedicated watch page for each video · Using third-party embedded players · Which URL is which? · Provide a high-quality video thumbnail · Provide consistent and unique information in your structured data · Enable specific video features · Video previews · Key moments · Live Badge · Allow Google to fetch your video files · Remove or restrict your videos · Remove a video · Restrict a video based on the user's location · Restrict using structured data · Restrict using a video sitemap · Optimize for SafeSearch · Monitor video watch pages with Search Console · Troubleshoot video issues

QUESTION 622 · D90 **Priority practice**

Why can an indexed page still have a video that is not indexed?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

Video indexing has separate requirements: an indexed well-performing watch page, a visible embedded video and a stable valid thumbnail, among others. Page indexing alone is insufficient.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“The indexed watch page must be performing well in Search before its video can be considered for indexing. Just because the watch page is indexed doesn't mean that the video will also be indexed.”

D90 · Video SEO best practices · Ensure your videos can be indexed

QUESTION 623 · D90 **Priority practice**

What qualifies as a watch page?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

A page whose main purpose is watching one video, such as an episode or news video. A product page with a supplementary demo or a review with a trailer is not automatically a watch page.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“A watch page 's main purpose is to show users a single video. The following pages are watch pages because watching an individual video is the main reason the user is visiting the page:”

D90 · Video SEO best practices · Create a dedicated watch page for each video

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“These pages aren't watch pages because the video is complementary to the rest of the content on the page:”

D90 · Video SEO best practices · Create a dedicated watch page for each video

QUESTION 624 · D90

Can the same video appear on a watch page and a product or article page?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

Yes. The guide permits both. A non-watch page may appear as a text result or Image result with a video badge, while dedicated video features require watch-page eligibility.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“It's fine to include the same video on both a watch page and another page alongside other information, like a news article or a product detail page; a non-watch page can still be eligible to appear as a”

D90 · Video SEO best practices · Create a dedicated watch page for each video

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“text result and Google Image result with a video badge”

D90 · Video SEO best practices · Create a dedicated watch page for each video

QUESTION 625 · D90

How should JavaScript video discovery be tested?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

Verify that a recognizable video container exists in Google's rendered HTML even if a media API fails, and that discovery does not require a click/swipe/typing interaction or fragment-based loading.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“If you're using a media API (for example, the Media Source API), make sure the HTML video container element is still injected even if the media API call fails (in addition to providing metadata about the video). That way Google can still locate the position of the video container even if there's an issue with calling the media API.”

D90 · Video SEO best practices · Help Google find your videos

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Don't rely on user actions (such as swiping, clicking, or typing) to load the video.”

D90 · Video SEO best practices · Help Google find your videos

QUESTION 626 · D90

What is the difference between loc, embedUrl and contentUrl?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

loc is the watch-page URL in a video sitemap. embedUrl identifies the player. contentUrl identifies the actual video bytes, corresponding to player_loc and content_loc for those sitemap resources.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“1. Watch page The URL of the watch page that's embedding the video. If you're using a video sitemap, this URL is the value for the <loc> video sitemap tag. <?xml version="1.0" encoding="UTF-8"?> <urlset xmlns="http://www.sitemaps.org/schemas/sitemap/0.9" xmlns:video="http://www.google.com/schemas/sitemap-video/1.1"> <url> <loc> https://example.com/videos/some_video_landing_page.html </loc> <video:video> ...”

D90 · Video SEO best practices · Which URL is which?

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“2. Video player The URL of a specific player for the video. This is often the src value for an <iframe> element in the HTML of the watch page: <iframe src=" https://example.com/videoplayer.php?video=123 " width="640" height="360" frameborder="0" allow="autoplay; fullscreen; picture-in-picture" allowfullscreen></iframe> How to provide the URL If you're using structured data, provide the video player URL as the value for the VideoObject.embedUrl property. "embedUrl" : " https://example.com/videoplayer.php?video=123 " If you're using a video sitemap, provide the video player URL as the value for the <video:player_loc> tag. <video:player_loc> https://example.com/videoplayer.php?video=123 </video:player_loc>”

D90 · Video SEO best practices · Which URL is which?

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE · EXACT EXCERPT

“" width="400" height="300"></embed> How to provide the URL If you're using structured data, provide the video file's URL as the value for the VideoObject.contentUrl property. "contentUrl" : " https://streamserver.example.com/video/123/file.mp4 " If you're using a video sitemap, provide the video file's URL as the value for the <video:content_loc> tag. <video:content_loc>”

D90 · Video SEO best practices · Which URL is which?

QUESTION 627 · D90

Why are expiring CDN thumbnail and video URLs a problem?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

Google needs stable media locations to process videos, confirm availability and enable features. Use one unique stable thumbnail per video and stable file URLs; verify Googlebot if providing controlled access.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Some CDNs use quickly expiring URLs. If the video's thumbnail URL changes too often, Google may not be able to successfully index your videos. To make sure your videos can be indexed, use a single unique and stable thumbnail URL for each video.”

D90 · Video SEO best practices · Use stable URLs

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“To make your videos eligible for specific features like key moments and video previews, make sure your video files are available at stable URLs too. This also helps Google discover and process the videos consistently, confirm they are still available, and collect signals on the videos.”

D90 · Video SEO best practices · Use stable URLs

QUESTION 628 · D90

What are the documented video thumbnail requirements?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

Use a supported format, at least 60×30 pixels with larger preferred, stable accessible URLs and access for Googlebot/Googlebot Images. At least 80% of pixels must have an alpha value above 250; keep thumbnail metadata sources consistent.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Size Minimum 60x30 pixels, larger preferred.”

D90 · Video SEO best practices · Provide a high-quality video thumbnail

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Transparency At least 80% of the thumbnail's pixels must have an alpha (transparency) value greater than 250.”

D90 · Video SEO best practices · Provide a high-quality video thumbnail

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“If you choose to specify multiple metadata sources (for example, specifying a thumbnail in both your sitemap and structured data), make sure you're using the same thumbnail URL per video across all metadata.”

D90 · Video SEO best practices · Provide a high-quality video thumbnail

QUESTION 629 · D90

What must Google fetch to show video previews and key moments?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

Actual video-file bytes, including supported streaming resources, must be accessible at stable URLs. Ensure page and video servers have crawling capacity; max-video-preview controls preview duration.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Google needs to successfully fetch the actual bytes of a video file to enable features like video previews and key moments .”

D90 · Video SEO best practices · Allow Google to fetch your video files

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Google selects a few seconds from your video to display a moving preview, which can help users better understand what they'll find in your video. To make your videos eligible for this feature, allow Google to fetch your video files . You can set the maximum duration for these video previews using the max-video-preview robots meta tag.”

D90 · Video SEO best practices · Video previews

QUESTION 630 · D90

How do Clip and SeekToAction differ for key moments?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

Clip explicitly supplies segment start/end times and labels. SeekToAction supplies the timestamp URL pattern so Google can identify moments automatically. Language support differs, and YouTube descriptions offer another route.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE · EXACT EXCERPT

“video is embedded on your web page or you're running a video platform , there are two ways that you can enable key moments: Clip structured data : Specify the exact start and end time to each segment, and what label to display for each segment. This is supported in all languages where Google Search is available. SeekToAction structured data : Tell Google where timestamps typically go in your URL”

D90 · Video SEO best practices · Key moments

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE · EXACT EXCERPT

“label to display for each segment. This is supported in all languages where Google Search is available. SeekToAction structured data : Tell Google where timestamps typically go in your URL structure, so that Google can automatically identify key moments and link users to those points within the video. This is supported for the following languages: English, Spanish, Portuguese, Italian, Chinese, French, Japanese,”

D90 · Video SEO best practices · Key moments

QUESTION 631 · D90

How do you opt out of key moments completely?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

Use nosnippet. This includes Google's automatic attempts to generate key moments, not just publisher-supplied segments.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“To opt out of the key moments feature completely (including any efforts Google may make to show key moments automatically for your video), use the nosnippet meta tag.”

D90 · Video SEO best practices · Key moments

QUESTION 632 · D90

Can Google index a third-party embedded video on both sites?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

Yes, both the publisher's page and the platform's equivalent page can appear if each meets video-indexing criteria. The publisher should still provide relevant structured data and may include the watch page in a sitemap.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“If your website embeds videos from third-party platforms like YouTube, Vimeo, or Facebook, Google may index the video both on your web page and on the third-party platform's equivalent page. Both versions may appear in video features on Google, as long as the pages meet the video indexing criteria .”

D90 · Video SEO best practices · Using third-party embedded players

QUESTION 633 · D90

How do expiry and noindex differ when retiring a video?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

A past video expiry suppresses its video appearance while the watch page may remain a text result. noindex on the watch page removes its indexability; 404/authentication are other permanent-removal options.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“When a video has an expiration date in the past, the video won't appear in video results. The watch page may still be shown as a text result, without a video thumbnail. This includes expiration dates from sitemaps, structured data, and meta tags . Make sure that your expiration dates are correct for each video. While this is useful if your video is no longer available after the expiration date, it's easy to accidentally set the date to the past for an available video. If a video doesn't expire, don't include expiration information.”

D90 · Video SEO best practices · Remove a video

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Include a noindex robots meta tag on any watch page that's embedding a removed or expired video. This prevents the watch page from being indexable.”

D90 · Video SEO best practices · Remove a video

QUESTION 634 · D90

What is required for urgent removal if a video is embedded on several pages?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

Request removal of the affected watch page and make removal permanent with an appropriate page-level change. Other embedding pages are not automatically removed and need their own actions.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“tag, require server-side authentication). If the video is embedded on other pages or sites, those pages won't be removed unless you file additional removal requests for each page embedding that video.”

D90 · Video SEO best practices · Remove a video

QUESTION 635 · D90

How do allow and deny country lists behave when empty?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

An empty allow list permits nowhere; an empty deny list permits everywhere. Use valid ISO country codes and only one restriction per video entry, or use VideoObject region properties.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“relationship="allow" : The video can appear only for the specified countries. If no countries are specified, the video won't appear anywhere.”

D90 · Video SEO best practices · Restrict using a video sitemap

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“relationship="deny" : The video can appear everywhere except for the specified countries. If no countries are specified, the video will appear everywhere.”

D90 · Video SEO best practices · Restrict using a video sitemap

QUESTION 636 · D90

Which Search Console reports distinguish video indexing from markup and traffic?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

Video indexing shows whether indexed watch pages have indexed videos and reasons for failure. Video rich results diagnoses VideoObject markup. Performance with Videos Search appearance measures visibility.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Video indexing report : See how many of your indexed watch pages contain an indexed video, and see reasons for why other videos didn't get indexed.”

D90 · Video SEO best practices · Monitor video watch pages with Search Console

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Video rich result report : Review and fix issues with your VideoObject structured data implementation.”

D90 · Video SEO best practices · Monitor video watch pages with Search Console

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Performance report : Use the Videos search appearance filter to monitor how your videos are performing in Google Search.”

D90 · Video SEO best practices · Monitor video watch pages with Search Console

QUESTION 637 · D90 Additional practice

How can a subscription watch page help Google find its gated video?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

The video guide recommends paywall structured data when users must sign in or subscribe, so Google can find and index the video. Still satisfy the watch-page, visible-video and thumbnail requirements rather than treating paywall markup as a complete solution.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“The video can't be hidden behind other elements. If you're using a paywall (for example, users need to sign in or subscribe before seeing the video), add paywall structured data so that Google can still find and index the video.”

D90 · Video SEO best practices · Ensure your videos can be indexed

QUESTION 638 · D90 Additional practice

What markup is described for a livestream's red LIVE badge?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

BroadcastEvent structured data. The guide says it can enable the badge for livestreaming video; meeting markup requirements does not guarantee a specific feature will appear for every query.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“For livestreaming videos, you can enable a red "LIVE" badge to appear in search results by using BroadcastEvent structured data .”

D90 · Video SEO best practices · Live Badge

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Not all features are eligible to trigger on all queries. Google doesn't guarantee that adding markup will result in a specific video feature in Search results; learn why in our”

D90 · Video SEO best practices · Enable specific video features

Which metadata should remain unique for each video across a large site?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

The guide specifically names `thumbnailUrl`, name and description. Ensure they match the actual video and other metadata, rather than reusing an unrelated thumbnail or one generic description for every video.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“To influence how your videos appear on Google, describe your video with structured data . Ensure that any information that you provide in structured data is consistent with the actual video content and other metadata you provide. Make sure to provide unique information in the `thumbnailUrl` , name , and description properties for each video on your site.”

D90 · Video SEO best practices · Provide consistent and unique information in your structured data

What server-capacity issue can arise when a watch page and video file are on different hosts?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

Both the page host and actual streaming server need sufficient resources for crawling. A healthy watch-page server does not compensate for an inaccessible or overloaded video/CDN host; verify both resources.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE · EXACT EXCERPT

“to support crawling. So if your landing page at `example.com/puppies.html` has an embedded puppies video served by `streamserver.example.com` , both `example.com` and `streamserver.example.com` must meet the technical requirements for Google Search and have available server capacity . If you're using a CDN, you might be able to get Search Console notifications about crawl errors. You'll need to be able to”

D90 · Video SEO best practices · Allow Google to fetch your video files

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE · EXACT EXCERPT

“video served by `streamserver.example.com` , both `example.com` and `streamserver.example.com` must meet the technical requirements for Google Search and have available server capacity . If you're using a CDN, you might be able to get Search Console notifications about crawl errors. You'll need to be able to verify ownership of your allocated URL space on the CDN (either a subdomain or subdirectory”

D90 · Video SEO best practices · Allow Google to fetch your video files

Visual Elements gallery of Google Search

Google last updated: 2026-02-04 · Reviewed 6 October 2026

<https://developers.google.com/search/docs/appearance/visual-elements-gallery>

Detailed points to revise

- This illustrated terminology guide covers text results, rich results, image results, video results and exploration features. UI appearance varies with time, device, country, language and query; not every result contains every possible element.
- Attribution identifies the source through site name, favicon and visible URL. The visible URL consists of domain plus breadcrumb; breadcrumb reflects site hierarchy and can be supported by Breadcrumb markup.
- Text results (formerly web results/plain blue links) can include attribution, title link, snippet, byline date, sitelinks, a text-result image and rich attributes.
- Sitelinks groups contain two or more shortcuts and can link to pages, headings or anchors, including localized variants. They are selected automatically.
- A text-result image is the relevant page image for the query and opens the embedding page; rich attributes such as ratings/recipe information commonly rely on structured data.
- Image results contain thumbnails and attribution; the guide says image-thumbnail clicks go to the image. Video results contain thumbnail, title, attribution and upload date; a video-thumbnail click goes to the embedding webpage.
- Byline dates are Google's estimated publication/update dates; video upload dates come from metadata. Use the linked feature guides for actual optimization rules.
- Exploration features include related searches and related questions/People Also Ask. Searches are generated from the initial query and other users' searches; expanded questions show a featured snippet. Publishers cannot directly choose these suggestions.
- Original annotated illustrations are linked in the source library so you can check each term visually without changing Google's diagrams.

Complete source section checklist: Anatomy of a Google Search results page · Attribution · Favicon · Site name · Visible URL · Domain · Breadcrumb · Text result · Attribution · Title link · Snippet · Byline date · Sitelinks group · Sitelink · Text result image · Rich attributes · Image result · Image thumbnail · Attribution · Video result · Video thumbnail · Title link · Attribution · Upload date · Exploration features · Related searches group · Related questions group

QUESTION 641 · D91

What does attribution include in a Google result?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

Source-identifying information such as site name, favicon and visible URL. The visible URL can show the domain and a breadcrumb reflecting page hierarchy.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Attribution describes the source of a search result, and can appear for a variety of search result types, including text, image, and video results. Attribution can include various aspects of the source, such as the name of the site, favicon, and URL to the web page.”

D91 · Visual Elements gallery of Google Search · Attribution

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Visible URL The URL of the page that's shown in a readable format. A visible URL has two parts: domain and breadcrumb. Domain The site address as defined by the domain name. This is the name you chose when setting up the website (for example, example.com). Breadcrumb The trail that shows the page's position within the site's hierarchy. Learn how to specify the trail with Breadcrumb structured data .”

D91 · Visual Elements gallery of Google Search · Attribution

QUESTION 642 · D91

Are rich attributes the same as a separate rich result type?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

Rich attributes are additional lines, such as stars or recipe details, that can appear within a text result and are typically powered by structured data. A result need not contain every possible visual element.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Rich attributes are one or more lines of additional information about the web page, such as review stars and recipe information. This information is typically powered by structured data , provided by you.”

D91 · Visual Elements gallery of Google Search · Rich attributes

QUESTION 643 · D91

What is the difference between a text-result image and a video thumbnail click?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

The text-result image opens the webpage embedding that image; a video thumbnail also opens its embedding video webpage. This gallery separately describes an Image-result thumbnail as leading to the image.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“A text result image is the most relevant image from that particular web page for the given query. Tapping it takes the user to the web page that's embedding the image. A text result image is more likely to appear for image-seeking queries.”

D91 · Visual Elements gallery of Google Search · Text result image

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Image thumbnail An image thumbnail for the indexed image that's embedded on a web page. Tapping or clicking it takes the user to the image. To optimize your image for image results, follow the image SEO best practices .”

D91 · Visual Elements gallery of Google Search · Image result

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Video thumbnail A video thumbnail for the indexed video that's embedded on a web page. Tapping or clicking it takes the user to the web page that's embedding the video. Learn how to specify a video thumbnail .”

D91 · Visual Elements gallery of Google Search · Video result

QUESTION 644 · D91

Can site owners directly select People Also Ask questions?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

The gallery says publishers cannot control what appears in exploration features. Expanded related questions show a featured snippet; relevant queries can inform useful content planning without guaranteeing placement.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Exploration features help searchers explore more questions or searches that are related to their original search query (also known as "People also ask"). While you can't control what shows up here, it can be helpful to pay attention to the related search queries when you're thinking about topics you could write about for your site.”

D91 · Visual Elements gallery of Google Search · Exploration features

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“A related questions group is a cluster of questions that are related to what the user initially searched for (also known as "People Also Ask"). When a user expands the question, they're shown a featured snippet. Learn how to manage featured snippets .”

D91 · Visual Elements gallery of Google Search · Related questions group

Are sitelinks in this visual gallery restricted to separate page URLs?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

No. Its sitelinks-group description includes other pages, headings or anchors within a page, and localized variations. Google chooses them automatically; the gallery is terminology, not a manual selection interface.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Sitelinks group Two or more links from the same domain or its localized variations that are clustered together under a text result. For example, the links could be other pages on that domain, headings, or anchors within that page. A sitelinks group contains two or more sitelinks: Sitelink A single link within a sitelinks group. While sitelinks are automated, there are some best practices you can follow for improving the quality .”

D91 · Visual Elements gallery of Google Search · Text result

Enable Web Stories on Google

Google last updated: 2026-07-01 · Reviewed 6 October 2026

<https://developers.google.com/search/docs/appearance/enable-web-stories>

Detailed points to revise

- Web Stories are tappable/swipeable web pages blending video, audio, images, animation and text. Normal web-page SEO still applies.
- Search single-result availability covers all Search regions/languages. Discover single-card availability covers Discover regions/languages and is most likely in the United States, India and Brazil; do not treat this as a guaranteed carousel everywhere.
- Build with a story editor or AMP engineering, test device layouts with Chrome DevTools and follow the dedicated creation guidance.
- A Story must be valid AMP. Validate with the Web Stories Google Test Tool, URL Inspection or AMP Linter; technical validity alone does not promise indexing or serving.
- Required preview metadata on every story: publisher-logo-src, poster-portrait-src, title and publisher. Inspect the actual preview in the Story test tool.
- Check indexing with URL Inspection, Page Indexing and Sitemaps reports; add site links or a sitemap for discovery. Every Story must have a self-referencing canonical and must not be blocked by robots.txt/noindex.
- Declare language variants appropriately and comply with content policies; examples and linked resources are preserved in the reference.

Complete source section checklist: Feature availability · Create the Web Story · Make sure the Web Story is valid AMP · Verify metadata · Check if the Web Story is indexed

QUESTION 646 · D92 **Priority practice**

Is AMP validity required for Google's Web Stories implementation?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

Yes. This guide requires a valid AMP story and provides Story Test Tool, URL Inspection and AMP Linter as validation routes.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Make sure the Web Story is valid AMP.”

D92 · Enable Web Stories on Google · Enable Web Stories on Google

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“AMP Linter : Validate Web Stories during development using the command line.”

D92 · Enable Web Stories on Google · Make sure the Web Story is valid AMP

QUESTION 647 · D92 Priority practice

Which four Web Story metadata fields are required?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

publisher-logo-src, poster-portrait-src, title and publisher. Validate the preview rather than assuming the editor supplies all fields correctly.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Remember that the following fields are required on every Web Story: publisher-logo-src , poster-portrait-src , title , and publisher .”

D92 · Enable Web Stories on Google · Verify metadata

QUESTION 648 · D92

What canonical rule applies to a Web Story?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

Each story must have a self-referencing canonical. Also keep it crawlable/indexable, link it from the site or sitemap, and declare localized versions where applicable.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“All Web Stories must be canonical. Make sure that each Web Story has a link rel="canonical" to itself. For example: <link rel="canonical" href="https://www.example.com/url/to/webstory.html"> If there are multiple versions of the same story in different languages, make sure to tell Google about localized versions .”

D92 · Enable Web Stories on Google · Check if the Web Story is indexed

QUESTION 649 · D92

Where can Web Stories appear geographically?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

Single Search results are available in all Search regions/languages. Discover single cards are available where Discover is available and most likely in the US, India and Brazil; display is not guaranteed.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Web Stories can appear as a single result on Google Search, which is available in all regions and languages where Google Search is available.”

D92 · Enable Web Stories on Google · Feature availability

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“In the Discover feed, Web Stories can appear as a single card where you can tap through the story. While this appearance is available in all regions and languages where Google Discover is available, it's most likely to appear in the United States, India, and Brazil.”

D92 · Enable Web Stories on Google · Feature availability

QUESTION 650 · D92

How would you investigate a valid Story that is not indexed?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

Check URL Inspection and indexing reports, robots/noindex access, self-canonical metadata and discovery via links/sitemap. AMP validity is one requirement, not proof of indexing.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Check to see if Google Search has indexed your Web Story. Use the URL Inspection Tool to submit individual URLs or review status using Page Indexing report or Sitemaps report . If your Web Story isn't indexed:”

D92 · Enable Web Stories on Google · Check if the Web Story is indexed

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Check that the Web Story URL isn't blocked from Googlebot in your robots.txt file or by a noindex tag.”

D92 · Enable Web Stories on Google · Check if the Web Story is indexed

QUESTION 651 · D92 Additional practice

How would you check a Web Story's small-screen layout before release?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

Use Chrome DevTools to simulate different device sizes and formats, then validate the Story and its preview with the appropriate tools. Layout testing complements AMP validity and indexing checks.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“If you have engineering resources, you can get started with AMP . To ensure your Web Story renders appropriately, we suggest using Chrome Developer Tools to simulate different device sizes and formats.”

D92 · Enable Web Stories on Google · Create the Web Story

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Web Stories Google Test Tool : Check that the Web Story is valid.”

D92 · Enable Web Stories on Google · Make sure the Web Story is valid AMP

Best practices for creating Web Stories

Google last updated: 2026-06-09 · Reviewed 6 October 2026

<https://developers.google.com/search/docs/appearance/web-stories-creation-best-practices>

Detailed points to revise

- Critical storytelling favors video; recommended storytelling adds a relatable perspective and a narrative arc with context, suspense and payoff.
- Critical design advice recommends approximately 280 characters per page, visible unblocked text and restrained animation. The separate content-policy page warns that a majority of pages over 180 characters may lose eligibility for richer experiences; these are different stated thresholds, so use the stricter policy when eligibility matters.
- Recommended design: Web Stories-appropriate calls to action, full-bleed high-quality assets, cover-page logo, brief videos, good balanced audio and optional auto-advance for video-only stories.
- Video guidance recommends under 15 seconds per page, or 60 seconds maximum; audio should be high quality, at least 5 seconds, with clear speech. The policy page separately encourages videos under 60 seconds.
- SEO fundamentals still apply: useful complete content, discoverable/indexable URLs, sitemap discovery, self-canonicals and localized-language handling.
- Story titles must be shorter than 90 characters; a descriptive title shorter than 70 is recommended. This Story-specific rule is distinct from the general Search title guide's absence of a fixed title-element limit.
- Attach AMP story metadata and ordinary page markup (title/description, structured data, Open Graph and Twitter cards). Recommendations include alt text, appropriate structured data and integrating Story links into homepage/category navigation.
- URLs do not need a special stories/amp naming convention; use a coherent site URL strategy. Story page attachments can add depth without withholding the essential narrative.
- Add accessible captions/subtitles, avoid burned-in text, and use semantic HTML. If the editor exports every slide as a video with baked-in text, the guide recommends the precise visible text as amp-video's title attribute only when semantic markup is unavailable.
- Add landscape support for desktop appearance. Valid AMP is required; poster-portrait-src should be at least 640×853 with 3:4 ratio, and publisher-logo-src at least 96×96 with 1:1 ratio. Avoid text baked into the poster; og:image is recommended.
- This page retains the older Index Coverage Report term; the newer enablement guide names Page Indexing. Use the current Search Console report name in practice.

Complete source section checklist: Storytelling · More storytelling best practices · Design · More design best practices · SEO · More SEO best practices · Technical · More technical best practices · Other resources

How do the two Web Stories pages differ on text length?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

The creation guide suggests about 280 characters per page, while the richer-experience content policy says Stories may be ineligible if a majority of pages exceed 180 characters. Explain both scopes and use the policy threshold for eligibility planning.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Reduce your character count Avoid including multiple pages with walls of text. Consider reducing text to approximately 280 characters per page (the length of a tweet).”

D93 · Best practices for creating Web Stories · Design

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“We don't allow Web Stories that are text heavy. Web Stories may not be eligible if the majority of pages have more than 180 characters of text. Usage of bite-sized video (less than 60 seconds per page) wherever possible is encouraged.”

D94 · Web Story Content Policies on Google · Text-heavy Web Stories

What are the Story-specific title recommendations?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

Keep the title shorter than 90 characters; a descriptive title shorter than 70 is recommended. This is specific Story advice, whereas the general title-link guide states no fixed title-element limit.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Keep the title short Keep titles shorter than 90 characters. We recommend using a descriptive title that is shorter than 70 characters.”

D93 · Best practices for creating Web Stories · SEO

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Write descriptive and concise text for your <title> elements. Avoid vague descriptors like "Home" for your home page, or "Profile" for a specific person's profile. Also avoid unnecessarily long or verbose text in your <title> elements. While there's no limit on how long a <title> element can be, the title link is truncated in Google Search results as needed, typically to fit the device width.”

D87 · Influencing your title links in search results · Best practices for influencing title links

QUESTION 654 · D93

What poster and publisher-logo dimensions does the creation guide give?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

Poster-portrait-src: at least 640×853 pixels and 3:4 ratio. Publisher-logo-src: at least 96×96 pixels and 1:1 ratio. Avoid burned-in poster text that obscures the result title.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Include the right poster image size and aspect ratio Make sure that the image linked to your <amp-story> poster-portrait-src attribute is at least 640x853px and use an aspect ratio of 3:4.”

D93 · Best practices for creating Web Stories · Technical

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Include the right aspect ratio for the logo Make sure that the logo image linked to your <amp-story> publisher-logo-src attribute is at least 96x96 px and aspect ratio of 1:1.”

D93 · Best practices for creating Web Stories · Technical

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Don't include text in the poster image Avoid using images that contain burned in text, as this could obstruct the title of your story when users preview your story in Search results. If users are unable to clearly read the title, they may be less likely to continue reading.”

D93 · Best practices for creating Web Stories · Technical

QUESTION 655 · D93

How should video and audio be sized for an engaging Story?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

The guide recommends videos under 15 seconds per page or 60 seconds maximum, and high-quality audio clips at least 5 seconds long with balanced volume and clear speech. These are format/design recommendations, not a generic video SEO rule.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Shorten video length We recommend videos that are less than 15 seconds per page, or 60 seconds maximum.”

D93 · Best practices for creating Web Stories · More design best practices

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Include audio Use high-quality audio clips that are at least 5 seconds long with balanced volume, and ensure speech is audible.”

[D93](#) · [Best practices for creating Web Stories](#) · [More design best practices](#)

QUESTION 656 · D93

Do Web Story URLs have to contain stories or amp?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

No. Integrate Stories into the site's broader URL strategy and link them from relevant homepage/category pages. A special landing page may help discovery but is optional.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE · EXACT EXCERPT

“additional special landing page like www.example.com/stories (which would then be linked from key pages like your home page) might also make sense. There is no need to indicate in the URL of a Web Story that it is using the Web Stories format or AMP Stories technology. Ideally, your Web Stories are integrated into a wider URL strategy. For example, if your "New York Travel" articles are using a format”

[D93](#) · [Best practices for creating Web Stories](#) · [More SEO best practices](#)

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE · EXACT EXCERPT

“in the URL of a Web Story that it is using the Web Stories format or AMP Stories technology. Ideally, your Web Stories are integrated into a wider URL strategy. For example, if your "New York Travel" articles are using a format like `/new-york/travel/title-of-article.html`”, then consider using the exact same directory structure and URL format for your Web Stories.”

[D93](#) · [Best practices for creating Web Stories](#) · [More SEO best practices](#)

QUESTION 657 · D93

How can video-only Story exports remain understandable when text is baked in?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

Semantic HTML is preferred. If the editor exports slides as videos and semantic markup is unavailable, put the precise displayed text in the amp-video title attribute, following this specific fallback guidance.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Optimize video-only stories We recommend that you use semantic HTML to build your Web Story. However, some Web Story editor tools may instead export a story that formats each slide as a video file that bakes in all the text into the video. In this case, we recommend that you add the precise text displayed inside of the video as a title attribute on the amp-video element. Again, only do this if you can't use semantic markup in your Web Stories.”

D93 · Best practices for creating Web Stories · More SEO best practices

QUESTION 658 · D93

Which practices improve Story accessibility and desktop usability?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

Keep text visible and unblocked, use captions and appropriate image alt text, avoid burned-in text that overlaps or overflows, and support landscape displays for desktop Search.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Include subtitles on video Add captions to your video to help readers better understand your story. Avoid captions that are burned into the video to ensure that they don't overlap with other content or flow off the screen.”

D93 · Best practices for creating Web Stories · More SEO best practices

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Include alt text on images We recommend including alt text on your images to improve your story's discoverability.”

D93 · Best practices for creating Web Stories · More SEO best practices

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Add support for landscape displays To enable Web Stories to appear in desktop Google Search results, add support for landscape displays .”

D93 · Best practices for creating Web Stories · More SEO best practices

QUESTION 659 · D93 Additional practice

Can a Web Story copied from a social platform keep instructions such as swipe up in another app?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

Adapt calls to action to actions readers can actually perform in the Web Story. The guide says to remove platform-specific calls to action when recreating social stories; do not leave navigation instructions that cannot work.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Use Web Stories-specific call to action When re-creating stories that were originally created for a social platform like Instagram, Snapchat or YouTube, be sure to remove any reader call-to-action specific to a certain platform. Make sure that users are able to follow any actions suggested in your Web Story.”

[D93](#) · [Best practices for creating Web Stories](#) · [More design best practices](#)

Web Story Content Policies on Google

Google last updated: 2025-12-10 · Reviewed 6 October 2026

<https://developers.google.com/search/docs/appearance/web-stories-content-policy>

Detailed points to revise

- Single-result Stories must satisfy Discover policies, Search Essentials and overall Search policies. Richer experiences additionally require Search Feature policies plus the listed Story content rules.
- Egregious violations can permanently exclude a site from richer Story experiences; do not confuse this statement with guaranteed removal from all ordinary web results.
- Copyright: Stories should be original or use material with permission; Google does not obtain rights for creators and may block infringing Stories.
- Text-heavy Stories may be ineligible if most pages exceed 180 characters. Bite-sized video under 60 seconds per page is encouraged; keep this policy separate from the creation guide's 280-character advice.
- Poor-quality stretched/pixelated assets and missing narrative/theme are prohibited. Stories must be complete and must not require external clicks to get essential information.
- Stories whose sole goal is advertising are disallowed. Affiliate links may occupy a minor part, display ads must follow Story Ad Guidelines, and affiliate programs must follow Search spam policies.

Complete source section checklist: Copyrighted content · Text-heavy Web Stories · Low quality assets · Lack of narrative · Incomplete stories · Overly commercial

QUESTION 660 · D94 **Priority practice**

Are the eligibility policies the same for single Story results and richer experiences?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

Single results require the general Search/Discover policies; richer experiences add Search Feature and specific Story policies. Egregious violations can permanently exclude a site from richer experiences.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“For your Web Stories to be eligible to appear on Google Discover and Search as single results, they must comply with Discover policies , Google Search Essentials , and Google Search's overall policies . In addition, for Web Stories to be eligible to appear on richer experiences on Google Search (for example, the carousel view), Web Stories must comply with the Search Feature content policies and the following additional content policies. In cases of egregious violations of the Web Stories Content Policies, a site may stop permanently appearing on the richer experiences on Google Search.”

D94 · [Web Story Content Policies on Google](#) · [Web Story Content Policies on Google](#)

QUESTION 661 · D94

Priority practice

Can a Story make users click to another site for the main conclusion?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

The policy disallows incomplete stories that require another website or app to supply essential information. Optional deeper detail is different from withholding the story's core narrative.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“We don't allow Web Stories that are incomplete or that require users to click links to other websites or apps to get essential information.”

D94 · [Web Story Content Policies on Google](#) · [Incomplete stories](#)

QUESTION 662 · D94

Are ads and affiliate links completely banned in Web Stories?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

No. A Story with advertising as its sole goal is disallowed; minor affiliate links and properly implemented display ads are permitted subject to the referenced policies.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“We don't allow Web Stories in which the sole goal is to advertise a service or a product, and especially if you may directly benefit from users consuming your Web Story. Affiliate marketing links are permissible as long as they are restricted to a minor part of the Web Story. Display ads may be placed following the Story Ad Guidelines . Good affiliate programs are supported based on spam policies for Google web search .”

D94 · [Web Story Content Policies on Google](#) · [Overly commercial](#)

QUESTION 663 · D94

What visual or narrative issues can disqualify a Story?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

Text-heavy pages, seriously stretched/pixelated assets, missing narrative structure, incompleteness or copyright infringement. The policy specifically warns about a majority of pages exceeding 180 characters.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“We don't allow Web Stories that are text heavy. Web Stories may not be eligible if the majority of pages have more than 180 characters of text. Usage of bite-sized video (less than 60 seconds per page) wherever possible is encouraged.”

D94 · Web Story Content Policies on Google · Text-heavy Web Stories

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“We don't allow Web Stories that contain images and video assets that are stretched out or pixelated to the point that the viewer's experience is negatively impacted.”

D94 · Web Story Content Policies on Google · Low quality assets

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“We don't allow Web Stories that are missing a binding theme or narrative structure from page to page.”

D94 · Web Story Content Policies on Google · Lack of narrative

QUESTION 664 · D94 Additional practice

Does appearing on Google transfer responsibility for copyright permission to Google?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

No. The Story policy says the creator must have permission for someone else's copyrighted material, and Google assumes no obligation to obtain those rights. Infringing Stories may be blocked from appearing.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“We don't allow Web Stories that infringe anyone's copyright. Web Stories are meant to reflect original works, so we don't allow Web Stories that include someone else's copyrighted work unless you have received permission. Google does not assume any obligation or responsibility with respect to obtaining rights for your Web Stories to appear across Google. If your Web Story infringes on someone else's copyright, we may block it from appearing. For more information, review our copyright procedures .”

D94 · Web Story Content Policies on Google · Copyrighted content

Package tracking Early Adopters Program

Google last updated: 2026-07-14 · Reviewed 6 October 2026

<https://developers.google.com/search/docs/appearance/package-tracking>

Detailed points to revise

- Package tracking is an API-backed Search experience where a user enters a package ID and Google retrieves the carrier's tracking information. It is not described as a schema.org-only integration.
- The feature is available in all Search countries/languages, but the Early Adopters Program is no longer accepting new partners. Do not propose a currently open application path.
- API expectations: almost no downtime, average response within 700 ms and 95th percentile no more than 1,000 ms. Failure can stop display of the carrier's tracking information.
- Required field CurrentStatus includes current status, when it became valid, and error states.
- Recommended fields: DeliveredDate, PromisedDate, TrackingNumber, TrackingURL, SupportPhoneNumbers, TransitEvents, CreateDate, PickupDate, TimestampEvent, LocationEvent and CanReschedule.
- TransitEvents describe interim journey events, including date/time and applicable city/state/country. Region-specific support numbers and rescheduling status are recommended; these are not a license to share recipient data.
- Google does not accept personal data or geographical information about the recipient or sender. Distinguish transit-event location from identifying a person's address/location.

Complete source section checklist: Feature availability · Availability and responsiveness · Content

QUESTION 665 · D95 Priority practice

Can a new carrier currently join the package-tracking program by adding schema?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

The page describes an API integration, and it explicitly says the early-adopters program is no longer accepting new partners. Do not promise eligibility through markup or a currently open signup.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“The package tracking early adopters program is no longer accepting new partners.”

D95 · Package tracking Early Adopters Program · Package tracking Early Adopters Program

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Package tracking is a feature that displays package tracking related information on Google. When people come to Search looking to track a package shipped with your company, they’ll be able to enter a package ID directly. The feature uses your API to retrieve the package tracking information and then displays it to the user. Here’s how package tracking information may appear on Google Search when a user seeks to track a package.”

D95 · Package tracking Early Adopters Program · Package tracking Early Adopters Program

QUESTION 666 · D95 Priority practice

What responsiveness requirements does package tracking specify?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

Almost no downtime, average API response within 700 ms, and 95th percentile at or below 1,000 ms. Google may stop showing tracking information if these requirements are missed.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“We expect almost no downtime from your API and require that your API respond within 700ms on average with the 95th percentile not exceeding 1,000ms. If your API doesn’t meet these requirements, we may stop displaying your package tracking information.”

D95 · Package tracking Early Adopters Program · Availability and responsiveness

QUESTION 667 · D95

What information is required versus recommended?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

CurrentStatus is required, including the time it became valid and error states. Delivery/promise times, tracking references, support, transit events, event locations and rescheduling are recommended fields listed in the source.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Required field CurrentStatus The current status of the package. This includes the date and time this status became valid and any error states.”

D95 · Package tracking Early Adopters Program · Content

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Recommended fields”

D95 · Package tracking Early Adopters Program · Content

QUESTION 668 · D95

Can the API send a recipient address because transit locations are recommended?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

No. Transit-event locations are listed, but personal and geographical information about the recipient or sender are explicitly excluded. Keep those scopes separate.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Any personal data about the recipient or sender of the package.”

D95 · Package tracking Early Adopters Program · Content

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Any geographical information about the recipient or sender of the package.”

D95 · Package tracking Early Adopters Program · Content

QUESTION 669 · D95 Additional practice

Would omitting CurrentStatus still satisfy package tracking if every recommended field is supplied?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

No. CurrentStatus is the required field, including when the status became valid and error states. Recommended delivery dates, tracking links and transit events cannot replace a required value.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Required field CurrentStatus The current status of the package. This includes the date and time this status became valid and any error states.”

D95 · Package tracking Early Adopters Program · Content

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“CurrentStatus The current status of the package. This includes the date and time this status became valid and any error states.”

D95 · Package tracking Early Adopters Program · Content

10 cross-topic scenarios

Practice the documented principle, evidence to inspect, your action and how you would judge the outcome. These are editorial interview scenarios.

QUESTION 120 · D02 **Cross-topic scenario**

A new product page is missing from Google. Walk me through the investigation.

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

Clarify the exact URL and expected query. Use URL Inspection to separate discovery, crawl access, rendering, indexing, and canonical status. Check discoverable internal links or sitemap presence, robots rules and noindex, HTTP and server errors, and the rendered main content. If it is indexed, assess whether it matches the query and provides useful information. Fix the observed stage rather than prescribing backlinks for every problem. This is a practical synthesis of pages 1, 2, 6, and 7.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“To check how Google sees your page, use the URL Inspection Tool in Search Console .”

D01 · Search Engine Optimization (SEO) Starter Guide · Check if Google can see your page the same way a user does

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“After a page is crawled, Google tries to understand what the page is about. This stage is called indexing and it includes processing and analyzing the textual content and key content tags and attributes, such as <title> elements and alt attributes, images , videos , and more.”

D02 · In-depth guide to how Google Search works · Indexing

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Check if Googlebot can access the page with the URL inspection tool .”

D07 · Get started with Search: a developer's guide · Control what content Google sees

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Check your HTML for noindex rules in meta tags.”

D07 · Get started with Search: a developer's guide · Control what content Google sees

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“The content on the page is irrelevant to users' queries”

D02 · In-depth guide to how Google Search works · Serving search results

A developer blocked a URL in robots.txt and added noindex, but it still appears. What happened?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

The crawl block can prevent Google from seeing the noindex directive. Decide whether the goal is index exclusion, crawl management, or privacy. For noindex processing, allow crawling; for private material, require access control. Reinspect the page after the chosen coherent setup is implemented. This applies pages 6 and 7.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“To block Google from finding your page, restrict access to your content to logged in users (for example, use a login page or password-protect your page).”

D07 · Get started with Search: a developer's guide · Control what content Google sees

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“To block Googlebot from crawling your page, create a robots.txt . A robots.txt is not a mechanism for keeping a web page out of Google. To keep a web page out of Google, use the noindex robots rules, or password-protect your page.”

D07 · Get started with Search: a developer's guide · Control what content Google sees

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“To block Google from indexing your page but still allow crawling, add a noindex tag . Combining multiple crawling and indexing rules might cause some rules to counteract other rules. Learn how to configure these rules properly by reading Combining crawling with indexing / serving rules .”

D07 · Get started with Search: a developer's guide · Control what content Google sees

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“To prevent only Google web crawlers from indexing a page:”

D40 · Block Search indexing with noindex · <meta> tag

A stakeholder wants 5,000 AI articles before the quarter ends. What is your response?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

Ask what audience need the pages serve and what unique contribution each provides. Assess overlap, accuracy, expert review, and the care given to each page. Publishing many pages mainly for ranking manipulation risks scaled content abuse; manual fact-checking must also include titles, descriptions, markup, and alt text. Propose production around validated useful content rather than the page-count target. This applies pages 3, 4, and 5.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE · EXACT EXCERPT

“Focus on what your users want, and avoid overdoing it. While it might be tempting to create separate content for every possible variation of how people might search (for example, by focusing on other queries that people have asked, or fan-out queries), doing so primarily to manipulate rankings or generative AI responses in Google Search violates Google's scaled”

D04 · Optimizing your website for generative AI features on Google Search · Create valuable, non-commodity content for your audience

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE · EXACT EXCERPT

“When creating content for the web, focus on accuracy, quality, and relevance, especially when automatically generating the content. Keep in mind that generative models don't retrieve facts, but predict a likely sequence of words based on their training data. Because of this, generative AI outputs may contain inaccuracies (also known as hallucinations). It is critical”

D05 · Google Search's guidance on using generative AI content on your website · Focus on accuracy, quality, and relevance

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Is the content mass-produced by or outsourced to a large number of creators, or spread across a large network of sites, so that individual pages or sites don't get as much attention or care?”

D03 · Creating helpful, reliable, people-first content · Content and quality questions

An agency says llms.txt, short chunks, and a proprietary AI schema will guarantee citations. How do you evaluate it?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

The AI guide says Google ignores llms.txt, requires no tiny-chunk format, and needs no special AI schema. The third-party guide rejects assumed internal-data access and guarantees. Request precise evidence and assess whether any remaining service improves real content, technical access, or measurement. Do not extend a Google-specific finding to every other AI system without separate evidence. This applies pages 4, 8, and 9.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE · EXACT EXCERPT

“LLMS.txt files and other "special" markup : You don't need to create new machine readable files, AI text files, markup, or Markdown to appear in Google Search (including its generative AI capabilities), as Google Search itself doesn't use them. Note that Google may discover, crawl, and index many kinds of files in addition to HTML on a website: this doesn't mean that”

D04 · [Optimizing your website for generative AI features on Google Search](#) · [Mythbusting generative AI search: what you don't need to do](#)

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“"Chunking" content: There's no requirement to break your content into tiny pieces for AI to better understand it. Google systems are able to understand the nuance of multiple topics on a page and show the relevant piece to users. However, sometimes shorter (or longer!) pages can work well depending on your audience and subject matter. There's no ideal page length, and in the end, make pages for your audience, not just for generative AI search.”

D04 · [Optimizing your website for generative AI features on Google Search](#) · [Mythbusting generative AI search: what you don't need to do](#)

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Overfocusing on structured data : Structured data isn't required for generative AI search, and there's no special schema.org markup you need to add. However, it's a good idea to continue using it as part of your overall SEO strategy, as it helps with being eligible for rich results on Google Search.”

D04 · [Optimizing your website for generative AI features on Google Search](#) · [Mythbusting generative AI search: what you don't need to do](#)

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Some third-party services provide data that some users of those tools misinterpret as somehow being from Google. Third-party tools don't have access to our internal ranking data. They can't guarantee performance. Any predictions are their own and like predictions generally, may not happen.”

D09 · [Google Search's guidance on using third-party SEO tools, services, and advice](#) · [Think critically about using third-party SEO tools and services](#)

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“No one can guarantee a #1 ranking on Google. Beware of SEOs that claim to guarantee rankings, allege a "special relationship" with Google, or advertise a "priority submit" to Google.”

D08 · [Do you need an SEO? · Things to consider when hiring an SEO](#)

An ecommerce site has accurate body copy but AI-generated metadata. Is that enough?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

No. Review generated titles, descriptions, structured data, and alt text against the actual products and claims. Validate relevant markup and review Merchant Center policy requirements for generated images and structured title/description attributes. Correct misleading fields before publication. This applies page 5.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE · EXACT EXCERPT

“When creating content for the web, focus on accuracy, quality, and relevance, especially when automatically generating the content. Keep in mind that generative models don't retrieve facts, but predict a likely sequence of words based on their training data. Because of this, generative AI outputs may contain inaccuracies (also known as hallucinations). It is critical”

D05 · Google Search's guidance on using generative AI content on your website · Focus on accuracy, quality, and relevance

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“For structured data, also ensure compliance with the general guidelines , the specific policies for the individual search features, and validate the markup to ensure eligibility for Search features .”

D05 · Google Search's guidance on using generative AI content on your website · Focus on accuracy, quality, and relevance

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“For ecommerce sites, Google Merchant Center has policies for AI-generated content . In particular, AI-generated images must contain metadata using the IPTC DigitalSourceType TrainedAlgorithmicMedia metadata. AI-generated product data such as title and description attributes must be specified separately and labeled as AI-generated.”

D05 · Google Search's guidance on using generative AI content on your website · Give users context

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE · EXACT EXCERPT

“structured_title”

S6 · AI-generated content · Title

The site is indexed but hardly visible for its desired queries. What would you investigate?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

Indexing is only one stage. Examine whether the content addresses the query, whether it is useful compared with competing results, and whether language, location, device, or presentation affects relevance. Inspect first-party performance evidence and any serving restrictions. Do not assume a crawling failure merely because rankings are weak. This applies pages 1, 2, 3, and 9.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“When a user enters a query, our machines search the index for matching pages and return the results we believe are the highest quality and most relevant to the user's query. Relevancy is determined by hundreds of factors, which could include information such as the user's location, language, and device (desktop or phone). For example, searching for "bicycle repair shops" would show different results to a user in Paris than it would to a user in Hong Kong.”

D02 · In-depth guide to how Google Search works · Serving search results

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“The content on the page is irrelevant to users' queries”

D02 · In-depth guide to how Google Search works · Serving search results

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“The quality of the content is low”

D02 · In-depth guide to how Google Search works · Serving search results

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“, which provides you with key information and data directly from Google Search itself.”

D09 · Google Search's guidance on using third-party SEO tools, services, and advice · Think critically about using third-party SEO tools and services

We are redesigning and moving domains. When should SEO be involved?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

Early, before URL, template, content, and rendering decisions are fixed. Plan the appropriate redirect mapping and sitemap changes, follow the site-move process, verify access and content on new pages, and monitor outcomes. Explain uncertainty instead of promising an instant unchanged ranking transfer. The timing and source migration requirements come from pages 6 and 8; operational validation is interview application.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“As with many business activities, sometimes hiring a professional can be helpful. For example, a great time to hire is when you're considering a site redesign (the earlier, the better), or planning to launch a new site. That way, you and your SEO can ensure that your site is designed to be search engine-friendly from the bottom up. However, a good SEO can also help improve an existing site.”

D08 · Do you need an SEO? · Things to consider when hiring an SEO

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“If you're migrating an entire site, implement all the 301 and sitemap changes you need, then tell Google about the move so that we can start crawling the new site and forwarding your signals to the new site. Learn how to migrate your site.”

D06 · Maintaining your website's SEO · Migrating a site

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Prepare a URL mapping from the current URLs to their corresponding new format.”

D48 · How to move a site · Overview

A health page has a fabricated doctor profile and polished AI text. What is the problem?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

The helpful-content guide explicitly treats fabricated authorship and credentials as deception. Health is a YMYL topic, so high accuracy, trustworthy provenance, and consistency with expert consensus are particularly important. Remove false identity claims, establish real qualified review, verify content, and explain the process honestly. This applies pages 3 and 5.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“However, avoid using deceptive authorship information. Fabricating creator profiles (such as by using AI-generated headshots, made-up names, or false credentials to make content appear as if it was written by human experts) is a form of deception. Any form of deception makes a page untrustworthy to both users and our automated quality systems, and is a signal of a low-quality page.”

D03 · Creating helpful, reliable, people-first content · Who (created the content)

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“While E-E-A-T itself isn't a specific ranking factor, using a mix of factors that can identify content with good E-E-A-T is useful. For example, our systems give even more weight to content that aligns with strong E-E-A-T for topics that could significantly impact the health, financial stability, or safety of people, or the welfare or well-being of society. We call these "Your Money or Your Life" topics, or YMYL for short.”

D03 · Creating helpful, reliable, people-first content · Get to know E-E-A-T and the quality rater guidelines

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Accuracy: For informational pages, the content should be factually accurate. For topics that could significantly impact people's lives or well-being (YMYL topics), the content must be highly accurate and consistent with established expert consensus.”

D03 · Creating helpful, reliable, people-first content · Main content

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE · EXACT EXCERPT

“When creating content for the web, focus on accuracy, quality, and relevance, especially when automatically generating the content. Keep in mind that generative models don't retrieve facts, but predict a likely sequence of words based on their training data. Because of this, generative AI outputs may contain inaccuracies (also known as hallucinations). It is critical”

D05 · Google Search's guidance on using generative AI content on your website · Focus on accuracy, quality, and relevance

QUESTION 128 · D01 Cross-topic scenario

A tool says adding 800 words and two H2s will fix the rankings. What do you do?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

There is no Google preferred word count or ideal heading count. Examine whether the page actually misses useful information or navigation. Add material only when it satisfies the intended audience, and distinguish the tool heuristic from an official ranking rule. This applies pages 1, 3, and 9.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Are you writing to a particular word count because you've heard or read that Google has a preferred word count? (No, we don't.)”

D03 · Creating helpful, reliable, people-first content · Avoid creating search engine-first content

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE · EXACT EXCERPT

“them out of order. The web in general is not valid HTML, so Google Search can rarely depend on semantic meanings hidden in the HTML specification. There's also no magical, ideal amount of headings a given page should have. However, if you think it's too much, then it probably is. Thinking E-E-A-T is a ranking factor No, it's not.”

D01 · Search Engine Optimization (SEO) Starter Guide · Things we believe you shouldn't focus on

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Some third-party services provide data that some users of those tools misinterpret as somehow being from Google. Third-party tools don't have access to our internal ranking data. They can't guarantee performance. Any predictions are their own and like predictions generally, may not happen.”

D09 · Google Search's guidance on using third-party SEO tools, services, and advice · Think critically about using third-party SEO tools and services

QUESTION 129 · D04 Cross-topic scenario

The ordinary Search report shows impressions, but the AI report is absent. Does that prove a technical penalty?

ANSWER TO PRACTISE · PARAPHRASE / INTERVIEW APPLICATION

No. The linked AI-report help page lists insufficient AI impressions and rollout/access explanations, and also recommends checking inclusion. First confirm the property and its inherited or explicit AI control. The report is a visibility source, not proof of a penalty merely because it is absent. Use its documented impressions correctly and measure business outcomes separately. This applies page 4 and supplementary source S2.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE · EXACT EXCERPT

“Your site hasn't received enough impressions”

S5 · Generative AI performance report (Search) · Not seeing the report?

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE · EXACT EXCERPT

“rolling out over time”

S5 · Generative AI performance report (Search) · Not seeing the report?

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE · EXACT EXCERPT

“Search generative AI control”

S3 · Search generative AI control · Search generative AI control

127 sourced definitions

Say the definition in your own words, then explain one practical consequence. Each entry includes supporting excerpts; the quick-review companion gives concise definitions and links.

301 redirect

An HTTP redirect indicating a permanent move and strongly signaling the destination as canonical.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“If you need to change the URL of a page as it is shown in search engine results, we recommend that you use a permanent server-side redirect whenever possible. This is the best way to ensure that Google Search and people are directed to the correct page. The 301 and 308 status codes mean that a page has permanently moved to a new location.”

D46 · [Redirects and Google Search](#) · [Permanent server-side redirects](#)

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Temporary Googlebot follows the redirect, but the indexing pipeline doesn't use the redirect as a signal that the redirect target should be canonical. The target page might still be indexed if other canonicalization signals are present. HTTP 302 (found) Set up server-side redirects . HTTP 303 (see other) HTTP 307 (temporary redirect) meta refresh (more than 0 seconds) Set up meta refresh redirects . HTTP refresh (more than 0 seconds)”

D46 · [Redirects and Google Search](#) · [Overview of redirect types](#)

302 redirect

An HTTP redirect indicating a temporary move; the original URL generally remains the preferred canonical.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“If you need to change the URL of a page as it is shown in search engine results, we recommend that you use a permanent server-side redirect whenever possible. This is the best way to ensure that Google Search and people are directed to the correct page. The 301 and 308 status codes mean that a page has permanently moved to a new location.”

D46 · [Redirects and Google Search](#) · [Permanent server-side redirects](#)

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Temporary Googlebot follows the redirect, but the indexing pipeline doesn't use the redirect as a signal that the redirect target should be canonical. The target page might still be indexed if other canonicalization signals are present. HTTP 302 (found) Set up server-side redirects . HTTP 303 (see other) HTTP 307 (temporary redirect) meta refresh (more than 0 seconds) Set up meta refresh redirects . HTTP refresh (more than 0 seconds)”

D46 · Redirects and Google Search · Overview of redirect types

404 response

An HTTP response indicating that the requested page is missing; a helpful custom error page should still return this status.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“When a user requests a page that has been removed, you can create a custom 404 page to provide a better experience. Just be sure that when a user requests a page that is no longer there, you return a true 404 error, not a soft 404 .”

D06 · Maintaining your website's SEO · Migrating a single URL

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“soft 404 pages : Return a 404 code when a page no longer exists.”

D22 · Troubleshoot Google Search crawling errors · Hide URLs that you don't want in search results

429 response

An HTTP response indicating too many requests; it can be used for urgent crawler throttling, with site-wide crawl-rate consequences.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE · EXACT EXCERPT

“If you need to urgently reduce the crawl rate for short period of time (for example, a couple of hours, or 1-2 days), then return 500 , 503 , or 429 HTTP response status code instead of 200 to the crawl requests. Google's crawling infrastructure reduces your site's crawling rate when it encounters a significant number of URLs with 500 , 503 , or 429 HTTP response”

D25 · Reduce the Google crawl rate · Urgently reduce crawler traffic (for emergencies)

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“: We don't recommend that you do this for a long period of time (meaning, longer than 1-2 days) as it may have a negative effect on how your site appears in Google products. For example, in case of Search, if Googlebot observes these status codes on the same URL for multiple days, the URL may be dropped from Google's index.”

D25 · Reduce the Google crawl rate · Urgently reduce crawler traffic (for emergencies)

503 response

An HTTP response indicating temporary service unavailability; short maintenance use differs from prolonged unavailability.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“If you need to urgently disable the site for 1-2 days, then return an informational error page with a 503 HTTP response status code instead of all content. Make sure to follow the best practices for disabling a site .”

D50 · Temporarily pause or disable a website · Not recommended: Disable the whole website

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“If you need to disable the site for a longer time, then provide an indexable home page as a placeholder for users to find in Search by using the 200 HTTP status code.”

D50 · Temporarily pause or disable a website · Not recommended: Disable the whole website

75th-percentile assessment

Assessing Web Vitals at the value met by 75% of page visits, separately for mobile and desktop.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“To ensure you're hitting the recommended target for these metrics for most of your users, a good threshold to measure is the 75th percentile of page loads, segmented across mobile and desktop devices.”

S4 · Web Vitals · Core Web Vitals

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Tools that assess Core Web Vitals compliance should consider a page passing if it meets the recommended targets at the 75th percentile for all three of the Core Web Vitals metrics.”

S4 · Web Vitals · Core Web Vitals

A/B testing

Comparing site variations; when separate URLs are used, Google recommends appropriate canonicals and temporary redirects.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE · EXACT EXCERPT

“URLs, you can use the rel="canonical" link attribute on all of your alternate URLs to indicate that the original URL is the preferred version. We recommend using rel="canonical" rather than a noindex meta tag because it more closely matches your intent in this situation. For instance, if you are testing variations of your home page, you don't want search engines not to index your home page; you just want them to understand”

D49 · [Minimize A/B testing impact in Google Search · Use rel="canonical" links](#)

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“If you're running a test that redirects users from the original URL to a variation URL, use a 302 (temporary) redirect , not a 301 (permanent) redirect. This tells search engines that this redirect is temporary—it will only be in place as long as you're running the experiment— and that they should keep the original URL in their index rather than replacing it with the target of the redirect (the test page). JavaScript-based redirects are also fine.”

D49 · [Minimize A/B testing impact in Google Search · Use 302 redirects, not 301 redirects](#)

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE · EXACT EXCERPT

“gathered enough data to draw a reliable conclusion. Once you've concluded the test, update your site with the desired content variation(s) and remove all elements of the test as soon as possible, such as alternate URLs or testing scripts and markup. If we discover a site running an experiment for an unnecessarily long time, we may interpret this as an attempt to deceive search engines and take action”

D49 · [Minimize A/B testing impact in Google Search · Run the experiment only as long as necessary](#)

AEO

Answer engine optimization, a term used for improving AI-search visibility; Google treats optimizing its generative search experience as SEO.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“"AEO" stands for "answer engine optimization" and "GEO" for "generative engine optimization". These are both terms you may see used to describe work specifically focused on improving visibility in AI search experiences. From Google Search's perspective, optimizing for generative AI search is optimizing for the search experience, and thus still SEO. If you're considering third-party "AEO" or "GEO" advice or services, review our”

D04 · [Optimizing your website for generative AI features on Google Search · Is SEO still relevant for generative AI search?](#)

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“We recommend carefully evaluating any advice you might be considering implementing against our official SEO guidance , including our guidance on optimizing for generative AI , and making your own informed decisions.”

D09 · [Google Search's guidance on using third-party SEO tools, services, and advice](#) · [Evaluate and verify external SEO advice against official Google guidelines](#)

Aggregator unit

A regional Search presentation linking to aggregator inventory or category pages, with participation requirements beyond ordinary markup.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“In this unit, eligible aggregators populate their unit with results relevant to the user's query. The top-ranked provider's results are expanded by default. For example, if a user searched for "hotels in paris", they may see a list of top-ranked hotels with photos, prices, or star ratings from an eligible provider. User clicks within the unit lead directly to that aggregator's website.”

D71 · [Aggregator unit in Google Search](#) · [How the aggregator unit works](#)

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Users have the ability to select a different provider from a list of alternative aggregators, if available, expanding a unit populated with results from the new aggregator. Only one aggregator unit will show at a time.”

D71 · [Aggregator unit in Google Search](#) · [How the aggregator unit works](#)

AI agent

An autonomous system that performs tasks for people, potentially interacting with pages through rendered views, the DOM or accessibility information.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“AI agents are autonomous systems that can perform tasks on behalf of people, such as booking a reservation or comparing product specifications. These agents can take many forms; for example, browser agents may access your website to gather the data they need to complete these tasks, such as analyzing visual renderings (like screenshots), inspecting the DOM structure, and interpreting the accessibility tree.”

D04 · [Optimizing your website for generative AI features on Google Search](#) · [Explore agentic experiences](#)

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“If this is something that's relevant to your business and you have extra time, check out the available agentic experiences and review the guide to agent-friendly website best practices , which gives some insights into how a website can generally prepare for current browser agents. Protocols like Universal Commerce Protocol (UCP) are emerging that will allow Search agents to do more.”

D04 · [Optimizing your website for generative AI features on Google Search](#) · [Explore agentic experiences](#)

AI Overviews and AI Mode

Google Search generative AI experiences grounded in core Search systems; ordinary SEO foundations remain relevant.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“In short, yes! The best practices for SEO continue to be relevant because our generative AI features on Google Search are rooted in our core Search ranking and quality systems. These features rely on AI techniques to highlight content from our Search index, such as:”

D04 · [Optimizing your website for generative AI features on Google Search](#) · [Is SEO still relevant for generative AI search?](#)

Allow

A robots.txt instruction permitting crawling of a matching path; the most specific applicable path rule wins.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“When matching robots.txt rules to URLs, crawlers use the most specific rule based on the length of the rule path. In case of conflicting rules, including those with wildcards, Google uses the least restrictive rule.”

D28 · [How Google interprets the robots.txt specification](#) · [Order of precedence for rules](#)

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“https://example.com/page.php5 allow: /page disallow: /*.ph Applicable rule : allow: /page , because in case of conflicting rules, Google uses the least restrictive rule.”

D28 · [How Google interprets the robots.txt specification](#) · [Order of precedence for rules](#)

Alt text

Descriptive image text; for an image used as a link, Google uses its alt attribute as anchor text.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“For images as links, Google uses the alt attribute of the img element as anchor text, so be sure to add descriptive alt text to your images :”

D13 · [Link best practices for Google](#) · [Anchor text placement](#)

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“As a fallback, Google can use the title attribute as anchor text if the <a> element is for some reason empty.”

D13 · [Link best practices for Google](#) · [Anchor text placement](#)

Anchor text

The visible text of a link, helping users and Google understand the linked page.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Good anchor text is descriptive, reasonably concise, and relevant to the page that it's on and to the page it links to. It provides context for the link, and sets the expectation for your readers. The better your anchor text, the easier it is for people to navigate your site and for Google to understand what the page you're linking to is about.”

D13 · [Link best practices for Google](#) · [Write good anchor text](#)

BERT

A system Google uses to understand how word combinations express different meanings and intent.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Bidirectional Encoder Representations from Transformers (BERT) is an AI system Google uses that allows us to understand how combinations of words express different meanings and intent.”

D66 · [A guide to Google Search ranking systems](#) · [BERT](#)

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Neural matching is an AI system that Google uses to understand representations of concepts in queries and pages and match them to one another.”

D66 · [A guide to Google Search ranking systems](#) · [Neural matching](#)

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“RankBrain is an AI system that helps us understand how words are related to concepts. It means we can better return relevant content even if it doesn't contain all the exact words used in a search, by understanding the content is related to other words and concepts.”

D66 · [A guide to Google Search ranking systems](#) · [RankBrain](#)

Breadcrumb

A hierarchical indication of a page's position within a site; appropriate structured data can help Google represent that hierarchy.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE · EXACT EXCERPT

“You can specify which image that you want Google to use for your organization's logo in Search results and your Google knowledge panel. To do this, add Organization structured data to your official website that identifies the location of your preferred logo . Breadcrumbs : Breadcrumb trails on a page indicate the page's position in the site hierarchy. A user can navigate all the way up in the”

D59 · [Establish your business details with Google](#) · [Update your site's Google knowledge panel](#)

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE · EXACT EXCERPT

“hierarchy, one level at a time, by starting from the last breadcrumb in the breadcrumb trail. To help Google understand your breadcrumbs, you can add Breadcrumb structured data to your site. Highlight your customer support methods Customers are often looking for ways to contact businesses, and Google works to show the best available information to help them in a variety of ways . You can”

D59 · [Establish your business details with Google](#) · [Update your site's Google knowledge panel](#)

Canonicalization

Selecting a representative URL from duplicate or very similar pages to reduce redundant results.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Canonicalization is the process of selecting the representative – canonical – URL of a piece of content. Consequently, a canonical URL is the URL of a page that Google chose as the most representative from a set of duplicate pages. Often called deduplication, this process helps Google show only one version of the otherwise duplicate content in its search results.”

D29 · [What is canonicalization](#) · [What is canonicalization](#)

CLS

Cumulative Layout Shift measures visual stability; a good value is at most 0.1 at the 75th percentile.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Largest Contentful Paint (LCP) : Measures loading performance. To provide a good user experience, strive to have LCP occur within the first 2.5 seconds of the page starting to load.”

D64 · Understanding Core Web Vitals and Google search results · Core Web Vitals metrics

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Interaction To Next Paint (INP) : Measures responsiveness. To provide a good user experience, strive to have an INP of less than 200 milliseconds .”

D64 · Understanding Core Web Vitals and Google search results · Core Web Vitals metrics

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“Cumulative Layout Shift (CLS) : Measures visual stability. To provide a good user experience, strive to have a CLS score of less than 0.1 .”

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GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Interaction to Next Paint (INP) : measures interactivity . To provide a good user experience, pages should have a INP of 200 milliseconds or less.”

S4 · Web Vitals · Core Web Vitals

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Cumulative Layout Shift (CLS) : measures visual stability . To provide a good user experience, pages should maintain a CLS of 0.1. or less.”

S4 · Web Vitals · Core Web Vitals

Content fingerprinting

Putting a version or content hash in a resource filename so changed JavaScript or CSS is fetched rather than served from a stale cache.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Googlebot caches aggressively in order to reduce network requests and resource usage. WRS may ignore caching headers. This may lead WRS to use outdated JavaScript or CSS resources. Content fingerprinting avoids this problem by making a fingerprint of the content part of the filename, like main.2bb85551.js . The fingerprint depends on the content of the file, so updates generate a different filename every time. Check out the web.dev guide on long-lived caching strategies to learn more.”

D33 · [Understand the JavaScript SEO basics](#) · [Use long-lived caching](#)

Core update

A broad change to Search’s systems; a visibility decline after one does not itself demonstrate a site-specific penalty.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Core updates are designed to ensure that overall, we're delivering on our mission to present helpful and reliable results for searchers. These changes are broad in nature, and don't target specific sites or individual web pages. As content on the web changes, we assess and update our systems to keep pace, as a whole.”

D68 · [Google Search's core updates and your website](#) · [How core updates work](#)

Core Web Vitals

User-experience metrics for loading, responsiveness and visual stability: LCP, INP and CLS.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Largest Contentful Paint (LCP) : Measures loading performance. To provide a good user experience, strive to have LCP occur within the first 2.5 seconds of the page starting to load.”

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S4 · Web Vitals · Core Web Vitals

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Cumulative Layout Shift (CLS) : measures visual stability . To provide a good user experience, pages should maintain a CLS of 0.1. or less.”

S4 · Web Vitals · Core Web Vitals

Crawl budget

The number of URLs Google’s crawlers can and want to crawl, governed by crawl capacity and crawl demand.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“The web is a nearly infinite space, exceeding Google's ability to explore every publicly accessible URL. As a result, there are limits to how much time and resources Google can devote to crawling any single site. The allocation of these resources is commonly called a site's crawl budget . In this context, Google's crawling infrastructure defines a site as a unique hostname. For example, <https://www.example.com/> and <https://code.example.com/> are treated as separate sites and have separate crawl budgets. A site's crawl budget is determined by two main elements: crawl capacity limit and crawl demand .”

S7 · Optimize your crawl budget · General theory of crawling

Crawl capacity limit

The crawling capacity Google permits to avoid overloading a site; server responsiveness affects it.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Google wants to crawl your site without overwhelming your servers. To prevent this, Google's crawlers calculate a crawl capacity limit (also known as hostload). This limits the total amount of time your server spends holding connections open for Google, factoring in both the number of parallel connections and their duration. This ensures Google can cover all your important content without overloading your servers.”

S7 · Optimize your crawl budget · Crawl capacity limit

Crawl demand

Google's desire to crawl URLs, influenced by factors such as inventory and how stale content may be.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

"For Googlebot, demand varies based on a site's size, update frequency, page quality, and relevance, compared to other sites. The primary factors you can influence are:"

S7 · [Optimize your crawl budget](#) · [Crawl demand](#)

Crawling

Fetching page content with an automated crawler. A discovered URL is not guaranteed to be crawled.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

"Crawling: Google downloads text, images, and videos from pages it found on the internet with automated programs called crawlers."

D02 · [In-depth guide to how Google Search works](#) · [Introducing the three stages of Google Search](#)

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

"Indexing: Google analyzes the text, images, and video files on the page, and stores the information in the Google index, which is a large database."

D02 · [In-depth guide to how Google Search works](#) · [Introducing the three stages of Google Search](#)

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

"Serving search results: When a user searches on Google, Google returns information that's relevant to the user's query."

D02 · [In-depth guide to how Google Search works](#) · [Introducing the three stages of Google Search](#)

Crypto redirect

A move communicated through explanatory text and a link; Google advises against relying on it when other redirect methods are available.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE · EXACT EXCERPT

“redirects . Only use JavaScript redirects if you can't do server-side or meta refresh redirects. Crypto redirect Learn more about crypto redirects . Don't rely on crypto redirects for letting search engines know that your content has moved unless you have no other choice.”

D46 · Redirects and Google Search · Overview of redirect types

data-nosnippet

An HTML attribute excluding a marked text region from snippets; its presence applies regardless of a false-looking value.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“You can designate textual parts of an HTML page not to be used as a snippet. This can be done on an HTML-element level with the data-nosnippet HTML attribute on span , div , and section elements. The data-nosnippet is considered a boolean attribute . As with all boolean attributes, any value specified is ignored. To ensure machine-readability, the HTML section must be valid HTML and all appropriate tags must be closed accordingly.”

D39 · Robots meta tag, data-nosnippet , and X-Robots-Tag specifications · Using the data-nosnippet HTML attribute

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“<p>This text can be shown in a snippet and this part would not be shown.</p>
<div data-nosnippet>not in snippet</div> <div data-nosnippet="true">also not in snippet</div> <div data-nosnippet="false">also not in snippet</div> <!-- all values are ignored --> <div data-nosnippet>some text</html> <!-- unclosed "div" will include all content afterwards --> <mytag data-nosnippet>some text</mytag> <!-- NOT VALID: not a span, div, or section --> <p>This text can be shown in a snippet.</p> <div data-nosnippet> <p>However, this is not in snippet.</p> Stuff not in snippet More stuff not in snippet </div>”

D39 · Robots meta tag, data-nosnippet , and X-Robots-Tag specifications · Using the data-nosnippet HTML attribute

Disallow

A robots.txt instruction restricting crawling of matching paths. A URL may still be indexed from other signals.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE · EXACT EXCERPT

“PDFs and other text-based formats supported by Google) from Google Search results. If other pages point to your page with descriptive text, Google could still index the URL without visiting the page. If you want to block your page from search results, use another method such as password protection or noindex . If your web page is blocked with a robots.txt file , its URL can still appear in search results, but the”

D27 · Introduction to robots.txt · What is a robots.txt file used for?

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE · EXACT EXCERPT

“method such as password protection or noindex . If your web page is blocked with a robots.txt file , its URL can still appear in search results, but the search result won't have a description . Image files, video files, PDFs, and other non-HTML files embedded in the blocked page will be excluded from crawling, too, unless they're referenced by other pages that are allowed for crawling. If you see this”

D27 · Introduction to robots.txt · What is a robots.txt file used for?

Discover

A feed showing content relevant to users' interests; eligibility does not require special markup or only newly published articles.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Content is automatically eligible to appear in Discover if it is indexed by Google and meets Discover's content policies . No special tags or structured data are required. Note that being eligible to appear in Discover is not a guarantee of appearing.”

D57 · Discover and your website · How content appears in Discover

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Content that may appear in Discover includes a wide range of topics that aligns with a person's interests. Older content may appear if it's helpful and relevant to individuals based on their interests.”

D57 · Discover and your website · How content appears in Discover

DOM text

Text accessible in the document object model; important copy should not exist only in CSS-generated content or a canvas.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Make sure your text content is accessible in the DOM. For example, content that is added via the CSS content property is not part of the DOM and Google Search ignores it at the moment. It's fine to use the content property for decorative content; Google Search may not index this content.”

D07 · [Get started with Search: a developer's guide](#) · [Don't forget about the words on the page](#)

Duplicate content

The same or similar content available through multiple URLs; ordinary duplication is not itself a manual-action penalty.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Having duplicate content on your site is not a violation of our spam policies, but it can be a bad user experience and search engines might waste crawling resources on URLs that you don't even care about. If you're feeling adventurous, it's worth figuring out if you can specify a canonical version for your pages. But if you don't canonicalize your URLs yourself, Google will try to automatically do it for you.”

D01 · [Search Engine Optimization \(SEO\) Starter Guide](#) · [Reduce duplicate content](#)

Dynamic rendering

Routing crawlers to rendered HTML while serving ordinary users normally; a workaround that Google does not recommend as a long-term default.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE · EXACT EXCERPT

“Dynamic rendering requires your web server to detect crawlers (for example, by checking the user agent). When your web server identifies a request from a crawler that does not support JavaScript or the JavaScript features required to render your content, this request is routed to”

D36 · [Dynamic rendering as a workaround](#) · [Understand how dynamic rendering works](#)

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE · EXACT EXCERPT

“your web server identifies a request from a crawler that does not support JavaScript or the JavaScript features required to render your content, this request is routed to a rendering server. Requests from users and crawlers without JavaScript issues are served normally. The rendering server responds to requests with a version of the content that's suitable to the crawler, for example, it may serve a”

D36 · [Dynamic rendering as a workaround](#) · [Understand how dynamic rendering works](#)

E-E-A-T

Experience, expertise, authoritativeness and trustworthiness; trust is central, and E-E-A-T is not itself one specific ranking factor.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Google's automated systems are designed to use many different factors to rank great content. After identifying relevant content, our systems aim to prioritize those that seem most helpful. To do this, they identify a mix of factors that can help determine which content demonstrates aspects of experience, expertise, authoritativeness, and trustworthiness, or what we call E-E-A-T.”

D03 · [Creating helpful, reliable, people-first content](#) · [Get to know E-E-A-T and the quality rater guidelines](#)

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Of these aspects, trust is most important. The others contribute to trust, but content doesn't necessarily have to demonstrate all of them. For example, some content might be helpful based on the experience it demonstrates, while other content might be helpful because of the expertise it shares.”

D03 · [Creating helpful, reliable, people-first content](#) · [Get to know E-E-A-T and the quality rater guidelines](#)

Ecosystem carousel

A regional carousel connecting users with providers in a relevant ecosystem, without requiring a new feed or markup type.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“To provide additional, relevant sources of information, the ecosystem carousel may appear when people search for specific information that benefit from data visualizations or interactivity with data (for example, stock charts, weather information, sports scores, translation).”

D73 · [Ecosystem carousel in Google Search](#) · [Ecosystem carousel in Google Search](#)

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“After clicking a tile in the carousel, the searcher is taken directly to that website. The order of websites in the carousel is determined by Search ranking algorithms based on non-discriminatory ranking principles designed to ensure users see the most relevant results for their location and language. To be eligible to appear in the carousel, check to see if you meet the requirements , and if you do, express interest in the feature .”

D73 · [Ecosystem carousel in Google Search](#) · [Ecosystem carousel in Google Search](#)

Eligibility versus display

Meeting technical, content and policy requirements makes a feature possible; it does not guarantee that Google shows it.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Important: Google does not guarantee that your structured data will show up in search results, even if your page is marked up correctly according to the Rich Results Test . Here are some common reasons why:”

[D83](#) · [General structured data guidelines](#) · [General structured data guidelines](#)

Enriched search result

A richer, interactive result experience beyond a basic rich result, subject to additional requirements.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“In addition to standard rich results, Google Search supports a more interactive and enhanced class of rich result called enriched search results . Enriched search results often include an immersive experience or other advanced interaction feature. For example, here is a Jobs enriched result that might appear if a user searched for "jobs in United States":”

[D84](#) · [Enriched search results](#) · [Enriched search results](#)

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Enriched search enables the user to search across the various properties of a structured data item; for example, a user might search for chicken soup recipes under 200 calories, or recipes that take less than 1 hour of preparation time.”

[D84](#) · [Enriched search results](#) · [Enriched search results](#)

Favicon

A site icon that may appear beside a result; it must be square and meet Google’s crawlability and size guidance.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Your favicon must be a square (1:1 aspect ratio) that's at least 8x8px. While the minimum size requirement is 8x8px, we recommend using a favicon that's larger than 48x48px so that it looks good on various surfaces. Google Search supports the following favicon file formats: BMP, GIF, ICO, PNG, JPEG, PPM, and TIFF.”

[D54](#) · [Define a favicon to show in search results](#) · [Guidelines](#)

Featured snippet

An automatically selected extract prominently answering a query; publishers cannot mark a page as the featured snippet.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“How can I mark my page as a featured snippet?”

[D55](#) · [Featured snippets and your website](#) · [How can I mark my page as a featured snippet?](#)

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“You can't. Google systems determine whether a page would make a good featured snippet for a user's search request, and if so, elevates it.”

[D55](#) · [Featured snippets and your website](#) · [How can I mark my page as a featured snippet?](#)

Flexible sampling

Approaches to offering some paywalled content access, including metering and lead-in, rather than requiring unlimited free access.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“There are two types of sampling we advise: metering , which provides users with a quota of articles to consume before requiring users to subscribe or log in, after which paywalls will start appearing; and lead-in , which offers a portion of an article's content without it being shown in full.”

[D56](#) · [Flexible Sampling general guidance](#) · [Flexible Sampling general guidance](#)

GEO

Generative engine optimization, another term for AI-search visibility work; it does not replace Google's established SEO principles.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“AEO” stands for “answer engine optimization” and “GEO” for “generative engine optimization”. These are both terms you may see used to describe work specifically focused on improving visibility in AI search experiences. From Google Search’s perspective, optimizing for generative AI search is optimizing for the search experience, and thus still SEO. If you’re considering third-party “AEO” or “GEO” advice or services, review our”

[D04 · Optimizing your website for generative AI features on Google Search · Is SEO still relevant for generative AI search?](#)

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“We recommend carefully evaluating any advice you might be considering implementing against our official SEO guidance , including our guidance on optimizing for generative AI , and making your own informed decisions.”

[D09 · Google Search’s guidance on using third-party SEO tools, services, and advice · Evaluate and verify external SEO advice against official Google guidelines](#)

Google Business Profile

A Google business-information product that can help local services and products be visible in Search and relevant AI responses.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Where appropriate, generative AI responses can include product listings, product information, and information about local businesses. Using products like Merchant Center (such as Merchant Center feeds) and Google Business Profiles can help your products and services to be visible in both AI responses and other Google Search results. Learn more about how to add and manage your business details on Google Search .”

[D04 · Optimizing your website for generative AI features on Google Search · Optimize your local business and ecommerce details](#)

Google request verification

Confirming genuine Google traffic with reverse and forward DNS checks, or matching published Google IP ranges at scale.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Run a reverse DNS lookup on the accessing IP address from your logs, using the host command.”

[D26 · Verify requests from Google crawlers and fetchers · Use command line tools](#)

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Run a forward DNS lookup on the domain name retrieved in step 1 using the host command on the retrieved domain name.”

D26 · [Verify requests from Google crawlers and fetchers](#) · [Use command line tools](#)

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Verify that it's the same as the original accessing IP address from your logs.”

D26 · [Verify requests from Google crawlers and fetchers](#) · [Use command line tools](#)

Google Search Console

Google's first-party tool for information and data about a site's presence in Google Search.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“, which provides you with key information and data directly from Google Search itself.”

D09 · [Google Search's guidance on using third-party SEO tools, services, and advice](#) · [Think critically about using third-party SEO tools and services](#)

Google-selected canonical

The representative URL Google actually chooses; inspect it when it differs from the publisher's preference.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Check which page Google considers to be the canonical page: Use the URL Inspection tool to check which page Google considers canonical and think about whether the Google-selected canonical makes more sense than your preferred canonical URL for your users coming from Google Search. Important: If a canonical URL is in a Search Console property that you don't own, you won't be able to see any of the traffic for your duplicate page.”

D31 · [Fix canonicalization issues](#) · [Fix canonicalization issues](#)

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Look for technical canonicalization issues: Verify whether an unexpected canonical URL preference is being signaled through technical misconfigurations. Review the common canonicalization issues table to check for issues like incorrect canonical elements, server misconfigurations, or missing localization annotations.”

D31 · [Fix canonicalization issues](#) · [Fix canonicalization issues](#)

Googlebot

Google's crawler that fetches pages; its crawl decisions and rate are algorithmic.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE · EXACT EXCERPT

"The first stage is finding out what pages exist on the web. There isn't a central registry of all web pages, so Google must constantly look for new and updated pages and add them to its list of known pages. This process is called "URL discovery". Some pages are known because Google has already visited them. Other pages are discovered when Google extracts a link from"

D02 · [In-depth guide to how Google Search works](#) · [Crawling](#)

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE · EXACT EXCERPT

"Once Google discovers a page's URL, it may visit (or "crawl") the page to find out what's on it. We use a huge set of computers to crawl billions of pages on the web. The program that does the fetching is called Googlebot (also known as a crawler, robot, bot, or spider). Googlebot uses an algorithmic process to determine which sites to crawl, how often, and how many"

D02 · [In-depth guide to how Google Search works](#) · [Crawling](#)

Hosting migration

Changing hosting infrastructure while retaining existing URLs; verify the new environment and DNS transition.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

"Follow this guide to minimize the impact of changing your site's hosting infrastructure on the site's performance in Google Search. A change in hosting infrastructure means switching hosting providers or moving to a content distribution network (CDN). This guide is only for migrations that don't affect the user-visible URL."

D47 · [Changing your hosting](#) · [Changing your hosting](#)

hreflang

An annotation identifying alternative language or regional versions of a page.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

"Use hreflang to tell Google about different language variations of pages on your site."

D06 · [Maintaining your website's SEO](#) · [Internationalized or multi-lingual sites](#)

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“If your site adapts the content of its pages based on the locale of the request, read how this can affect Google's crawl of your site .”

D06 · [Maintaining your website's SEO · Internationalized or multi-lingual sites](#)

Image sitemap

Image information added to a sitemap, either alongside page URLs or in a separate sitemap.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Image sitemaps are a way of telling Google about other images on your site, especially those that we might not otherwise find (such as images your site reaches with JavaScript code). You can create a separate image sitemap or add image sitemap tags to your existing sitemap; either approach is equally fine for Google.”

D17 · [Image sitemaps · Image sitemaps](#)

indexifembedded

With noindex, permits indexing when content is embedded through an iframe or similar tag; alone it has no effect.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“indexifembedded Google is allowed to index the content of a page if it's embedded in another page through iframes or similar HTML tags, in spite of a noindex rule. indexifembedded only has an effect if it's accompanied by noindex .”

D39 · [Robots meta tag, data-nosnippet , and X-Robots-Tag specifications · Valid indexing and serving rules](#)

Indexing

Analyzing a page and its text, images, video and metadata, and potentially storing information in Google's index.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“After a page is crawled, Google tries to understand what the page is about. This stage is called indexing and it includes processing and analyzing the textual content and key content tags and attributes, such as <title> elements and alt attributes, images , videos , and more.”

D02 · [In-depth guide to how Google Search works · Indexing](#)

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Google also collects signals about the canonical page and its contents, which may be used in the next stage, where we serve the page in search results. Some signals include the language of the page, the country the content is local to, and the usability of the page.”

D02 · In-depth guide to how Google Search works · Indexing

INP

Interaction to Next Paint measures responsiveness; a good value is at most 200 milliseconds at the 75th percentile.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Largest Contentful Paint (LCP) : Measures loading performance. To provide a good user experience, strive to have LCP occur within the first 2.5 seconds of the page starting to load.”

D64 · Understanding Core Web Vitals and Google search results · Core Web Vitals metrics

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D64 · Understanding Core Web Vitals and Google search results · Core Web Vitals metrics

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Cumulative Layout Shift (CLS) : Measures visual stability. To provide a good user experience, strive to have a CLS score of less than 0.1 .”

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S4 · Web Vitals · Core Web Vitals

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Cumulative Layout Shift (CLS) : measures visual stability . To provide a good user experience, pages should maintain a CLS of 0.1. or less.”

S4 · Web Vitals · Core Web Vitals

Intrusive interstitial

An overlay or intermediate experience that obstructs access to expected main content; legal requirements have different considerations.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Instead of full page interstitials, use banners that take up only a small fraction of the screen to grab your users' attention. Banners ensure that users and search engines can get to the content as soon as they land on the page.”

D63 · Avoid intrusive interstitials and dialogs · Use banners instead of interstitials

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Don't obscure the entire page with interstitials.”

D63 · Avoid intrusive interstitials and dialogs · Avoid common mistakes

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Don't redirect the user to a separate page for their consent or input.”

D63 · Avoid intrusive interstitials and dialogs · Avoid common mistakes

IPTC DigitalSourceType

Image provenance metadata; Merchant Center requires TrainedAlgorithmicMedia metadata for AI-generated images.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“For ecommerce sites, Google Merchant Center has policies for AI-generated content . In particular, AI-generated images must contain metadata using the IPTC DigitalSourceType TrainedAlgorithmicMedia metadata. AI-generated product data such as title and description attributes must be specified separately and labeled as AI-generated.”

D05 · Google Search's guidance on using generative AI content on your website · Give users context

Job sites feature

A regional job-site aggregator presentation and refinement chip; it is distinct from the JobPosting structured-data feature.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“The "Job sites" refinement chip can help users focus the Search page on aggregator text results. Searchers can activate the refinement chips at the top of the Search results page or by clicking More sites on the aggregator carousel.”

D74 · Job sites: aggregator carousel and refinement chip · Job sites: aggregator carousel and refinement chip

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“These experiences are available to users in the EEA who are searching for job-related queries.”

D74 · Job sites: aggregator carousel and refinement chip · Feature availability

JSON-LD

A supported structured-data format placing linked data in a JSON script block; Google generally recommends it.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“If you're new to structured data, check out schema.org beginner's guide to structured data . While the guide focuses on Microdata, the basic ideas are relevant for JSON-LD and RDFa.”

D82 · Introduction to structured data markup in Google Search · Get started with structured data

lastmod

A sitemap timestamp for the last significant update; it must reflect actual changes rather than routine regeneration.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Google uses the <lastmod> value if it's consistently and verifiably (for example by comparing to the last modification of the page) accurate. The <lastmod> value should reflect the date and time of the last significant update to the page. For example, an update to the main content, the structured data, or links on the page is generally considered significant, however an update to the copyright date is not.”

D15 · Build and submit a sitemap · Additional notes about XML sitemaps

Lazy loading

Deferring resources or content until needed; make loading possible when visible in the viewport without user interaction.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“To ensure that Google sees all content on your page, make sure that your lazy-loading implementation loads all relevant content whenever it is visible in the viewport. Here are a few methods to implement lazy-loading:”

D35 · [Fix lazy-loaded content](#) · [Load content when it's visible in the viewport](#)

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“The methods mentioned don't rely on user actions, such as scrolling or clicking, to load content, which is important as Google Search does not interact with your page.”

D35 · [Fix lazy-loaded content](#) · [Load content when it's visible in the viewport](#)

LCP

Largest Contentful Paint measures loading performance; a good value is at most 2.5 seconds at the 75th percentile.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Largest Contentful Paint (LCP) : Measures loading performance. To provide a good user experience, strive to have LCP occur within the first 2.5 seconds of the page starting to load.”

D64 · [Understanding Core Web Vitals and Google search results](#) · [Core Web Vitals metrics](#)

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Interaction To Next Paint (INP) : Measures responsiveness. To provide a good user experience, strive to have an INP of less than 200 milliseconds .”

D64 · [Understanding Core Web Vitals and Google search results](#) · [Core Web Vitals metrics](#)

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Cumulative Layout Shift (CLS) : Measures visual stability. To provide a good user experience, strive to have a CLS score of less than 0.1 .”

D64 · [Understanding Core Web Vitals and Google search results](#) · [Core Web Vitals metrics](#)

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Interaction to Next Paint (INP) : measures interactivity . To provide a good user experience, pages should have a INP of 200 milliseconds or less.”

S4 · [Web Vitals](#) · [Core Web Vitals](#)

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Cumulative Layout Shift (CLS) : measures visual stability . To provide a good user experience, pages should maintain a CLS of 0.1. or less.”

S4 · [Web Vitals](#) · [Core Web Vitals](#)

Lead-in

Showing part of an article before requiring payment or subscription to access the remainder.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“There are two types of sampling we advise: metering , which provides users with a quota of articles to consume before requiring users to subscribe or log in, after which paywalls will start appearing; and lead-in , which offers a portion of an article's content without it being shown in full.”

D56 · [Flexible Sampling general guidance](#) · [Flexible Sampling general guidance](#)

llms.txt

A machine-readable file some services may use; Google Search says it ignores such files for visibility and ranking.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE · EXACT EXCERPT

“LLMS.txt files and other "special" markup : You don't need to create new machine readable files, AI text files, markup, or Markdown to appear in Google Search (including its generative AI capabilities), as Google Search itself doesn't use them. Note that Google may discover, crawl, and index many kinds of files in addition to HTML on a website: this doesn't mean that”

D04 · [Optimizing your website for generative AI features on Google Search](#) · [Mythbusting generative AI search: what you don't need to do](#)

Main content

Any part of a page directly helping it fulfill its purpose, including text, media, tools, relevant user contributions and tabbed information.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Google Search defines "main content" as any part of the web page that directly helps the page achieve its purpose. Depending on the primary intent of the page, the main content directly fulfills the page's purpose and could include:”

D03 · Creating helpful, reliable, people-first content · Main content

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Primary text and media: The main text, articles, images, audio, or video files on the page.”

D03 · Creating helpful, reliable, people-first content · Main content

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Interactive features: Built-in functionality such as calculators, online tools, games, or search functionality.”

D03 · Creating helpful, reliable, people-first content · Main content

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“User-generated contributions: Forum discussions, customer reviews, comments, or user-uploaded media when they directly fulfill the page's purpose (for example, when the page is about discussing a particular user question).”

D03 · Creating helpful, reliable, people-first content · Main content

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Tabbed or expanded sections: Information housed behind interactive tabs (such as product specifications, safety notes, or user reviews).”

D03 · Creating helpful, reliable, people-first content · Main content

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Page titles and headings: The visible title and headings throughout a page that summarize its topic and helps users make informed decisions about visiting.”

D03 · Creating helpful, reliable, people-first content · Main content

max-image-preview

A directive controlling allowed image-preview size: none, standard or large.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE · EXACT EXCERPT

“in search results. If you don't specify the max-image-preview rule, Google may show an image preview of the default size. Accepted [setting] values: none : No image preview is to be shown. standard : A default image preview may be shown. large : A larger image preview, up to the width of the viewport, may be shown. This applies to all forms of search results (such as Google web search,”

D39 · Robots meta tag, data-nosnippet , and X-Robots-Tag specifications · Valid indexing and serving rules

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE · EXACT EXCERPT

“the max-image-preview rule, Google may show an image preview of the default size. Accepted [setting] values: none : No image preview is to be shown. standard : A default image preview may be shown. large : A larger image preview, up to the width of the viewport, may be shown. This applies to all forms of search results (such as Google web search, Google Images, Discover, Assistant). However, this”

D39 · Robots meta tag, data-nosnippet , and X-Robots-Tag specifications · Valid indexing and serving rules

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE · EXACT EXCERPT

“preview of the default size. Accepted [setting] values: none : No image preview is to be shown. standard : A default image preview may be shown. large : A larger image preview, up to the width of the viewport, may be shown. This applies to all forms of search results (such as Google web search, Google Images, Discover, Assistant). However, this limit does not apply in cases where a publisher”

D39 · Robots meta tag, data-nosnippet , and X-Robots-Tag specifications · Valid indexing and serving rules

max-snippet

A directive setting the maximum text-snippet length in characters; -1 permits no specified limit and 0 prevents text snippets.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE · EXACT EXCERPT

“max-snippet: [number] Use a maximum of [number] characters as a textual snippet for this search result. (Note that a URL may appear as multiple search results within a search results page.) This does not affect image or video previews. This applies to all forms of search results (such as Google”

D39 · Robots meta tag, data-nosnippet , and X-Robots-Tag specifications · Valid indexing and serving rules

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE · EXACT EXCERPT

“[number] is specified. If you don't specify this rule, Google will choose the length of the snippet. Special values: 0 : No snippet is to be shown. Equivalent to nosnippet . -1 : Google will choose the snippet length that it believes is most effective to help users discover your content and direct users to your site. Examples: To stop a snippet from displaying in search results: <meta”

D39 · Robots meta tag, data-nosnippet , and X-Robots-Tag specifications · Valid indexing and serving rules

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE · EXACT EXCERPT

“don't specify this rule, Google will choose the length of the snippet. Special values: 0 : No snippet is to be shown. Equivalent to nosnippet . -1 : Google will choose the snippet length that it believes is most effective to help users discover your content and direct users to your site. Examples: To stop a snippet from displaying in search results: <meta name="robots" content="max-snippet:0"> To allow”

D39 · Robots meta tag, data-nosnippet , and X-Robots-Tag specifications · Valid indexing and serving rules

max-video-preview

A directive setting the video-preview length in seconds; -1 permits no specified limit and 0 allows a static image.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE · EXACT EXCERPT

“max-video-preview: [number] Use a maximum of [number] seconds as a video snippet for videos on this page in search results. If you don't specify the max-video-preview rule, Google may show a video snippet in search results, and you leave it up to Google to decide how long the preview may be.”

D39 · Robots meta tag, data-nosnippet , and X-Robots-Tag specifications · Valid indexing and serving rules

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE · EXACT EXCERPT

“rule, Google may show a video snippet in search results, and you leave it up to Google to decide how long the preview may be. Special values: 0 : At most, a static image may be used, in accordance to the max-image-preview setting. -1 : There is no limit. This applies to all forms of search results (at Google: web search, Google Images, Google Videos, Discover, Assistant). This rule is”

D39 · Robots meta tag, data-nosnippet , and X-Robots-Tag specifications · Valid indexing and serving rules

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE · EXACT EXCERPT

“-1 : There is no limit. This applies to all forms of search results (at Google: web search, Google Images, Google Videos, Discover, Assistant). This rule is ignored if no parseable [number] is specified. Example: < meta name="robots" content="max-video-preview:-1" >”

D39 · Robots meta tag, data-nosnippet , and X-Robots-Tag specifications · Valid indexing and serving rules

Merchant Center

A Google product for supplying product information, including feeds, that can help products appear in Search and AI responses.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Where appropriate, generative AI responses can include product listings, product information, and information about local businesses. Using products like Merchant Center (such as Merchant Center feeds) and Google Business Profiles can help your products and services to be visible in both AI responses and other Google Search results. Learn more about how to add and manage your business details on Google Search .”

D04 · [Optimizing your website for generative AI features on Google Search](#) · [Optimize your local business and ecommerce details](#)

Meta description

A page-level summary that Google may use for a snippet; page content and the user’s query can produce a different snippet.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Snippets are automatically created from page content. Snippets are designed to emphasize and preview the page content that best relates to a user's specific search. This means that Google Search might show different snippets for different searches.”

D81 · [Control your snippets in search results](#) · [How snippets are created](#)

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Snippets are primarily created from the page content itself. However, Google sometimes uses the meta description HTML element if it might give users a more accurate description of the page than content taken directly from the page.”

D81 · [Control your snippets in search results](#) · [How snippets are created](#)

Metering

Offering a limited number of free articles before requiring a subscription.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“There are two types of sampling we advise: metering , which provides users with a quota of articles to consume before requiring users to subscribe or log in, after which paywalls will start appearing; and lead-in , which offers a portion of an article's content without it being shown in full.”

D56 · [Flexible Sampling general guidance](#) · [Flexible Sampling general guidance](#)

Microdata

A supported structured-data format using HTML attributes to associate properties with visible content.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“If you're new to structured data, check out [schema.org beginner's guide to structured data](#) . While the guide focuses on Microdata, the basic ideas are relevant for JSON-LD and RDFa.”

[D82](#) · [Introduction to structured data markup in Google Search](#) · [Get started with structured data](#)

Mobile-first indexing

Using the mobile version’s content, fetched by the smartphone crawler, for indexing and ranking.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Google uses the mobile version of a site's content, crawled with the smartphone agent , for indexing and ranking. This is called mobile-first indexing .”

[D32](#) · [Mobile site and mobile-first indexing best practices](#) · [Mobile site and mobile-first indexing best practices](#)

mRSS

A supported Media RSS alternative for supplying video information to Google.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“While Google recommends using video sitemaps, we also support mRSS feeds.”

[D19](#) · [Video sitemaps and alternatives](#) · [Sitemap alternative: mRSS](#)

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Google supports mRSS , an RSS module that supplements the element capabilities of RSS 2.0 . mRSS feeds are very similar to video sitemaps and can be tested, submitted, and updated just like sitemaps.”

[D19](#) · [Video sitemaps and alternatives](#) · [Sitemap alternative: mRSS](#)

Neural matching

An AI system that understands representations of concepts in queries and pages and matches them.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Bidirectional Encoder Representations from Transformers (BERT) is an AI system Google uses that allows us to understand how combinations of words express different meanings and intent.”

D66 · [A guide to Google Search ranking systems](#) · [BERT](#)

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Neural matching is an AI system that Google uses to understand representations of concepts in queries and pages and match them to one another.”

D66 · [A guide to Google Search ranking systems](#) · [Neural matching](#)

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“RankBrain is an AI system that helps us understand how words are related to concepts. It means we can better return relevant content even if it doesn't contain all the exact words used in a search, by understanding the content is related to other words and concepts.”

D66 · [A guide to Google Search ranking systems](#) · [RankBrain](#)

News sitemap

A sitemap extension for news articles; keep news entries limited to articles published in the previous two days.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Only include recent URLs for articles that were created in the last two days. Once the articles are older than two days, either remove those URLs from the news sitemap or remove the <news:news> metadata in your sitemap from the older URLs.”

D18 · [News sitemaps](#) · [News sitemap best practices](#)

noimageindex

A page-level directive preventing indexing of images from that page; an image may still be indexed from another page.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Note that adding the noimageindex robots tag to a particular page will also prevent that images embedded in that page from getting indexed. However, if the same images also appear in other pages, they might get indexed through those pages. To make sure a particular image is blocked no matter where it appears, use the noindex X-Robots-Tag HTTP response header.”

D44 · [Remove images hosted on your site from search results](#) · [Remove images with the noindex X-Robots-Tag HTTP header](#)

noindex

A directive preventing indexing after Google can crawl and process it; it does not make the content private.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“There are two ways to implement noindex : as a <meta> tag and as an HTTP response header. They have the same effect; choose the method that is more convenient for your site and appropriate for the content type. Specifying the noindex rule in the robots.txt file is not supported by Google.”

D40 · [Block Search indexing with noindex](#) · [Implementing noindex](#)

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Instead of a <meta> tag, you can return an X-Robots-Tag HTTP header with a value of either noindex or none in your response. A response header can be used for non-HTML resources, such as PDFs, video files, and image files. Here's an example of an HTTP response with an X-Robots-Tag header instructing search engines not to index a page:”

D40 · [Block Search indexing with noindex](#) · [HTTP response header](#)

Non-commodity content

Distinctive information or experienced analysis that adds value beyond common knowledge and recycled summaries.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE · EXACT EXCERPT

“Providing a unique point of view : Our AI systems take a look at a variety of sources, so it can be helpful to have a unique viewpoint that stands out. For example, a first-hand review provides a unique perspective based on personal experience, whereas a summary of existing content simply restates information already available elsewhere. Create the content yourself”

D04 · [Optimizing your website for generative AI features on Google Search](#) · [Create valuable, non-commodity content for your audience](#)

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Creating non-commodity content that's helpful, reliable, and people-first : Be sure that you're writing non-commodity content that your readers will find helpful and reliable. Commodity content (for example, something like "7 Tips for First-Time Homebuyers") is often based on common knowledge, which could originate from anyone, and typically adds little unique insight for readers. In contrast, non-commodity content (such as "Why We Waived the Inspection & Saved Money: A Look Inside the Sewer Line") provides unique expert or experienced takes that go beyond common knowledge and the ordinary.”

D04 · [Optimizing your website for generative AI features on Google Search](#) · [Create valuable, non-commodity content for your audience](#)

nosnippet

A directive preventing text snippets and video previews in Search; it differs from excluding the page from indexing.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“noindex Do not show this page, media, or resource in search results. If you don't specify this rule, the page, media, or resource may be indexed and shown in search results. To remove information from Google, follow our step-by-step guide .”

D39 · [Robots meta tag, data-nosnippet , and X-Robots-Tag specifications](#) · [Valid indexing and serving rules](#)

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE · EXACT EXCERPT

“nosnippet Do not show a text snippet or video preview in the search results for this page. A static image thumbnail (if available) may still be visible, when it results in a better user experience. This applies to all forms of search results (at Google:”

D39 · [Robots meta tag, data-nosnippet , and X-Robots-Tag specifications](#) · [Valid indexing and serving rules](#)

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE · EXACT EXCERPT

“nosnippet Do not show a text snippet or video preview in the search results for this page. A static image thumbnail (if available) may still be visible, when it results in a better user experience. This applies to all forms of search results (at Google: web search, Google Images, Discover, AI Overviews, AI Mode) and will also”

D39 · [Robots meta tag, data-nosnippet , and X-Robots-Tag specifications](#) · [Valid indexing and serving rules](#)

Package tracking feature

An early-adopter carrier integration for shipment status; the current guide says it is not accepting new partners.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“The package tracking early adopters program is no longer accepting new partners.”

D95 · [Package tracking Early Adopters Program](#) · [Package tracking Early Adopters Program](#)

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Package tracking is a feature that displays package tracking related information on Google. When people come to Search looking to track a package shipped with your company, they'll be able to enter a package ID directly. The feature uses your API to retrieve the package tracking information and then displays it to the user. Here's how package tracking information may appear on Google Search when a user seeks to track a package.”

D95 · [Package tracking Early Adopters Program](#) · [Package tracking Early Adopters Program](#)

PageRank

A link-analysis system that remains part of Google's ranking systems; links are not the whole ranking process.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE · EXACT EXCERPT

“by subdirectories, but other times it might make sense to partition topics into subdomains, depending on your site's topic or industry. PageRank While PageRank uses links and is one of the fundamental algorithms at Google, there's much more to Google Search than just links. We have many ranking signals, and PageRank is just one of those. Duplicate content "penalty" If you have some”

D01 · [Search Engine Optimization \(SEO\) Starter Guide](#) · [Things we believe you shouldn't focus on](#)

People-first content

Content created primarily to help an intended human audience rather than manipulate search rankings.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“People-first content means content that's created primarily for people, and not to manipulate search engine rankings. How can you evaluate if you're creating people-first content? Answering yes to the questions below means you're probably on the right track with a people-first approach.”

D03 · [Creating helpful, reliable, people-first content](#) · [Focus on people-first content](#)

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Does your content clearly demonstrate first-hand expertise and a depth of knowledge (for example, expertise that comes from having actually used a product or service, or visiting a place)?”

D03 · [Creating helpful, reliable, people-first content](#) · [Focus on people-first content](#)

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“After reading your content, will someone leave feeling they've learned enough about a topic to help achieve their goal?”

D03 · Creating helpful, reliable, people-first content · Focus on people-first content

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Will someone reading your content leave feeling like they've had a satisfying experience?”

D03 · Creating helpful, reliable, people-first content · Focus on people-first content

Places sites feature

A regional presentation and refinement option for sites supplying place information; availability is feature-specific.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“This page describes features for Places sites in Google Search, including the aggregator carousel and refinement chips for local business and hotel queries in Türkiye. Publishers don't need to add any markup to be eligible for the aggregator carousel or refinement chips.”

D75 · Places sites: aggregator carousel and refinement chip · Places sites: aggregator carousel and refinement chip

Preferred source

A source a user selects to appear more often for relevant stories in Top Stories; it does not guarantee exclusive results.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“If you're a website owner, you can help your audience find your publication as a preferred source in Google Search. When a user selects your site as a preferred source, your content is more likely to appear in "Top Stories", highlighted with a "preferred" badge. In AI Mode and AI Overviews, your content can be highlighted with a "preferred" badge for users who have selected your site as a preferred source.”

D65 · Help your readers find your site through preferred sources in Google Search · Help your readers find your site through preferred sources in Google Search

Query fan-out

Concurrent related queries generated to gather additional information for an original user query.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Query fan-out : A set of concurrent, related queries generated by the model to request more information and fetch additional relevant search results to address the user's query. For example, if the original user's query is "how to fix a lawn that's full of weeds", fanout queries might include "best herbicides for lawns", "remove weeds without chemicals", and "how to prevent weeds in lawn".”

D04 · [Optimizing your website for generative AI features on Google Search](#) · [Is SEO still relevant for generative AI search?](#)

RAG

Retrieval-augmented generation: grounding an AI response in relevant, current pages retrieved through core Search systems.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Retrieval-augmented generation (RAG) : A technique (also known as grounding) used to improve the quality, accuracy, and freshness of AI responses by relying on our core Search ranking systems to retrieve relevant, up-to-date web pages from our Search index. Our systems then review the specific information from those retrieved pages to generate a more reliable and helpful response, showing prominent, clickable links to relevant web pages that support the information in the response.”

D04 · [Optimizing your website for generative AI features on Google Search](#) · [Is SEO still relevant for generative AI search?](#)

RankBrain

An AI system that relates words to concepts, helping find relevant content even without the exact query wording.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Bidirectional Encoder Representations from Transformers (BERT) is an AI system Google uses that allows us to understand how combinations of words express different meanings and intent.”

D66 · [A guide to Google Search ranking systems](#) · [BERT](#)

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Neural matching is an AI system that Google uses to understand representations of concepts in queries and pages and match them to one another.”

D66 · [A guide to Google Search ranking systems](#) · [Neural matching](#)

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“RankBrain is an AI system that helps us understand how words are related to concepts. It means we can better return relevant content even if it doesn't contain all the exact words used in a search, by understanding the content is related to other words and concepts.”

D66 · [A guide to Google Search ranking systems](#) · [RankBrain](#)

RDFa

A supported structured-data format using HTML attributes to express linked-data properties.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“If you're new to structured data, check out [schema.org](#) beginner's guide to structured data . While the guide focuses on Microdata, the basic ideas are relevant for JSON-LD and RDFa.”

D82 · [Introduction to structured data markup in Google Search](#) · [Get started with structured data](#)

Redirect chain

A sequence of redirects before the final destination; avoid unnecessary hops during migrations.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Avoid chaining redirects. While Googlebot can follow up to 10 hops in a "chain" of multiple redirects (for example, Page 1 > Page 2 > Page 3), we advise redirecting to the final destination directly. If this is not possible, keep the number of redirects in the chain low, ideally no more than 3 and fewer than 5. Chaining redirects adds latency for users, and not all user agents and browsers support long redirect chains.”

D48 · [How to move a site](#) · [Plan your redirect strategy](#)

rel=canonical

A declaration of the publisher's preferred representative URL; it is a strong signal rather than an absolute command.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Redirects : A strong signal that the target of the redirect should become canonical.”

D30 · [How to specify a canonical URL with rel="canonical" and other methods](#) · [How to specify a canonical URL with rel="canonical" and other methods](#)

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“rel="canonical" link annotations : A strong signal that the specified URL should become canonical.”

D30 · [How to specify a canonical URL with rel="canonical" and other methods](#) · [How to specify a canonical URL with rel="canonical" and other methods](#)

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Sitemap inclusion : A weak signal that helps the URLs that are included in a sitemap become canonical.”

D30 · [How to specify a canonical URL with rel="canonical" and other methods](#) · [How to specify a canonical URL with rel="canonical" and other methods](#)

rel=nofollow

A qualification for a link relationship the publisher does not endorse; it does not guarantee the target is never crawled or indexed.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Links marked with these rel attributes will generally not be followed. Remember that the linked pages may be found through other means, such as sitemaps or links from other sites, and thus they may still be crawled. These rel attributes are used only in <a> elements that Google can crawl , except nofollow , which is also available as robots meta tag .”

D41 · [Qualify your outbound links to Google](#) · [Qualify your outbound links to Google](#)

rel=sponsored

A link qualification for advertising, sponsorship or other paid placements.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“rel="sponsored" Mark links that are advertisements or paid placements (commonly called paid links) with the sponsored value. Read more about Google's stance on paid links . Appenzeller Note: The nofollow attribute was previously recommended for these types of links and is still an acceptable way to flag them, though sponsored is preferred.”

D41 · [Qualify your outbound links to Google](#) · [Qualify your outbound links to Google](#)

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“rel="ugc" We recommend marking user-generated content (UGC) links, such as comments and forum posts, with the ugc value. Appenzeller If you want to recognize and reward trustworthy contributors, you might remove this attribute from links posted by members or users who have consistently made high-quality contributions over time. Read more about how to prevent user-generated spam on your site and platform .”

D41 · [Qualify your outbound links to Google](#) · [Qualify your outbound links to Google](#)

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“rel="nofollow" Use the nofollow value when other values don't apply, and you'd rather Google not associate your site with, or crawl the linked page from, your site. For links within your own site, use the robots.txt disallow rule . Appenzeller”

D41 · [Qualify your outbound links to Google](#) · [Qualify your outbound links to Google](#)

rel=ugc

A link qualification for user-generated contributions such as forum posts and comments.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“rel="sponsored" Mark links that are advertisements or paid placements (commonly called paid links) with the sponsored value. Read more about Google's stance on paid links . Appenzeller Note: The nofollow attribute was previously recommended for these types of links and is still an acceptable way to flag them, though sponsored is preferred.”

D41 · [Qualify your outbound links to Google](#) · [Qualify your outbound links to Google](#)

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“rel="ugc" We recommend marking user-generated content (UGC) links, such as comments and forum posts, with the ugc value. Appenzeller If you want to recognize and reward trustworthy contributors, you might remove this attribute from links posted by members or users who have consistently made high-quality contributions over time. Read more about how to prevent user-generated spam on your site and platform .”

D41 · [Qualify your outbound links to Google](#) · [Qualify your outbound links to Google](#)

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“rel="nofollow" Use the nofollow value when other values don't apply, and you'd rather Google not associate your site with, or crawl the linked page from, your site. For links within your own site, use the robots.txt disallow rule . Appenzeller”

D41 · [Qualify your outbound links to Google](#) · [Qualify your outbound links to Google](#)

Rendering

Processing a page, including supported JavaScript, to obtain the content a browser would display.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“During the crawl, Google renders the page and runs any JavaScript it finds using a recent version of Chrome , similar to how your browser renders pages you visit. Rendering is important because websites often rely on JavaScript to bring content to the page, and without rendering Google might not see that content.”

D02 · [In-depth guide to how Google Search works](#) · [Crawling](#)

Responsive design

A configuration serving the same URL and HTML while adapting its display for devices; Google recommends it for maintainability.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Responsive design: Serves the same HTML code on the same URL regardless of the users' device (for example, desktop, tablet, mobile, non-visual browser), but can display the content differently based on the screen size. Google recommends Responsive Web Design because it's the easiest design pattern to implement and maintain.”

D32 · [Mobile site and mobile-first indexing best practices](#) · [Create a mobile-friendly site](#)

Reviews system

A system rewarding substantial analysis and original review research; it differs from evaluating customer comments on product pages.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“The reviews system is designed to evaluate articles, blog posts, pages or similar first-party standalone content written with the purpose of providing a recommendation, giving an opinion, or providing analysis. It does not evaluate third-party reviews, such as those posted by users in the reviews section of a product or services page.”

D67 · [Google Search's reviews system and your website](#) · [How the reviews system works](#)

Rich result

A Search result with additional presentation features made possible by supported content and compliant markup; display is not guaranteed.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Google uses structured data that it finds on the web to understand the content of the page, as well as to gather information about the web and the world in general, such as information about the people, books, or companies that are included in the markup. For example, when a recipe page has JSON-LD structured data (describing the title of the recipe, the author of the recipe, and other details), Google Search can use that information to display a rich result for the recipe.”

[D82 · Introduction to structured data markup in Google Search](#) · [How structured data works in Google Search](#)

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Adding structured data can enable search results that are more engaging to users and might encourage them to interact more with your website, which are called rich results . Here are some case studies of websites that have implemented structured data for their site:”

[D82 · Introduction to structured data markup in Google Search](#) · [Why add structured data to a page?](#)

Robots wildcard

The * character matches any character sequence in a robots path; \$ marks the end of a URL.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“* designates 0 or more instances of any valid character.”

[D28 · How Google interprets the robots.txt specification](#) · [URL matching based on path values](#)

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“\$ designates the end of the URL.”

[D28 · How Google interprets the robots.txt specification](#) · [URL matching based on path values](#)

robots.txt

A host-specific file that tells supported crawlers which resources they may request; it is not a privacy mechanism.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“A robots.txt file tells search engine crawlers which URLs the crawler can access on your site. This is used mainly to avoid overloading your site with requests; it is not a mechanism for keeping a web page out of Google . To keep a web page out of Google, block indexing with noindex or password-protect the page.”

[D27 · Introduction to robots.txt](#) · [Introduction to robots.txt](#)

Scaled content abuse

Producing many pages without added user value, particularly to manipulate ranking; using AI does not excuse this behavior.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Generative AI can be particularly useful when researching a topic, and to add structure to original content. However, using generative AI tools or other similar tools to generate many pages without adding value for users may violate Google's spam policy on scaled content abuse . If you're using generative AI content on your website, make sure your work meets the standards of the Search Essentials and our spam policies .”

[D05 · Google Search's guidance on using generative AI content on your website](#) · [Google Search's guidance on using generative AI content on your website](#)

Search profile

A Google profile users can follow to discover content from creators or organizations, including through Discover.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“A Search profile brings together your content from across the web and social platforms into a single destination on Google. When readers follow your Search profile, it makes your content that's linked on your Search profile (such as your content on Instagram, TikTok, YouTube, X, Facebook, and your website) more likely to appear for your audience on Google Discover .”

[D78 · Add a Search profile badge to your website](#) · [How Search profiles work on Google](#)

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“If you're a website owner, you can help your audience find your publication as a preferred source in Google Search. When a user selects your site as a preferred source, your content is more likely to appear in " Top Stories ", highlighted with a "preferred" badge. In AI Mode and AI Overviews, your content can be highlighted with a "preferred" badge for users who have selected your site as a preferred source.”

[D65 · Help your readers find your site through preferred sources in Google Search](#) · [Help your readers find your site through preferred sources in Google Search](#)

Search quality raters

People who evaluate whether Search systems provide good results; their individual ratings do not directly set rankings.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Search quality raters are people who give us insights on if our algorithms seem to be providing good results, a way to help confirm our changes are working well. In particular, raters are trained to understand if content has strong E-E-A-T. The criteria they use to do this is outlined in our search quality rater guidelines .”

D03 · [Creating helpful, reliable, people-first content](#) · [Get to know E-E-A-T and the quality rater guidelines](#)

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Search raters have no control over how pages rank. Rater data is not used directly in our ranking algorithms. Rather, we use them as a restaurant might get feedback cards from diners. The feedback helps us know if our systems seem to be working.”

D03 · [Creating helpful, reliable, people-first content](#) · [Get to know E-E-A-T and the quality rater guidelines](#)

SEO

Helping search engines understand content and helping people find a site and decide whether to visit it.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“When you built your website, you likely created it with your users in mind, trying to make it easy for them to find and explore your content. One of those users is a search engine, which helps people discover your content. SEO—short for search engine optimization—is about helping search engines understand your content, and helping users find your site and make a decision about whether they should visit your site through a search engine.”

D01 · [Search Engine Optimization \(SEO\) Starter Guide](#) · [Search Engine Optimization \(SEO\) Starter Guide](#)

Server-side rendering

Producing page HTML on the server; it can improve access to content rather than relying entirely on client-side JavaScript.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Keep in mind that server-side or pre-rendering is still a great idea because it makes your website faster for users and crawlers, and not all bots can run JavaScript.”

D33 · [Understand the JavaScript SEO basics](#) · [How Google processes JavaScript](#)

Serving search results

Selecting relevant results from the index in response to a query, considering quality and context.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“When a user enters a query, our machines search the index for matching pages and return the results we believe are the highest quality and most relevant to the user's query. Relevancy is determined by hundreds of factors, which could include information such as the user's location, language, and device (desktop or phone). For example, searching for "bicycle repair shops" would show different results to a user in Paris than it would to a user in Hong Kong.”

D02 · [In-depth guide to how Google Search works](#) · [Serving search results](#)

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“The content on the page is irrelevant to users' queries”

D02 · [In-depth guide to how Google Search works](#) · [Serving search results](#)

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“The quality of the content is low”

D02 · [In-depth guide to how Google Search works](#) · [Serving search results](#)

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Robots meta rules prevent serving”

D02 · [In-depth guide to how Google Search works](#) · [Serving search results](#)

Single-page application

An application using one HTML page; each independently meaningful screen or content item still needs a discoverable URL.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“For JavaScript apps that have only one HTML page, make sure that each screen or piece of individual content has a URL.”

D07 · [Get started with Search: a developer's guide](#) · [Check your links](#)

Site name

The name identifying a site in Search, distinct from a page-specific title link.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“When Google lists a page in search results, it shows the name of the site the page comes from. This is called the site name. Note that the site name is different from the per-page title links (title links are specific to each web page, whereas the site name is for the entire site).”

[D79](#) · [Provide a site name to Google Search](#) · [Provide a site name to Google Search](#)

Sitelinks

Additional links under a result that Google generates automatically from a site’s structure and other signals.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“At the moment, sitelinks are automated. We’re always working to improve our sitelinks algorithms, and we may incorporate site owner input in the future. There are best practices you can follow, however, to improve the quality of your sitelinks.”

[D80](#) · [Sitelinks](#) · [Sitelinks best practices](#)

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“We only show sitelinks for results when we think they’ll be useful to the user. If the structure of your site doesn’t allow our algorithms to find good sitelinks, or we don’t think that the sitelinks for your site are relevant for the user’s query, we won’t show them.”

[D80](#) · [Sitelinks](#) · [Sitelinks](#)

Sitemap

A file giving information about pages, videos and other files, and their relationships, to help discovery and crawling.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“A sitemap is a file where you provide information about the pages, videos, and other files on your site, and the relationships between them. Search engines like Google read this file to crawl your site more efficiently. A sitemap tells search engines which pages and files you think are important in your site, and also provides valuable information about these files. For example, when the page was last updated and any alternate language versions of the page.”

[D14](#) · [Learn about sitemaps](#) · [Learn about sitemaps](#)

Sitemap index

A file listing multiple sitemap files so large URL inventories can be split and submitted together.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“If you have a sitemap that exceeds the size limits , you'll need to split up your large sitemap into multiple sitemaps such that each new sitemap is below the size limit. Once you've split up your sitemap, you can use a sitemap index file as a way to submit many sitemaps at once.”

D16 · [Manage your sitemaps with a sitemap index file](#) · [Manage your sitemaps with a sitemap index file](#)

Snippet

A Search result’s descriptive text, generated mainly from page content and sometimes from its meta description.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Snippets are automatically created from page content. Snippets are designed to emphasize and preview the page content that best relates to a user's specific search. This means that Google Search might show different snippets for different searches.”

D81 · [Control your snippets in search results](#) · [How snippets are created](#)

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Snippets are primarily created from the page content itself. However, Google sometimes uses the meta description HTML element if it might give users a more accurate description of the page than content taken directly from the page.”

D81 · [Control your snippets in search results](#) · [How snippets are created](#)

Soft 404

A URL whose content indicates an error or missing page without the appropriate missing-page HTTP response.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“A soft 404 error is when a URL that returns a page telling the user that the page does not exist and also a 200 (success) status code . In some cases, it might be a page with no main content or empty page.”

D22 · [Troubleshoot Google Search crawling errors](#) · [soft 404 errors](#)

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“If you removed the page and there's no replacement page on your site with similar content, return a 404 (not found) or 410 (gone) response (status) code for the page. These status codes indicate to search engines that the page doesn't exist and you don't want search engines to index the page.”

[D22 · Troubleshoot Google Search crawling errors · The page and content are no longer available](#)

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“If your page has moved or has a clear replacement on your site, return a 301 (permanent redirect) to redirect the user. This won't interrupt their browsing experience and it's also a great way to tell search engines about the new location of the page. Use the URL Inspection tool to verify whether your URL is actually returning the correct code.”

[D22 · Troubleshoot Google Search crawling errors · The page or content is now somewhere else](#)

Spam update

A notable improvement to automated spam detection, distinct from the systems' ongoing detection work.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“While Google's automated systems to detect search spam are constantly operating, we occasionally make notable improvements to how they work. When we do, we refer to this as a spam update and share when they happen on our list of Google Search ranking updates .”

[D69 · Google Search spam updates and your site · Google Search spam updates and your site](#)

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“For example, SpamBrain is our AI-based spam-prevention system. From time-to-time, we improve that system to make it better at spotting spam and to help ensure it catches new types of spam.”

[D69 · Google Search spam updates and your site · Google Search spam updates and your site](#)

Structured data

Standardized markup supplying explicit information about a page and classifying its content for supported Search features.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Google uses structured data that it finds on the web to understand the content of the page, as well as to gather information about the web and the world in general, such as information about the people, books, or companies that are included in the markup. For example, when a recipe page has JSON-LD structured data (describing the title of the recipe, the author of the recipe, and other details), Google Search can use that information to display a rich result for the recipe.”

D82 · [Introduction to structured data markup in Google Search](#) · [How structured data works in Google Search](#)

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D82 · [Introduction to structured data markup in Google Search](#) · [Why add structured data to a page?](#)

Structured-data carousel beta

A region-limited host carousel with summary and standalone detail pages; it is different from an aggregator unit.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Google uses structured data to understand the content on the page and show that content in a richer appearance in search results, which is called a rich result . This guide focuses on a new carousel rich result that's in beta , which is a list-like rich result that people can scroll horizontally to see more entities from a given site (also known as a host carousel). Each tile in the carousel may have information from your site about the price, rating, and images for entities on the page.”

D77 · [Structured data carousels \(beta\)](#) · [Structured data carousels \(beta\)](#)

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“To be eligible for this beta rich result, add ItemList structured data in combination with at least one one of the following supported structured data items:”

D77 · [Structured data carousels \(beta\)](#) · [Structured data carousels \(beta\)](#)

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“The aggregator unit is a multi-provider feature designed for Vertical Search Services (VSSs), including Online Travel Agencies (OTAs), Comparison Shopping Services, metasearch engines, and directories. Aggregator units allow users to more easily see results from aggregators for queries related to hotels, flights, long-distance trains, products, and local businesses.”

D71 · [Aggregator unit in Google Search](#) · [How the aggregator unit works](#)

structured_description

The Merchant Center attribute for an AI-generated description, with content and digital_source_type sub-attributes.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“For ecommerce sites, Google Merchant Center has policies for AI-generated content . In particular, AI-generated images must contain metadata using the IPTC DigitalSourceType TrainedAlgorithmicMedia metadata. AI-generated product data such as title and description attributes must be specified separately and labeled as AI-generated.”

D05 · [Google Search's guidance on using generative AI content on your website](#) · [Give users context](#)

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE · EXACT EXCERPT

“structured_title”

S6 · [AI-generated content](#) · [Title](#)

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE · EXACT EXCERPT

“structured_description”

S6 · [AI-generated content](#) · [Description](#)

structured_title

The Merchant Center attribute for an AI-generated title, with content and digital_source_type sub-attributes.

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D05 · [Google Search's guidance on using generative AI content on your website](#) · [Give users context](#)

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE · EXACT EXCERPT

“structured_title”

S6 · [AI-generated content](#) · [Title](#)

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE · EXACT EXCERPT

“structured_description”

S6 · AI-generated content · Description

Supplier unit

A regional presentation of suppliers’ own listings, distinct from aggregator links; consult its specific eligibility guide.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“The supplier unit is a dedicated feature for direct providers (for example, individual hotels or airlines, brick-and-mortar business owners, or providers of services like plumbing) that appears alongside the aggregator unit . The supplier unit only appears if the aggregator unit appears.”

D72 · Supplier unit in Google Search · How the supplier unit works

Title link

The clickable headline of a Search result; Google can generate it from several sources, beyond the HTML title.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Google Search uses the following sources to automatically determine title links:”

D87 · Influencing your title links in search results · How title links in Google Search are created

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Content in og:title meta tags”

D87 · Influencing your title links in search results · How title links in Google Search are created

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“WebSite structured data”

D87 · Influencing your title links in search results · How title links in Google Search are created

Top Places List

A feature showing eligible publisher lists of places; follow the guide's content and publisher requirements.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

"If your business is mentioned in any "top places" lists online, Google might show a rich result that shows the lists that mention your business. For example, if your restaurant appears in a "Top 10 Chinese restaurants in NYC" list and a "Best restaurants in the city" list on qualified websites, these lists would be shown in your business's search result. This feature is only for businesses with a physical location."

[D60](#) · [Top Places List](#) · [Top Places List](#)

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

"The list must be curated by the content provider, be genuine, independent, and not sponsored."

[D60](#) · [Top Places List](#) · [Requirements for the listing site](#)

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

"The list must not consist of templated sentences built from data or automated metrics."

[D60](#) · [Top Places List](#) · [Requirements for the listing site](#)

Translated result

A result offering a Google-translated page experience when relevant; the publisher does not need to opt in.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

"This feature is applicable across all pages and results based on the user's language. You don't need to do anything to opt in."

[D88](#) · [Translated results in Google Search](#) · [Opting in or out of translated results](#)

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

"If the user clicks the translated title link, they're presented with a page that's been machine translated. Users also have an option to view the original search result, and access the entire page in the original language."

[D88](#) · [Translated results in Google Search](#) · [How translated results work](#)

URL discovery

Finding that a URL exists, for example through links from known pages or a sitemap; discovery precedes a possible crawl.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE · EXACT EXCERPT

“The first stage is finding out what pages exist on the web. There isn't a central registry of all web pages, so Google must constantly look for new and updated pages and add them to its list of known pages. This process is called "URL discovery". Some pages are known because Google has already visited them. Other pages are discovered when Google extracts a link from”

D02 · In-depth guide to how Google Search works · Crawling

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE · EXACT EXCERPT

“Once Google discovers a page's URL, it may visit (or "crawl") the page to find out what's on it. We use a huge set of computers to crawl billions of pages on the web. The program that does the fetching is called Googlebot (also known as a crawler, robot, bot, or spider). Googlebot uses an algorithmic process to determine which sites to crawl, how often, and how many”

D02 · In-depth guide to how Google Search works · Crawling

URL Inspection

A Search Console tool for investigating what Google sees and a URL's crawling, indexing and canonical status.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“When Google crawls a page, it should ideally see the page the same way an average user does . For this, Google needs to be able to access the same resources as the user's browser. If your site is hiding important components that make up your website (like CSS and JavaScript), Google might not be able to understand your pages, which means they might not show up in search results or rank well for the terms you're targeting.”

D01 · Search Engine Optimization (SEO) Starter Guide · Check if Google can see your page the same way a user does

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“To check how Google sees your page, use the URL Inspection Tool in Search Console .”

D01 · Search Engine Optimization (SEO) Starter Guide · Check if Google can see your page the same way a user does

URL migration

Moving content to different URLs, requiring destination preparation, URL mapping, redirects and monitoring.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Prepare the new site and test it thoroughly.”

D48 · [How to move a site](#) · [Overview](#)

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Prepare URL mapping”

D48 · [How to move a site](#) · [Prepare URL mapping](#)

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Monitor traffic”

D48 · [How to move a site](#) · [Monitor traffic](#)

Video sitemap

A sitemap extension describing videos, including their thumbnail, title, description and content or player location.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“To make sure Google can use your mRSS feed, you must use the following required tags:”

D19 · [Video sitemaps and alternatives](#) · [mRSS reference](#)

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE · EXACT EXCERPT

“<video:content_loc> A URL pointing to the actual video media file. The file must be one of the supported formats. It's required to provide either a <video:content_loc> or <video:player_loc> tag. We recommend that you provide the <video:content_loc> tag, if possible. This is the most effective way for Google to fetch your video content files. If <video:content_loc> isn't available, provide <video:player_loc>”

D19 · [Video sitemaps and alternatives](#) · [Video sitemap reference](#)

Watch page

A page whose main purpose is watching a single video; it differs from a page where video is incidental.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“A watch page 's main purpose is to show users a single video. The following pages are watch pages because watching an individual video is the main reason the user is visiting the page:”

D90 · [Video SEO best practices](#) · [Create a dedicated watch page for each video](#)

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“These pages aren't watch pages because the video is complementary to the rest of the content on the page:”

D90 · [Video SEO best practices](#) · [Create a dedicated watch page for each video](#)

Web Story

A visual, tap-through content format; Google’s implementation requires valid AMP and specified metadata.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Make sure the Web Story is valid AMP .”

D92 · [Enable Web Stories on Google](#) · [Enable Web Stories on Google](#)

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“AMP Linter : Validate Web Stories during development using the command line.”

D92 · [Enable Web Stories on Google](#) · [Make sure the Web Story is valid AMP](#)

X-Robots-Tag

An HTTP response header carrying indexing or preview directives, including for non-HTML resources such as PDFs.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“To block indexing of non-HTML resources, such as PDF files, video files, or image files, use the X-Robots-Tag response header instead.”

D39 · [Robots meta tag, data-nosnippet , and X-Robots-Tag specifications](#) · [Using the robots meta tag](#)

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“The X-Robots-Tag can be used as an element of the HTTP header response for a given URL. Any rule that can be used in a robots meta tag can also be specified as an X-Robots-Tag . Here's an example of an HTTP response with an X-Robots-Tag instructing crawlers not to index a page:”

D39 · Robots meta tag, data-nosnippet , and X-Robots-Tag specifications · Using the X-Robots-Tag HTTP header

XML sitemap

A sitemap format that can include supported extensions for images, video, news and language alternatives.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“Google supports the sitemap formats defined by the sitemaps protocol . Each format has its own benefits and shortcomings; choose the one that is the most appropriate for your site and setup (Google doesn't have a preference). The following table compares the different sitemap formats:”

D15 · Build and submit a sitemap · Build and submit a sitemap

YMYL

Your Money or Your Life topics that can significantly affect health, financial stability, safety or societal well-being.

GOOGLE DOCUMENT EVIDENCE

“While E-E-A-T itself isn't a specific ranking factor, using a mix of factors that can identify content with good E-E-A-T is useful. For example, our systems give even more weight to content that aligns with strong E-E-A-T for topics that could significantly impact the health, financial stability, or safety of people, or the welfare or well-being of society. We call these "Your Money or Your Life" topics, or YMYL for short.”

D03 · Creating helpful, reliable, people-first content · Get to know E-E-A-T and the quality rater guidelines

Build three truthful project stories

Interview coaching, not a Google requirement.

- Technical: a genuine crawl, rendering, indexing, migration, or performance problem you diagnosed. Explain the evidence that distinguished it from other possible causes.
- Content: a real improvement to usefulness, originality, relevance, or trustworthy production. Explain what changed for readers, not just how many words you added.
- Business: an example where you aligned SEO work with qualified leads, purchases, or another genuine objective. State your measurement method and limitations.
- For each story: business problem → baseline → evidence → your action → result → timeframe → limitations and what you learned. Use actual figures where available, and state clearly when attribution is uncertain.

Five questions to ask your employer

- What business outcome should this SEO role improve, and what does success look like over the next several months?
- Which parts of the website and search performance are the main concern today?
- How are content, development, analytics, and SEO decisions shared across the team?
- Are redesigns, platform changes, market expansion, or domain moves planned?
- What access and implementation resources are available, and how are recommendations prioritized?

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